- Arguably, the best known Biblical story is that of Moses leading the nation of Israel out of Egypt
  - The exodus is a literal, historical account of God orchestrating miraculous and important events in the course of fulfilling His promises
    - The book was written by Moses, a fact every New Testament author and even Jesus Himself testified
    - The events of the book took place in the 16th–15th centuries BC, and cover a little more than 215 years of time
  - Moses relates the story as an eyewitness account of historical events
    - Throughout its history Israel has always considered the story to be historical fact
    - Later writers in scripture refer back to the story of Israel leaving Egypt, meeting the Lord at the mountain and entering the period of desert wandering as a literal account
      - Stephen in Acts 7 recounts the story of Israel including a literal Exodus
      - Jesus Himself spoke of God's appearance to Moses and the giving of the Law as a literal account
      - The New Testament letter authors included many references to the book of Exodus
        - Only Psalms and Isaiah are quoted more than the book of Exodus
  - A literal understanding of this book gives added power and significance to the prophetic pictures embedded into the storyline of Exodus
    - The Exodus story is incredibly rich in pictures of sin, redemption, baptism, the Kingdom and judgment
    - Exodus is especially rich in pictures of Christ and His redemptive work
    - Above all, the story of Exodus is a story of God's sovereignty to accomplish His purposes in and through the lives of men
      - Eugene Merrill called Exodus the "most significant historical and theological event of the Old Testament"
- Like any book of Scripture, a proper understanding of Exodus depends on our knowledge of scripture overall (and to some degree on our familiarity with ancient history and culture)
  - So as we study this account, we'll take time in places to examine other Biblical texts, particularly Genesis, and the historical events of the period
    - Even a cursory glance at the book of Exodus will demonstrate a clear dependence on the earlier book of Genesis
    - For example, in the opening verses of Chapter 1, we'll find immediate references to the story of Joseph
    - For that matter, the entire story of the Exodus is made necessary because of events in Genesis

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        - Some of which we'll study tonight
    - There are six parts to the book
        - Part 1 (Chapters 1-4) is the call of Moses
        - Part II (Chapters 5-11) is God's demonstration of His power
        - Part III (Chapter 12-15) is the exodus
        - Part IV (Chapters 16-31) is the giving of the Law
        - Part V (Chapters 32-34) is the breaking and renewing of the covenant
        - Part VI (Chapters 35-40) is the construction of the tabernacle
    - Regarding the historical background of Egypt, we will spend time tonight learning a little history of Egypt leading up to the Exodus
        - We want to understand some of the politics of the Egypt that welcomed Joseph and enslaved his relatives
        - In coming weeks, we'll study considerably more Egyptian history and culture
- First, we'll start in Chapter 1 learning some important Jewish history

Ex. 1:1 **Now these are the names of the sons of Israel who came to Egypt with Jacob; they came each one with his household:**
Ex. 1:2 **Reuben, Simeon, Levi and Judah;**
Ex. 1:3 **Issachar, Zebulun and Benjamin;**
Ex. 1:4 **Dan and Naphtali, Gad and Asher.**
Ex. 1:5 **All the persons who came from the loins of Jacob were seventy in number, but Joseph was already in Egypt.**
Ex. 1:6 **Joseph died, and all his brothers and all that generation.**
Ex. 1:7 **But the sons of Israel were fruitful and increased greatly, and multiplied, and became exceedingly mighty, so that the land was filled with them.**

- Moses, the author of Exodus, recounts the history of Israel entering into the land of Egypt
    - Moses is referring back to the story he originally told in Genesis 46
        - According to Genesis 46, Israel left Canaan and brought all his descendants with him
        - His family included his 11 sons (not counting Joseph who was already living in Egypt)
        - Jacob's grandsons and granddaughters were also included
        - According to v.5, Israel's family numbered 70 altogether
    - In Genesis 46:26 we hear this:

Gen. 46:26 **All the persons belonging to Jacob, who came to Egypt, his direct**

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descendants, not including the wives of Jacob's sons, were sixty-six persons in all,
Gen. 46:27 **and the sons of Joseph, who were born to him in Egypt were two; all the persons of the house of Jacob, who came to Egypt, were seventy.**

- All the decedents of Jacob were 66, but then we read in the next verse that all the persons of Jacob's house were 70, like Exodus 1
  - The difference is simple and Moses makes clear why the numbers are different
  - In v.26 he is describing all those who are descended from Jacob and came to Egypt in response to Joseph's call
    - That number excludes Jacob himself (he isn't descended from himself) and it excludes Joseph's family (who were already in Egypt)
  - The second number (70) is a description of all the persons of Jacob's house
    - This number would include Jacob and Joseph's family
    - Since Joseph had two sons by this time, the difference between the two descriptions is four people
  - Later in Acts, Stephen describes the family of Jacob as having 75 persons in all
    - His number includes the five grandsons of Joseph born to Manasseh and Ephraim
- As you may remember, Joseph's story was central to how the nation of Israel ended up in Egypt
  - Joseph was sold into bondage by his brothers in Genesis 37
    - Later Joseph rises to power as the second most powerful man in charge in Egypt
    - And during a time of famine, the sons of Jacob come seeking relief in Egypt and meet Joseph, the son they sold into bondage
    - Ultimately, Joseph reveals himself to his brothers and invites them all to live in Egypt under the protection of Pharaoh
  - That's a short recap of HOW God brought Israel into Egypt, but it doesn't answer the question of WHY God did this to Israel
    - Why did God cause Israel to leave Canaan and dwell in a foreign land?
    - Why did God allow Israel to become enslaved there?
- The answer for why Israel, comes in two parts
  - The first part of the answer is found much earlier than the story of Joseph…all the way back in the story of Noah in Genesis 9
    - After the flood, Noah and his three sons exit the Ark and are camped somewhere near the Ark
    - One night Noah drinks too much and ends up naked in his tent
  - One of his sons, Ham, enters the tent and finds his father naked

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        - Later he tells his brothers what he found and takes pleasure in sharing the story of his father's shame
        - Noah's other sons act properly, covering their father's shame without looking upon his nakedness
    - When Noah discovers that Ham had treated him with contempt, Noah is stirred to pronounce a prophetic judgment
        - In reality, Noah's pronouncement was a judgment God Himself inspired for His eternal purposes
        - Since all three sons of Noah were God-fearing, Noah doesn't condemn Ham directly
    - Instead, Noah condemns Ham's son, Canaan

Gen. 9:24 **When Noah awoke from his wine, he knew what his youngest son had done to him.**
Gen. 9:25 **So he said,**
"Cursed be Canaan;
A servant of servants
He shall be to his brothers."

- With those words, Noah condemned the entire line of Canaan to destruction
    - The Hebrew word for cursed is *arar*, which means to bring to an end
    - So the line of Canaan must come to an end, according to God's prophetic word spoken by Noah
- Now flash forward 360 years to the story of Abraham
    - God first promised that Israel would enter Egypt when He made His covenant with Abraham

Gen. 15:12 **Now when the sun was going down, a deep sleep fell upon Abram; and behold, terror and great darkness fell upon him.**
Gen. 15:13 **God said to Abram, "Know for certain that your descendants will be strangers in a land that is not theirs, where they will be enslaved and oppressed four hundred years.**
Gen. 15:14 **"But I will also judge the nation whom they will serve, and afterward they will come out with many possessions.**
Gen. 15:15 **"As for you, you shall go to your fathers in peace; you will be buried at a good old age.**
Gen. 15:16 **"Then in the fourth generation they will return here, for the iniquity of the Amorite is not yet complete."**

- The Lord told Abraham that his descendants would be strangers in a land that was not

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their own for 400 years

- Furthermore, they would be enslaved and oppressed for a time in that foreign land
  - At the end of this period, God would judge the nation that oppressed Israel
- God promised Abraham that the nation that blesses Israel will be blessed, while the nation that curses Israel will be cursed
  - When Egypt was friendly to Israel, the nation of Egypt prospered
  - When Egypt turned against Israel, they eventually met judgment by the hand of God
- In the fourth generation, Israel would return to Canaan
  - Four generations later – Abraham's great, great grandchildren – would return to Canaan to receive a land God had set aside for them

- In v.16 God gives Abraham one of the reasons why his descendants must go to Egypt for this time, and the answer is connected to the curse on Canaan
  - God tells Abraham that the iniquity or the sin of the Amorite is not yet complete
    - The term "Amorite" is a generic term referring to all the "ites" living in Canaan… all the Canaanite people
    - God says the Canaanites had not yet reached the point where their sin was complete or full
    - We must interpret the meaning of the term "full" by the context of God's covenant with Abraham
  - God is not suggesting that the Canaanites' sin was insufficient to warrant God bringing eternal judgment for their sin
    - Just one sin is sufficient to warrant God's judgment
    - Only by His grace does any man remain alive even one day
    - And all men who die in their sins will be judged
  - Therefore, God isn't talking about an eternal judgment moment, though certainly all the Canaanite people faced judgment when they died
    - Instead, God was talking about the moment they encountered an earthly judgment
      - The destruction of the Canaanite people and their removal from the land in keeping with Noah's prophecy
    - God is saying that the time for their removal from the land had not yet arrived
      - Therefore the Canaanite people still had more time left to sin in the land prior to their removal
- Some commentators have concluded that God meant he was giving the Canaanites more time to repent
  - This can't be the proper interpretation either
  - According to the Bible, the repentance that leads to God's forgiveness and to salvation is something granted by God

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- It is not something men arrive at by themselves in the course of time

Acts 11:18 When they heard this, they quieted down and glorified God, saying, "Well then, God has granted to the Gentiles also the repentance that leads to life."

2Cor. 7:10 For the sorrow that is according to the will of God produces a repentance without regret, leading to salvation, but the sorrow of the world produces death.

- So God isn't delaying because God wanted to give them time to repent
  - According to the curse God spoke through Noah, there would be no granting of repentance for the Canaanite people
  - Once God pronounces a curse, His word is fast and sure and cannot be changed
- So why is God waiting to bring the earthly judgment He promised for the Canaanite people and give the land to Israel?
  - The answer is God determined that the sinful Canaanite people would receive judgment at the hands of the Jewish people
    - Abraham's descendants were appointed to conquer the Canaanite people living in the land
    - Under Joshua, they would wipe them out, erase their memory and displace them forever
  - But at the point God reveals this plan to Abraham, Israel isn't even a nation as yet
    - The nation grows slowly at first
    - Even though 175 years have passed, the nation consists of only a dozen people
    - And as Israel follows Joseph into Egypt in the beginning of the Exodus, there are still only 70 members in the household
  - While God is capable of defeating any people, nevertheless 70 men, women and children are hardly enough to occupy and care for the land
    - So God tells Abraham that a period of 400 years must pass before the nation of Israel will be numerous enough to occupy and hold the land God will give them
- So the first reason God sends Israel into Egypt is to multiply them in a fertile land where Israel would prosper
  - Chapter 1 of Exodus tells us the story of Israel multiplying
    - Notice in vs.6-7 that after Joseph and his brothers die in Egypt, the nation of Israel remains fruitful and increases greatly
    - In fact, in that verse there is a repetition of the increase to add emphasis
      - Fruitful, increased greatly, and exceedingly mighty, the land of Goshen was filled with them

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        - So Israel was living in the fertile valley of Goshen, where the Pharaoh assigned them to live
- But why did God want Israel to incubate in a foreign land, and more specifically why did Israel need to be enslaved during that time?
    - The second reason also comes from Genesis 38, from the story of Judah
        - As we noted earlier tonight, the story of Joseph begins in Chapter 37 with his descent into Egypt
        - And then Joseph's story picks up again in Chapter 39 in the house of Potiphar
        - Interrupting Joseph's story is a single chapter telling the story of Judah and Tamar
    - Time doesn't permit me to recount the entire chapter in detail – it's worth your time to read it – but we can summarize it quickly
        - Judah is a son of Jacob who takes a wife from among the Canaanite people
        - The sons of this marriage are evil and the Lord kills both of them
        - Later God permits Judah to have children through his widowed daughter-in-law, a Jewish woman
- In the story of Judah, we learn two important details
    - For the first time the children of Israel had begun to marry outside their family and to take wives from among the cursed Canaanite people
        - None of the patriarchs dared to do this before, since God had commanded them to remain separate from the Canaanite people
            - Abraham, Isaac and Jacob took wives from their family in Haran
            - But the Canaanites were a cursed people according to Noah
            - So if a member of Israel intermarried with Canaanites, then their children would be cursed as well
        - Consequently when Judah marries a Canaanite woman and has two sons, both his sons were evil in the sight of the Lord
            - And the Lord put them to death
    - Therefore, Judah's choice to marry a Canaanite threatened the very survival of the nation of Israel
        - If his brothers followed suit, every tribe of Israel might fall under the curse
        - God must act to prevent this sin from spreading
- Even more importantly, Judah was the tribe carrying the seed promise God delivered to Abraham
    - Paul explains in Galatians that the Seed promise God gave Abraham was a reference to the coming Messiah
        - Through one line of Abraham, God would bring the One Who would be sent into the world to bless Israel and all the nations
        - That seed promise was inherited by one child in each generation

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        - It moved from Abraham to Isaac (not Ishmael) then to Jacob (not Esau)
    - In Chapter 38 of Genesis we learn that God intended the seed promise to follow into the line of Judah
        - Judah's line would ultimately produce the Messiah
        - Yet in Chapter 38 we find Judah attempting to intermarry with Canaanites, which would have brought an end to God's promise
    - Immediately, we recognize the problem with the nation of Israel waiting out their 400 years while living in the land of Canaan
        - Had God left them in Canaan, the nation of Israel will have become Canaanites through intermarriage
        - Even more distressing, the line of the Messiah will be polluted by intermarrying with the line of the Canaanites
        - God's entire plan for Israel and the Canaanites and the Messiah would been disrupted
- So the second reason the Lord moved Israel into Egypt was to protect them from the intermarriage that was taking place in Canaanites
    - The story of Judah interrupts the story of Joseph to explain why God was working to place Joseph and his family in Egypt
        - The nation needed to leave Canaan until they were strong enough to return and defeat the people
        - And in the meantime, they must be removed from the temptation to intermarry with the Canaanites
    - God goes a couple steps further to protect the nation of Israel
        - First, he isolated them from the Egyptians during their initial years in Egypt
            - They lived in Goshen, which was a remote corner of the nation unfrequented by Egyptians
        - Secondly, God also determined that Israel would become slaves in Egypt
            - As slaves, Israel was precluded from marrying with the Egyptian culture whatsoever
    - So to the question why did God send Israel to Egypt, the answers are:
        - To give time for the nation to grow large enough to defeat Canaan and take possession of the land
        - To separate them from the possibility of intermarrying with other nations while they waited
        - Later God codifies the nation's separation from the world through the giving of a Law that precludes the nation from mixing with Gentiles
- Looking back at Chapter 1, we noted that the nation of Israel grew and prospered while they lived in Goshen, just as God intended
    - And at a point, God moves to bring Israel from being a privileged people in Egypt to slaves

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- Beginning in the next verse

Ex. 1:8 Now a new king arose over Egypt, who did not know Joseph.

- Egypt now has a new Pharaoh who didn't know Joseph
  - At first glance this is an odd statement, when you consider how prominent Joseph must have been
    - A Pharaoh was usually the son of a previous Pharaoh, so how could a new Pharaoh arise that would not know Joseph?
    - We should expect that the story of Joseph would have been handed down and known from generation to generation
      - After all, we're still talking about him today
  - The answer is that a regime change has occurred in Egypt
    - To understand this situation, we need a little history lesson on Egypt
- When Joseph came to Egypt, he entered the land during the 16th dynasty
  - The 13th–17th dynasties were ruled by a people called the Hyksos
    - These people were not Egyptians but foreigners from the region of Haran in the Fertile Crescent
      - They conquered the Egyptians in 1670 BC
    - The Hyksos were Semitic people, descended from Noah's son Shem
      - They shared the same family origins as the Hebrew people
      - But the people of Egypt were Hamites, descended from Noah's son Ham
  - So these Semites were the rulers over Egypt but they themselves were not Egyptians
    - The Egyptians hated the Hyksos conquerers and Semites in general
    - Naturally, the Hyksos themselves were welcoming to other Semite people who desired to immigrate into Egypt
      - The presence of other Semites in the land helped strengthen the Hyksos' rule over the native Egyptian people
      - This explains why Joseph was elevated into power by the Hyksos Pharaoh
      - As a fellow Semite, Joseph was a welcome ally to the Hyksos ruler
  - Furthermore, when the Pharaoh learned that Joseph had more family in Canaan, the Pharaoh immediately welcomed them to immigrate
    - Joseph knew that native Egyptians would not have received his family warmly, so he suggests that Pharaoh give his family a remote corner of Egypt called Goshen
    - Here we see the way God ensured that Israel remained separate from the Egyptians while living in the land
- Eventually, the Hyksos reign came to an end

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- The 17th dynasty was overthrown by an Egyptian called Ahmose, who established himself as Pharaoh of the 18th dynasty
  - Ahmose was a Hamite, a native Egyptian, so he restored Egypt to Egyptian rule
  - He came to power in 1570 BC
- This is the Pharaoh who did not know Joseph mentioned in v.8
  - He was ignorant of Joseph because he was not a descendant of the previous line of Pharaohs
  - Instead, he represented a new dynasty or house of rule, one that had no connection to past dynasties and its allies
    - The 18th dynasty is considered the height of Egyptian power
    - This was the first dynasty where kings called themselves Pharaoh
- The new dynasty's arrival resulted in an immediate change in the prospects for a semite living in Egypt
  - Ahmose's forces killed or ran out of town any Semites in the previous dynasty
  - Those that remained in the land were enslaved
  - This was the fate experienced by Joseph's descendants as fulfillment of God's promise to Abraham

Ex. 1:9 He said to his people, "Behold, the people of the sons of Israel are more and mightier than we.
Ex. 1:10 "Come, let us deal wisely with them, or else they will multiply and in the event of war, they will also join themselves to those who hate us, and fight against us and depart from the land."
Ex. 1:11 So they appointed taskmasters over them to afflict them with hard labor. And they built for Pharaoh storage cities, Pithom and Raamses.
Ex. 1:12 But the more they afflicted them, the more they multiplied and the more they spread out, so that they were in dread of the sons of Israel.
Ex. 1:13 The Egyptians compelled the sons of Israel to labor rigorously;
Ex. 1:14 and they made their lives bitter with hard labor in mortar and bricks and at all kinds of labor in the field, all their labors which they rigorously imposed on them.

- Pharaoh Ahmose tells the Egyptians they had reason to fear the Hebrews
  - In v.9, our English translation does not serve us well
    - It says that the Hebrews are more and mightier than the Egyptians
    - But Israel didn't outnumber all Egyptians
    - The correct Hebrew translation would read "Israel is too numerous and mighty"
    - Ahmose is concerned that with so many Semites still living in the land, his rule is threatened

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- Ahmose appoints taskmasters over them, enslaving them in hard labor
  - The work of the Jews was responsible for creating important Egyptian cities, including Raamses and Pithom, also called Heliopolis

- Though the labor of the Hebrews was certainly beneficial to Ahmose, his primary motivation for enslaving them wasn't to get free labor
  - His main concern was in stopping the growth of the people
    - Usually, hard slave labor will decrease the strength of a people and reduce their number
    - Ahmose wanted to wear the Hebrews down to nothing
  - Yet in v.12 we're told that his strategy didn't work
    - Against all logic, the nation continued to grow in the face of the persecution and hardship
    - The number of Hebrews were so numerous and vigorous that they caused dread for the Egyptians
    - And the harder the Egyptians punished the nation with hard labor, the heartier they grew
      - This is exactly as God intended it to be
      - In their weakness, God's strength was shown to the Egyptians
      - And in persecution, God grows His people
- The New Testament echoes this truth in several ways
  - First, we see church history repeat this pattern
    - Whenever the church has suffered under the worst persecution, it has grown the fastest
    - And that growth has always been of the best kind
      - The church grew among committed disciples who faced persecution with courage speaking openly about Jesus in the face of great trials
      - The weakness evident in the Western church today is probably related to our comfortable circumstances
  - Secondly, the New Testament calls every Christian to rejoice in trials and persecutions knowing these tests will produce greater strength in our personal faith and walk

James 1:2 **Consider it all joy, my brethren, when you encounter various trials,**
James 1:3 **knowing that the testing of your faith produces endurance.**
James 1:4 **And let endurance have its perfect result, so that you may be perfect and complete, lacking in nothing.**

- Like the nation of Israel as a whole, we can expect to see unexplainable growth in the face of trials that we might expect to crush us

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- It's in the moments when our strength fades that God's power shines through us
- Another 25 years pass and Ahmose dies, so his son, Amenhotep I, decides to try a new tactic to stem the growing population of Hebrews

Ex. 1:15 Then the king of Egypt spoke to the Hebrew midwives, one of whom was named Shiphrah and the other was named Puah;
Ex. 1:16 and he said, "When you are helping the Hebrew women to give birth and see them upon the birthstool, if it is a son, then you shall put him to death; but if it is a daughter, then she shall live."
Ex. 1:17 But the midwives feared God, and did not do as the king of Egypt had commanded them, but let the boys live.
Ex. 1:18 So the king of Egypt called for the midwives and said to them, "Why have you done this thing, and let the boys live?"
Ex. 1:19 The midwives said to Pharaoh, "Because the Hebrew women are not as the Egyptian women; for they are vigorous and give birth before the midwife can get to them."
Ex. 1:20 So God was good to the midwives, and the people multiplied, and became very mighty.
Ex. 1:21 Because the midwives feared God, He established households for them.

- Amenhotep gives direction to the head midwives of Israel to begin killing all male children at birth
  - These women would have passed this instruction on to the rest of the midwives who served Jewish mothers
    - Their names were Semite names, so they were likely Semite slaves themselves, though not Jewish
  - The plan was to make it look as though the children died at childbirth
    - In that day Jews counted ethnicity through the father
    - You were a Jew if your father was a Jew
    - So if the nation lost a generation of boys, then the girls would have married Egyptian men
    - And the next generation would have been considered Egyptian
    - Like with the Canaanites, the nation would have been slowly destroyed by assimilation
  - As before with Judah, God intervened to protect the integrity of the nation of Israel
    - He ensures these women were God-fearing and unwilling to obey the Pharaoh's instructions
    - When Pharaoh realized that young Jewish boys were still running around, the midwives give an excuse
      - Jewish women are vigorous and give birth before midwives can intervene

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        - It's a lie but one intended to protect God's people in the face of a greater sin, similar to the choice Rahab faced
    - And as a reward, God establishes a household for them
        - Meaning he gives them husbands and families as rewards for their faithfulness
- Like his father, Amenhotep's plan failed to destroy the people of Israel

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- The nation of Israel is held in bondage in Egypt
  - God is growing them into a people who will inherit the land God has promised to them
    - He placed them in Egypt to keep the nation from intermarrying with the Canaanites during this period of incubation
    - And now the Lord has allowed Israel to become slaves in Egypt to protect them from intermarrying with Egyptians as well
  - Meanwhile, the Pharaohs of the 18th Dynasty are intent on destroying the Semites of Israel
    - Their hatred of the Jewish people stems in part from Egypt's recent history of Semitic conquerers who ruled Egypt in the 13th-17th Dynasties
    - But it also comes from the threat the large and growing nation of Israel poses to the rule of the Pharaoh
      - It's as if another nation were growing inside the nation of Egypt, threatening to displace the native people
  - So first the Pharaoh Ahmose and later his son Amenhotep I tried to weaken the nation through harsh labor
    - But God supernaturally preserved the nation of Israel during this time
    - Even in their trials and difficulties, they still grew and prospered as a nation
      - This frustrated the Pharaohs to no end
      - And it led to even harsher tactics in an attempt to stop the nation's growth
- At the end of Chapter 1, Amenhotep I sought to kill all male children in a surreptitious manner using midwives to take the child's life unbeknownst to the mothers
  - When the midwives failed to cooperate, the plan failed, so Amenhotep takes an even bolder step

Ex. 1:22 Then Pharaoh commanded all his people, saying, "Every son who is born you are to cast into the Nile, and every daughter you are to keep alive."

- Amenhotep I decrees that the Egyptians themselves were commissioned to kill Hebrew male children
  - The nature of the death would be drowning by throwing them into the Nile river
    - Why would the people of Egypt be willing to participate in such a plan?
    - Since the Nile River was itself considered to be a god, the people were probably told the river god required these children as a sacrifice
  - In any case, the Pharaoh's plan is a last attempt to stop the Jewish growth
  - We don't know how many Hebrew boys were killed in this way, but we can conclude that it had little effect on the overall population growth of Israel
    - When Israel finally leaves Egypt, it is several million strong

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        - And it reaches this number after only a few generations
        - The Lord continued to bless the nation with great growth despite the enemy's efforts to halt it
- This final verse of Chapter 1 leads us directly into the story of Moses

Ex. 2:1 **Now a man from the house of Levi went and married a daughter of Levi.**
Ex. 2:2 **The woman conceived and bore a son; and when she saw that he was beautiful, she hid him for three months.**
Ex. 2:3 **But when she could hide him no longer, she got him a wicker basket and covered it over with tar and pitch. Then she put the child into it and set it among the reeds by the bank of the Nile.**
Ex. 2:4 **His sister stood at a distance to find out what would happen to him.**

- The story of Moses begins with a mention of his parents
    - They are not named here, though we finally get their names in Exodus 6
        - Both his parents are of the tribe of Levi
        - In fact, Moses' father married his own aunt, which was permitted in that day
    - In v.2 the mother gives birth to a son, and immediately she notices something unique about this boy
        - The text says he was beautiful, but the word in Hebrew is *tov*, which has a wide variety of meanings
        - It usually means good or beautiful or favorable, but it can also mean worthy or pleasing, as in pleasing in the sight of the Lord
        - We know every mother thinks her own son to be beautiful, so this can't be the only reason she felt the need to hide her son
            - Perhaps other Jewish mothers tried to hide their children as well
        - But the meaning of the verse is that Moses' mother had faith in God that her son was special to His plan in some way
    - Hebrews tells us this:

Heb. 11:23 **By faith Moses, when he was born, was hidden for three months by his parents, because they saw he was a beautiful child; and they were not afraid of the king's edict.**

- Josephus wrote that Moses' father had been given a revelation from God that Moses would humble the Egyptians
    - We don't know if this report is true or not
- After three months, Moses' mother resorts to a desperate act to save her son's life
    - She places him in a basket (or ark) and waterproofs it with pitch

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        - After placing the child in the ark, she sets it afloat on the Nile
        - It's ironic that Moses' mother tried to save her child by placing him in the Nile, since the Pharaoh's command was that male children be tossed in the Nile
    - We don't know what she expected to happen to the baby, but she must have hoped some Egyptian would claim the child
        - She would rather the child live with another woman than die with her
        - Moses' sister, Miriam, stands at a distance to watch what may happen to her baby brother
            - Perhaps the mother couldn't bear to watch herself
            - So she has Moses' sister report back to her mother what happens
- Even at this early point in the story, we see a couple of important themes of Exodus emerging
    - First, Exodus is a story of God's sovereignty
        - We've already reflected on God's sovereignty in how Israel ended up in Egypt and in slavery
            - God was working even from the days of Noah and then later in the covenant of Abraham to prepare a place for Israel
            - But He sends them to Egypt for a time to ensure they were ready to inherit the land
            - And then He holds Israel in slavery to ensure the integrity of the nation while they grew
    - Now we see God beginning the work of bringing Israel out of slavery
        - The first step is the preparation of a deliverer
        - God intends to raise up a man of prominence and stature among the Hebrews, a man who can humble the Egyptians
            - But how will God do this while Israel is in slavery?
        - The answer comes in the form of the edict of Amenhotep I
            - The decree that all males should die forces Moses' mother to give him up to become an Egyptian
            - In that way, God ensures that Moses will enjoy the best of Egypt during his upbringing
            - And this upbringing uniquely prepares him to serve in the role God has appointed
        - We'll see much more of this theme in Exodus
- Closely connected to the first theme is a second major theme of Moses as a picture of Christ
    - Just as Jesus is the Deliverer Who will lead Israel out of the slavery of sin, so will Moses be a lesser form of deliverer for the nation
        - The story of Moses begins in a similar manner to the story of Jesus

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        - Like Moses, Jesus is born of humble circumstances to godly parents
        - And like Moses, Jesus was saved from a ruler intent on destroying male children
    - You may remember that Jesus was an infant when King Herod heard the prophecy that the Messiah had been born to Israel
        - He was worried that this king might displace him on the throne of Israel, so asked the magi to tell him where the child was
        - When the magi tricked Herod, he responded by trying to kill all the male children in Bethlehem
        - God warns Joseph through an angel telling him to take Jesus to Egypt
    - Later, Matthew refers to this connection in his gospel

Matt. 2:14 So Joseph got up and took the Child and His mother while it was still night, and left for Egypt.
Matt. 2:15 He remained there until the death of Herod. This was to fulfill what had been spoken by the Lord through the prophet: "OUT OF EGYPT I CALLED MY SON."

- Matthew quotes from Hosea 11 in drawing the connection between Jesus and Moses
    - When we look at Hosea 11:1 we find this:

Hos. 11:1 When Israel was a youth I loved him,
And out of Egypt I called My son.

- In Hosea, Israel is called God's son
    - Later in the Exodus story, God tells Pharaoh that the Lord will take his firstborn son since Egypt has refused to release God's son, Israel
- But Matthew makes a broader application of Hosea's prophecy, creating a connection between Moses and Jesus
    - Just as Moses began life as an infant raised in Egypt, similarly God's son – Israel's deliverer – began his early years in Egypt
    - This early connection is intended to alert us to the broader comparison between Moses and Jesus
    - Therefore, Moses is a shadow of Jesus

Ex. 2:5 The daughter of Pharaoh came down to bathe at the Nile, with her maidens walking alongside the Nile; and she saw the basket among the reeds and sent her maid, and she brought it to her.
Ex. 2:6 When she opened it, she saw the child, and behold, the boy was crying.

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And she had pity on him and said, "This is one of the Hebrews' children."
Ex. 2:7 **Then his sister said to Pharaoh's daughter, "Shall I go and call a nurse for you from the Hebrew women that she may nurse the child for you?"**
Ex. 2:8 **Pharaoh's daughter said to her, "Go ahead." So the girl went and called the child's mother.**
Ex. 2:9 **Then Pharaoh's daughter said to her, "Take this child away and nurse him for me and I will give you your wages." So the woman took the child and nursed him.**
Ex. 2:10 **The child grew, and she brought him to Pharaoh's daughter and he became her son. And she named him Moses, and said, "Because I drew him out of the water."**

- Since it's God's plan to see Moses set afloat in the Nile, naturally God has prepared the perfect person to receive the child
  - The daughter of the Pharaoh was bathing in the Nile, which was a common practice
    - The daughter is a woman called Hatshepsut
    - Hatshepsut becomes a key player in the story of Exodus
  - Understanding Hatshepsut's role in Egypt and in the story of Moses is important and worth a few minutes of Egyptian history
    - Hatshepsut's is the daughter of Thutmose I, the son of Amenhotep I
    - At the time she finds Moses, Hatshepsut's father, Thutmose I, has just inherited the throne and begun to rule
    - Later her father will take a second wife and father a male heir
- Moses's sister observes Hatshepsut claim Moses from the river
  - This brave girl has the presence of mind to approach Pharaoh's daughter offering to find a Hebrew woman capable of nursing the baby
    - Clearly, Pharaoh's daughter would not have had milk to feed the infant, so she was open to this offer
    - And Miriam knew exactly who to find…Moses' own mother
  - Hatshepsut hires Moses' mother to nurse and care for the child, a perfect result
    - In fact, in those days mothers typically nursed a child until its fifth birthday
    - So Moses' mother will have the benefit of raising Moses until his fifth birthday
      - During these years, she would have been able to impress upon Moses his Jewish roots, a foundation that will be important to Moses later in life
- In v. 10 Pharaoh's daughter names Moses
  - His name in Hebrew is Mosheh, which is actually an Egyptian word
    - Members of an Egyptian dynasty took their names from the dynasty family name

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        - The name was usually a combination of the dynasty family name plus a prefix taken from an Egyptian god
      - So the family name of the 18th dynasty was Mosheh (or mose)
        - Notice that the first ruler in this dynasty period was Ahmose
        - And the current Pharaoh is Thutmose I
    - So Moses was probably given a longer name at this point
      - We don't know what the first part of his name was, but it was probably the name of the Nile river god
      - This would explain why Hatshepsut says Moses' name was a reminder that he was taken from the river
      - Interestingly, the word *mosheh* in Hebrew has become a pun
        - It is similar to another Hebrew word, *mashah*, which means to draw water
- Now the story of Moses jumps forward from his birth to a moment 40 years later

Ex. 2:11 Now it came about in those days, when Moses had grown up, that he went out to his brethren and looked on their hard labors; and he saw an Egyptian beating a Hebrew, one of his brethren.
Ex. 2:12 So he looked this way and that, and when he saw there was no one around, he struck down the Egyptian and hid him in the sand.

- In v.11 we're told that Moses went out to his brethren, meaning the Hebrew slaves
  - He's there to observe or take notice of their hard labors
    - While there he notices an Egyptian beating one of the Hebrews
    - At this point, Moses decides to act in defense of the Hebrew
      - He first makes sure that no Egyptian is watching
      - Then when the coast is clear, Moses kills the Egyptian taskmaster and buries him in the sand
  - This scene raises more questions that it answers
    - Moses could have visited the Hebrew slaves any day in his first forty years
    - And if he had made such a visit, he probably would have seen this same scene play out many times
      - An Egyptian taskmaster beating a Hebrew
      - This had been happening for many years
    - So why does Moses take this action at this point?
- Two places in the New Testament help fill in the gaps to explain Moses' behavior

Heb. 11:24 By faith Moses, when he had grown up, refused to be called the son of

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Pharaoh's daughter,
Heb. 11:25 choosing rather to endure ill-treatment with the people of God than to enjoy the passing pleasures of sin,
Heb. 11:26 considering the reproach of Christ greater riches than the treasures of Egypt; for he was looking to the reward.

- Hebrews says that Moses reached a point when, by faith, he repudiated his identity as a son of Pharaoh's daughter
  - This decision carried significant implications for him, of course
    - It meant setting aside a life of power and comfort in the Pharaoh's house
    - He would no longer have access to the wealth of Egypt and the fine living it provided
    - This is probably the moment when Moses dropped the first part of his name, the part referring to the Egyptian god of the Nile
      - By dropping the Egyptian god, Moses was declaring himself to be a follower of the Hebrew God
  - In this way, Moses chose to be associated with the Hebrew people
    - He would endure ill-treatment in his new identity
    - Notice the language the Hebrew writer uses to compare the two lives
      - Living in the way of the Egyptian society was enjoying the passing pleasures of sin
      - While enduring the suffering of the Hebrews was sharing in the reproach of Christ
  - Why did Moses take this step?
    - Hebrews says Moses' decision was a matter of faith, in that Moses recognizes that the eternal reward for God's people was a much greater prize than anything Egypt could offer
    - But what caused Moses to come to this understanding? Why did he wait until he was nearly forty years old to make this move?
- These events happen when Moses is nearly 40 years old, and around this time, Moses' adopted mother, Hatshepsut, dies
  - Here again, we need a little Egyptian political history to appreciate everything happening at this point in Moses' life
  - Thutmose I begins to rule in 1525 BC
    - Interestingly, Thutmose I is not the son of Amenhotep I
      - Amenhotep dies childless
      - But Amenhotep's sister was married, and her husband becomes the next Pharaoh
      - So Thutmose I is the brother-in-law of Amenhotep I

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- Thutmose I had a daughter by his first wife, Hatshepsut
  - To gain a male heir, he took a second wife
  - This son becomes Pharaoh Thutmose II
- Thutmose II eventually becomes Pharaoh and sires a male heir, Thutmose III
  - When Thutmose II dies unexpectedly in 1504 BC, his son, Thutmose III inherited the throne
  - But at the time of his father's death, Thutmose III was very young, just a small child
  - So his aunt, Hatshepsut, seized the opportunity to take control of the throne of Egypt
- In reality, Hatshepsut was the Pharaoh of Egypt
  - She was an unusually strong woman in a male-dominated culture
  - Queen Hatshepsut adopted certain male mannerisms to minimize objections to her rule including the wearing of a false beard that appears on some Egyptian pictures of her (Constable)

- Queen Hatshepsut reigned Egypt until her death in 1485 BC
  - So long as Hatshepsut was alive, her nephew Thutmose III remained in the shadows unable to consolidate his power
    - She controlled the power centers of Egypt and ensured that the ruling class and military of Egypt remained loyal to her
    - So for the first half of his adult life, Thutmose III was little more than a puppet Pharaoh
    - All the while, he deeply resented Hatshepsut's domination of his throne
  - After Hatshepsut's death, Thutmose III goes on a vendetta to erase her memory
    - He had all official references to her removed from monuments and buildings, her face chiseled off wall art, etc.
    - And any of her allies in power were systematically eliminated
  - Obviously, Moses was closely associated with Hatshepsut, so he was especially vulnerable
    - It was only a matter of time before Thutmose III acted against Moses, probably sooner than later
    - Realizing that he had nothing to hold him to Egyptian culture, Moses is stirred to reconnect to his Hebrew people and act upon his faith
- Moses' faith led him to choose God's people over Egypt, but it was the circumstances of Hatshepsut's death and Thumose III's threats that prompted Moses' timing
  - Every walk of obedience involves both faith tugging on our heart and the Lord pushing us through circumstances
    - Moses must have given thought to his fellow Hebrews on numerous occasions in the past

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        - He may have even witnessed similar moments of brutality
    - But on this day, Moses was stirred to take action in defense of Israel
        - Because God eliminated Moses' other options, he was able to see clearly that his future lay with Israel and his people
- After taking this step, a curious thing happens

Ex. 2:13 He went out the next day, and behold, two Hebrews were fighting with each other; and he said to the offender, "Why are you striking your companion?"
Ex. 2:14 But he said, "Who made you a prince or a judge over us? Are you intending to kill me as you killed the Egyptian?" Then Moses was afraid and said, "Surely the matter has become known."
Ex. 2:15 When Pharaoh heard of this matter, he tried to kill Moses. But Moses fled from the presence of Pharaoh and settled in the land of Midian, and he sat down by a well.

- Moses returns to the Hebrew encampment the next day
    - At this point he sees two Hebrew slaves fighting with one another
        - Moses steps in to stop the fight, asking one of them why they are fighting
        - The one responds, who made you our prince or judge?
        - Then he asks, are you going to kill me as you killed the Egyptian?
    - Moses is stunned to hear this comment
        - These two Hebrews were not involved in the previous day's events
        - The only person who saw Moses kill the Egyptian was the Hebrew that Moses had saved
            - Yet the next day the news has spread so far and fast that these two Hebrew youths already know the story
            - This leads Moses to remark that surely the matter has become known
    - Moses realizes that Hebrews are spreading the story about the murder
        - And if the Hebrews are speaking this openly about it, then eventually the news will get back to the Pharaoh
        - And Thutmose III is looking for any reason to have Moses put to death
- Even more disturbing to Moses than their loose lips was the Hebrews' unwillingness to be ruled by him
    - The fighting youths ask Moses who appointed him as prince or judge over them
        - Clearly, the Hebrews weren't interested in seeing Moses leading them
        - And they even mocked him a little for his presumptuousness in assuming he could be their leader

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- Was Moses actually seeking to lead the Hebrews when he killed the Egyptian?
  - Let's consider what Stephen tells us in Acts

Acts 7:22 "Moses was educated in all the learning of the Egyptians, and he was a man of power in words and deeds.
Acts 7:23 "But when he was approaching the age of forty, it entered his mind to visit his brethren, the sons of Israel.
Acts 7:24 "And when he saw one of them being treated unjustly, he defended him and took vengeance for the oppressed by striking down the Egyptian.
Acts 7:25 "And he supposed that his brethren understood that God was granting them deliverance through him, but they did not understand.

- Stephen recounts the history of Exodus 2
  - Moses was a man of power in words and deeds as he approached his fortieth birthday
    - And at that time in his life, it "entered his mind" to visit his brethren
    - While Stephen doesn't tell us why it entered his mind, we already learned why
    - It was God working through faith in Moses' heart and the circumstances of his adoptive mother's death to prompt this visit
  - Then Stephen relates the story of Moses killing the Egyptian taskmaster
    - Notice that Stephen gives the correct perspective on Moses' actions
    - Moses didn't murder the Egyptian; Moses came to aid of a fellow Hebrew
      - This is a type of justifiable homicide
- Then in v.25 we get to the most important part of Stephen's testimony
  - Moses supposed that the Hebrew people would understand and recognize that Moses was acting this way because he was called to be their deliverer
    - Specifically, God had called Moses to this role, and Moses knew this even at this early time
    - So Moses takes this action expecting that the rest of God's plan will fall into place
      - The Hebrew people would embrace Moses and rally behind him
      - Then God would produce a miraculous escape for the nation led by Moses
    - But as Stephen says, the Hebrews didn't understand this about Moses
      - This explains why Moses returned the next day thinking he was the new Hebrew leader
      - When they mock him and reject him, he is surprised
      - And if the Hebrew people won't support him, Moses knows he has only one choice left

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        - He will have to run away from Egypt and the Pharaoh
- Moses had the right idea, but the wrong timing
    - Moses was on the right track, but he didn't understand God's entire program
        - Specifically, he didn't realize that another 40 years needed to pass before it would be time to bring Israel out of Egypt
        - Understanding this history helps explain Moses' hesitation to take the reigns of authority when God finally appears and tells Moses it's time to return to Egypt
    - We'll study that moment in the coming weeks, but even now we can understand Moses' reluctance
        - He remembers that Israel didn't want to follow him the first time
            - Moses probably dismissed the whole idea once he fled the land
        - Remember this story the next time you feel discouraged in your own pursuit of ministry
            - God may have laid something on your heart, and you felt that burden and recognized the call
            - But so often, our timing is off
        - And if we act too early, as we often will, and God doesn't bring us the results we expect because the timing isn't right, just remember that the gifts and the calling of God are irrevocable
            - Sooner or later the timing will be right
            - And if we use our past disappointment as reason to say no when God gives the green light, then we will make the same mistake twice
            - We will have missed God's timing
    - There is another picture of Christ in this part of Moses' story
        - Jesus lived a normal life until he reached his 30th year
            - Then he received a call from God to go out as leader of the Jewish nation
        - And like Moses, the Jews didn't recognize Jesus as their appointed leader
        - And so they rejected him, requiring that Jesus return for Israel in a future day
            - In the meantime, Israel is left in their bondage, bondage to sin
- In v.15, Moses makes his escape and finally stops traveling when he reaches Midian, stopping at a well
    - If you have studied Genesis with me, then you know anytime a traveler stops at a well, good things are about to happen
        - Sure enough…

Ex. 2:16 **Now the priest of Midian had seven daughters; and they came to draw water and filled the troughs to water their father's flock.**
Ex. 2:17 **Then the shepherds came and drove them away, but Moses stood up and**

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helped them and watered their flock.
Ex. 2:18 **When they came to Reuel their father, he said, "Why have you come back so soon today?"**
Ex. 2:19 **So they said, "An Egyptian delivered us from the hand of the shepherds, and what is more, he even drew the water for us and watered the flock."**
Ex. 2:20 **He said to his daughters, "Where is he then? Why is it that you have left the man behind? Invite him to have something to eat."**
Ex. 2:21 **Moses was willing to dwell with the man, and he gave his daughter Zipporah to Moses.**
Ex. 2:22 **Then she gave birth to a son, and he named him Gershom, for he said, "I have been a sojourner in a foreign land."**

- Moses is in Midian, which is the land in the northwestern corner of Saudi Arabia, just south of Jordan
  - While there, he encounters seven daughters who came together to draw water for their father's flock
    - As the story goes, a band of hooligan shepherds ran the women off
    - But Moses decided to intervene coming to the aid of the women
  - The women ran to tell their father of the stranger's kindness
    - We know that Moses was not a Hamite, yet they call him an Egyptian
    - This means Moses was probably shaved like an Egyptian with the characteristic clothing and makeup of Egyptians
  - In their excitement, the women left Moses behind, so Dad tells them to find him and invite him to dinner
    - The father's name is Reuel
    - In the next chapter, he is called Jethro, which is his priestly title like Pharaoh (but his name is Reuel)
    - One thing leads to another, and Moses marries one of the daughters and they have a son, Gershom, which means driven out
- For the next forty years Moses will serve Jethro
  - Remember, Jethro is the priest of Midian
    - So his son-in-law (Moses) may have also been considered a priest
    - He was also a shepherd during this time
  - Though it may not be intended by scripture, there seems to be another picture of Christ in these details
    - After Jesus was resurrected, he left to go to the house of His Father
    - While there, he is serving as our High Priest
    - And He is the Shepherd of Gentile people

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- Again, this comparison may be a stretch, but it is interesting

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Exodus 3-4

- We are still in the midst of the call of Moses
    - He has departed Egypt and settled in Midian
        - He has found a wife, Zipporah
        - And he has a son, Gershom
    - And another forty years has passed, as Moses established a new life for himself in Midian
        - But while he was still in Egypt, Moses received a call from God to lead the Israelites out of bondage
        - Moses acted prematurely on that call, when he killed the Hebrew taskmaster
        - And the people of Israel saw no reason to rally behind Moses
    - Now God is ready to act to return Israel to the land He promised them through Abraham

Ex. 2:23 Now it came about in the course of those many days that the king of Egypt died. And the sons of Israel sighed because of the bondage, and they cried out; and their cry for help because of their bondage rose up to God.
Ex. 2:24 So God heard their groaning; and God remembered His covenant with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob.
Ex. 2:25 God saw the sons of Israel, and God took notice of them.

- After 40 years the Pharaoh dies
    - The Pharaoh is Thutmose III, who had desired to kill Moses and anyone connected to Hutshepshut
        - With Thutmose III's passing, his son Amenhotep II comes to power in Egypt in 1447 BC
    - At about this time, the Lord heard the groaning of the people of Israel and remembered His covenant with Abraham
        - Whenever we see the Bible using human characteristics to describe the Lord and His actions, we are observing an anthropomorphism

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        - In this case, God is described as hearing and remembering, which are human traits
            - God is all spirit and therefore doesn't hear with ears and doesn't remember, as if to call to mind something forgotten
            - All things are continually before God's attention and His knowledge has no limits
    - Therefore, these statements are saying something about God but are not literal descriptions of God
        - When the scripture describes God as hearing, it means God is inclined toward a plea or request
        - Likewise, when God remembers, it means the time for God to act has come to pass
            - So putting them together, it means God is now inclined to act on behalf of the nation of Israel
        - The action God is ready to take is to keep His promise to the patriarchs and free Israel

- Now we jump forward 40 years
    - It's been two years since Amenhotep II has inherited the throne
        - Moses spends his days shepherding Jethro's flock
        - Until one day...

Ex. 3:1 Now Moses was pasturing the flock of Jethro his father-in-law, the priest of Midian; and he led the flock to the west side of the wilderness and came to Horeb, the mountain of God.
Ex. 3:2 The angel of the LORD appeared to him in a blazing fire from the midst of a bush; and he looked, and behold, the bush was burning with fire, yet the bush was not consumed.
Ex. 3:3 So Moses said, "I must turn aside now and see this marvelous sight, why the bush is not burned up."

- Moses is near Horeb, the mountain of God
    - Remember, Midian is roughly directly south of Canaan in the northwestern tip of Saudi Arabia

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- As Moses is in this area, he comes upon a bush burning in the desert
  - In this region of the Middle East, the weather is incredibly hot
  - It virtually never rains
  - And it's not uncommon for shrubs to catch fire in the intense heat and dryness
- In this case, Moses can tell there's something different because the bush isn't being consumed by the fire
  - So he goes to investigate

- The bush was a theophany
  - A theophany is a physical manifestation of God
    - Specifically, this theophany displayed the Shechinah glory of God
    - The Shechinah glory is usually fire, smoke and/or cloud which represents the glory of God
  - We're told that the angel of the Lord is appearing in this moment
    - The angel of the Lord appears over 50 times in the Old Testament
    - These appearances are all appearances of the Second Person of the Godhead
      - A pre-incarnate Christ
  - We can see this clearly in every context because the "angel" is always addressed as God in the same context
    - Notice in the next verse, the Person speaking from the bush is called God

- In fact, the only Member of the Godhead Who is ever made visible in the Creation is the Second Person

Heb. 1:3 **And He is the radiance of His glory and the exact representation of His nature, and upholds all things by the word of His power.**

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- Jesus is the radiance of the Father's glory
  - Like the light beams coming from the sun, Jesus is the part of the Father that we can see

Col. 1:15 **He is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of all creation.**

Col. 1:19 **For it was the Father's good pleasure for all the fullness to dwell in Him,**

- Again, Jesus is the only Member of the Godhead Who has been made visible to us in Creation
  - All the fullness of the Godhead dwells in Christ
  - That's why Jesus said:

John 14:9 **Jesus said to him, "Have I been so long with you, and yet you have not come to know Me, Philip? He who has seen Me has seen the Father; how can you say, 'Show us the Father'?**

- At the time of Moses, Jesus has yet to take a human form, so any physical manifestation of Christ had to take other forms
  - Here He's a burning bush, later He's a pillar of fire and cloud
  - Other times we aren't told how He appears
  - The form usually has some meaning for the situation
    - In this case, a bush that burns but isn't consumed suggests the situation of Israel in Egypt
    - They are in torment by the bondage, but the torment hasn't consumed the nation
    - In fact, Israel has historically used the picture of a burning bush as a symbol of their race - persecuted and afflicted but not extinguished

- Moses' encounter with Christ in a burning is an iconic scene
  - In fact, we often talk about seeking a "burning bush" from God meaning a clear revelation
    - Many Christians wonder why Moses received something so clear and direct from the Lord while they struggle to understand God's will

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        - They beg the Lord to give them a burning bush too

    - While the desire to hear clearly from God is understandable, the request itself suggests that our imperfect obedience is a consequence of poor hearing rather than poor listening

        - In reality, our true challenge is to listen to what the Lord has already said and is saying to us

        - Because we have already received something greater than the burning bush

        - We have already received a word from Christ? In fact, we have many words from Christ

            - The word of God is the words of Christ

                - He is the Word!

                - Have we understood and obeyed all that it contains?

                - If we were, I wonder how many of our life issues and problems would vanish?

        - Furthermore, He came in the flesh and modeled a life recording in the Gospels...are we emulating that standard yet?

        - And most importantly, we have the Spirit of Christ living inside each of us, a blessing the OT saints couldn't know

Heb. 1:1 God, after He spoke long ago to the fathers in the prophets in many portions and in many ways,
Heb. 1:2 in these last days has spoken to us in His Son, whom He appointed heir of all things, through whom also He made the world.

- When Moses lived, there was no Scripture whatsoever

    - Revelation from God depended entirely on God appearing to men and intervening in their lives with His instructions

        - Can you imagine walking your entire life as a believer with no Scripture to turn to in a daily basis?

        - In fact, this appearance before Moses is the first known revelation from God to anyone on earth for over 200 years

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- What if the only word we had from God came sporadically, separated by decades or centuries?
    - When it comes to knowing and understanding God's will for our lives, did Moses have it easier or do we?
- After all, Who was in that bush?
    - Moses was receiving a word from Christ
    - So when we ask for a "burning bush" like Moses received, we're just asking for is a word from Christ
- So when we look past what we've been given already and demand a theophany or direct revelation instead, we're actually taking a step back
    - In a sense we're trading in the full revelation of Christ found in His word and His Spirit dwelling in us for the a lessor form of Christ like the Moses received
    - If Christ could speak clearly to Moses through a bush, can we expect Him to speak clearly to us by His Spirit within?
    - If a few words spoken in the desert can change the course of Moses' life, can the words of Scripture gives us all we need for life and holiness?

- Here's what Moses heard in that bush

Ex. 3:4 When the LORD saw that he turned aside to look, God called to him from the midst of the bush and said, "Moses, Moses!" And he said, "Here I am."
Ex. 3:5 Then He said, "Do not come near here; remove your sandals from your feet, for the place on which you are standing is holy ground."
Ex. 3:6 He said also, "I am the God of your father, the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob." Then Moses hid his face, for he was afraid to look at God.

- The Lord begins the conversation by calling to Moses by repeating his name
    - When the Lord calls a man with a repeating of his name, it signals a commission or calling from the Lord
        - The same pattern happens to Abraham, Jacob and later Samuel
        - So here the Lord is calling Moses to his mission, forty years later
    - Moses responds and walks toward the bush

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        - The Lord instructs Moses not to come near and to remove the sandals off his feet, since it was holy ground
        - Then the Lord identifies Himself as the God of the patriarchs
    - Moses hides his face in response, even afraid to look at God
        - The fear of the Lord is a palpable, instinctive response of sinful flesh to the holiness of God
        - If Moses responds this way to a theophany, a representation of God, then how do you think we'll feel when we stand in the presence of God Himself?
        - It is a terrifying thing to fall into the hands of the living God
- Next comes the specific calling of God for Moses

Ex. 3:7 The LORD said, "I have surely seen the affliction of My people who are in Egypt, and have given heed to their cry because of their taskmasters, for I am aware of their sufferings.
Ex. 3:8 "So I have come down to deliver them from the power of the Egyptians, and to bring them up from that land to a good and spacious land, to a land flowing with milk and honey, to the place of the Canaanite and the Hittite and the Amorite and the Perizzite and the Hivite and the Jebusite.
Ex. 3:9 "Now, behold, the cry of the sons of Israel has come to Me; furthermore, I have seen the oppression with which the Egyptians are oppressing them.
Ex. 3:10 "Therefore, come now, and I will send you to Pharaoh, so that you may bring My people, the sons of Israel, out of Egypt."

- God begins in explaining his purpose in appearing to Moses
    - God is ready to respond to the affliction of Israel
        - God will deliver the nation from Egypt
            - Notice that God doesn't say Moses will deliver them
            - God will deliver them, but He's inviting Moses to join Him in that work
        - After they leave the land of Egypt, God will deliver them to Canaan
            - To a land flowing with milk and honey

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- The phrase is an indication of the prosperity in the land
    - If the land is flowing with milk, then it's a measure of how many livestock the land can support
        - A land flowing with milk must be able to support many, many cattle
    - And if the land is flowing with honey, then it means there must be countless number of bees in the land
        - So many bees could only be possible if the land is covered with blossoming plants, indicating rich farming land and a plentiful harvest

- Notice the land they will receive is the land currently held by the various "ites"
    - These are the people God told Abraham must be displaced because of their iniquity
        - Notice there are only six "ites" listed here
        - In other places, we find more or less listed according to God's purpose
            - The number six stands for sinful men, a reminder of the iniquity of the Amorites
    - This is further evidence to us that God is fulfilling the word He gave in the covenant with Abraham

- Then God invites Moses to join in this great work
    - God says I will send you to Pharaoh, and you will bring my people out of Egypt
        - In response to God's call, Moses asks two questions and raises three objections

Ex. 3:11 But Moses said to God, "Who am I, that I should go to Pharaoh, and that I should bring the sons of Israel out of Egypt?"
Ex. 3:12 And He said, "Certainly I will be with you, and this shall be the sign to you that it is I who have sent you: when you have brought the people out of Egypt, you shall worship God at this mountain."

- Having heard God's instructions, Moses asks the obvious question

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- Who am I?
  - What he means is how can I expect to be successful in this kind of task?
  - Pharaoh is so powerful and strong, but I am not
- God answers the question by assuring Moses that God is not asking Moses to go alone or in his own power
  - Furthermore, God gives Moses a sign that He is hearing from the true God
  - After they leave Egypt, Moses will find himself at this same mountain worshipping God

- Then Moses asks a second question

Ex. 3:13 Then Moses said to God, "Behold, I am going to the sons of Israel, and I will say to them, 'The God of your fathers has sent me to you.' Now they may say to me, 'What is His name?' What shall I say to them?"
Ex. 3:14 God said to Moses, "I AM WHO I AM"; and He said, "Thus you shall say to the sons of Israel, 'I AM has sent me to you.'"
Ex. 3:15 God, furthermore, said to Moses, "Thus you shall say to the sons of Israel, 'The LORD, the God of your fathers, the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob, has sent me to you.' This is My name forever, and this is My memorial-name to all generations.

- This is such a fascinating question...Moses says what do I say if they ask who you are?
  - We might wonder why would Israel would dare ask who God was...wouldn't Israel know the God of the their fathers?
    - Remember they haven't heard from this God in their lifetimes
      - The last time Israel heard from God was in Jacob's lifetime
    - Plus, Israel has been living for centuries in a pagan culture where many gods are hailed by the Egyptians
    - Moses understood that Israel would be unfamiliar with their own God, so he asks for what to say in response to the question
  - In answer to the question, God gives Moses His name

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- The name of God is I am Who I am
    - Literally in Hebrew, God's name is "One Who causes all to be" or "One Who is"
- The word for I am is hayah in Hebrew
    - It is an active form of the verb to be
    - It means to exist in action, suggesting God is calling Himself the real God who proves His existence by His works
        - As opposed to false gods who are silent and still
- The Jews abbreviate hayah as YHWH to avoid saying the name
    - Everywhere you see the word "LORD" in your BIble, this is a use of the word YHWH in the original Hebrew
- So the word "LORD" in our Bible is actually a substitute for the name of God, which is HAYAH
    - Notice at the end of v.14 God repeats his name as I AM (hayah) sent you

- But knowing God's name doesn't really get to the true essence of Moses' presumed question from his countrymen
    - They wouldn't simply want to know the name of God, they want to know His identity and their relationship to Him
        - So God gives Moses that answer as well
        - He is the God of their fathers, Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob

- Having answered Moses' questions, God gives Moses a detailed explanation of what will happen in this plan

Ex. 3:16 **"Go and gather the elders of Israel together and say to them, 'The LORD, the God of your fathers, the God of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, has appeared to me, saying, "I am indeed concerned about you and what has been done to you in Egypt.**
Ex. 3:17 **"So I said, I will bring you up out of the affliction of Egypt to the land of the Canaanite and the Hittite and the Amorite and the Perizzite and the Hivite and the Jebusite, to a land flowing with milk and honey."'**

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Ex. 3:18 "They will pay heed to what you say; and you with the elders of Israel will come to the king of Egypt and you will say to him, 'The LORD, the God of the Hebrews, has met with us. So now, please, let us go a three days' journey into the wilderness, that we may sacrifice to the LORD our God.'
Ex. 3:19 "But I know that the king of Egypt will not permit you to go, except under compulsion.
Ex. 3:20 "So I will stretch out My hand and strike Egypt with all My miracles which I shall do in the midst of it; and after that he will let you go.
Ex. 3:21 "I will grant this people favor in the sight of the Egyptians; and it shall be that when you go, you will not go empty-handed.
Ex. 3:22 "But every woman shall ask of her neighbor and the woman who lives in her house, articles of silver and articles of gold, and clothing; and you will put them on your sons and daughters. Thus you will plunder the Egyptians."

- Moses is to repeat God's assurances that He is responding to their concerns and will deliver them
    - The people of Israel will pay heed to Moses' words and the elders of Israel will even join you in stepping before Pharaoh to make a request
        - The first request you will make of Pharaoh will be for Israel to go three days journey into the desert to sacrifice and worship to the Lord
            - This may sound like a strange request
            - Isn't Moses supposed to lead Israel out of Egypt permanently?
        - Actually, God is referring to Israel leaving Egypt
            - A three-days journey from Pharaoh was the time needed to travel to the border of Egypt and Canaan
            - God's words are simply a way of saying let us leave your country so we may go and worship out God
    - To this request, God says I know Pharaoh will say no, unless he is forced
        - So God is prepared to force him
            - God will send "all my miracles" which will cause Pharaoh to let my people go

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        - This is an interesting technique to gain His desired outcome, considering all the ways God could have accomplished this outcome
            - He could have simply killed all the Egyptians like the angel of the Lord did when the Assyrians attack
            - It's clear that God has more going on then simply freeing the nation of Israel
                - God's method is far more than merely a convenient way to force the Pharaoh's hand
                - God will be create pictures, demonstrate His power and create prophetic patterns

- Lastly, God promises His people will leave Egypt with many possessions
    - This is also in keeping with His promises to Abraham
        - God told Abraham that Israel would come out with many possessions
        - And here again, God reminds Moses that Israel will leave rich
    - In fact, the women in Israel will simply ask their Egyptian neighbors to give them their possessions
        - And these people will be so fearful of the God of Israel and so happy to see the Jews leaving, they will oblige by giving away their possessions
        - Thus ensuring that Israel will be well compensated for their many years of slave work
            - In this way, God even repays them for the time He caused them to endure slavery

- Once Moses hears the whole plan, his attitude changes
    - Moses brings God three objections to participating in this plan
        - These objections are a marked contrast to the earlier Moses, who rushed in early
        - In fact, the story of Exodus traces three distinct periods in Moses' life, and all three periods last forty years

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- The first 40 years is Moses growing up in Egypt
  - Moses is young, confident, presumptuous, and running ahead of God
  - As a result he faces disappointment and retreats
- The second 40 years is Moses in Midian
  - He is older, resigned, self-doubting, and reluctant to accept God's call, falling behind God
  - As a result, he witnesses God's power and glory and instruction
  - He learns God can do great things with humble servants, but He demands response and obedience
- Finally, the last 40 years are spent wandering in the desert with God's people
  - Moses is seasoned, mature, wise and steady
  - He is walking side by side with God
  - He faces trials but leads God's people with diligence despite many challenges
  - He learns that God is holy and just and good

- At this point, we're looking at the reluctant, self-doubting Moses
  - So chapter 14, Moses raises three objections to serving God in this way

Ex. 4:1 Then Moses said, "What if they will not believe me or listen to what I say? For they may say, 'The LORD has not appeared to you.'"
Ex. 4:2 The LORD said to him, "What is that in your hand?" And he said, "A staff."
Ex. 4:3 Then He said, "Throw it on the ground." So he threw it on the ground, and it became a serpent; and Moses fled from it.
Ex. 4:4 But the LORD said to Moses, "Stretch out your hand and grasp it by its tail" – so he stretched out his hand and caught it, and it became a staff in his hand –
Ex. 4:5 "that they may believe that the LORD, the God of their fathers, the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob, has appeared to you."
Ex. 4:6 The LORD furthermore said to him, "Now put your hand into your bosom." So he put his hand into his bosom, and when he took it out, behold, his hand was leprous like snow.

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Ex. 4:7 Then He said, "Put your hand into your bosom again." So he put his hand into his bosom again, and when he took it out of his bosom, behold, it was restored like the rest of his flesh.
Ex. 4:8 "If they will not believe you or heed the witness of the first sign, they may believe the witness of the last sign.
Ex. 4:9 "But if they will not believe even these two signs or heed what you say, then you shall take some water from the Nile and pour it on the dry ground; and the water which you take from the Nile will become blood on the dry ground."

- Moses first objection is, "What if they don't believe me?"
    - Now notice something interesting at this point
        - God has told Moses that he will be sent to Egypt to free his people from Pharaoh's grip
        - And God has said that Pharaoh won't listen so God is prepared to bring miracles against the king to compel him to listen
        - So wouldn't Moses' first concern be that Pharaoh won't listen to him?
            - But that's not Moses' first thought
        - Moses' first thought is what if the Jewish people don't believe him?
            - We remember Moses earlier experience trying to take charge
            - The Jews rejected his leadership, so now Moses wonders why would they accept me as their leader now?
- Moses' doubt is one shared by many who step out into leadership
    - Ministry would be so easy if it weren't for all the people
        - People don't necessarily want to be led, especially when they need to be corrected, admonished and challenged
        - In Moses' case, the people were going to be called to leave everything they knew and enter a strange and uncertain world
    - The fact remains, God calls men to leads His people, then and now

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Eph. 4:11 And He gave some as apostles, and some as prophets, and some as evangelists, and some as pastors and teachers,
Eph. 4:12 for the equipping of the saints for the work of service, to the building up of the body of Christ;

- These leadership positions are intended to bring good things for the people
- It's to our advantage to work with our leaders than to work against them

Heb. 13:17 Obey your leaders and submit to them, for they keep watch over your souls as those who will give an account. Let them do this with joy and not with grief, for this would be unprofitable for you.

- When we receive that call, as Moses did here, our first thought may be, "God, who will follow me?"
  - Do you know what the true answer is to that question?
    - No one is going to receive you
    - In fact, no one should receive us
  - Look how God answered Moses when he asked this question
    - God didn't say, "Oh come now Moses, why wouldn't they accept you?"
      - You're so smart, your so handsome
        - After all, you look just like Charleton Heston
      - You've been trained in the Pharaoh's courts
      - You went to the best seminary, you had the best professors
      - You've written all those great books
      - Of course the people will receive you
  - No, God didn't say that; God told Moses I will validate your ministry
    - Notice in v.2 God showed Moses how He could use his staff to perform a miraculous sign

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- Then in v.6 God showed Moses how he could turn his own hand leprous and then heal it
- Finally, in verse 9 God's tells Moses how he can turn the Nile into blood

- By these three miracles, God promises to validate Moses' ministry before himself, Israel and Pharaoh
  - They bolster Moses' own confidence, gain the trust of Israel and earn the respect of Pharaoh
- Like Moses, we too will gain confidence to serve in our calling knowing God is fully prepared to validate His call on our lives and ministry
  - We can expect He will do so by displaying His power through our work and in the fruit of our ministry
  - We can't point to our lack of pedigree or authority as an excuse for not serving His people
- The key is to keep a humble view of self without losing confidence in the power of God

"Cherish the lowliest thought you choose of yourself, but unite it with the loftiest conception of God's All- Sufficiency. Self-depreciation may lead to the marring of a useful life. We must think soberly of ourselves, not too lowly, as not too extravagantly. The one talent must not be buried in the earth." Frederick Meyer

- We should respond like the prophet Amos, a sheepherder sent to prophecy against the evil king Jeroboam of the northern kingdom

Amos 7:14 Then Amos replied to Amaziah, "I am not a prophet, nor am I the son of a prophet; for I am a herdsman and a grower of sycamore figs.
Amos 7:15 "But the LORD took me from following the flock and the LORD said to me, 'Go prophesy to My people Israel.'

- Then Moses raised a second objection

Ex. 4:10 Then Moses said to the LORD, "Please, Lord, I have never been eloquent, neither recently nor in time past, nor since You have spoken to Your servant; for I am slow of speech and slow of tongue."
Ex. 4:11 The LORD said to him, "Who has made man's mouth? Or who makes him mute or deaf, or seeing or blind? Is it not I, the LORD?
Ex. 4:12 "Now then go, and I, even I, will be with your mouth, and teach you what you are to say."

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- Moses was concerned the people wouldn't receive him, now his concerns turns to his lack of strength and skill, particularly as a messenger
    - Moses he tells God that if God needs someone to speak to the Pharaoh, He should look for someone who is eloquent
        - Someone who has the natural ability to do the job
    - Moses describes himself as slow of speech, slow of tongue
        - Actually he says I'm not a man of speech, I have a heavy mouth
        - Have you ever heard it taught that maybe Moses stuttered or that he had some kind of speech impediment?
        - That may be true, but these phrases more accurately describe someone who isn't good at speaking on their feet
        - Someone who can't form thoughts and words in a difficult situation – heavy mouth
    - In others, Moses is just like you and me
        - It's just as likely and perhaps ever more likely that Moses was simply expressing the concern that we all share
        - We don't feel confident speaking boldly in difficult situations
        - What if the president of the US called you and asked you to lead the delegation negotiating a difficult treaty with Iran?
            - Wouldn't we doubt we had the speaking skills to do that job?
            - Are we eloquent enough? Can we think fast enough to counter difficult arguments?
        - I think that's Moses' concern here
            - He worries that his abilities aren't up to the immense task God is assigning to him
    - Again, Moses is right
        - His tongue isn't good enough, he isn't smart enough
        - He doesn't have enough ability
        - But God does

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- Look at God's response in vs.11-12
    - God will make Moses' abilities equal to the task
        - God reminds Moses, who made your mouth? Who gives man the power to hear or see…or for that matter, do anything?
        - Is it not the Lord?
        - It's a marionette looking up at the hand pulling the strings complaining it doesn't have the strength to lift its legs
            - The statement assumes that our work for God is a product of our own abilities
    - But our ability to do anything of value for God is always dependent on Him working through us
        - Not only when we speak to kings, but when we speak quietly to our hurting friend
        - For He is the one who formed us and gave us life and saved us and directs us

Prov. 16:9 **The mind of man plans his way,**
But the LORD directs his steps.

- Moses gives one final objection

Ex. 4:13 **But he said, "Please, Lord, now send the message by whomever You will."**
Ex. 4:14 **Then the anger of the LORD burned against Moses, and He said, "Is there not your brother Aaron the Levite? I know that he speaks fluently. And moreover, behold, he is coming out to meet you; when he sees you, he will be glad in his heart.**
Ex. 4:15 **"You are to speak to him and put the words in his mouth; and I, even I, will be with your mouth and his mouth, and I will teach you what you are to do.**
Ex. 4:16 **"Moreover, he shall speak for you to the people; and he will be as a mouth for you and you will be as God to him.**
Ex. 4:17 **"You shall take in your hand this staff, with which you shall perform the signs."**

- The objection can be hard to interpret
    - Most English translations show Moses asking God to send someone else
        - This is a reasonable interpretation, and it fits the context well

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        - But the literal Hebrew simply says, "Lord, send by the hand You send."

    - Some have interpreted Moses objection to say, "Won't you send someone beside (along with) me?"

        - In this interpretation, which I prefer, Moses is objecting to doing this by himself

- In response, God grows angry with Moses' objections

    - Before we look at God's specific response, it should catch our attention that persistent objecting to the call of God risks His anger

        - God's patience is limited, and He will show anger at times

        - In every case, God's response is perfect and just, and sometimes the right response is anger

    - Why is God angry at Moses?

        - Because Moses has cast doubt on God's preparations to handle Moses' needs

            - Moses wanted company, but God knew this already that

            - Notice in v.14 Aaron, Moses' brother, is already headed toward him

        - Aaron was the older, eloquent brother of Moses

            - While Moses enjoyed life in the Pharaoh's court, Aaron lived with the Jews in Goshen

            - We're never told how Aaron was permitted to leave Egypt and travel to Moses, but we assume he escaped by God's hand

    - So Aaron has been brought to Moses just in time to accompany and support Moses' ministry

        - God says He will give Moses the words to tell Aaron, and God will be with Aaron as he speaks

        - The Church today mirrors this experience, in that ministry is a team sport

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- No one in the body is expected or even called to work alone
- God will bring us the people we need when we need them
    - Physical support
    - Prayer support
    - Financial support
    - Counsel and emotional support

- Moses had a role and Aaron had a role, and both were working as God had gifted them
    - And neither had an excuse not to respond to God's call

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- While in Midian, Moses received God's call (or commission) to return to Egypt and lead Israel free from bondage
  - At hearing God's instructions, Moses asked questions and raised objections
    - God answered the questions, rebutted the objections, and gave Moses assurances
    - All that remains is for Moses to obey the word of the Lord
  - So Moses makes arrangements to leave Midian

Ex. 4:18 Then Moses departed and returned to Jethro his father-in-law and said to him, "Please, let me go, that I may return to my brethren who are in Egypt, and see if they are still alive." And Jethro said to Moses, "Go in peace."
Ex. 4:19 Now the LORD said to Moses in Midian, "Go back to Egypt, for all the men who were seeking your life are dead."
Ex. 4:20 So Moses took his wife and his sons and mounted them on a donkey, and returned to the land of Egypt. Moses also took the staff of God in his hand.

- The Lord appeared to Moses at Mt. Horeb, so the first thing Moses does in response to the Lord's directions is return to his father-in-law's home
  - Moses asks Jethro's permission to return to Egypt with his family in obedience to God's call
    - Moses served Jethro in his home, so the custom of the day required Moses to gain Jethro's permission to leave
    - Furthermore, Jethro was the patriarch, the head of the household, so Moses must respect his authority
  - Jethro, a priest of God, naturally grants Moses his blessing to leave
    - I say "naturally" because if God has called Moses to leave, then we can naturally expect God to pave the way for Moses
    - God was no doubt working in the heart of Jethro to ensure his agreement with Moses' request
  - Interestingly, while Moses is still in Midian preparing to leave, the Lord appears to Moses a second time
    - We don't know what form the Lord took in this appearance, but the message He delivers Moses is clear enough
      - The Lord repeats the instructions for Moses to go back because the Pharaoh who was seeking Moses' life is dead
    - Why did God give Moses this second appearance I wonder?
      - Perhaps Moses was wavering in his determination to obey the Lord's call?
      - If so, then this moment is an encouraging example of God's persistence and His patience in compensating for our weaknesses in responding to God's call

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- If God has called us to accomplish something in His name, then we can trust He will equip us to meet the demands of the call
  - And equipping means not only talents and gifts for the work but also sufficient focus, conviction and urgency to stick with His mission
  - If Moses was reconsidering departing Midian, God's second appearance ensured Moses put all doubts aside
- I think we all benefit from this kind of prodding
  - God's equipping will always be sufficient to meet the demands of our mission

2Cor. 9:8 **And God is able to make all grace abound to you, so that always having all sufficiency in everything, you may have an abundance for every good deed;**

- Our test is whether we will accept the opportunity to join in the work
- Moses accepted God's call, so he took his family, including his two sons, mounted them on a donkey, took hold of God's staff and started for Egypt

Ex. 4:21 **The LORD said to Moses, "When you go back to Egypt see that you perform before Pharaoh all the wonders which I have put in your power; but I will harden his heart so that he will not let the people go.**
Ex. 4:22 **"Then you shall say to Pharaoh, 'Thus says the LORD, "Israel is My son, My firstborn.**
Ex. 4:23 **"So I said to you, 'Let My son go that he may serve Me'; but you have refused to let him go. Behold, I will kill your son, your firstborn."'"**

- Now the Lord appears to Moses a third time as he is traveling to Egypt
  - In this appearance the Lord reminds Moses to perform all the signs God required
    - God gave these wonders and powers to Moses for specific reasons
    - Just as God will equip us for the work He has appointed for us, God also expects us to use what He has given
      - In the same way that we are disobedient to refuse God's calling, we are equally disobedient if we neglect the gifts He has given us for our ministry
      - Moses was told to use all the miracles God gave him
    - Were Moses to appear before Pharaoh and choose not to perform all these miracles, God's purposes in Moses' calling could not be met
      - God not only prescribes the object of our ministry, but He also prescribes the manner of our ministry
      - We do not have the latitude to invent our own methods, but we are called to labor according to the same Spirit that equipped us and called us

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- By the same token, when we obey our call, follow the Spirit's lead, and use the gifts God has given us, are we assured everything will work smoothly?
  - Not necessarily…consider the rest of God's revelation to Moses
  - God tells Moses He will harden Pharaoh's heart so that Pharaoh will not allow Israel to leave
- Can we imagine any statement more confusing to Moses' ears?
  - He was sent with a mission to free Israel, and God gave Moses a promise that this mission would succeed
  - God even gave Moses special powers to ensure that Pharaoh pays heed to Moses' message
  - But now God tells Moses He will be working behind the scenes to prevent Pharaoh from responding affirmatively

- When we serve the Lord, we need to guard against running ahead of Him in assuming too much about how God defines success
  - Moses knew God intended to free the Israelites…God said as much
    - But now God informs Moses that the plan is a little more complicated than that
    - There would first be a period of frustration and delay as God's purposes in Pharaoh were met in his refusal to comply
    - God graciously revealed this detail to Moses to help him maintain a proper perspective
      - How easily Moses could have been discouraged if he hadn't understood this detail
      - In fact, Moses still experiences doubts despite this detail
  - Becoming disappointed in the results God gives us in ministry can lead to a mindset I call the Elijah Complex
    - It refers to 1 Kings 19 where Elijah fails to lead Israel out of their idolatry using his miraculous power to call fire down from heaven
      - So Elijah runs from Israel to the mountain of God pouting about how his mission had been a failure
    - At the mountain Elijah demands that God take his life, since there was no one left in Israel who would respond to his ministry
      - Elijah has a pity party because he assumed his purpose in ministry was to bring the entire nation to repentance
      - Elijah was mad at God for not bringing him the results he anticipated
    - God answered Elijah saying everything was going as planned
      - God had 7,000 faithful men in Israel just as God had intended
      - God's purpose in Elijah's ministry was different than Elijah assumed, and the consequence for Elijah's self-pity was his removal as prophet
  - Don't succumb to the Elijah Complex

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        - Don't prejudge God's purposes in your call or evaluate the results you obtain against some personal objective
    - God tells Moses to prepare for nine rounds of disappointment in his confrontation with Pharaoh
        - Moses must eventually tell Pharaoh that Israel is God's firstborn, and as a result, Pharaoh will lose his first born
        - As we will learn, God is speaking of the tenth and final plague against Egypt
            - And it's this judgment that finally brings about the Exodus
    - You may also know that this tenth plague leads to the Jews' Passover observance
        - When we get to Chapter 12, we'll examine all the ways in which this final judgment pictures Christ and our salvation
        - Obviously, God's eternal purposes were being served in Pharaoh's recalcitrance
        - Without it, we would have no Passover memorial
- As we look a little more closely at God's methods, many Christians find difficulty with God's words in v.21
    - The difficulty is not in understanding what the text says…the meaning is plainly clear
        - The difficulty comes in the willingness to accept what the text says
    - In v.21, God says He will harden Pharaoh's heart so that Pharaoh will resist Moses' call to set Israel free
        - The hardening won't change the ultimate outcome
            - But it is an important part of God's plan for determining the way the events play out
        - Throughout the entire account of the exodus, the Bible has 20 mentions of Pharaoh's heart being hardened
            - Ten times God hardens the heart
            - Four times, Pharaoh hardens his own heart
            - And another six times, we hear of Pharaoh's heart being hardened without an actor being identified
    - Some students and teachers are uncomfortable with the prospect of God directing Pharaoh in this way, so they search for a cause and effect relationship
        - They point to Pharaoh's choice to harden his own heart during the initial plagues as justification for God further hardening Pharaoh's heart during later plagues
            - It suggests that God required some provocation by Pharaoh before He would be right to harden Pharaoh's heart
            - As if without such justification, God would have been wrong to act in this way
        - These explanations parse the text in unhelpful and inaccurate ways, and they

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misrepresent God's sovereignty and character

- Clearly in this verse, God declares from the start that He intends to prevent Pharaoh from agreeing too quickly
  - Therefore, we shouldn't make too much of who does the hardening first or who does it most, etc.
    - Early on in the confrontation, Pharaoh's hard heart naturally resists Moses' requests without any help from God
    - Later as the plagues take their toll, God will intercede to prevent Pharaoh from giving up too soon
  - The main issue we must wrestle with is the simple fact that God actively prevents Pharaoh from relenting until the moment God desires

- To make proper sense of God's actions, notice that God's hardening is not for the purpose of preventing Pharaoh's salvation
  - We're told that God's hardening is for the purpose of ensuring Pharaoh would not let Israel go too soon
    - More importantly, there is no need for God to harden Pharaoh against believing and being saved
  - Like all men, Pharaoh was born lost and by his own nature, he will remain lost forever unless God intervenes to grant mercy and bring faith
    - God doesn't harden a heart to make someone unbelieving and lost
    - Men are born lost and unreceptive to the Gospel, and they remain that way apart from God's merciful intervention
    - Paul said in Romans 2:

Rom. 3:11 **THERE IS NONE WHO UNDERSTANDS,**
THERE IS NONE WHO SEEKS FOR GOD;

- And Jesus said in John 6:

John 6:65 **And He was saying, "For this reason I have said to you, that no one can come to Me unless it has been granted him from the Father."**

- So God's purpose in hardening Pharaoh's unbelieving heart was simply to ensure Pharaoh's behavior follows God's plan
  - The power of God's miracles are so great that a man like Pharaoh might have been compelled to relent sooner than God preferred
  - Perhaps 4 or 5 of the plagues would have been enough to persuade Pharaoh to release the Israelites
    - But God wants to release ten plagues and show His power in a mighty way

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        - So He hardens Pharaoh's heart to prevent a premature change of mind
    - And this, too, is God's sovereign right, as Paul reminds us in Romans 9:

Rom. 9:17 For the Scripture says to Pharaoh, "FOR THIS VERY PURPOSE I RAISED YOU UP, TO DEMONSTRATE MY POWER IN YOU, AND THAT MY NAME MIGHT BE PROCLAIMED THROUGHOUT THE WHOLE EARTH."
Rom. 9:18 So then He has mercy on whom He desires, and He hardens whom He desires.

- Paul quotes from Exodus 9:16 where God says He raised up Pharaoh for the sole purpose of making him an object onto which God could project His power
    - And by demonstrating His power against the Pharaoh's stubborn refusals, God's name would be proclaimed throughout the entire world
- God has mercy on Whom He wishes and hardens Whom He wishes
    - Israel was receiving God's mercy while Pharaoh was being hardened
        - In neither case are we speaking of personal salvation
        - The nation of Israel was to be set free from bondage
        - And the nation of Egypt was to endure 10 plagues before that freedom was granted
        - And God worked in Pharaoh's heart to ensure this plan came about
    - Paul's point is that God has absolute authority over the events of the world and of individual lives
        - God has all the right and power to decide who receives His mercy and who He hardens
        - In this way, all events in human history transpire according to God's eternal plan and will

Rom. 9:16 So then it does not depend on the man who wills or the man who runs, but on God who has mercy.

- God can and will use everything in His creation to bring Himself glory
    - Some men are called to receive God's mercy, so they might glorify Him in their faith and obedience
    - Other men are left in their sin so that God may receive glory for His perfect justice in displaying them as objects of His wrath
        - This was God's plan for Pharaoh; he was raised up to be an object of God's wrath and power
        - And Moses needed to understand that plan so that he wouldn't become discouraged by the Pharaoh's stubbornness

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- With this clarification, Moses is almost ready to enter Egypt and serve God in this calling
  - But before Moses can serve, God must address an issue of obedience in Moses' life

Ex. 4:24 Now it came about at the lodging place on the way that the LORD met him and sought to put him to death.
Ex. 4:25 Then Zipporah took a flint and cut off her son's foreskin and threw it at Moses' feet, and she said, "You are indeed a bridegroom of blood to me."
Ex. 4:26 So He let him alone. At that time she said, "You are a bridegroom of blood" — because of the circumcision.

- In this passage, we find one of the most enigmatic passages in the Old Testament
  - Moses is traveling to Egypt with Zipporah and his two sons
    - As they lodged somewhere along the trail, the Lord appears before them and seeks to put "him" to death
    - In response, Moses' wife performs a circumcision on the second son, and then the Lord relents
  - The passage is difficult to interpret because of a feature of Hebrew grammar
    - Hebrew often leaves out pronouns (e.g., he, his, her)
    - Under these circumstances, the actor and the object of an action are assumed and must be determined by the context
    - The assumptions we must make in assigning pronouns can have a dramatic impact on our interpretation
  - In v.24 my Bible says that the Lord met "him" and sought to put "him" to death
    - In Hebrew this literally reads, "The Lord encountered and sought to take life"
    - So who is the Lord meeting and whose life is He seeking to take?
  - Many interpreters have assumed that the "he" was Moses
    - Moses was traveling with his wife Zipporah and his two sons and it appears likely the second son wasn't circumcised
    - So interpreters assume the Lord is angry at Moses for not circumcising the second boy as required
- All Jews were bound by the covenant made with Abraham to circumcise their children on the eighth day

Gen. 17:10 "This is My covenant, which you shall keep, between Me and you and your descendants after you: every male among you shall be circumcised.
Gen. 17:14 "But an uncircumcised male who is not circumcised in the flesh of his foreskin, that person shall be cut off from his people; he has broken My covenant."

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- If someone was not circumcised, they were to be cutoff from his people
  - In Hebrew, the meaning of cutoff is literally “destroyed” or “killed"
  - But notice in Genesis 17 who is commanded to die for failing to be circumcised
  - The penalty of death is to be applied to the one who wasn’t circumcised
    - That is, the child is to be put to death
- Circumcision was an outward sign in the body of Jewish men to remind the nation of God’s promise to make a nation of Abraham’s seed
  - If a parent refused to circumcise their son, they were disobeying God and excluding their son from inclusion of the promises God made to the nation
  - God created the nation by His promise to Abraham, so Jewish males who lacked this sign of the covenant could not enjoy membership in the nation formed by that promise
- Secondly, God has given Moses a mission that will announce the death of Pharaoh’s son as penalty for Pharaoh’s failure to obey God’s command
  - So it makes sense for God to threaten Moses with the death of his son for Moses’ failure to obey God’s commandment
- Therefore, the “him” who is in danger of dying is not Moses but Moses’ child
- Zipporah understands the situation, so she promptly circumcises her son on the spot, then she throws (or touches) the skin at “his” feet
  - Again, we’re left guessing a little about what’s happening, but here’s what I think happened
    - Moses’ wife Zipporah was not a Jewish woman; she’s a Midianite
      - Moses had met her in Midian, present day Saudi Arabia
      - She knew nothing of this practice of circumcision
    - Then after the birth of their first son, Gershome, Moses would have explained the Jewish practice of circumcision
    - Zipporah probably didn’t object at the time either because she wasn’t familiar with the practice or simply hadn’t seen it performed
  - But after having seen it the first time, Zipporah had seen enough
    - Perhaps she was appalled by the bloody affair
    - So she forbids it when the second son, Eliezer comes along
    - But now that the Lord is threatening to take the child’s life, Zipporah has no choice but to comply
  - This would explain the peculiar way she performs the circumcision
    - She circumcises the child and throws the skin at “his” feet in disgust
      - As she does this, she calls Moses a bridegroom of blood, so she was probably throwing the skin at Moses
    - She meant that her marriage to Moses required a spilling of blood every time

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their marriage brought forth new life

- Do you see a picture of Christ in this portrayal?
  - Once again, Moses represents Jesus, Who is our bridegroom
    - And we are His Bride by faith, and that faith produces new spiritual life in each of us
    - But that new life came only by the blood of Christ on the cross
  - He is a bridegroom of blood for each of us as well
    - But while Zipporah reacted in disgust to the spilling of blood, we respond in joy for the life it brings
- More significant and troubling, however, was Moses' failure to contend with her decision
  - Here's a man God has appointed to lead God's nation of people
    - To represent God to Pharaoh and to the nation of Israel
    - Yet he wasn't leading spiritually within his own home on an issue as basic as obedience to God's commandment to circumcise
    - Only after God threatens the child with death does Zipporah take appropriate action
  - Moses must have learned his lesson, because after her display of disgust and disrespect, Moses sends Zipporah and the boys back to Jethro
    - Moses goes alone into the land of Egypt, and we hear nothing of her again until Exodus 18 when Jethro brings the family to meet Moses at Mt. Sinai
  - God demands that those who might lead His people lead first in their own lives and families
    - Paul expresses this same expectation for leaders in the church

1Tim. 3:4 He must be one who manages his own household well, keeping his children under control with all dignity
1Tim. 3:5 (but if a man does not know how to manage his own household, how will he take care of the church of God?),

- Moses deferred to his wife's ignorance concerning a major issue in the family's spiritual life, and his abdication of leadership almost led to the death of his son
  - Don't assume Moses' situation is an extreme example
    - A man's failure to lead his family spiritually may eventually place his children in life or death circumstances
    - At the very least, it will lead to discord, dissension and disobedience within the family
  - And mothers play an equally important role in a family's obedience to the Lord
    - Apart from her responsibility to show respect and support for the husband's leadership, a wife and mother is also a leader over the children

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        - A mother must model obedience and godliness while handing out correction to ensure her children's obedience
        - Most importantly, godly parents please the Lord and curry blessing for the entire family
- God brought Moses and his family to this point because it wasn't enough that Moses heard and responded to God's call
    - Nor was it enough that Moses relied on God's power to equip him for the task
        - Those things are important, but they're not enough
    - Moses also needed to conform his own life to God's commands and expectations
        - Moses had to demonstrate obedience in his own life before He could be useful to God in calling other men to obedience
    - Consider the irony had Moses gone to Pharaoh and to the Jewish people and demanded they keep God's commands, and all the while Moses was failing to keep the most basic of commandments in his day
        - What is your readiness to serve God in ministry?
        - We all have a calling to serve God in various places and in various ways
        - But our personal ministry as a disciple is our first and most powerful testimony, and it goes everywhere we go
            - It goes to the office, to school, to the ball field…
            - And certainly to the mission field
        - I believe many men find their opportunities in ministry restrained by God because of continuing disobedience

Ex. 4:27 Now the LORD said to Aaron, "Go to meet Moses in the wilderness." So he went and met him at the mountain of God and kissed him.
Ex. 4:28 Moses told Aaron all the words of the LORD with which He had sent him, and all the signs that He had commanded him to do.
Ex. 4:29 Then Moses and Aaron went and assembled all the elders of the sons of Israel;
Ex. 4:30 and Aaron spoke all the words which the LORD had spoken to Moses. He then performed the signs in the sight of the people.
Ex. 4:31 So the people believed; and when they heard that the LORD was concerned about the sons of Israel and that He had seen their affliction, then they bowed low and worshiped.

- We remember God assured Moses he would have Aaron's assistance
    - Now Moses tells how God brought Aaron to leave Egypt (how Aaron arranged to leave Egypt, we don't know)
        - Aaron reaches Moses in the desert at Mt. Sinai near the beginning of Moses' trip

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        - Moses greets Aaron and explains the whole story to him
        - From this point, Aaron becomes Moses' spokesman
    - They both travel to Egypt and assemble the elders of Israel
        - While in captivity (or because of their captivity), Israel maintained not only its identity but also its leadership structure
            - They had elders over the tribes, and the elders held authority over the people
            - The people followed their leaders' judgments
    - In this case, the leaders hear the testimony of Aaron and they see the miraculous signs Moses performs
        - Consequently, they're convinced Moses was sent by God
        - So they respond by declaring that God has visited His people, then they bow and worship God
- Here is a beautiful example of how we measure the success of our service
    - Moses went as God directed
        - He went to the people God directed
        - He went in the company of those God delivered
        - He took advantage of the gifts God provided
        - And he relied on the support God provided
    - And by these things, Moses prompted God's people to worship and praise God's name
        - The truest measure of our service to God is whether by that service we inspire others to worship and serve the Lord

Ex. 5:1 **And afterward Moses and Aaron came and said to Pharaoh, "Thus says the LORD, the God of Israel, 'Let My people go that they may celebrate a feast to Me in the wilderness.'"**
Ex. 5:2 **But Pharaoh said, "Who is the LORD that I should obey His voice to let Israel go? I do not know the LORD, and besides, I will not let Israel go."**
Ex. 5:3 **Then they said, "The God of the Hebrews has met with us. Please, let us go a three days' journey into the wilderness that we may sacrifice to the LORD our God, otherwise He will fall upon us with pestilence or with the sword."**
Ex. 5:4 **But the king of Egypt said to them, "Moses and Aaron, why do you draw the people away from their work? Get back to your labors!"**
Ex. 5:5 **Again Pharaoh said, "Look, the people of the land are now many, and you would have them cease from their labors!"**
Ex. 5:6 **So the same day Pharaoh commanded the taskmasters over the people and their foremen, saying,**
Ex. 5:7 **"You are no longer to give the people straw to make brick as previously;**

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let them go and gather straw for themselves.
Ex. 5:8 **"But the quota of bricks which they were making previously, you shall impose on them; you are not to reduce any of it. Because they are lazy, therefore they cry out, 'Let us go and sacrifice to our God.'**
Ex. 5:9 **"Let the labor be heavier on the men, and let them work at it so that they will pay no attention to false words."**

- In Chapter 5, Moses has his initial encounter with Pharaoh, Amenhotep II
  - Moses speaking through Aaron demands that Pharaoh let Israel go to the wilderness and celebrate a feast
    - This request was the one God directed Moses to deliver to Pharaoh
  - As we noted previously, Moses' request implied Israel was seeking to be set free
    - Asking to walk a three-days journey into the wilderness meant walking to the Egyptian border with Canaan
    - Imagine if the slaves of a Southern plantation in the U.S. had asked their master to allow them to travel to the Mason-Dixon line to worship the Lord
      - The slave master would have have understood he would never expect to see those slaves return
      - Similarly, the Pharaoh knew such a journey would mean the end of this plentiful pool of cheap labor
- Therefore, the Pharaoh's response to Moses and Aaron was entirely expected and logical
  - Pharaoh begins by declaring he has never heard of a god called Lord *("hayah")* and therefore, he has no need to obey such a God
    - No doubt this was true
    - Egypt had over 80 gods, but none were known by this name
  - After the Pharaoh's initial refusal, Aaron persists adding that the Jews were required to obey the Lord lest He bring judgment
    - Aaron explains that failure to obey the Lord brings the Lord's wrath and judgment
      - Interestingly, Moses was acutely aware of the relationship between disobedience and God's wrath as a result of failing to circumcise his son
    - Aaron's statement to Pharaoh is interesting, because it serves as a prophetic warning to Pharaoh himself
      - Pharaoh will experience the judgment of God for failure to comply
      - So not only does Pharaoh know God's will, but he also understands that failure to comply will bring judgment
- Pharaoh still denies Moses' request just as God said would happen
  - But what God didn't tell Moses was Pharaoh would react harshly to the request
    - Pharaoh brings a retribution against the Hebrews as a result of Moses' request

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        - Pharaoh commands that the Hebrews would no longer have straw provided to them for the making of bricks
    - Straw was the binding agent in clay bricks, and without straw, the bricks would be brittle and useless
        - Previously the Hebrews had straw provided to them, but now this would cease
        - The Hebrews would have to go throughout the land of Israel to collect their own straw
            - This required considerable time and effort, reducing the labor and time available to make bricks
            - Nevertheless, the daily quota for bricks remains the same
    - So Pharaoh's command makes life considerably harsher for the Jews
- Pharaoh's response is more than mere spite; there was political wisdom here
    - Pharaoh linked the Jews' harsh circumstances to Moses' actions
        - Pharaoh wanted the Jews to blame Moses for their situation
        - As a result, the people would then reject Moses and Aaron's leadership and refuse to follow them further
    - This is often the technique of despots trying to hold onto power
        - By setting their opponents against one another, the king can weaken the resolve of the opposition
        - This will be a challenge for Moses and Aaron

Ex. 5:10 So the taskmasters of the people and their foremen went out and spoke to the people, saying, "Thus says Pharaoh, 'I am not going to give you any straw.
Ex. 5:11 'You go and get straw for yourselves wherever you can find it, but none of your labor will be reduced.'"
Ex. 5:12 So the people scattered through all the land of Egypt to gather stubble for straw.
Ex. 5:13 The taskmasters pressed them, saying, "Complete your work quota, your daily amount, just as when you had straw."
Ex. 5:14 Moreover, the foremen of the sons of Israel, whom Pharaoh's taskmasters had set over them, were beaten and were asked, "Why have you not completed your required amount either yesterday or today in making brick as previously?"
Ex. 5:15 Then the foremen of the sons of Israel came and cried out to Pharaoh, saying, "Why do you deal this way with your servants?
Ex. 5:16 "There is no straw given to your servants, yet they keep saying to us, 'Make bricks!' And behold, your servants are being beaten; but it is the fault of your own people."
Ex. 5:17 But he said, "You are lazy, very lazy; therefore you say, 'Let us go and

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sacrifice to the LORD.'
Ex. 5:18 **"So go now and work; for you will be given no straw, yet you must deliver the quota of bricks."**
Ex. 5:19 **The foremen of the sons of Israel saw that they were in trouble because they were told, "You must not reduce your daily amount of bricks."**
Ex. 5:20 **When they left Pharaoh's presence, they met Moses and Aaron as they were waiting for them.**
Ex. 5:21 **They said to them, "May the LORD look upon you and judge you, for you have made us odious in Pharaoh's sight and in the sight of his servants, to put a sword in their hand to kill us."**
Ex. 5:22 **Then Moses returned to the LORD and said, "O Lord, why have You brought harm to this people? Why did You ever send me?**
Ex. 5:23 **"Ever since I came to Pharaoh to speak in Your name, he has done harm to this people, and You have not delivered Your people at all."**

- Egyptians had three levels of authority ruling over the Hebrew slaves
  - Officers, taskmasters, and foremen
    - The officers and taskmaster were Egyptians
    - The foremen, however, were Jews appointed to oversee the labors of their fellow slaves
  - The taskmaster and foremen delivered the bad news to the Jews: no more straw
    - Naturally, the extra work made it impossible for the Jews to meet the daily quota for bricks
    - As a result, the Egyptian taskmasters began beating the Jewish foremen
      - Not all Jews were beaten, but the foremen were as punishment for the Jews' failure to meet quota
  - To the foremen the new situation makes no sense, so they go to Pharaoh hoping to reason with him
    - They want to know why Pharaoh would make their job harder since it wasn't in Pharaoh's own interests to slow their work
  - Pharaoh gives them the reason for the harsh treatment
    - Moses' request to let the Jews go into the desert meant the slaves were lazy and had spare time
    - So Pharaoh places the blame at Moses' feet
- So the foremen fall for Pharaoh's trick, and they meet with Moses and Aaron
  - In v.21 they tell Moses and Aaron that God will judge them for bringing this outcome upon the people
    - The meeting disturbs Moses greatly, so he goes before the Lord and laments his situation

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        - Moses went expecting to bring a blessing and relief to the people
        - Instead, he sees that his work is bringing greater misery to the people and leading them to resent him for it
    - Furthermore, Moses begins to prejudge the outcome of God's work
        - In verse 23 Moses accuses God of not delivering the people as God promised
        - Isn't it remarkable how quickly Moses has lost his composure despite all the assurance and prophetic knowledge God gave Moses?
    - Moses assumed his arrival would mean great relief for Israel
        - He probably expected he would be met by cheering crowds hoisting him high on their shoulders, naming children after him
        - Instead, they're cursing his name
- God calls us to serve His people, but our service usually isn't intended to make peoples' lives easier, happy or more comfortable, at least not in this world
    - We may hope to bring a blessing to people through our service, but too often we equate "blessing" with physical or emotional comfort or some material benefit
        - But the Bible equates blessing with suffering, hardship, persecution, testing, trials and self-sacrifice
        - Those we serve or lead may not always like what God calls us to deliver, whether in what we say or call them to do, but don't let that distract you
            - Ministry isn't a popularity contest
- And our leaders bear the worst of this burden
    - They must serve as examples of these truths in their own lives and as those with the unenviable task of calling others to live likewise
        - Moses and Aaron can't make excuses for their words and actions
        - Nor can they remove these burdens from the people
        - They can't soften the message or back down from God's calling
            - What is happening is according to God's will
    - Unfortunately, some leaders choose the easy path with their people
        - Rather than declaring the reality of sin and the need to crucify the flesh, they tickle ears with teaching that pleases the flesh
        - Rather than demanding we each walk according to the faith we have been given, we make excuses for sin and create exceptions for every commandment in Scripture
        - When we make the spiritual walk of those we lead easier beyond what God permits, we do them a serious disservice
            - And we bring the prospect of judgment upon ourselves

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- Moses has experienced his first confrontation with Pharaoh, and the result was greater misery and hardship for Israel
  - God's purpose in the encounter was to steel Moses and Aaron for what follows
    - This won't be easy, it will be complicated, but it will come to pass as God has promised
  - Meanwhile, it also caused the Israelites to grumble against Moses and his leadership
    - That too was training for Moses, because there is a lot more of that grumbling coming
- Now we see God roll up His sleeves and begin the work of freeing Israel
  - But first, God wants Moses to understand the privilege it is for Moses to see God working in this way

Ex. 6:1 **Then the LORD said to Moses, "Now you shall see what I will do to Pharaoh; for under compulsion he will let them go, and under compulsion he will drive them out of his land."**
Ex. 6:2 **God spoke further to Moses and said to him, "I am the LORD;**
Ex. 6:3 **and I appeared to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, as God Almighty, but by My name, LORD, I did not make Myself known to them.**
Ex. 6:4 **"I also established My covenant with them, to give them the land of Canaan, the land in which they sojourned.**
Ex. 6:5 **"Furthermore I have heard the groaning of the sons of Israel, because the Egyptians are holding them in bondage, and I have remembered My covenant.**
Ex. 6:6 **"Say, therefore, to the sons of Israel, 'I am the LORD, and I will bring you out from under the burdens of the Egyptians, and I will deliver you from their bondage. I will also redeem you with an outstretched arm and with great judgments.**
Ex. 6:7 **'Then I will take you for My people, and I will be your God; and you shall know that I am the LORD your God, who brought you out from under the burdens of the Egyptians.**
Ex. 6:8 **'I will bring you to the land which I swore to give to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, and I will give it to you for a possession; I am the LORD.'"**
Ex. 6:9 **So Moses spoke thus to the sons of Israel, but they did not listen to Moses on account of their despondency and cruel bondage.**

- The Lord announces to Moses that He will cause Moses to set Israel free from the land
  - In fact, Pharaoh will actually drive Israel out of the land
    - He will do so out of compulsion
    - The Lord will create the motivation for Pharaoh to do this
      - But as we noted last week, the Lord will ensure that Pharaoh hesitates until the last judgment is finished

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        - It's as if Pharaoh is a rubber band the Lord wants to stretch to the furthest extent possible before releasing the tension
        - And with that release, Israel is launched out of the land
    - In vs.6-8 comes an important set of verses theologically
        - In v.2 God repeats His name to Moses
        - He says I am Who I am (*hayah*)
            - Or as we have it translated, Lord or Jehovah
            - God gives Moses His personal name, which God chose to associate with His work to free Israel
- When God appeared to Moses to announce the plan to free Israel, God told Moses to declare that the God, I AM, has come to keep His promise to Israel
    - Forevermore, the God Jehovah will be known as a covenant keeping God
        - God wants His personal name to identify God as a covenant keeper
        - But God tells Moses that He did not make Himself known to the patriarchs in the same way that He is now prepared to reveal Himself to Moses and Israel
    - When God says He didn't make Himself known to the patriarchs as Jehovah, He doesn't mean that the patriarchs didn't know that name
        - On the contrary, they did know His personal name
        - We can find times in Genesis where the patriarchs use the name Jehovah as they speak to God
        - God meant that the patriarchs didn't experience the Lord in the same way Moses and Israel will now know Him
        - In the time of the patriarchs, God was known as a covenant-making God, El Shaddai, God Almighty
            - That name implied God was capable of doing what He promised
    - In v.4 the Lord reminds Moses that He also established His covenant with the patriarchs, just as God has made promises to Moses
        - Those promises stipulated that God would bring Israel into the land of Canaan after a period of slavery
        - But the patriarchs never saw these promises fulfilled
        - They knew God as a promise making God, but they never had the opportunity to know Him as a promise-keeping God
            - They knew God in a limited way in the sense that they couldn't see the promises kept
            - Ultimately, the patriarchs will all experience God's faithfulness fully in the Kingdom, when all God's promises are fully met
- Then God brings Moses the fullest understanding of God's plan for His people
    - In vs.6-8 God delivers seven "I will's" to Moses

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        - Taken together, these seven statements declare God's full program for Israel in the Exodus
        - First, God will redeem Israel out of Egypt and out of bondage with great judgments
        - Second, God will make Israel a people for Himself
        - Third, God will bring them into the land He promised them
    - These statements are the fulfillment of God's promises and a demonstration of His covenant keeping character
        - But these statements have much greater, farther reaching consequences than merely the Exodus story
        - They are prophetic of a later period of promise keeping
    - Each of these I WILLs are lessor examples of a much greater redemption God will work for the sake of Israel in a future day
        - First, God will redeem Israel out of Egypt
            - Egypt in scripture is a common symbol for the Gentile world
        - Then God will remove Israel from bondage
            - Physical bondage is commonly a picture in Scripture for spiritual bondage
            - Paul says we are either a slave to sin or a slave to Christ
            - Israel's physical bondage in Egypt becomes a picture, therefore, of Israel's spiritual bondage to sin
        - Third, God will deliver Israel into the land He promised them
            - This land will be the inheritance God gave Israel
            - But the writer of Hebrews tells us that the rest Israel entered under Joshua wasn't the ultimate fulfillment of God's promised rest
            - So there remains a future day when Israel's rest will be fully realized in a greater sense and a greater place
        - Finally, all of this will happen in concert with great judgments
- Taken together these statements are speaking of the day God brings a glorified Israel into the Kingdom
    - Ezekiel describes that day

Ezek. 36:22 "Therefore say to the house of Israel, 'Thus says the Lord GOD, "It is not for your sake, O house of Israel, that I am about to act, but for My holy name, which you have profaned among the nations where you went.
Ezek. 36:23 "I will vindicate the holiness of My great name which has been profaned among the nations, which you have profaned in their midst. Then the nations will know that I am the LORD," declares the Lord GOD, "when I prove Myself holy among you in their sight.
Ezek. 36:24 "For I will take you from the nations, gather you from all the lands and

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bring you into your own land.
Ezek. 36:25 **"Then I will sprinkle clean water on you, and you will be clean; I will cleanse you from all your filthiness and from all your idols.**
Ezek. 36:26 **"Moreover, I will give you a new heart and put a new spirit within you; and I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh.**
Ezek. 36:27 **"I will put My Spirit within you and cause you to walk in My statutes, and you will be careful to observe My ordinances.**
Ezek. 36:28 **"You will live in the land that I gave to your forefathers; so you will be My people, and I will be your God.**

- First, God will regather Israel out of the nations of the world
  - And He will bring them into the Land
  - Once there, God will give the nation of Israel a new heart, sprinkled clean by the Spirit
  - And by this new heart, the nation will become fully obedient to the Law of God… glorified, in other words
- Clearly, these events are in our future, and they represent a much greater fulfillment of the things God is doing here in Exodus
  - In fact, the Exodus story was orchestrated by God precisely for the purpose of creating this foreshadowing

Ezek. 20:33 **"As I live," declares the Lord GOD, "surely with a mighty hand and with an outstretched arm and with wrath poured out, I shall be king over you.**
Ezek. 20:34 **"I will bring you out from the peoples and gather you from the lands where you are scattered, with a mighty hand and with an outstretched arm and with wrath poured out;**
Ezek. 20:35 **and I will bring you into the wilderness of the peoples, and there I will enter into judgment with you face to face.**
Ezek. 20:36 **"As I entered into judgment with your fathers in the wilderness of the land of Egypt, so I will enter into judgment with you," declares the Lord GOD.**
Ezek. 20:37 **"I will make you pass under the rod, and I will bring you into the bond of the covenant;**
Ezek. 20:38 **and I will purge from you the rebels and those who transgress against Me; I will bring them out of the land where they sojourn, but they will not enter the land of Israel. Thus you will know that I am the LORD.**

- Notice the similarity in the language between the promise to redeem Israel in Exodus and the promise to perform a greater redemption in the future?
  - We are watching the picture God created in the lives of Moses and Israel to foreshadow an even greater delivery still to come

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- And the great judgments of the Exodus are foreshadows of the judgments of Tribulation
  - In both cases, the judgments precede the release of Israel from bondage and their worship of God at a mountain
  - In the case of Exodus, the mountain is Horeb and they worship in the context of Law
  - In the second, greater example, the mountain is Zion in the Kingdom and the worship will be in the context of grace

- In v.7 God finishes the I WILLs declaring that Israel will be His people and the whole nation will know Him
  - This too is a prophetic reference to a future deliverance

Jer. 31:31 "Behold, days are coming," declares the LORD, "when I will make a new covenant with the house of Israel and with the house of Judah,
Jer. 31:32 not like the covenant which I made with their fathers in the day I took them by the hand to bring them out of the land of Egypt, My covenant which they broke, although I was a husband to them," declares the LORD.
Jer. 31:33 "But this is the covenant which I will make with the house of Israel after those days," declares the LORD, "I will put My law within them and on their heart I will write it; and I will be their God, and they shall be My people.
Jer. 31:34 "They will not teach again, each man his neighbor and each man his brother, saying, 'Know the LORD,' for they will all know Me, from the least of them to the greatest of them," declares the LORD, "for I will forgive their iniquity, and their sin I will remember no more."

- In these opening verses of Chapter 6, God is telling Moses that you are about to see something your ancestors never experienced
  - You will know a God of power and faithfulness delivering on His promises
    - But even then, Moses is only seeing a part of that faithfulness
    - There will be an even greater display of God's faithfulness to Israel in the future made known in Christ
  - As church saints, we have already received that greater revelation of God's faithfulness
    - By our own faith and the indwelling of the Spirit, we have proof in our own life of God as a promises-keeping God
    - Yet we too have even more to see in a future day when Christ comes for us
  - This is why the writer of Hebrews can say:

Heb. 1:1 God, after He spoke long ago to the fathers in the prophets in many portions and in many ways,

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Heb. 1:2 **in these last days has spoken to us in His Son, whom He appointed heir of all things, through whom also He made the world.**

- We have gained far more than Moses ever knew, even having seen the miracles
- The Bible tells us that our present experience is a greater revelation than anything God gave those who came before us
- If offered the chance, the Old Testament saints would have traded what they received for the chance to know the Messiah in the way we do
- Finally, Moses tells all this to Israel, in v.9
  - But naturally, they don't listen to him
  - They are so despondent as a result of their circumstances, they can't consider these important issues
    - Who could blame them at this point
- Now God repeats His previous instructions to Moses

Ex. 6:10 **Now the LORD spoke to Moses, saying,**
Ex. 6:11 **"Go, tell Pharaoh king of Egypt to let the sons of Israel go out of his land."**
Ex. 6:12 **But Moses spoke before the LORD, saying, "Behold, the sons of Israel have not listened to me; how then will Pharaoh listen to me, for I am unskilled in speech?"**
Ex. 6:13 **Then the LORD spoke to Moses and to Aaron, and gave them a charge to the sons of Israel and to Pharaoh king of Egypt, to bring the sons of Israel out of the land of Egypt.**

- Moses once again starts to doubt his abilities to accomplish the task facing him
  - He is back to assuming the success of this mission depends on him
    - Moses complains that if the Israelites haven't listened to him, how would he expect to influence Pharaoh
    - In v.12 Moses uses a graphic description to explain his weakness
      - My English version says "I am unskilled in speech"
      - But in Hebrew it literally says I am a man of uncircumcised lips
      - He literally means he speaks as if he has a layer of skin enclosed over his mouth
      - I watched the movie pretty closely, and I'm pretty sure Charlton Heston's make-up artist overlooked that detail
  - From the sound of it, Moses is simply incapable of performing this task
    - But God will still succeed, because God has chosen to work through Moses and Aaron

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- And this leads Moses to provide his own genealogy
  - The timing of the genealogy is important
  - At the point where God is preparing to begin His work of judgment in Egypt, Moses establishes he and Aaron are men called by God

Ex. 6:14 These are the heads of their fathers' households. The sons of Reuben, Israel's firstborn: Hanoch and Pallu, Hezron and Carmi; these are the families of Reuben.
Ex. 6:15 The sons of Simeon: Jemuel and Jamin and Ohad and Jachin and Zohar and Shaul the son of a Canaanite woman; these are the families of Simeon.
Ex. 6:16 These are the names of the sons of Levi according to their generations: Gershon and Kohath and Merari; and the length of Levi's life was one hundred and thirty-seven years.
Ex. 6:17 The sons of Gershon: Libni and Shimei, according to their families.
Ex. 6:18 The sons of Kohath: Amram and Izhar and Hebron and Uzziel; and the length of Kohath's life was one hundred and thirty-three years.
Ex. 6:19 The sons of Merari: Mahli and Mushi. These are the families of the Levites according to their generations.
Ex. 6:20 Amram married his father's sister Jochebed, and she bore him Aaron and Moses; and the length of Amram's life was one hundred and thirty-seven years.
Ex. 6:21 The sons of Izhar: Korah and Nepheg and Zichri.
Ex. 6:22 The sons of Uzziel: Mishael and Elzaphan and Sithri.
Ex. 6:23 Aaron married Elisheba, the daughter of Amminadab, the sister of Nahshon, and she bore him Nadab and Abihu, Eleazar and Ithamar.
Ex. 6:24 The sons of Korah: Assir and Elkanah and Abiasaph; these are the families of the Korahites.
Ex. 6:25 Aaron's son Eleazar married one of the daughters of Putiel, and she bore him Phinehas. These are the heads of the fathers' households of the Levites according to their families.
Ex. 6:26 It was the same Aaron and Moses to whom the LORD said, "Bring out the sons of Israel from the land of Egypt according to their hosts."
Ex. 6:27 They were the ones who spoke to Pharaoh king of Egypt about bringing out the sons of Israel from Egypt; it was the same Moses and Aaron.

- We can make a few observations concerning this genealogy, beginning with the final verse
  - Moses says his purpose in giving this record was to establish conclusively for Israel that Aaron and Moses had authority and standing to act as God's representative
    - They were Jews who descended from the families that came to Egypt with Jacob
    - As such, they were eligible to share in the promises of God

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        - And in centuries to come, the names Moses and Aaron would be uniquely associated with this event and this call
    - Though Israel wouldn't listen to Moses in his own day, nevertheless Scripture properly records that Moses and Aaron were the legitimate representatives chosen by God
- Moses begins the genealogy where his last genealogy of Genesis ended, the line of Jacob's sons
    - Among the sons of Jacob, Moses traces the first four only
        - He is connecting the dots to Levi, and once he reaches Levi, he stops
        - Now Moses moves down the family tree toward himself
- Now in Chapter 7, God answers Moses' concerns once again

Ex. 7:1 **Then the LORD said to Moses, "See, I make you as God to Pharaoh, and your brother Aaron shall be your prophet.**
Ex. 7:2 **"You shall speak all that I command you, and your brother Aaron shall speak to Pharaoh that he let the sons of Israel go out of his land.**
Ex. 7:3 **"But I will harden Pharaoh's heart that I may multiply My signs and My wonders in the land of Egypt.**
Ex. 7:4 **"When Pharaoh does not listen to you, then I will lay My hand on Egypt and bring out My hosts, My people the sons of Israel, from the land of Egypt by great judgments.**
Ex. 7:5 **"The Egyptians shall know that I am the LORD, when I stretch out My hand on Egypt and bring out the sons of Israel from their midst."**
Ex. 7:6 **So Moses and Aaron did it; as the LORD commanded them, thus they did.**
Ex. 7:7 **Moses was eighty years old and Aaron eighty-three, when they spoke to Pharaoh.**

- As He has said before, God reminds Moses that Moses does not need to speak (at least not much)
    - God will deliver instructions to Moses, but not to Aaron
        - Then as Moses retransmits those instructions to Aaron, Moses acts in the place of God for Aaron
            - That's the meaning of the phrase "I make you as if God"
        - Then Aaron will act as Moses' (and God's) prophet to Pharaoh
        - In this way, Moses says everything God says, and Aaron says everything that Moses says
            - This little arrangement saves Moses from having to speak, since this is a weakness for Moses
    - We've heard this plan before, but each time it's repeated, it's still fascinating

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        - Wouldn't it have been simpler to work through Aaron alone?
            - Why the two-step process of representation?
            - I believe God is establishing a pattern for Israel that begins here and continues throughout their existence
        - God will raise up leaders in Israel and prophets
            - Leaders will be elders, judges and kings
            - But these men will be distinct from prophets, who come bearing the words of God
        - Until this point, God had never established either role
            - This marks a transition from patriarchal rule (or the dispensation of patriarchs) to the dispensation of Law
            - In the new period of God's economy, men will receive God's word as instructions for living and serving Him
            - And other men will rule over Israel according to that word
        - Here we see the beginnings of that pattern
- God also reminds Moses that Pharaoh's heart will be hardened against his words
    - Notice again the source of the hardening: God Himself
        - In the early stages of the confrontation, Pharaoh won't need God's hardening, because Pharaoh himself is predisposed to reject Moses' request
        - But when the plagues begin to wear down Pharaoh's resolve (at about plague 5), God steps in to harden Pharaoh's heart further
        - This will ensure Pharaoh continues to say no to Moses until the very end of the plagues
    - The effect of God's plan is to magnify His glory in the end
        - In v.5 God declares that in this way, all Egypt will know the living God
        - They will know this truth not only because Israel is set free but also because of the judgments themselves
    - It's important to note that Egypt is not going to believe in the word of the Lord so as to be saved
        - God is simply saying that they will recognize the truth of God but without saving faith as a result
        - Similar to the way James says that demons can know about God

James 2:19 **You believe that God is one. You do well; the demons also believe, and shudder.**

- The Egyptians will be forced to acknowledge that the God of Israel is the true God
- But this acknowledgement is not the same thing as saving faith

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- God's intent is that every tongue will confess and every knee shall bow at the name of Jesus
  - But that moment doesn't produce universal salvation
  - Only those who make that acknowledgement on the basis of faith in this life will receive His mercy
- This section provides yet another shadow of the end times deliverance of Israel
  - If you have studied through our Revelation study, then this connection will be easy to see
    - Once again, Egypt represents the world that experiences God's wrath in Tribulation
    - And in the last day of Tribulation, as God brings the judgments of Tribulation to conclusion, the world will acknowledge God
    - But they will fail to believe so as to be saved

Rev. 9:20 **The rest of mankind, who were not killed by these plagues, did not repent of the works of their hands, so as not to worship demons, and the idols of gold and of silver and of brass and of stone and of wood, which can neither see nor hear nor walk;**
Rev. 9:21 **and they did not repent of their murders nor of their sorceries nor of their immorality nor of their thefts.**

- Lastly, we're given the ages of Moses and Aaron at the time the plagues begin
  - Moses was 80 and Aaron was his older brother at 83
  - Scripture gives ages to help us track the passage of events accurately
  - And it notes significant moments in a person's life, as when a child is born
- Now it's time for Moses to confront Pharaoh and display one of the miracles God gave to Moses, the miracle of the staff becoming a snake

Ex. 7:8 **Now the LORD spoke to Moses and Aaron, saying,**
Ex. 7:9 **"When Pharaoh speaks to you, saying, 'Work a miracle,' then you shall say to Aaron, 'Take your staff and throw it down before Pharaoh, that it may become a serpent.'"**
Ex. 7:10 **So Moses and Aaron came to Pharaoh, and thus they did just as the LORD had commanded; and Aaron threw his staff down before Pharaoh and his servants, and it became a serpent.**
Ex. 7:11 **Then Pharaoh also called for the wise men and the sorcerers, and they also, the magicians of Egypt, did the same with their secret arts.**
Ex. 7:12 **For each one threw down his staff and they turned into serpents. But Aaron's staff swallowed up their staffs.**
Ex. 7:13 **Yet Pharaoh's heart was hardened, and he did not listen to them, as the**

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LORD had said.

- God tells Moses that Pharaoh will ask him to work a miracle
  - When this happens, Moses is to use the serpent miracle God gave him
    - It was common in the ancient world for men to demand proof of an oracle's legitimacy in the form of miracles
      - We see this same pattern even in the time of Jesus
      - The people expect Jesus to perform miracles to validate His claims as Messiah
      - Often times Jesus obliged to prove His claims
    - God tells Moses to expect the same request and to honor it with the miracle God gave him for this purpose
  - God knows what Pharaoh will say, and so God has already given Moses the tools to respond
    - This is further proof of God's equipping power
    - Based on this clear example from Exodus, two things are abundantly clear
      - First, men spend way too much time worrying about our abilities to get the job done for God
        - That worry just gets in the way of our obedience
      - Secondly, all that worry is unnecessary because God is always going to equip us for the work He gives us
    - God has even prepared Moses with a miracle specially suited to meet the request of Pharaoh
- As Moses and Aaron came to Pharaoh, they perform the miracle as directed
  - Moses' staff miraculously becomes a snake
    - Rather than become flustered, Pharaoh simply calls for his wise men and sorcerers and magicians
      - These men practice the occult, the dark arts
      - These men are similar to those who served in Nebuchadnezzar's court in Babylon
    - The text says in v.11 that these men performed "the same" as Moses using their secret arts
  - Based on the text, there is no hint that these events are parlor tricks or gimmicks
    - In both cases, the appearance of the serpent is a real event, a real miracle
    - The magicians' snakes are no less real than Moses'
      - Verse 11 tells us they were the same
  - This moment proves that miraculous signs and wonders are not unique to God

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        - Satan has supernatural power as well, and he displays it here through the work of these magicians
        - Obviously, all power extends from God, so Satan's power to perform these miracles is a power God gave Satan
            - Furthermore, God is permitting Satan to work in this way for the time being
- The very fact that Satan can counterfeit God's work through signs and miracles is proof to us that we cannot form our understanding of truth on the basis of such things
    - Powers and miracles are not conclusive evidence of truth unless the message they support is in agreement with Scripture
        - The testimony of a prophet must comport with the overall testimony of Scripture, otherwise they are to be dismissed
    - At the core of this issue is the difference between experiential truth and expositional truth
        - Experiential truth is any experience that teaches a spiritual truth
            - The moment of Pentecost was experiential truth for those who experienced it
        - Expositional truth is the truth revealed by the word of God
            - God's word is truth to all who learn it
            - The Bible itself teaches that expositional truth always trumps experiential truth

Matt. 24:35 **"Heaven and earth will pass away, but My words will not pass away.**

- If our experiences (e.g., feelings, thoughts, things we hear or events we witness) conflict with the word of God, then those experiences are not valid truth
    - For example, if we had witnessed this scene in Pharaoh's court, and if we relied entirely on experiential truth, we might conclude that God and Satan have equal power
    - But by the word of God, we know this is not true
        - Satan is not equal to God and cannot prevail
- We can have confidence that God will preserve His word in an accurate way because it is the pre-eminent source of truth in Creation
    - In fact, this scene gives us additional proof of the trustworthiness of Scripture, as handed down through the centuries within the Jewish nation
        - Moses never names the magicians who performed these miracles in Pharaoh's court
        - But as this story was told and retold in Jewish families through the centuries after Moses, the names of these men were preserved
        - Such that thousands of years later, Paul knew these names and recorded them in New Testament scripture

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2Tim. 3:6 For among them are those who enter into households and captivate weak women weighed down with sins, led on by various impulses,
2Tim. 3:7 always learning and never able to come to the knowledge of the truth.
2Tim. 3:8 Just as Jannes and Jambres opposed Moses, so these men also oppose the truth, men of depraved mind, rejected in regard to the faith.
2Tim. 3:9 But they will not make further progress; for their folly will be obvious to all, just as Jannes's and Jambres's folly was also.

- Notice that Paul names the magicians who performed in Pharaoh's court
  - They were Jannes and Jambres, men who opposed Moses
  - These names were preserved in Jewish tradition and validated when Paul included them in scripture under the inspiration of the Spirit
  - The point being that these two names were preserved accurately in Jewish tradition for centuries though Moses never recorded them
    - Therefore, it's all the more certain that God's word in written form was preserved accurately by the scribes of Israel
    - This word is God's word
- Here again we have a picture of the last days and the deliverance of the Jews during Tribulation
  - In that future time, Paul tells us that Satan will deceive the entire world with signs and wonders, seemingly equal to God

2Th. 2:8 Then that lawless one will be revealed whom the Lord will slay with the breath of His mouth and bring to an end by the appearance of His coming;
2Th. 2:9 that is, the one whose coming is in accord with the activity of Satan, with all power and signs and false wonders,
2Th. 2:10 and with all the deception of wickedness for those who perish, because they did not receive the love of the truth so as to be saved.

- Also, note Paul's purpose in mentioning these two men to Timothy
  - Paul uses them as examples of how the enemy can use deception and wonders to gain a foothold among weak Christians
    - They are men of depraved mind and without faith (rejected by God)
    - Paul says these deceivers will not win in the end, but they will fool some people
  - They prey on the weak
    - And they deceive people who are weighed down by sin and seek for some greater experience beyond the word of God
    - Like those Hebrews mentions

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Heb. 5:13 For everyone who partakes only of milk is not accustomed to the word of righteousness, for he is an infant.
Heb. 5:14 But solid food is for the mature, who because of practice have their senses trained to discern good and evil.

- At this point, God gives a demonstration of the superiority of His power by making his snake swallow the snakes of the magicians
  - The whole scene must have been a bit bizarre, but it made the point to Pharaoh and the court
    - Nevertheless, Pharaoh felt no reason to comply with Moses' directive
    - Even had he been willing to acknowledge that Moses had power greater than his magicians, it didn't force Pharaoh to comply
  - So this miracle sets the stage for the coming plagues
- So now we're ready to begin studying the famous plagues of Egypt
  - Tonight, we'll start with an introduction to the plagues
  - First, these events are most properly called judgments, not plagues
    - Each of the ten events is a specific judgment delivered by God
  - Secondly, these judgments are targeted at achieving three outcomes
    - To free Israel
    - To punish Egypt
    - To condemn Egyptian idolatry
    - The first two reasons are clear enough from what we've already read
      - God has said repeatedly that He is acting to free Israel and punish Pharaoh for his stubbornness
    - The third reason takes some additional study to discover
  - When God prepares the tenth judgment, He says this to Moses

Ex. 12:12 'For I will go through the land of Egypt on that night, and will strike down all the firstborn in the land of Egypt, both man and beast; and against all the gods of Egypt I will execute judgments — I am the LORD.

- Notice God says He is working to judge the gods of Egypt
- Later in Numbers, Moses records this:

Num. 33:3 They journeyed from Rameses in the first month, on the fifteenth day of the first month; on the next day after the Passover the sons of Israel started out boldly in the sight of all the Egyptians,
Num. 33:4 while the Egyptians were burying all their firstborn whom the LORD had

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struck down among them. The LORD had also executed judgments on their gods.

- As Israel leaves Egypt, Moses notes that these judgments were executed upon Egypt's gods
- So these judgments are crafted in such a way that they expose the true nature of Egypt's gods – that they are not real gods after all
    - Each judgment takes a specific form that is designed to assault a set of Egyptian gods associated with that judgment
    - As we go through the judgments, we will connect each judgment to a god or gods of Egypt
        - The Egyptians themselves would have no choice but to take note of this connection
        - They will see each plague cutting to the heart of something they worshipped, thereby displaying that thing to be powerless in the face of God's power
- The next thing to note about the judgments is their orderliness
    - God is a God of order
        - Every detail about these events is crafted like pieces in a puzzle
        - In that way, God's wisdom and power and purposes are made evident
    - The judgments follow multiple patterns
    - The judgments themselves can been grouped into three groups of three
        - With the tenth plague standing by itself at the end
            - The number 9 is the number for judgment in Scripture
            - While the number ten is the number of testimony
    - They use natural phenomenon that have been intensified to an extreme degree
        - None of the plagues themselves are unprecedented by their nature
        - But in their intensity, they are unprecedented
        - The Egyptians worshipped gods that represented the creation, so God uses the creation to harm Egypt
    - They come by the hand of different actors
        - The first three come by Aaron
        - The second three come by God acting alone
        - The final three come by Moses
    - Some of the judgment include advanced warning
        - The warnings come in a specific pattern as well
        - The first two judgments of each group have warnings
        - The first warning of every group always comes in the morning, signaling a new

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series is starting

- The first two plagues are mimicked by the Egyptian magicians
  - As a result, they impact everyone, including the Jews
  - God's judgments are not impacting the Jews, but when the sorcerers get into the act, their work impacts the Jews
  - This reminds us that though God is not bringing judgment against His people, the enemy's response will produce collateral damage
    - We see a similar pattern in Tribulation, where the Lord brings judgments against the world and then Satan responds by persecuting the believers
  - After the first two plagues, the magicians cease copying God, and then the remaining plagues only impact Egypt
    - This is an example of the principle Peter teaches:

2Pet. 2:9 then the Lord knows how to rescue the godly from temptation, and to keep the unrighteous under punishment for the day of judgment,

- The next pattern to note is that these plagues increase in severity by group
  - The first three are called loathsome by scripture
    - This means detestable or revolting
    - The Egyptians were greatly disturbed by them, but they themselves weren't impacted directly
    - After they end, all returns to normal
  - The second group are painful
    - They inflict discomfort against the Egyptian people
    - A more serious outcome
  - Finally, the last three are grievous and intensely destructive
    - They exceed anything before
    - They leave a lasting impact
- Altogether, these judgments require 6 months of time to play out, so this is not a quick experience
  - Next time we will begin to examine the plagues in groups

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- Tonight, we'll study the first nine judgments that the Lord visits upon Egypt
  - That will be followed next time with an in-depth study of the tenth judgment
  - In studying the first nine judgments, we'll use a simple pattern
    - We'll review the form of each judgment
    - We'll note any unique details of each judgment
    - We'll consider the way in which each judgment undermined the Egyptians' faith in their false gods
    - And on occasion we'll highlight significant issues or prophetic aspects of the events
  - And remember the orderliness we discussed last week
    - The plagues run in groups of three
    - The first two of each group come with warnings

Ex. 7:13 Yet Pharaoh's heart was hardened, and he did not listen to them, as the LORD had said.
Ex. 7:14 Then the LORD said to Moses, "Pharaoh's heart is stubborn; he refuses to let the people go.
Ex. 7:15 "Go to Pharaoh in the morning as he is going out to the water, and station yourself to meet him on the bank of the Nile; and you shall take in your hand the staff that was turned into a serpent.
Ex. 7:16 " You shall say to him, 'The LORD, the God of the Hebrews, sent me to you, saying, "Let My people go, that they may serve Me in the wilderness. But behold, you have not listened until now."
Ex. 7:17 'Thus says the LORD, "By this you shall know that I am the LORD: behold, I will strike the water that is in the Nile with the staff that is in my hand, and it will be turned to blood.
Ex. 7:18 "The fish that are in the Nile will die, and the Nile will become foul, and the Egyptians will find difficulty in drinking water from the Nile."'"
Ex. 7:19 Then the LORD said to Moses, "Say to Aaron, 'Take your staff and stretch out your hand over the waters of Egypt, over their rivers, over their streams, and over their pools, and over all their reservoirs of water, that they may become blood; and there will be blood throughout all the land of Egypt, both in vessels of wood and in vessels of stone.'"
Ex. 7:20 So Moses and Aaron did even as the LORD had commanded. And he lifted up the staff and struck the water that was in the Nile, in the sight of Pharaoh and in the sight of his servants, and all the water that was in the Nile was turned to blood.
Ex. 7:21 The fish that were in the Nile died, and the Nile became foul, so that the Egyptians could not drink water from the Nile. And the blood was through all the land of Egypt.

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Ex. 7:22 But the magicians of Egypt did the same with their secret arts; and Pharaoh's heart was hardened, and he did not listen to them, as the LORD had said.
Ex. 7:23 Then Pharaoh turned and went into his house with no concern even for this.
Ex. 7:24 So all the Egyptians dug around the Nile for water to drink, for they could not drink of the water of the Nile.
Ex. 7:25 Seven days passed after the LORD had struck the Nile.

- The first judgment is the plague of blood
  - Since this is the first plague in the series of three, the warning comes in the morning
    - God tells Moses to go before Pharaoh while he is at the water in the morning
    - Meeting him at the bank, announce that his stubbornness will now result in God's judgment
  - Specifically, Aaron will announce that the God of the Hebrews has declared that they be let go, but since Pharaoh refused, all water will become blood
    - All water in Egypt will be turned into blood
      - All rivers, all storage containers
    - And vessels of wood and stone
      - These terms refer to bowls used in pagan religious ceremonies
      - So that Egypt's religious practices are impacted as well
  - And blood instantly makes life in the water die off
    - The fish die, and men cannot drink it
    - Plus, blood will begin to spoil almost immediately, causing the waters to be foul and smell badly
- In v.24, we read that the Egyptians were finally able to find some water to drink by digging for it
  - The water under the land had not been polluted
    - Only the surface water had been polluted
    - But then the magicians get into the act
  - The magicians are called by Pharaoh to offer a response to Moses' act
    - Like they did with the snake, the magicians are able to accomplish the same outcome
      - The water they turn to blood was likely the new water sources that the Egyptians uncovered in their rush to find new water
    - Pharaoh might have expected the magicians to act against Moses' work, so as to return the blood to water
      - But the best they could do was add more blood to the problem

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        - I'm sure they appreciated the magician's helpful work!
    - The magicians were working their secret arts, which means working with power Satan gave them as they worshipped the enemy
        - Satan has power to counterfeit God's work, even to the point of making water turn to blood
            - But Satan's power is limited in that he cannot undo the work of God
            - And he cannot do more than God created him to do
                - Just as we cannot do more than God created us to do
        - Therefore, Satan acts by watching God and mimicking in a false way what he sees God doing
            - Remember, Satan wants to be God, so it only makes sense that his method of operating is to imitate God
        - In the end times judgments, we'll see Satan doing similar things
            - He will bring a false Christ, a false prophet and false miracles
            - Each will be a replica of something God has done earlier, but his imitations are corrupt and nothing but lies
- Blood judgment mirrors one of the judgments in the Tribulation period
    - In fact, we can find parallels for the first nine judgments within the events of Tribulation
        - Some have a direct connection like the blood judgment
        - Others are implied
            - We'll point out these connections with each judgment
            - But the main point is that this period of judgment is a foreshadowing of the Tribulation
    - Like we taught in an earlier week, the ten plagues eventually result in Israel set free from bondage, worshipping at the mountain of God and entering into the promised land
        - This earlier event set in place the pictures and representations of God at work
        - For the effect that the future generation of Israel who will experience the Tribulation will see the pattern and come to understand God's purposes
- Moses says this plague lasts seven days
    - Men can live up to seven days without fresh water
        - But perhaps some Egyptians died as a result of this waiting
        - By and large, however, the judgment was less about destroying life than it was to serve as a warning and example of what will follow
        - The point was to show Egypt and Israel Who was God
    - To that point, let's note which Egyptian gods were mocked by this judgment
        - Nile River

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- Khnum – guardian of the Nile source
- Hapi – the Spirit of the Nile
- Osiris – guardian of the underworld and the Nile was his blood stream
- Sepek – Crocodile god
- Neith – Lapes fish protector
- Hathor – Chromis fish protector

- Altogether, this judgment has made Egypt question the power of their gods when the Hebrew God was able to render them useless
  - This lesson is also supposed to impress upon Israel the strength of their God
  - Don't underestimate the impact of these judgments on Israel as well
    - This judgment impacted them as well, especially since the magicians counterfeited the miracle
    - But until this moment, the Jews had never seen their God at work
    - Entire generations had come and gone without knowing the power of God
  - In fact, only the patriarchs had seen God at work, and on occasion their enemies did as well
    - Furthermore, there is no written scripture
    - No graven images, no statuettes
    - The Jews have only their very existence to validate the truth of God
      - They are a people called by God and created from Abraham's loins
      - And here they are now seeing this God at work for the first time
- So these ten judgments are intended for Egypt and the world, but their most lasting impact will be on the conscience of Israel
  - Now we see more reason for God hardening Pharaoh's heart
  - He desires for Israel to know Him in a way they have never known before
    - And this revelation of God will produce a lasting, permanent mark on the psyche of Israel
    - Never again will the nation fail to understand the God they worship
    - These miracles including those at the mountain and those that occur in the desert will create that lasting impression
  - If you want to understand how unique this work of God truly is, consider that God has only worked this way during three times in history
    - Beside the time of Exodus, God has performed dramatic miracles on a widespread basis only twice more
      - During the ministry of Elijah and Elisha
      - And in the time of Jesus and the Apostles
    - Apart from these three times, God has never resorted to a widespread use

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of miracles to make an impression

- All three times, the work was done in preparation for a time of judgment for Israel
  - Here it precedes Israel's time wandering in the desert
  - In Elijah and Elisha, it preceded the judgment against the ten tribes in the northern kingdom
  - And with Jesus and the Apostles, it preceded the current period of Israel's hardening, the destruction of the temple and their scattering in AD 70
- There is yet one final time of God working through widespread miracles on the earth
  - This time will come in conjunction with God's chastisement of Israel and the world during Tribulation

- Now we move to the second judgment

Ex. 8:1 Then the LORD said to Moses, "Go to Pharaoh and say to him, 'Thus says the LORD, "Let My people go, that they may serve Me.
Ex. 8:2 "But if you refuse to let them go, behold, I will smite your whole territory with frogs.
Ex. 8:3 "The Nile will swarm with frogs, which will come up and go into your house and into your bedroom and on your bed, and into the houses of your servants and on your people, and into your ovens and into your kneading bowls.
Ex. 8:4 "So the frogs will come up on you and your people and all your servants."'"
Ex. 8:5 Then the LORD said to Moses, "Say to Aaron, 'Stretch out your hand with your staff over the rivers, over the streams and over the pools, and make frogs come up on the land of Egypt.'"
Ex. 8:6 So Aaron stretched out his hand over the waters of Egypt, and the frogs came up and covered the land of Egypt.
Ex. 8:7 The magicians did the same with their secret arts, making frogs come up on the land of Egypt.
Ex. 8:8 Then Pharaoh called for Moses and Aaron and said, "Entreat the LORD that He remove the frogs from me and from my people; and I will let the people go, that they may sacrifice to the LORD."
Ex. 8:9 Moses said to Pharaoh, "The honor is yours to tell me: when shall I entreat for you and your servants and your people, that the frogs be destroyed from you and your houses, that they may be left only in the Nile?"
Ex. 8:10 Then he said, "Tomorrow." So he said, "May it be according to your word, that you may know that there is no one like the LORD our God.
Ex. 8:11 "The frogs will depart from you and your houses and your servants and your people; they will be left only in the Nile."

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Ex. 8:12 Then Moses and Aaron went out from Pharaoh, and Moses cried to the LORD concerning the frogs which He had inflicted upon Pharaoh.
Ex. 8:13 The LORD did according to the word of Moses, and the frogs died out of the houses, the courts, and the fields.
Ex. 8:14 So they piled them in heaps, and the land became foul.
Ex. 8:15 But when Pharaoh saw that there was relief, he hardened his heart and did not listen to them, as the LORD had said.

- The second judgment is a plague of frogs
  - As we said in our introduction last week, the first three judgments are milder than all that follow
    - They create temporary discomfort
    - And as with all the plagues, God takes natural phenomenon and intensifies them to an uncomfortable and even deadly level
    - For now, these are just uncomfortable
  - Once again, God tells Moses to warn Pharaoh
    - God will smite Egypt with frogs
    - The word smite is simply the word for strike
    - From the Nile, the entire land will be invaded by Frogs
      - The frogs will find their way into every place and will come to everyone
      - Notice in v.4 God sends this plague against Pharaoh's people but Israel isn't mentioned
  - As before, Aaron stretches out the rod of Moses, and it leads to the invasion of frogs over the entire land of Egypt
    - Here again we see Moses working through Aaron
    - The first three plagues are done through the agency of Aaron
      - And note that the rod of Moses plays a prominent part in the story through the Exodus
      - As Moses is a picture of Jesus ruling over His people, then the rod of Moses is also a picture of Jesus' rod of iron from the Psalms
      - But unlike Jesus, Moses makes do with a wooden rod
  - The frog plague has a parallel to the Tribulation, just as with blood
    - While there is no frog plague in Tribulation, there is a moment when demons enter the world to deceive the kings of the nations
      - And in Rev 16:13 the spirits are called "frogs"
    - The only explanation for God using that term to describe the demons would seemingly be to create the connection back to Exodus
- Once again the magicians copy this miracle

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- This example gives us another piece of evidence to teach us the power of Satan
  - Here we see him creating life, at least in the sense that he was able to bring more creatures to the event
  - But notice again, he only counterfeits God's work
    - Satan has the power to create life in the form of new frogs
    - But he lacked the power to simply get rid of the frogs that God already created
    - Which would seem the easier task? Yet Satan couldn't do the thing Pharaoh would have wanted the most
  - This is our proof that Satan's power always remains in check by God
  - But since we know Satan can perform miracles of this degree, we have all the more reason to stay close to Scripture and to the Spirit so that we aren't drawn away by these powers

- The gods mocked by this plague are:
  - Hapi
    - This god was credited with bringing fertility to the land through the flooding of the Nile
    - Normally, the sound of frogs in Egypt is a welcome sign
    - It means the Nile is receding from the annual flood and the land has been made fertile by the flood waters and the time to plant has come
      - But the bothersome nature of the frogs mocks Hapi
  - Heqt
    - A goddess with the head of a frog and the body of a woman
    - The wife of Khnum and the emblem of fertility
- After the blood plague, Pharaoh simply turned and went into the palace, but after the frogs he asks Moses to intervene and seek relief
  - This tells us how onerous the frogs were for the Egyptians
    - They effect was more jarring than even having all water turned to blood
    - When Moses hears the Pharaoh's request, he asks Pharaoh to name the day for the frogs to go away
      - Pharaoh responds with tomorrow, perhaps thinking that was the best he could do
      - Moses says it will be as Pharaoh spoke so that he might know that Moses is working with the one and only God
  - Then Moses immediately goes to God in prayer asking the Lord to give Pharaoh the relief he sought
    - We might have thought that God would leave the plague in place until it had the desired effect

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        - But that's missing the entire point of the plagues
            - God can compel Pharaoh at any point, with or without plagues
            - He could have simply placed it on Pharaoh's heart to let them go
                - Just as God did to Cyrus in Persia when He released Zerubbabel and the rest of Israel
            - The purpose of the plagues is to demonstrate the power of God to Israel and the World
        - So Moses intercedes for Pharaoh
            - How did Moses know that God would agree?
            - Did Moses know in advance that his idea was consistent with God's expectations?
                - Maybe God intended to let the judgment run seven days like the blood?
        - But God does as Moses requests
            - In v.13 we're told that the Lord did according to the word of Moses
            - That seems like a backward sentence
    - What we're seeing here is a picture of intercession
        - Moses picturing Christ, we see how Christ intercedes for us with the Father
        - When we make a request of the Father that is in keeping with the Father's desires, he receives that request by way of a mediator
        - The Son, Christ, intercedes for us, and the Father does according to the Son's intercession
            - This is not because Moses or even Christ has control over the Father
            - Rather, the Father has chosen Moses (and Christ) to represent Him
            - Therefore, the Father is willing to receive Moses' request and act upon it, because it suited His purposes
    - But don't miss the courage and boldness of Moses
        - We are likewise commanded to go boldly into prayer because we have a Lord Who is interceding
        - And when that prayer aligns with the heart of God, we can expect it to be met with acceptance
        - So the closer we walk with the Lord, the more we'll know His will and pray in union with it
- Based on that intercession, God causes the frogs to die
    - And with the mass death of millions of frogs, the nation began to stink with rotting flesh
    - As that plague passed, the Pharaoh let the misery of it fade from his mind
        - So he hardened his heart

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        - So far, the Lord has no need to step in and harden on top of what Pharaoh is willing to do on his own
- Now the final plague of the first series arrives, and as the pattern dictates, it comes without warning

Ex. 8:16 Then the LORD said to Moses, "Say to Aaron, 'Stretch out your staff and strike the dust of the earth, that it may become gnats through all the land of Egypt.'"
Ex. 8:17 They did so; and Aaron stretched out his hand with his staff, and struck the dust of the earth, and there were gnats on man and beast. All the dust of the earth became gnats through all the land of Egypt.
Ex. 8:18 The magicians tried with their secret arts to bring forth gnats, but they could not; so there were gnats on man and beast.
Ex. 8:19 Then the magicians said to Pharaoh, "This is the finger of God." But Pharaoh's heart was hardened, and he did not listen to them, as the LORD had said.

- As with all of the first three, Aaron is the actor bringing the plague to Egypt
    - As he strikes his staff on the earth, the dust of the ground becomes something
        - My English Bible says gnats, others say lice
        - But the Hebrew word is an enigma
        - Dr. Fruchtenbaum suggests it means mixture, as in a mixture of insects
            - That's probably the best description we have
    - This plague brings a mixture of insects upon Egypt
        - The mixture includes insects like gnats that annoy and others like lice that infest the body
        - Still others may have spoiled food and others made sleep difficult
        - The purpose was an infestation so severe it made life miserable
    - When looking for a parallel in the time of Tribulation, we have to look a little harder, because there is no direct reference to insects
        - We know there are two witnesses who have the power to bring plagues
        - And the description in Revelation is this

Rev. 11:6 These have the power to shut up the sky, so that rain will not fall during the days of their prophesying; and they have power over the waters to turn them into blood, and to strike the earth with every plague, as often as they desire.

- We might assume that the plagues these men bring include a plague similar to this one

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- We can make that assumption simply because it refers to them turning water to blood and to strike (or smite) the earth with every plague
  - It doesn't say to strike with whatever plague they want
  - Rather, it says they strike with every plague, as if there were a prescribed number of plagues that must be sent through these men
- Taken together, the reference to blood and every plague suggests strongly that they are called to mimic the plagues of Egypt

- Now for the first time, the magicians couldn't replicate the miracle
  - It's not clear why Satan can no longer counterfeit the miracle
    - But the mere fact that Satan hit a limit tells us that Satan has limits
    - Soon enough, God's power is seen to be clearly greater than Satan's
  - When they can't replicate it, the magicians correctly declare that this plague is from the finger of God
    - Now we see the plagues having their desired effect among the Egyptians
  - The plague also had the effect of mocking the Egyptian priesthood
    - Egyptian priests were scrupulous about cleanliness, as was required by Egyptian practice
    - They shaved their entire bodies to remove all hair in an attempt to ensure no insects were living on their body
      - During this plague, the priesthood is mocked by their inability to keep the insects off their bodies
  - Regarding the gods of Egypt, this plague mocked:
    - Uatchit – protected Egyptians from swarming insects
    - Seb – protected people from lice
- Nevertheless, Pharaoh's heart was hardened and the process moves forward

Ex. 8:20 **Now the LORD said to Moses, "Rise early in the morning and present yourself before Pharaoh, as he comes out to the water, and say to him, 'Thus says the LORD, "Let My people go, that they may serve Me.**
Ex. 8:21 **"For if you do not let My people go, behold, I will send swarms of flies on you and on your servants and on your people and into your houses; and the houses of the Egyptians will be full of swarms of flies, and also the ground on which they dwell.**
Ex. 8:22 **"But on that day I will set apart the land of Goshen, where My people are living, so that no swarms of flies will be there, in order that you may know that I, the LORD, am in the midst of the land.**
Ex. 8:23 **"I will put a division between My people and your people. Tomorrow this sign will occur."'"**
Ex. 8:24 **Then the LORD did so. And there came great swarms of flies into the**

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house of Pharaoh and the houses of his servants and the land was laid waste because of the swarms of flies in all the land of Egypt.
Ex. 8:25 **Pharaoh called for Moses and Aaron and said, "Go, sacrifice to your God within the land."**
Ex. 8:26 **But Moses said, "It is not right to do so, for we will sacrifice to the LORD our God what is an abomination to the Egyptians. If we sacrifice what is an abomination to the Egyptians before their eyes, will they not then stone us?**
Ex. 8:27 **"We must go a three days' journey into the wilderness and sacrifice to the LORD our God as He commands us."**
Ex. 8:28 **Pharaoh said, "I will let you go, that you may sacrifice to the LORD your God in the wilderness; only you shall not go very far away. Make supplication for me."**
Ex. 8:29 **Then Moses said, "Behold, I am going out from you, and I shall make supplication to the LORD that the swarms of flies may depart from Pharaoh, from his servants, and from his people tomorrow; only do not let Pharaoh deal deceitfully again in not letting the people go to sacrifice to the LORD."**
Ex. 8:30 **So Moses went out from Pharaoh and made supplication to the LORD.**
Ex. 8:31 **The LORD did as Moses asked, and removed the swarms of flies from Pharaoh, from his servants and from his people; not one remained.**
Ex. 8:32 **But Pharaoh hardened his heart this time also, and he did not let the people go.**

- The next judgment begins the next series of three, so the first plague comes with a warning in the morning
  - God promises now that He will send biting flies
    - Remember the first series produced severe annoyances
    - But each plague left the people largely untouched
    - And the effects were temporary and quickly reversible
    - Now the plagues get progressively worse and begin to impact people and animals in severe ways
  - This plague will bring swarms of biting flies to the Egyptians, but not to the people of Israel
    - In fact, from this point forward, the judgments are specifically directed at only the Egyptians
    - The earlier judgments were of a type that even Israel was impacted
      - But from here on the severity is too great for God's people to be included
  - This pattern also mirrors the judgments of Tribulation
    - The Tribulation judgments comes in three sets as well, and like Exodus, the first set of judgments impacts all people, including believers on earth
    - When the second set of judgments begin, the Lord begins to make distinctions

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        - The trumpet judgments are sent against those without the seal of God
- Notice in v.24 that the arrival of the flies comes by the Lord alone
    - For this series of judgments, God acts alone to bring them to Pharaoh
    - The arrival of the flies made the land lay waste, we're told
        - The strength of that phrase gives us an indication of how severe this plague was for Egypt
        - A description of the event from Keil and Delitzsch:

"When enraged, they fasten themselves upon the human body, especially upon the edges of the eyelids. . . . [they] not only tortured, 'devoured' (Ps. 78:45) the men, and disfigured them by the swellings produced by their sting, but also killed the plants in which they deposited their eggs . . . ."

"The blood-sucking gadfly or dogfly was something to be abhorred and may in part have been responsible for the great deal of blind men in the land. . . .

- In response, Pharaoh is finally moved to negotiate, the first of three times he will attempt to negotiate
    - He hopes he can persuade Moses to accept something less than he is asking
    - His first proposal is to have Israel sacrifice to their God as they desired, but they must do it in the land of Egypt
        - Obviously, Pharaoh knows that if Israel is released to worship outside the land, they will never return
        - So he is looking for a way to keep the slave labor
    - Interestingly, Moses addresses this offer by objecting to a detail in Pharaoh's plan
        - He notes that the animals Israel will sacrifice are animals Egypt either detests (like sheep) or worships (like bulls)
        - In either case, the sight of Israelites working with such animals in a sacrifice would so deeply offend Egyptian culture it would lead to a riot and stoning of the Jews
        - Remember, as slaves they could be killed with impunity by any Egyptian, so the threat was real
    - Still, we might have expected Moses to simply say that God wasn't interested in a compromise
        - Instead, Moses proves to be a tough negotiator, able to stand up to politicians and stick to his guns
        - Moses would have made a great NRA president
- This leads Pharaoh to offer another concession
    - They can go into the desert, but just don't go too far

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        - It's becoming more and more obvious that Pharaoh's chief concern is the escape of the slaves
        - He is trying to keep the nation close at hand and prevent their departure
    - But because Moses began to negotiate on the terms of the deal, now he has little choice but to accept the compromise
        - Perhaps he assumed that if they made it in to the desert at all, that would be enough to ensure their departure
        - Or perhaps he knew that Pharaoh would go back on his deal
            - The latter seems likely because in v.29 Moses says don't deal deceitfully with us
            - Moses is preparing for disappointment
- So, once again Moses intercedes for Pharaoh and the flies leave
    - These flies were not going to stop biting until Moses prayed, so the intercession was necessary to stop the plague
        - As expected, however, the Pharaoh decided they had survived another plague, so why let the people go
        - In fact, we must imagine at this point that the on-again/off-again pattern of the plagues played into Pharaoh's self-deception
    - When we experience God's displeasure on an occasional basis, it's tempting often to think that the worst is behind us
        - We let the hope that the past won't repeat itself give us reason to go on sinning
        - That's a foolish game, because God always has more staying power and more options
        - We can't let God's forbearance become our ignorant excuse to go on sinning

Heb. 10:26 For if we go on sinning willfully after receiving the knowledge of the truth, there no longer remains a sacrifice for sins,
Heb. 10:27 but a terrifying expectation of judgment and THE FURY OF A FIRE WHICH WILL CONSUME THE ADVERSARIES.

- Finally, the gods mocked by this judgment:
    - Principally one: Baalzebub – lord of the flies
        - This is the pagan demon closely associated with Satan himself
- The second plague in the second series also comes with a warning

Ex. 9:1 Then the LORD said to Moses, "Go to Pharaoh and speak to him, 'Thus says the LORD, the God of the Hebrews, "Let My people go, that they may serve Me.
Ex. 9:2 "For if you refuse to let them go and continue to hold them,

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Ex. 9:3 behold, the hand of the LORD will come with a very severe pestilence on your livestock which are in the field, on the horses, on the donkeys, on the camels, on the herds, and on the flocks.
Ex. 9:4 "But the LORD will make a distinction between the livestock of Israel and the livestock of Egypt, so that nothing will die of all that belongs to the sons of Israel.""'"
Ex. 9:5 The LORD set a definite time, saying, "Tomorrow the LORD will do this thing in the land."
Ex. 9:6 So the LORD did this thing on the next day, and all the livestock of Egypt died; but of the livestock of the sons of Israel, not one died.
Ex. 9:7 Pharaoh sent, and behold, there was not even one of the livestock of Israel dead. But the heart of Pharaoh was hardened, and he did not let the people go.

- Now God brings pestilence to the livestock of Egypt
  - Pestilence is any disease
    - Some believe this is anthrax, which is extremely deadly for animals
    - Now for the first time the Egyptians are going to suffer loss of personal property
  - But God offers some mercy to the Egyptians, at least for a time
    - The pestilence impacted only the livestock in the field, which would have been most of them
    - Those that were still left in the stables were not impacted
    - They become fodder for a future plague
  - Still, this is a massive loss of life among livestock
    - Except that the livestock of Israel are left untouched
    - Again, the distinction is useful to God in showing Himself to be the God of the Hebrews
- The Pharaoh wanted to know for sure that what Moses told him was true
  - He sought as to whether the livestock of Israel survived
    - Historical records indicate that this Pharaoh was particularly given to worshipping cattle
    - Gispen wrote:

"Amenhotep II surpassed all his predecessors in his fanatical devotion to the worship of animals, and especially of the bull. In 1906 a statue made of sandstone was excavated representing a cow and Amenhotep II leaning his head under its head; he is also depicted kneeling under a cow, drinking its divine milk. He is thus seen as child and slave of the cow goddess. What a threat this must have been to him!

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- Speaking of the gods mocked in this judgment
  - Apis Bull – the sacred bull always kept out in the open
  - Mnevis – sacred bull of the god Ra
  - Hathor – goddess with a head of a cow and body of a woman
  - Knom – Ram-like god
- This judgment mirrors the fourth seal judgment, which brings pestilence to the world
- Unsurprisingly, Pharaoh doesn't relent at all
  - This is one stubborn man
  - His nation has lost significant wealth but still he holds on
- The final plague of the second series and the final plague of the night comes without warning again

Ex. 9:8 Then the LORD said to Moses and Aaron, "Take for yourselves handfuls of soot from a kiln, and let Moses throw it toward the sky in the sight of Pharaoh.
Ex. 9:9 "It will become fine dust over all the land of Egypt, and will become boils breaking out with sores on man and beast through all the land of Egypt."
Ex. 9:10 So they took soot from a kiln, and stood before Pharaoh; and Moses threw it toward the sky, and it became boils breaking out with sores on man and beast.
Ex. 9:11 The magicians could not stand before Moses because of the boils, for the boils were on the magicians as well as on all the Egyptians.
Ex. 9:12 And the LORD hardened Pharaoh's heart, and he did not listen to them, just as the LORD had spoken to Moses.

- God turns dust into boils on the bodies of the Egyptians
  - The dust is taken from the Jewish kilns
    - These are the ovens used to make bricks
    - This connection gave the Jews a chance to see God working for their revenge in the face of their harsh treatment
    - I wonder if during these periods of the plagues, the Egyptians started treating Israel better or worse?
  - Boils is exactly like one of the Tribulation judgments
    - These boils were on every man, including the magicians
    - It made the magicians look particularly foolish when they couldn't mimic or even escape the effect of this plague
  - The magicians were still trying to counter Moses' work, but this time they couldn't stand before Pharaoh
    - The reason was because they were bed-ridden with the sores

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- Since we know that all the plagues were an intensification of existing natural phenomenon, the question arrives of what kind of sickness is this?
  - One theory was proposed by Keil and Delitzsch:

The natural substratum of this plague is discovered by most commentators in the so-called Nile-blisters, which come out in innumerable little pimples upon the scarlet-coloured skin, and change in a short space of time into small, round, and thickly-crowded blisters. This is called by the Egyptians Hamm el Nil, or the heat of the inundation. According to Dr. Bilharz, it is a rash, which occurs in summer, chiefly towards the close at the time of the overflowing of the Nile, and produces a burning and pricking sensation upon the skin; or, in Seetzen's words, 'it consists of small, red, and slightly rounded elevations in the skin, which give strong twitches and slight stinging sensations, resembling those of scarlet fever'. The cause of this eruption, which occurs only in men and not in animals, has not been determined; some attributing it to the water, and others to the heat.

- The gods impacted by this judgment were the Egyptian gods of healing
  - Sekhmet – body of a woman and the head of a lioness and had power of epidemics
  - Serapis – god of healing
  - Imhotep – god of medicine
- Finally, notice that now comes the time for God to harden Pharaoh's heart
  - Apparently, the boils might have been enough to bring Pharaoh around had God not stopped him from relenting
  - These sores must have been so painful, that the thought of continuing would have been too much
    - But God's plan must continue, so Pharaoh is hardened against the prospect of allowing the Israelites to continue
- Next time we finish the plagues, including moving into the tenth plague

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Exodus 10

- In our last meeting, we quickly covered the first six plagues of the judgments against Egypt
    - We focused on the overall pattern and picture God was creating through the judgments
        - The judgments follow the structure we identified as we began this part of our study
        - The first nine judgment come in groups of three with certain expectations for how they start and progress
        - We have also noticed how they foreshadow the judgments of Tribulation and how they were intended as an assault against Egypt's gods
    - Tonight we conclude that examination, including learning about the most important judgment, the tenth judgment of the first born
- We left off ready to look at the final three plagues, beginning with the seventh judgment

Ex. 9:13 Then the LORD said to Moses, "Rise up early in the morning and stand before Pharaoh and say to him, 'Thus says the LORD, the God of the Hebrews, "Let My people go, that they may serve Me.
Ex. 9:14 "For this time I will send all My plagues on you and your servants and your people, so that you may know that there is no one like Me in all the earth.
Ex. 9:15 "For if by now I had put forth My hand and struck you and your people with pestilence, you would then have been cut off from the earth.
Ex. 9:16 "But, indeed, for this reason I have allowed you to remain, in order to show you My power and in order to proclaim My name through all the earth.

- Since this is the first of a three-judgment group, the judgment is preceded with a warning to Pharaoh in the morning
    - This opening is different than those that have preceded it
        - The Lord begins with the same demand: Let my people go
        - But rather than waiting for Pharaoh to respond, the Lord continues with an ominous warning
            - He says this time I will bring "all" my plagues

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- Pharaoh is no longer in a position to stop the judgments
- They are all coming upon Pharaoh and he must endure all remaining judgments
- And the Lord says in .v14 that this must happen so that the people of Egypt and the world will know there is no one like the Lord

- Next the Lord sets the record straight with Pharaoh
  - Pharaoh thinks he has survived the plagues by dint of his god's protection or his own strength
  - But the Lord tells Pharaoh that his survival is merely proof of God's mercy
    - Had the Lord wanted to wipe out Pharaoh and the Egyptians people, they would have been gone already
    - But in v.16, the Lord says that Pharaoh and Egypt have been allowed to remain so that they could be witnesses to God's power
    - And in return, they would proclaim God's name throughout the world

- These statements convey weighty theology we must understand to see God's actions in Exodus properly
  - First, God holds the life of every man in His hands, and He allows unbelievers to live along side believers
    - Though we understand and agree with this statement, don't overlook it's significance
      - The earth is populated with billions of people and most do not know and follow the living God
      - They are disobedient, ungodly, and corrupt, and they offend a holy and just God
      - Yet since Cain, they have lived and enjoyed the blessings of a world God created for His glory
    - In the Beatitudes, the Lord cites this principle in pointing out the Lord's long suffering and merciful nature

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Matt. 5:44 "But I say to you, love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you,
Matt. 5:45 so that you may be sons of your Father who is in heaven; for He causes His sun to rise on the evil and the good, and sends rain on the righteous and the unrighteous.

- God is willing to support the physical needs of people whose very existence is offensive to His Holy nature

- The second point is that God does this for His glory
  - Many believers have questioned why God allows so much evil to live side by side with His children, and the answer is here
  - When God chooses to judge the ungodly, He will have the opportunity He desires to display His power and bring glory to His name
    - This moment in the Exodus is an example of that purpose at work
    - As Paul explains

Rom. 9:17 For the Scripture says to Pharaoh, "FOR THIS VERY PURPOSE I RAISED YOU UP, TO DEMONSTRATE MY POWER IN YOU, AND THAT MY NAME MIGHT BE PROCLAIMED THROUGHOUT THE WHOLE EARTH."
Rom. 9:18 So then He has mercy on whom He desires, and He hardens whom He desires.
Rom. 9:19 You will say to me then, "Why does He still find fault? For who resists His will?"
Rom. 9:20 On the contrary, who are you, O man, who answers back to God? The thing molded will not say to the molder, "Why did you make me like this," will it?
Rom. 9:21 Or does not the potter have a right over the clay, to make from the same lump one vessel for honorable use and another for common use?
Rom. 9:22 What if God, although willing to demonstrate His wrath and to make His power known, endured with much patience vessels of wrath prepared for destruction?
Rom. 9:23 And He did so to make known the riches of His glory upon vessels of mercy, which He prepared beforehand for glory,
Rom. 9:24 even us, whom He also called, not from among Jews only, but also from among Gentiles.

- The Tribulation will be another such opportunity

- So God tells Pharaoh that he has been preserved through the first plagues so that he would lead to God's name proclaimed in all the world

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- And now that we've reached the final four plagues, the Lord reiterates that Pharaoh will see "all" the plagues God has designed
    - We've known this from the beginning, but now the Lord reveals this reality to Pharaoh himself
    - God's judgment has a purpose, and that purpose is not redemptive
    - That's the difference between discipline and judgment
        - Discipline is God's displeasure dispensed against His children for the purpose of correcting disobedience
            - It has a redemptive purpose
        - Judgment is God's wrath poured out against His enemies as just condemnation for sin
            - It has no redemptive purpose; it is entirely punitive
- These plagues are judgments, not discipline, as so they will continue regardless of Pharaoh's behavior
    - In fact, the Lord is actively working to keep the Pharaoh's heart hard and unresponsive to the pressure God applies
    - And as the ten plagues play out, the Lord's power is made known and His name is proclaimed throughout the world
    - Who is God's intended audience for this display of power and glory?
        - God's people, of course
        - As Paul said

Rom. 9:23 **And He did so to make known the riches of His glory upon vessels of mercy, which He prepared beforehand for glory,**

- The unbelieving world will see these wonders too, but they cannot be persuaded by wonders
- Daniel speaks of this same principle in describing the effects of the Tribulation judgments upon the world of the last days

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Dan. 12:10 "Many will be purged, purified and refined, but the wicked will act wickedly; and none of the wicked will understand, but those who have insight will understand.

- The final series of Exodus judgments are intended to complete the display of God's power, not to change Pharaoh's mind
- And the final series of Tribulation judgments, the bowl judgments, serve the same purpose
  - They bring God's wrath against the world and its leaders
  - And they have no redemptive purpose, since they bring no new faith
  - They are exclusively intended to demonstrate God's power against unbelievers for the benefit of an audience of believers

- Turning to the seventh judgment itself, God describes Pharaoh what will happen

Ex. 9:17 "Still you exalt yourself against My people by not letting them go.
Ex. 9:18 "Behold, about this time tomorrow, I will send a very heavy hail, such as has not been seen in Egypt from the day it was founded until now.
Ex. 9:19 "Now therefore send, bring your livestock and whatever you have in the field to safety. Every man and beast that is found in the field and is not brought home, when the hail comes down on them, will die.'"'"
Ex. 9:20 The one among the servants of Pharaoh who feared the word of the LORD made his servants and his livestock flee into the houses;
Ex. 9:21 but he who paid no regard to the word of the LORD left his servants and his livestock in the field.
Ex. 9:22 Now the LORD said to Moses, "Stretch out your hand toward the sky, that hail may fall on all the land of Egypt, on man and on beast and on every plant of the field, throughout the land of Egypt."
Ex. 9:23 Moses stretched out his staff toward the sky, and the LORD sent thunder and hail, and fire ran down to the earth. And the LORD rained hail on the land of Egypt.
Ex. 9:24 So there was hail, and fire flashing continually in the midst of the hail, very severe, such as had not been in all the land of Egypt since it became a nation.
Ex. 9:25 The hail struck all that was in the field through all the land of Egypt, both man and beast; the hail also struck every plant of the field and shattered every tree of the field.
Ex. 9:26 Only in the land of Goshen, where the sons of Israel were, there was no hail.

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- God warns He will send a plague of hail unseen before in the land of Egypt
    - The purpose of the hail will be to destroy all man and animal life among those left exposed in the field, and to ruin the crops in the field
        - Notice there is a degree of mercy available here for any God-fearing Egyptians in the land
        - Those who heed this warning can at least preserve their livestock from death
            - Their crops will still be ruined though
        - You would think that by now many in Egypt are beginning to get the message and would heed the warning, and this is true
            - In fact, the people of Egypt are beginning to question their Pharaoh's reasoning in not giving in to the Lord's demands
            - Remember, the people of Egypt haven't had their hearts hardened by the Lord as has Pharaoh
            - So they are more easily persuaded and have reached the point of capitulation
        - So for these God-fearing Egyptians, there is now mercy found in this plague
- So the Lord sends a very severe plague of hail against Egypt
    - Notice that this final group of three plagues is accomplished through the hand of Moses
        - And when Moses stretches out his hand, he brings a storm mixing hail, thunder, and fire
            - That's a bad combination even by Texas standards
        - The description of the event continues to emphasize the unprecedented nature of this judgment
    - The effect is devastating
        - Every plant and every tree of the field was shattered
            - Animals and people left out died as well

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- We've seen pictures of areas devastated by hurricanes and Egypt must have looked like that and worse

- But the land of Israel is untouched, as we've seen since the third plague

- This plague parallels both the first trumpet and the seventh bowl judgment

- As before, the Pharaoh reacts and calls for Moses

Ex. 9:27 Then Pharaoh sent for Moses and Aaron, and said to them, "I have sinned this time; the LORD is the righteous one, and I and my people are the wicked ones.
Ex. 9:28 "Make supplication to the LORD, for there has been enough of God's thunder and hail; and I will let you go, and you shall stay no longer."
Ex. 9:29 Moses said to him, "As soon as I go out of the city, I will spread out my hands to the LORD; the thunder will cease and there will be hail no longer, that you may know that the earth is the LORD'S.
Ex. 9:30 "But as for you and your servants, I know that you do not yet fear the LORD God."
Ex. 9:31 (Now the flax and the barley were ruined, for the barley was in the ear and the flax was in bud.
Ex. 9:32 But the wheat and the spelt were not ruined, for they ripen late.)
Ex. 9:33 So Moses went out of the city from Pharaoh, and spread out his hands to the LORD; and the thunder and the hail ceased, and rain no longer poured on the earth.
Ex. 9:34 But when Pharaoh saw that the rain and the hail and the thunder had ceased, he sinned again and hardened his heart, he and his servants.
Ex. 9:35 Pharaoh's heart was hardened, and he did not let the sons of Israel go, just as the LORD had spoken through Moses.

- Pharaoh continues to seek anyway possible to stop the judgments, especially when he's in the midst of the judgment

- He'll say anything, promise anything to bring it to an end

- In this case, he announces quiet dramatically that he and his people are wicked and have sinned while the Lord is the righteous One

- What do we make of this type of confession?

- The Bible describes moments like this, for example

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Heb. 12:15 See to it that no one comes short of the grace of God; that no root of bitterness springing up causes trouble, and by it many be defiled;
Heb. 12:16 that there be no immoral or godless person like Esau, who sold his own birthright for a single meal.
Heb. 12:17 For you know that even afterwards, when he desired to inherit the blessing, he was rejected, for he found no place for repentance, though he sought for it with tears.

- Esau is held up as an example of a man who came up short of the grace of God
  - As a result, when he learned of the consequences of his sin, he displayed tears of regret hoping to plead his case
  - His unpleasant circumstances drove his tears
  - But the Bible says clearly that these tears were not the result of godly repentance
- As Paul explains

2Cor. 7:10 For the sorrow that is according to the will of God produces a repentance without regret, leading to salvation, but the sorrow of the world produces death.

- The kind of sorrow Esau displayed - and the kind Pharaoh is displaying - is the sorrow of the world
  - It looks convincing and it may fool us to think there has been a change of heart
  - But soon enough, the truth will become known
  - An unrepentant heart ceases it's sorrow once the consequences have been removed
    - You will very often see this pattern in children
    - When they are caught in a mistake, they cry tears in the face of a punishment
  - If we relent too quickly, we risk allowing them to fool us into thinking they have truly repented when in fact it's just a game to get rid of the consequences
  - Making this mistake repeatedly with kids leads them to adopt a specific behavioral condition with a very technical name: they become monsters

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        - And with adults, we need to keep a discerning attitude toward those who claim a changed heart, even accompanying tears, but don't show true spiritual change

- The first clue to know that nothing has really changed in Pharaoh's heart is his request that Moses pray for him
    - Rather than Pharaoh opening dialog directly with the Lord, he asks someone else to approach the Lord on his behalf
        - This is a typical pattern when unbelievers try to project a spiritual perspective
        - To their unbelieving ears, it sounds spiritual to ask for prayer, and it is, but in this context it simply highlights that the person has no personal relationship with the Lord
            - You see the same thing in Acts 8 when Simon the magician asks Peter to pray for him to receive God's forgiveness
            - True repentance will always lead the sinner to pray to the Lord himself confessing his own sin
    - Pharaoh also promises (again) to let Israel go
        - As we read in v.30, Moses isn't fooled by this display
        - Nevertheless, Moses agrees to stop the plague after he has left the city of Pharaoh
        - And once the pressure is taken off, Pharaoh remains as he is
            - The leopard doesn't change his stripes, as I'm known to say
        - Notice also that God is still at work hardening the Pharaoh's heart
    - In vs.31-32 Moses makes an interesting comment regarding the effects of the plague
        - The Egyptians raised three kinds of grain, primarily
            - Barley, flax and wheat
        - As this plague hit, the flax and barley were ripening in the field

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        - This happens in Jan and Feb every year
    - The wheat doesn't come up until Mar or Apr, so that crop was sparred at this point
        - However, they will be lost in the next plague
        - This means that there is about 2 months between the hail and the eighth plague
- Finally, there were multiple Egyptian gods discredited in this judgment
    - Shu - Sky god and son of Ra
    - Nut - sky goddess
    - Seth - agricultural god
    - Isis - agricultural goddess

- Now we move to the eighth plague

Ex. 10:1 **Then the LORD said to Moses, "Go to Pharaoh, for I have hardened his heart and the heart of his servants, that I may perform these signs of Mine among them,**
Ex. 10:2 **and that you may tell in the hearing of your son, and of your grandson, how I made a mockery of the Egyptians and how I performed My signs among them, that you may know that I am the LORD."**

- Before the seventh plague, the Lord explained His purposes in preserving the life of Pharaoh and the Egyptians despite Pharaoh's resistance
    - The purpose was to use Pharaoh as a platform on which the Lord would display His power and glorify His name among the nations
    - Now as He begins the eighth plague, the Lord gives Moses additional information about His purposes in extending this drama further
        - The Lord tells Moses to once again approach Pharaoh with his request
        - And because the Lord has continued to harden the Pharaoh's heart, this request will give yet another opportunity for GOd to display HIs power
    - But then the Lord adds a new purpose: so that Moses and the Israelites will recount what they see to future generations

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- Specifically, God wants Israel to remember how God made a mockery of Egyptian power
  - God mocks Pharaoh, the Egyptian gods, the Egyptian might, and in the end the Egyptian army
  - And the Lord wants this story to become part of Israel collective conscience
- We noted in the last judgment that the intended audience for God's display of power was primarily His children
  - Here we see the Lord confirming that intention
  - And this display of power is unprecedented in all history
  - It will only be equaled and exceeded in Tribulation

- This reminds us of one of our responsibilities as believers of the living God
  - We have been ushered into the family of God by God's mercy for the purpose of bringing glory to God
    - Our very existence is proof of His goodness, and so we testify by our mere existence
    - But that's the least we can do
    - The call of faith of is ultimately a call to works that testify to the glory of God, as Jesus said

Matt. 5:16 "Let your light shine before men in such a way that they may see your good works, and glorify your Father who is in heaven.

- So when the Lord has revealed His power and goodness to us, as He is doing here to Israel, an expectation attaches that we would respond with testimony
  - Moses was to declare God's works to Israel
  - And in turn Israel would make this declaration to one another from generation to generation
  - And so the glory of this work is preserved for future generations

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- Likewise, we should seek an attitude of thankfulness coupled with the self-discipline to speak of God's work and glory to everyone we encounter
    - Even simple comments like "God told me..." or "I felt the Lord leading me..." will communicate His work to unbelievers
    - As the Psalmist said

Psa. 71:14 But as for me, I will hope continually,
And will praise You yet more and more.
Psa. 71:15 My mouth shall tell of Your righteousness
And of Your salvation all day long;
For I do not know the sum of them.
Psa. 71:16 I will come with the mighty deeds of the Lord GOD;
I will make mention of Your righteousness, Yours alone.
Psa. 71:17 O God, You have taught me from my youth,
And I still declare Your wondrous deeds.
Psa. 71:18 And even when I am old and gray, O God, do not forsake me,
Until I declare Your strength to this generation,
Your power to all who are to come.

- So then came the instructions for the next plague

Ex. 10:3 Moses and Aaron went to Pharaoh and said to him, "Thus says the LORD, the God of the Hebrews, 'How long will you refuse to humble yourself before Me? Let My people go, that they may serve Me.
Ex. 10:4 'For if you refuse to let My people go, behold, tomorrow I will bring locusts into your territory.
Ex. 10:5 'They shall cover the surface of the land, so that no one will be able to see the land. They will also eat the rest of what has escaped — what is left to you from the hail — and they will eat every tree which sprouts for you out of the field.
Ex. 10:6 'Then your houses shall be filled and the houses of all your servants and the houses of all the Egyptians, something which neither your fathers nor your grandfathers have seen, from the day that they came upon the earth until this day.'" And he turned and went out from Pharaoh.

- The eighth plague is locusts, another example of intensifying a natural phenomenon

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- The second in the series always comes with a warning, and the Pharaoh learns that this plague will cover the earth of Egypt with locusts
  - There will be so many that the ground will literally be black
  - Locusts occasionally swarm in various places on earth, and the effect is always devastating
    - They are voracious eaters consuming virtually any vegetation
- The Lord says this particular plague will bring so many locusts that Egypt will have nothing to compare it to
  - The numbers will exceed anything that has existed before
  - Everywhere except Goshen will be so covered you will not be able to see the land underneath
  - They will eat anything that survived the hail, which means the wheat that has come up since the hail hit
  - Also, any remaining trees that have begun to grow back in the two months since the hail
- This plague has an indirect connection to the Tribulation judgments
  - In the fifth Trumpet judgment, demons are released from the pit to torment men for five months
  - And John describes the appearance of these demons as looking like locusts

Ex. 10:7 Pharaoh's servants said to him, "How long will this man be a snare to us? Let the men go, that they may serve the LORD their God. Do you not realize that Egypt is destroyed?"
Ex. 10:8 So Moses and Aaron were brought back to Pharaoh, and he said to them, "Go, serve the LORD your God! Who are the ones that are going?"
Ex. 10:9 Moses said, "We shall go with our young and our old; with our sons and our daughters, with our flocks and our herds we shall go, for we must hold a feast to the LORD."
Ex. 10:10 Then he said to them, "Thus may the LORD be with you, if ever I let you and your little ones go! Take heed, for evil is in your mind.
Ex. 10:11 "Not so! Go now, the men among you, and serve the LORD, for that is what you desire." So they were driven out from Pharaoh's presence.

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- I mentioned in the previous judgment that the populace of Egypt was losing patience with the Pharaoh's stubbornness
    - And now we see that insurrection beginning to take shape publicly
        - Before the plague has even begun, the servants of Pharaoh opening challenge Pharaoh in his court
        - They ask Pharaoh how long he intends to let this go on, since Egypt is destroyed
            - The Hebrew word for destroyed means "annihilated"
        - Obviously, these servants believe Moses' word and fully expect something bad to happen in response to Moses' warning
    - It's hard to overstate how striking this conversation would have been
        - The Pharaoh was considered a god and his authority could never be challenged
        - Should anyone ever dare to do so, death would follow quickly
    - The fact these servants were willing to challenge Pharaoh publicly tells us two things
        - First, it's an indication of how bad things have become in Egypt
            - The people are willing to risk death to make their opinions known to Pharaoh
        - Secondly, it shows God at work to discredit the most power Egyptian god...the Pharaoh himself
            - The people have begun to question his judgment
            - More importantly, they have seen that there is a power in creation that far exceeds the power of Pharaoh
            - And this greater power is humiliating and annihilating Pharaoh and Egypt along with it
- Probably shocked by his servants' daring and sensing some vulnerability, the Pharaoh calls for Moses and Aaron to return
    - Then Pharaoh makes his third attempt to negotiate a face-saving compromise

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- He begins by asking Moses who of the nation would be going out of Egypt
- He's implying that not all would leave

- Moses responds with the obvious answer
  - We're all going, old, young, sons, daughters, animals, everyone
  - Once again, Moses is taking Israel away from Egypt forever
    - While Pharaoh is looking for a way to force Israel to be kept in the land
    - The entire discussion of leaving to sacrifice is merely pretext for discussing a full release of Israel
- Pharaoh's response is a bit difficult to understand in our English translation, because the translation is wrong
  - Pharaoh says in a sarcastic tone may your Lord be with you should I ever let you and your little ones go
    - He's saying that should I ever let you go, then you had better have your God on your side to protect you
  - Why does he say this?
    - Because in the second half of the verse Pharaoh says evil in your mind
    - That is an unfortunate translation of the Hebrew and it completely obscures Pharaoh's real meaning
      - The Hebrew only says "See Ra is before you"
    - The word Ra is the name of the Egyptian sun god
      - But that word (ra) is also the Hebrew word for evil
      - The translators have taken the word ra to be the Hebrew word for evil rather than seeing it as the name of the Egyptian sun god
  - But Pharaoh used the name Ra, not the Hebrew word for evil
    - Pharaoh was considered to be the incarnation of Ra on earth

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- So Pharaoh was saying Ra was standing before Moses (meaning Pharaoh was standing before Moses)
- And Pharaoh was threatening Moses by suggestion that if Moses and Israel were ever released, they would need protection from the wrath of Pharaoh

- And with that Pharaoh grants only the men to go worship
  - Normally, this would be a sensible compromise, since women usually didn't participate in religious ceremony in Eastern cultures
  - But of course, that's not God's plan
  - With that, Pharaoh sends Moses and Aaron away hoping they accept the deal and he avoids the plague

Ex. 10:12 Then the LORD said to Moses, "Stretch out your hand over the land of Egypt for the locusts, that they may come up on the land of Egypt and eat every plant of the land, even all that the hail has left."
Ex. 10:13 So Moses stretched out his staff over the land of Egypt, and the LORD directed an east wind on the land all that day and all that night; and when it was morning, the east wind brought the locusts.
Ex. 10:14 The locusts came up over all the land of Egypt and settled in all the territory of Egypt; they were very numerous. There had never been so many locusts, nor would there be so many again.
Ex. 10:15 For they covered the surface of the whole land, so that the land was darkened; and they ate every plant of the land and all the fruit of the trees that the hail had left. Thus nothing green was left on tree or plant of the field through all the land of Egypt.
Ex. 10:16 Then Pharaoh hurriedly called for Moses and Aaron, and he said, "I have sinned against the LORD your God and against you.
Ex. 10:17 "Now therefore, please forgive my sin only this once, and make supplication to the LORD your God, that He would only remove this death from me."
Ex. 10:18 He went out from Pharaoh and made supplication to the LORD.
Ex. 10:19 So the LORD shifted the wind to a very strong west wind which took up the locusts and drove them into the Red Sea; not one locust was left in all the territory of Egypt.
Ex. 10:20 But the LORD hardened Pharaoh's heart, and he did not let the sons of Israel go.

- Just as God promised, locusts consume Egypt

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- Whatever food sources the people had managed to cultivate since the devastating hail were now gone
    - For 24 hours an east wind brought locusts from somewhere so that by morning the next day they wind had delivered them
        - Notice that the plague is a supernatural increase of a natural event
        - The locust were brought in the usual way, by a wind
        - But this wind brought a lot more locusts than usual!
    - After a day or so of munching on everything Egypt had, the Pharaoh pulls another crocodile tear episode
        - He calls for Moses again, begs for forgiveness
        - Moses appealed to the Lord, and the wind reversed taking the locusts into the sea
    - Notice the removal of the plagues was as miraculous as their arrival
        - Egypt didn't even have a single locust remaining in the land to give evidence of what had happened
        - All that remained was the evidence of what the locusts had done
- And of course Pharaoh's heart is hardened to continue to process
- The gods mocked in this plague were
    - Seth - the agriculture god that looked like a locust
    - Isis - the agricultural god

- The ninth plague is now upon Egypt, and as with the final plague of every series, it comes without warning

Ex. 10:21 **Then the LORD said to Moses, "Stretch out your hand toward the sky, that there may be darkness over the land of Egypt, even a darkness which may be felt."**
Ex. 10:22 **So Moses stretched out his hand toward the sky, and there was thick darkness in all the land of Egypt for three days.**
Ex. 10:23 **They did not see one another, nor did anyone rise from his place for three days, but all the sons of Israel had light in their dwellings.**

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- Moses initiates a darkness on the land that Moses describes as being felt
    - This tells us that this darkness is part physical, part spiritual
        - People can see nothing whatsoever
        - It's as if they have gone completely blind
    - But it can be felt also
        - It brings everything in Egypt to a stop
        - Certainly the darkness would have greatly reduced people's movement
            - But complete stillness is better explained by the darkness having a debilitating effect
            - This is probably what Moses meant by the darkness being felt
        - But Goshen still has light in homes, but notice this implies that Goshen itself did experience the outer darkness
            - So the sun isn't shining in Egypt, though the Israelites can compensate with internal lights
            - That was absent elsewhere in Egypt
- Consider God's sense of irony in this judgment
    - In an earlier moment the Pharaoh had declared that Israel had better fear the Egyptian sun god Ra
        - Now this plague, which came without warning, plunges Egypt into a sunless existence
    - In the pantheon of Egyptian gods, more gods represented the sun, moon and stars than any other part of creation
        - A partial list of gods mocked in this judgment includes:
            - Ra - the sun god (ram)
            - Khepre - another sun god (eagle)
            - Harakhte - another sun god (hawk)
            - Aten - sun disk god

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- Horus - winged sun disk god
- Atum - god of the setting sun
- Thoth - moon god
- Nut - sky goddess

Ex. 10:24 Then Pharaoh called to Moses, and said, "Go, serve the LORD; only let your flocks and your herds be detained. Even your little ones may go with you."
Ex. 10:25 But Moses said, "You must also let us have sacrifices and burnt offerings, that we may sacrifice them to the LORD our God.
Ex. 10:26 "Therefore, our livestock too shall go with us; not a hoof shall be left behind, for we shall take some of them to serve the LORD our God. And until we arrive there, we ourselves do not know with what we shall serve the LORD."
Ex. 10:27 But the LORD hardened Pharaoh's heart, and he was not willing to let them go.
Ex. 10:28 Then Pharaoh said to him, "Get away from me! Beware, do not see my face again, for in the day you see my face you shall die!"
Ex. 10:29 Moses said, "You are right; I shall never see your face again!"

- God has to set a time limit on this plague, because until the darkness is lifted, Pharaoh and Moses could never meet
    - So once the darkness ends after three days, Pharaoh calls for Moses and then says Israel may go
        - And for the fourth time Pharaoh tries to negotiate with Moses
            - He says leave the flocks
            - Remember, his purpose in these negotiations is to give Israel reason to return
        - And this was Pharaoh's weakest reason yet
            - He was risking that Israel would go without their flocks and still not come back, though it would have been risky for Israel
            - The flocks were needed to sustain such a large group of people
    - Moses makes the obvious point to Pharaoh
        - If we don't take our flocks, we won't be able to sacrifice

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        - Moses says quite comically not a hoof will be left behind
        - Perhaps Pharaoh was even giving some consideration to Moses' demands, but it didn't matter
            - God stepped in to harden Pharaoh's heart thus ensuring that the tenth and final judgment would take place
    - This plague has a direct parallel to the plagues of Tribulation
        - There are several instances of the sky being darkened in Tribulation
        - But the most direct parallel is found in the fifth bowl judgment when a similar darkness comes upon the world
            - In that case, the darkness is so great it leaves men gnawing their tongues in pain
- In scripture, the number nine is associated with judgment
    - The first nine judgments are clearly separated from the tenth judgment so as to make a point that this is a period of judgment for Israel
        - And the nine judgments are grouped in threes
        - The number three is the number for God in complete form
        - Taken together, we have a series of plagues designed to communicate God at work bringing judgment
    - And the number ten is the number for testimony
        - Testimony refers to a witness of God
        - And the tenth plague will be that witness to the world of God's work
- In fact, looking looking across all nine plagues, God has shown his power in multiple ways
    - He has shown His power over the natural world, proving He is the Creator
        - Egypt believed other gods were responsible for elements of creations, but God reveals those other gods to be frauds
    - He has shown his power over life and death, having taken Egyptian lives and livestock while preserving Israel untouched

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        - Egypt believed they were preserved by their own power and the power of their gods

    - The Lord has shown his power to sovereignly control human events to confirm to His eternal plan

        - These plagues and the effect they have on Egypt is a perfect picture of God's work still to come during Tribulation

        - Leaving us with evidence that God is at work orchestrating all human history toward an appointed end

    - God has demonstrated His authority over the hearts of men

        - Pharaoh was raised up for the purpose of God turning his heart as God pleased, yielding the outcome God assigned from the beginning

    - Finally, God has demonstrated that He is a covenant-keeping God, fulfilling all the things He promised centuries earlier

- Next time we focus down on the final judgment, which established the Passover feast

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Exodus 11/12

SLIDE 11/12-1

- Having covered the nine plagues of judgment (9=judgment), we now turn to the tenth and most important plague of testimony (10=testimony)
    - Chapter 11 provides a description of the plague much in the same way as the earlier plagues
        - But the tenth plague is intended to stand apart from the rest

SLIDE 11/12-2

        - It doesn't follow the patterns we've been tracking in the earlier plagues
    - Then following the brief description in chapter 11, the Lord gives Moses a new set of instructions centered around the tenth plague and its meaning for Israel

Ex. 11:1 **Now the LORD said to Moses, "One more plague I will bring on Pharaoh and on Egypt; after that he will let you go from here. When he lets you go, he will surely drive you out from here completely.**
Ex. 11:2 **"Speak now in the hearing of the people that each man ask from his neighbor and each woman from her neighbor for articles of silver and articles of gold."**
Ex. 11:3 **The LORD gave the people favor in the sight of the Egyptians. Furthermore, the man Moses himself was greatly esteemed in the land of Egypt, both in the sight of Pharaoh's servants and in the sight of the people.**

- Chapter 11 is both a continuation of the meeting depicted in chapter 10 and an introduction for what comes next
    - In chapter 10 we heard Pharaoh order Moses to leave and never return, and Moses agreed angrily
        - But before Moses departs from the presence of Pharaoh, he delivers this message concerning the tenth plague
        - So this chapter gives us additional information concerning what was spoken in that final meeting
        - And it sets up the arrival of the final plague
    - First, the Lord had informed Moses of the tenth and final plague before Moses had his final meeting with Pharaoh
        - This judgment would be the one to free Israel

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- In fact, the tenth will cause Egypt to drive Israel from the land

- In preparation for that moment, God directs Israel to be prepared to ask their Egyptian neighbors for articles of gold and silver

  - The request must have sounded crazy at the time

- But in v.3 Moses explains why the request isn't so crazy after all

  - The Lord will cause the Egyptians to esteem the people of Israel and Moses and agree to the request

Ex. 11:4 Moses said, "Thus says the LORD, 'About midnight I am going out into the midst of Egypt,
Ex. 11:5 and all the firstborn in the land of Egypt shall die, from the firstborn of the Pharaoh who sits on his throne, even to the firstborn of the slave girl who is behind the millstones; all the firstborn of the cattle as well.
Ex. 11:6 'Moreover, there shall be a great cry in all the land of Egypt, such as there has not been before and such as shall never be again.
Ex. 11:7 'But against any of the sons of Israel a dog will not even bark, whether against man or beast, that you may understand how the LORD makes a distinction between Egypt and Israel.'
Ex. 11:8 "All these your servants will come down to me and bow themselves before me, saying, 'Go out, you and all the people who follow you,' and after that I will go out." And he went out from Pharaoh in hot anger.

- Moses delivers a warning to Pharaoh regarding this final plague

  - The Lord will personally go out into the land of Egypt causing all the firstborn in Egypt to die

    - Both man and animal will die

      - When we reach chapter 13, we learn why God is taking the lives of both man and beast in this judgment

    - When we hear "firstborn" we should remember that age is not a consideration in this judgment

      - A father or mother or grandfather or grandmother who is the firstborn would also die in this judgment

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- Even Pharaoh himself might have died except that he wasn't the first born son of Thutmose III
  - Amenhoptep II had an older brother born to a different mother
  - But before Thutmose III died, his wife and eldest son died
  - As a result, Thutmose III took a second wife and she bore Amenhotep II

- The result of this judgment would be grief beyond anything the nation had experienced thus far
  - Yet God would continue to show distinction between His people and those of Egypt
  - Notice that God is working to discriminate nations, not individuals
    - There is not attempt to tie these judgments to the behavior of individuals other than Pharaoh
    - God is judging one nation for the sake of another nation
    - This reminds us that God's covenants with Israel operate on a national level, which is something we'll see more later
  - Having delivered the full word of the Lord to Pharaoh, Moses leaves hot with anger
    - This moment is the same one depicted in Exodus 10:29

Ex. 11:9 Then the LORD said to Moses, "Pharaoh will not listen to you, so that My wonders will be multiplied in the land of Egypt."
Ex. 11:10 Moses and Aaron performed all these wonders before Pharaoh; yet the LORD hardened Pharaoh's heart, and he did not let the sons of Israel go out of his land.

- The chapter ends with a two verse summary of all that has transpired leading into the tenth judgment
  - God set about to ensure Pharaoh wouldn't listen to Moses
    - And this was done to ensure that all God's wonders would be multiplied in the land of Egypt
  - Moses and Aaron performed these wonders as God instructed
    - And the Lord did as He promised, hardening the Pharaoh's heart

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- Now the Lord gives a series of instructions to Moses to prepare the nation of Israel for this tenth judgment

Ex. 12:1 **Now the LORD said to Moses and Aaron in the land of Egypt,**
Ex. 12:2 **"This month shall be the beginning of months for you; it is to be the first month of the year to you.**

  - By the nature of these instructions, it becomes clear that the tenth plague is intended to carry special meaning for the nation
    - The tenth plague will go by the name of Passover
    - The word comes from the nature of the plague itself, as we'll see

- God's first instruction concerning the Passover concerns the Jewish calendar
  - Remember that the eighth plague destroyed the wheat, which comes up in early March
    - And the ninth plague followed soon thereafter
    - Now the tenth plague is set to happen during late March or April
  - God tells Moses that this month will now become the first month of the year for Israel

SLIDE 11/12-3

    - The Bible calls this month by two different names
    - At the time of Moses, the Jews called it Aviv as we'll see later in chapter 13 of Exodus
      - The name Aviv means fresh young ears, as in the new stalks of grain
      - The month comes in the early Spring, and so the name suggests the beginning of a new harvest
    - After the nation of Israel went into captivity in Babylon, the nation began using the Babylonian word Nisan instead of Aviv
      - Though the word changed, it is the same month on the calendar in early Spring
  - Prior to this change, the nation of Israel followed the same calendar as the Egyptians (and the rest of the ancient east)

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        - The ancient east calendar was a lunar calendar with twelve months

            - The first month of each year occurred in the autumn, between September and October

            - The first month is called Tishri

            - So God changed the first month of the year from Tishri to Aviv - a difference of six months

- Why did God direct this change?

    - The answer is found by looking more closely at the Egyptian calendar

    - The Egyptians saw great spiritual significance in each lunar period and with the astrological sign associated with each month

        - For example, the month of Tishri was began when the sun entered the constellation Libra, which occurs in Sept-Oct

            - Each new month was marked by the arrival of a new constellation in the sky

        - The 12 astrological signs we still have today come from the Egyptian occult religious system

            - If you read your horoscope, you are observing the same Egyptian calendar that existed in the day of Israel

    - Each month in the calendar carried significant spiritual meaning for the Egyptians, especially the first month of the year

        - Each month's astrological sign taught an aspect of Egyptian spiritual beliefs

            - Collectively the twelve astrological signs taught Egyptian theology

        - For example, the first month of Tishri is associated with Libra,

            - The word Libra means scales or weights and the constellation resembles a pair of scales

            - Egyptian believed this sign taught that the gods would weigh a man's deeds upon his death and assess his entry into the afterlife based on the weight of his deeds

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- If the man's deeds could tip the scales in his favor, then he would pass the test of the gods and be granted entry into the after life
- A poor judgment at the scales resulted in the Egyptian version of hell

- So Egypt began each calendar year with a month that reminded them to recommitment to a year of good deeds
  - We many still make New Years resolutions today

- While Israel didn't share in the Egyptian's religious views, it did use the same calendar
  - So until the Exodus, Tishri was the first month of the year for Israel as well
  - Interestingly, after God changed the first month to Aviv, the Jews still wanted to count the start of a new year in Tishri
    - They claim to have counted every year since the creation of Adam
      - By their reckoning, our current year is 5773
    - So to disrupting that count, the Jews continued waiting until Tishri to increase the count of the year
    - We call this the Jewish civic calendar
  - So the Jews number each month beginning with Aviv
    - Aviv is the first month, Tishri is the seventh month, etc.
    - This calendar dictates the observance of the feasts and festivals of the Law
  - But the count of years is incremented in the seventh month of Tishri
    - It would be like us calling January the first month but waiting for July before adding one to the year

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- When God changes this practice in Exodus 12, He sets Israel apart from Egypt and the rest of the ancient world
    - While the rest of the ancient East would observe a new year in the month of Tishri, Israel would observe it in Aviv in the Spring
        - And they would observe it in connection with Passover, a memorial to their flight from Egypt
        - And as we'll see later in the chapter, the defining moment in the Passover is the sacrifice of a lamb
        - This detail is the piece we needed to finally understand why God made this change
    - While the month of Tishri corresponds to Libra, the scales, the month of Aviv begins when the sun moves into the constellation Aries
        - And the constellation Aries is pictured as a sacrificial ram
        - In Egyptian theology, the month of Aviv taught of the need for atoning sacrifice to appease the gods
        - So now we see the Lord purposes in taking the Egyptian symbology and repurposing it for Israel
            - The new calendar will be yet another way He causes Israel to become a distinct people
            - And the change counters the Egyptian theology by placing primary importance on the atoning sacrifice of the Passover rather than on personal works
- As we now look at the instructions of the Passover that God gives to Israel, we will also look for all the ways in which these details complete the picture of Christ
    - The Passover is without a doubt the clearest picture of Christ found in the Old Testament
        - In fact, Paul calls Jesus our Passover in 1Cor 5:7
        - And the importance and uniqueness of the Passover is also reflected in the prominence of the feast in both the OT and NT
    - The Passover is mentioned more than any other feast

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- Jesus isn't just pictured by the Passover feast He becomes its fulfillment
- Jesus dies on the day of Passover

Ex. 12:3 "Speak to all the congregation of Israel, saying, 'On the tenth of this month they are each one to take a lamb for themselves, according to their fathers' households, a lamb for each household.
Ex. 12:4 'Now if the household is too small for a lamb, then he and his neighbor nearest to his house are to take one according to the number of persons in them; according to what each man should eat, you are to divide the lamb.
Ex. 12:5 'Your lamb shall be an unblemished male a year old; you may take it from the sheep or from the goats.
Ex. 12:6 'You shall keep it until the fourteenth day of the same month, then the whole assembly of the congregation of Israel is to kill it at twilight.

- On the tenth day of Aviv, each in family in the nation would take a lamb into their father's house
    - Smaller families would combine to form a single family
        - The purpose in the combining was to ensure that the feast was celebrated corporately
        - The original Passover was a corporate event, one that involved the entire nation of Israel
            - The nation suffered in slavery as a single entity and so it earned its freedom as a single entity
            - If a family were only two or three, the sense of corporate involvement was lost, so smaller families combined to create larger groups
            - According to v.4 the combining continued until there were enough people to ensure the lamb was consumed
    - The sacrifice itself had to selected and kept in a certain way
        - According to v.5, they could sacrifice a male lamb (or a male goat)
        - The lamb had to be a male unblemished
            - A blemish meant any defect in his health or appearance

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- Only lambs that appeared to be perfect could be sacrificed

- It must be one year old

- The lamb must have reached adult age, yet still be in the prime of life

- Finally, the lamb is brought into the father's house on the tenth day of Aviv

- The the lamb remains in the home until the day of the sacrifice

- The day of the day of sacrifice was to be four days later, on the fourteenth of Aviv

- Then v.6 says that all Israel was to collective sacrifice their lambs at twilight

- In the Hebrew, the timing is not actually twilight

- It reads literally "between the two evenings"

- Jews understood the phrase to refer to the period from noon until nightfall

- In other words, the phrase "between the two evenings" means "afternoon"

- So the timing for the killing of the lambs in Israel must take place from 12:00 to 6:00 PM

- In Jesus day, Josephus reports that the Pharisees customarily killed the national passover lamb exactly at 3:00 PM, since this time falls exactly between noon and 6:00 PM

- How do these details contribute to a picture of the Lord?

- To understand the connection we need to jump forward to the finally week of Jesus life as recorded in the Gospels

- On the tenth day of Aviv, Jesus entered Jerusalem on a donkey and promptly went to the Temple court

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John 2:13 The Passover of the Jews was near, and Jesus went up to Jerusalem.
John 2:14 And He found in the temple those who were selling oxen and sheep and doves, and the money changers seated at their tables.
John 2:15 And He made a scourge of cords, and drove them all out of the temple, with the sheep and the oxen; and He poured out the coins of the money changers and overturned their tables;
John 2:16 and to those who were selling the doves He said, "Take these things away; stop making My Father's house a place of business."
John 2:17 His disciples remembered that it was written, "ZEAL FOR YOUR HOUSE WILL CONSUME ME."

- Jesus entered the courts of the temple and found corruption and sin inside the walls
    - He reacts in righteous anger at what He finds and famously runs the money changers out of the temple
        - We'll come back to this moment later in our study of the Passover
    - Then notice that Jesus, who is our Passover Paul says, calls the Temple His "Father's house"
        - We noted a moment ago that the lamb must be taken into the father's household on the tenth of Aviv
        - Here we see the Lamb of God entering His father's house on the appointed day
- Secondly, Passover was a corporate celebration, one that reminded the Jews of their collective exodus from slavery
    - Similarly, Jesus was a single sacrifice for all the sins of the people
    - Jesus was offered to the nation as Lamb of God given to take away the sin of Israel
        - Just as the nation was to come together and observe the Passover together, the nation as a whole was required to accept the sacrifice of the Messiah
        - Either the entire nation of Israel would embrace their Messiah or they would collectively reject him
        - As we know, the nation rejected their Messiah, and so they collectively remained in bondage to sin

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- Thirdly, the sacrifice itself had requirements
  - It must be an adult make in the prime of life and without blemish
  - Jesus fit this description exactly
    - We know He was male and at the strongest time in life
    - We also know He was without blemish
    - Paul says:

2Cor. 5:21 He made Him who knew no sin to be sin on our behalf, so that we might become the righteousness of God in Him.

- We can find an even more specific parallel between Jesus and the Passover Lamb
  - While the lamb was living in the father's house, the family would spend the four days inspecting the lamb for defects
    - If a defect was discovered, the lamb wouldn't have been suitable for the sacrifice
    - The same pattern repeated itself in the case of Jesus
  - After Jesus entered the Temple, he began teaching the people
    - As He taught, the religious leaders conspired against Him in an attempt to discredit Jesus in the sight of the people
    - Luke reports:

Luke 19:47 And He was teaching daily in the temple; but the chief priests and the scribes and the leading men among the people were trying to destroy Him,
Luke 19:48 and they could not find anything that they might do, for all the people were hanging on to every word He said.

  - Each day Jesus spent in the temple leading up to the Passover, He was confronted by a different group of Jewish leaders
    - First it was the chief priests and scribes and Pharisees
    - Then the Herodians
    - Finally the Sadducees

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- Each group tried to trick Jesus with questions designed to make Him look foolish
    - But in case, Jesus answered the charge successfully and turned the shame back on His accusers
    - This went on for four days and at the end, Jesus was found innocent and blameless
    - He was without blemish

- Finally, Jesus was placed on the cross exactly four days later, on the day of Passover
    - Jesus was hung on the cross at nine in the morning Mark tells us
        - And Mark also tells us that Jesus died at exactly 3:00 PM
        - Jesus died at exactly the same moment that the High Priest of Israel was sacrificing the national Passover lamb that day
            - There has never been such a useless animal sacrifice offered
    - So Jesus fit these requirements perfectly as the Lamb of God sacrificed
        - And remember that we've already noted how the Exodus itself is a picture
            - God frees Israel from slavery in Egypt and brings them to worship at a mountain
            - Ultimately He brings them to the doorstep of the Promised Land
        - This story pictures God's future work of freeing Israel from the bondage of sin and unbelief
            - After the judgments of Tribulation, God will bring faith to the nation of Israel and lead them to worship at Mt Zion in the Kingdom
            - Then the nation will enter into the eternal Promised Land
    - And how does God accomplish this work of redemption on behalf of Israel?
        - It doesn't come as a result of the judgments

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        - They merely set up the ultimately event: the Passover
        - Because of the Passover, Israel finally gains its freedom
    - Likewise, at the end of Tribulation Israel will come to faith not because of the judgments of Tribulation
        - Rather, it will be by the grace of the Lamb of God, Jesus
        - By His sacrifice, the nation will be saved and receive their Lord

Ex. 12:7 **'Moreover, they shall take some of the blood and put it on the two doorposts and on the lintel of the houses in which they eat it.**
Ex. 12:8 **'They shall eat the flesh that same night, roasted with fire, and they shall eat it with unleavened bread and bitter herbs.**
Ex. 12:9 **'Do not eat any of it raw or boiled at all with water, but rather roasted with fire, both its head and its legs along with its entrails.**
Ex. 12:10 **'And you shall not leave any of it over until morning, but whatever is left of it until morning, you shall burn with fire.**
Ex. 12:11 **'Now you shall eat it in this manner: with your loins girded, your sandals on your feet, and your staff in your hand; and you shall eat it in haste — it is the LORD'S Passover.**
Ex. 12:12 **'For I will go through the land of Egypt on that night, and will strike down all the firstborn in the land of Egypt, both man and beast; and against all the gods of Egypt I will execute judgments — I am the LORD.**
Ex. 12:13 **'The blood shall be a sign for you on the houses where you live; and when I see the blood I will pass over you, and no plague will befall you to destroy you when I strike the land of Egypt.**

- God continues with the instructions to Israel
    - The blood of the lamb was to be applied to the doorway of each house
        - The blood was to be applied with hyssop branch (v.22)
        - It was applied to the top beam and the side beams but not the threshold
            - The threshold can be tread upon
        - The blood represented the life of the animal, since the blood poured out resulted in the death of the animal
    - Following this the animals was to be roasted by fire, not boiled or prepared in any other way

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- The animal was roasted whole with head and legs still attached to the body
    - My version mentions entrails, but that's an unfortunate translation
    - The animal was gutted, but the carcass was left entirely intact
    - The intent was that the animal would still resemble an animal after cooking
        - It wasn't sectioned into parts and made to appear simply as meat
- Furthermore, the entire animal had to be consumed or else burned
    - The sacrifice was to be totally consumed as if it had disappeared
    - In the day of the Exodus, this it made sense that nothing was to be left after the meal
    - The nation was to leave in haste immediately afterward, and so there would be no way to preserve leftover meat

- Next, the people were to eat the meal ready to leave in haste
    - They were dressed in a way that indicated they were ready to move on command
        - This is a requirement unique to the first Passover
        - In future observances of the Passover, this was no longer observed
        - Jesus Himself didn't observe this command when He celebrated the meal with the disciples on the night before He died
- Finally, the Lord tells Israel that the blood on the door will be their salvation when the judgment of death comes
    - The Lord is intent on going out into the land of Egypt and bringing death to the first born

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- Israel will escape this judgment through the application of this blood
    - In past judgments, the nation did nothing to escape the plagues
    - But now they must apply the blood to escape
    - This final judgment will come to Israel also unless they apply the blood

- We can easily see how these details are reflective of Jesus
    - The Bible tells us that the blood of Christ is the atonement for our sin

1John 1:7 but if we walk in the Light as He Himself is in the Light, we have fellowship with one another, and the blood of Jesus His Son cleanses us from all sin.

1Pet. 1:18 knowing that you were not redeemed with perishable things like silver or gold from your futile way of life inherited from your forefathers,
1Pet. 1:19 but with precious blood, as of a lamb unblemished and spotless, the blood of Christ.

- His blood stands between us and the judgment that comes upon all men for their sin, the Second Death
    - It covers us and when God looks upon us, He "sees" the blood of Christ and does not bring judgment against us
- Furthermore, the blood was applied in a shape reminiscent of the cross

- But the blood itself wouldn't save the family unless it was applied in the manner God described
    - They had to apply it to the door in faith that God would keep His word
    - They knew God was bringing this judgment, and they had faith in His word that He would spare Israel by the blood

- Speaking of Moses, the writer says

Heb. 11:28 By faith he kept the Passover and the sprinkling of the blood, so that he who destroyed the firstborn would not touch them.

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- Next come more instructions concerning the observance of this feast in the future

Ex. 12:14 'Now this day will be a memorial to you, and you shall celebrate it as a feast to the LORD; throughout your generations you are to celebrate it as a permanent ordinance.
Ex. 12:15 'Seven days you shall eat unleavened bread, but on the first day you shall remove leaven from your houses; for whoever eats anything leavened from the first day until the seventh day, that person shall be cut off from Israel.
Ex. 12:16 'On the first day you shall have a holy assembly, and another holy assembly on the seventh day; no work at all shall be done on them, except what must be eaten by every person, that alone may be prepared by you.
Ex. 12:17 'You shall also observe the Feast of Unleavened Bread, for on this very day I brought your hosts out of the land of Egypt; therefore you shall observe this day throughout your generations as a permanent ordinance.
Ex. 12:18 'In the first month, on the fourteenth day of the month at evening, you shall eat unleavened bread, until the twenty-first day of the month at evening.
Ex. 12:19 'Seven days there shall be no leaven found in your houses; for whoever eats what is leavened, that person shall be cut off from the congregation of Israel, whether he is an alien or a native of the land.
Ex. 12:20 'You shall not eat anything leavened; in all your dwellings you shall eat unleavened bread.'"

- The Passover is commanded as a single-day memorial forever in Israel
    - It is a single day event, and it should be observed perpetually
        - This means we can expect to see the nation celebrating it even in the Kingdom
        - The Passover day may be the origin for the term "day of the Lord" among the OT prophets
            - The term "day of the Lord" refers to the period of Tribulation in the last days
                - This is a time of judgment followed by blessing for Israel
            - Similarly, the day of Passover was a day of judgment followed by blessing for Israel
    - This event is to be combined with a second memorial that begins on the very next day

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        - The Jews were to eat only unleavened bread for seven day
        - The leaven or yeast was to be removed from the house on the first day
        - After this, no may eat leavened bread
            - The penalty for eating leavened bread in v.15 is to be "cut off"
            - The word in Hebrew implies killed, so the penalty for eating leavened bread was to be put to death
    - The first and the seventh days of the feast are Sabbath days when no work may take place
        - Work may be done in between these days
        - But no leaven may be eaten during the entire seven days
    - At the time of the Exodus, this seven day period corresponded to the time between the killing of the first born and the nation's arrival at the coast of the Red Sea
        - After seven days of literally constant traveling, they finally stopped
        - This constant travel prevented the nation from taking time to bake leavened bread, thus necessitating the unleavened bread

- These instructions continue to parallels between the Exodus and Jesus as the Passover Lamb
    - First, Passover feast is a permanent ordinance never to end
        - Similarly, the sacrifice of Jesus, our Passover Lamb, is a forever sacrifice that never ceases to be effective in atoning for sin

Heb. 7:27 who does not need daily, like those high priests, to offer up sacrifices, first for His own sins and then for the sins of the people, because this He did once for all when He offered up Himself.

    - Having accepted the sacrifice of Christ on our behalf, believers now enter a new period of life
        - We are called to set aside sin and live a life set apart for the glory of God

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- We are called to a walk of sanctification in which we told not to sin but rather pursue holiness
    - In the Bible yeast or leaven is a picture of sin
    - So to remove yeast or leaven from the home was a picture of removing sin from our life
    - The seven days represent our life lead after our salvation in Christ when we are working to avoid sin

1Cor. 5:6 **Your boasting is not good. Do you not know that a little leaven leavens the whole lump of dough?**
1Cor. 5:7 **Clean out the old leaven so that you may be a new lump, just as you are in fact unleavened. For Christ our Passover also has been sacrificed.**
1Cor. 5:8 **Therefore let us celebrate the feast, not with old leaven, nor with the leaven of malice and wickedness, but with the unleavened bread of sincerity and truth.**

- Our walk with Christ in faith is a time when we are working to put aside sin, but this period is sandwiched between two other moments where we do no work
    - On the day of our salvation, we are not working at all
    - Instead, our salvation comes by faith and not by works
    - Similarly, at the end of our life in Christ, we will see the final step of redemption take place when we will be glorified
        - And that day is also a day in which God does all the work and we do nothing but receive His grace

Rom. 8:30 **and these whom He predestined, He also called; and these whom He called, He also justified; and these whom He justified, He also glorified.**

- Lastly, in the day of Israel's redemption, this pattern repeats
    - The nation will be called to accept their sacrifice and those who do will be given the right to enter the Kingdom
        - But only the righteous can enter the Kingdom

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1Cor. 6:9 Or do you not know that the unrighteous will not inherit the kingdom of God? Do not be deceived; neither fornicators, nor idolaters, nor adulterers, nor effeminate, nor homosexuals,
1Cor. 6:10 nor thieves, nor the covetous, nor drunkards, nor revilers, nor swindlers, will inherit the kingdom of God.

- Therefore, the one in Israel who is not free of leaven (i.e., sin) will be cut off from the rest of Israel
  - This refers to how the unbelieving Jews will die at the coming of Christ at the end of Tribulation
  - Only those free of sin will enter the kingdom after the Tribulation
  - The rebels will be cut off

Ezek. 20:36 "As I entered into judgment with your fathers in the wilderness of the land of Egypt, so I will enter into judgment with you," declares the Lord GOD.
Ezek. 20:37 "I will make you pass under the rod, and I will bring you into the bond of the covenant;
Ezek. 20:38 and I will purge from you the rebels and those who transgress against Me; I will bring them out of the land where they sojourn, but they will not enter the land of Israel. Thus you will know that I am the LORD.

- So with the instructions given and the memorial set, the time comes for the lambs to be sacrificed
  - The lamb has spent four days in the homes of the Jews
    - So the 14th of Aviv has arrived and the lambs are killed and sacrificed

Ex. 12:21 Then Moses called for all the elders of Israel and said to them, "Go and take for yourselves lambs according to your families, and slay the Passover lamb.
Ex. 12:22 "You shall take a bunch of hyssop and dip it in the blood which is in the basin, and apply some of the blood that is in the basin to the lintel and the two doorposts; and none of you shall go outside the door of his house until morning.
Ex. 12:23 "For the LORD will pass through to smite the Egyptians; and when He sees the blood on the lintel and on the two doorposts, the LORD will pass over the door and will not allow the destroyer to come in to your houses to smite you.
Ex. 12:24 "And you shall observe this event as an ordinance for you and your children forever.

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Ex. 12:25 "When you enter the land which the LORD will give you, as He has promised, you shall observe this rite.
Ex. 12:26 "And when your children say to you, 'What does this rite mean to you?'
Ex. 12:27 you shall say, 'It is a Passover sacrifice to the LORD who passed over the houses of the sons of Israel in Egypt when He smote the Egyptians, but spared our homes.'" And the people bowed low and worshiped.
Ex. 12:28 Then the sons of Israel went and did so; just as the LORD had commanded Moses and Aaron, so they did.
Ex. 12:29 Now it came about at midnight that the LORD struck all the firstborn in the land of Egypt, from the firstborn of Pharaoh who sat on his throne to the firstborn of the captive who was in the dungeon, and all the firstborn of cattle.
Ex. 12:30 Pharaoh arose in the night, he and all his servants and all the Egyptians, and there was a great cry in Egypt, for there was no home where there was not someone dead.
Ex. 12:31 Then he called for Moses and Aaron at night and said, "Rise up, get out from among my people, both you and the sons of Israel; and go, worship the LORD, as you have said.
Ex. 12:32 "Take both your flocks and your herds, as you have said, and go, and bless me also."
Ex. 12:33 The Egyptians urged the people, to send them out of the land in haste, for they said, "We will all be dead."
Ex. 12:34 So the people took their dough before it was leavened, with their kneading bowls bound up in the clothes on their shoulders.

- The angel of the Lord goes throughout the land of Egypt taking the life of the first born at midnight
    - Every house experienced death of some kind
        - Every first born male human being and animal perished
        - The cries of Egypt were great that night and the Jews would have heard them
        - But not a single person died in Israel
    - Pharaoh loses his first born son, a boy whose identity has been lost to history
        - But we know his successor Thutmose IV was not the first born son

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        - In fact, he invented a story that the Sphinx appeared to him in a dream and told him he would be king if he cleared the sand covering the Sphinx
        - It was a cover story to gain acceptance as the Pharaoh since he wasn't the first born

- With this final plague, the Pharaoh relents entirely
    - He make no attempt to compromise
        - God is no longer hardening his heart
        - And the death of his son leaves him without the will to fight Israel any longer
    - He orders Moses and Aaron to see him in the middle of the night and then orders all Israel to leave
        - The people of Egypt also urged the Jews to leave, since they had no idea how far this was going
        - They feared that everyone would die soon
    - The opportunity to leave combined with the pressure from the people of Egypt created the need to leave in haste
        - Taking their time was simply not an option, which is why the Lord called for Israel to eat the Passover meal in haste
        - They would now begin a seven day journey into the wilderness during which time they would eat unleavened bread

Ex. 12:35 Now the sons of Israel had done according to the word of Moses, for they had requested from the Egyptians articles of silver and articles of gold, and clothing;
Ex. 12:36 and the LORD had given the people favor in the sight of the Egyptians, so that they let them have their request. Thus they plundered the Egyptians.
Ex. 12:37 Now the sons of Israel journeyed from Rameses to Succoth, about six hundred thousand men on foot, aside from children.
Ex. 12:38 A mixed multitude also went up with them, along with flocks and herds, a very large number of livestock.
Ex. 12:39 They baked the dough which they had brought out of Egypt into cakes of unleavened bread. For it had not become leavened, since they were driven out of Egypt and could not delay, nor had they prepared any provisions for themselves.

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- As the Egyptians urged the Jews to leave, they remembered what Moses had instructed them to do earlier
    - They took advantage of the opportunity to request articles of gold and silver from their neighbors
        - Since the people were desperate to see Israel leave, they gladly gave the Jews whatever they wanted just to see them leave
        - In this way they plundered the Egyptians
            - After centuries of working for free, the nation left rich at the expense of the Egyptians
            - The wealth they collect here will be used to outfit the first tabernacle
    - Finally, the nation baked unleavened bread to eat during the exodus, since there was no time to back proper bread
        - Of course they was in keeping with God's instructions as well
- When they left, the men alone number 600,000
    - Therefore, the nation was about 2 million strong
        - This is a huge army of people moving together through the desert
        - And they had a huge number of livestock as well

SLIDE 11/12-3

    - Supporting them in harsh circumstances will require a series of miracles
        - The first move is a short step away from their homes in Ramses to a point near the outskirts of Egypt in Succoth
        - From here they step into the Sinai peninsula and leave Egypt

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Exodus 13

SLIDE 13-1

- With the start of chapter 12, we entered the third division of the book of Genesis, God's redemption of His people through the Passover and it runs through chapter 13
    - Last week we studied the details of the Passover judgment, including looking for many of the signs of Christ evident in the memorial
        - And at the end of the lessons, we had reached the point where the nation was no longer enslaved
        - They were now free to leave
    - Not only were they leaving behind slavery, they also left behind poverty
        - They walked out a rich nation, having plundered the Egyptians
        - Now Moses records the departure and the early stages of the Exodus
            - Last week we read they traveled a short distance from their encampment in Rameses to Succoth

SLIDE 13-2

            - This brings them to the border of Egypt
            - At this point, they leave Egypt and become a nation under the charge of the Lord

Ex. 12:40 Now the time that the sons of Israel lived in Egypt was four hundred and thirty years.
Ex. 12:41 And at the end of four hundred and thirty years, to the very day, all the hosts of the LORD went out from the land of Egypt.

SLIDE 13-3

- Moses reports that the nation of Israel lived in Egypt for 430 years
    - And that after 430 years, to the very day, all the host of the Lord went out from Egypt
        - God's sovereignty is clearly evident in Moses' statement
        - God orchestrated events so that the day of their departure matched perfect a day 430 years earlier
    - But this synchronicity is even more remarkable than it seems at first

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- And in order to understand how, we need to take a closer look at the 430 year period Moses is describing here
- We will rely extensively on the slide handouts to explain this section of Scripture

- First, let's consider Paul's commentary on this timeline in Galatians

SLIDE 13-4

Gal. 3:16 Now the promises were spoken to Abraham and to his seed. He does not say, "And to seeds," as referring to many, but rather to one, "And to your seed," that is, Christ.
Gal. 3:17 What I am saying is this: the Law, which came four hundred and thirty years later, does not invalidate a covenant previously ratified by God, so as to nullify the promise.
Gal. 3:18 For if the inheritance is based on law, it is no longer based on a promise; but God has granted it to Abraham by means of a promise.

- Paul uses to mile markers to anchor the 430 year period
  - One anchor is the giving of the covenant to Abraham when he left Ur and entered Canaan
    - This is the Abrahamic Covenant
  - The other anchor is the giving of the Law at Mt. Sinai
  - Between these two points Paul says there are 430 years
- If we place that timeline on top of the earlier timeline of Exodus 12, we immediately find an apparent conflict
  - Israel could not live in Egypt for 430 years AND the time between Abraham's covenant and Moses' covenant also be 430 years
  - So we have a dilemma to resolve
  - But it gets worse

- When we look at the moment when Abraham received that covenant in Genesis 15, we hear the Lord say this:

SLIDE 13-5

Gen. 15:13 God said to Abram, "Know for certain that your descendants will be strangers in a land that is not theirs, where they will be enslaved and oppressed four hundred years.

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- The Lord's testimony to Abram seems to say that his descendants would be in Egypt for four hundred years
  - Again, if we overlay this timeline on the others, we find a third contradiction
  - Stephen repeats the 400 number in his speech in Acts 7

Acts 7:6 **"But God spoke to this effect, that his DESCENDANTS WOULD BE ALIENS IN A FOREIGN LAND, AND THAT THEY WOULD BE ENSLAVED AND MISTREATED FOR FOUR HUNDRED YEARS.**

  - Now the period of time in Egypt is 400 years long, or so it seems
  - Now we have three different statements to reconcile
  - But it gets worse
- In that same giving of the covenant, the Lord reveals to Abraham that his descendants will eventually return to the land
  - And that return will happen after four generations

SLIDE 13-6

Gen. 15:16 **"Then in the fourth generation they will return here, for the iniquity of the Amorite is not yet complete."**

  - The four generations that experienced time in Egypt began with Jacob's sons who entered the land
    - We can trace the generations who lived in the land in severals places in the Bible
    - In Exodus 6, 1Chron 6 and 1Chron 23 we see the genealogy of Israel traced during the time of sojourn in Egypt
  - Using the genealogy in Exodus 6 we trace the four generations from Jacob to Moses
    - Jacob's son, Levi, entered the land
    - He brought a son Kohath with him when he entering Egypt
      - So even as the time in Egypt began, the next generation was already alive

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- Then Kohath had a sin Amram
- And Amram was the father of Moses

- So the four generations can be represented by Levi, Kohath, Amram and finally Moses
- Moses was the last generation to live in Egypt

- Even under the most generous estimates of age, we cannot cover 400 years (much less 430 years) with only four generations
- Even the most generous estimates still fall over a hundred years short
- So the "four generations" requirement places an upper limit on how long the nation lived in Egypt
- And this upper limit is far less than 400 years, probably closer to half that time
- So now we have a fourth discrepancy to reconcile
- But it gets worse

- While we can't accurate determine the length of time between generations in Egypt, we can accurately calculate the time between generations before Israel entered Egypt
- Abraham received the promise of the covenant when he was 100 SLIDE 13-7
- It was 25 more years before Isaac was born
- It was 60 more years before Jacob was born
- And Jacob was 130 years old when he entered Egypt

Gen. 47:9 **So Jacob said to Pharaoh, "The years of my sojourning are one hundred and thirty; few and unpleasant have been the years of my life, nor have they attained the years that my fathers lived during the days of their sojourning."**

- Therefore, we can easily calculate a period of 215 years between the moment Abraham received his covenant and the moment Israel entered Egypt
- This number places a limit on how long Israel could live in Egypt

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        - So now we have a fifth data point to reconcile
        - We had better stop looking for before it gets even worse

- As you might imagine, people who doubt the Bible's authority and wish to discredit what it says have pointed to these apparent inconsistencies as proof of the Bible's untrustworthiness
    - As you'll soon see, such claims are merely proof that the accuser is ignorant of Scripture and lacks the counsel of the Holy Spirit
        - We may not always be able to solve the riddles of scripture in a moment when we're challenged
        - But we can rest assured that the riddles have solutions and the Lord will shame all His accusers in the day of His glory
    - And this riddle is no different, so let's solve it
- First, let's begin with the scripture references that provide unshakable time anchors SLIDE 13-8
    - For example, Paul's teaching in Galatians clearly establishes that the period of time between the two covenants was 430 years
        - Everything else must fit within that period
    - Secondly, the ages of the patriarchs are irrefutable in scripture
        - So we know the time from the covenant with Abraham until Jacob entered Egypt was 215 years
        - These two data points give us something to work with when examining the rest of the references
    - The next thing we notice is that the 215 is exactly half of 430
        - So using simple math, we calculate that the period from Jacob's entry into Egypt until the nation leaves under Moses' leadership was also 215 years SLIDE 13-9
        - Therefore, the period of four generations mentioned in Genesis 15 spanned a second period of 215 years
            - This length of time works much better when calculating the ages of the Levi's descendants than the earlier 400 year suggestion

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- Next, let's revisit where we started tonight in Exodus 12

SLIDE 13-10

Ex. 12:40 Now the time that the sons of Israel lived in Egypt was four hundred and thirty years.
Ex. 12:41 And at the end of four hundred and thirty years, to the very day, all the hosts of the LORD went out from the land of Egypt.

- In my Bible (NASB) we read that the sons of Israel lived in Egypt four hundred and thirty years
  - Interestingly, Moses is using the 430-year period again as did Paul
  - But Moses seems to say the 430 years represents the time Israel lived in Egypt
    - But we've already established conclusively that Israel could only have lived in Egypt for 215 years
- This statement flatly contradicts what we've already concluded, so how can we reconcile this verse?
  - The answer comes from a closer examination of the Hebrew text itself
  - And in this case, we need to go back to one of the earliest translations of the Hebrew Bible, the Septuagint (LXX)
    - The LXX was a Greek translation of the Hebrew Bible authored by 70 learned Jewish leaders
    - It represents one of the most authoritative versions of the Jewish scriptures in existence
  - When we look at these same verses found in the LXX, this is what we read

Ex. 12:40 And the sojourning of the children of Israel, while they sojourned in the land of Egypt and the land of Chanaan, was four hundred and thirty years.
Ex. 12:41 And it came to pass after the four hundred and thirty years, all the forces of the Lord came forth out of the land of Egypt by night.

- Notice that this translation counts the 430 years very differently
  - Here the time period includes all the people of the seed promise sojourned in both the land of Egypt and the land of Canaan

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        - Then the 430 years was complete when the sojourning ended
        - When the nation was no longer wandering in a land that wasn't their own, then the clock stopped

- So the period of 430 in Exodus 12 is the same period that Paul is describing SLIDE 13-11
    - It is the period from the call to Abram and the giving of the covenant until the giving of the second covenant when Israel left Egypt
        - The period is a total of 430 years, divided into two halves of 215 years
    - Notably, Moses says they nation left on 430 years exactly on the day
        - What day would that be then?
        - What happened exactly 430 years earlier from the day Israel left Egypt?
        - It was the day God appeared to Abraham in Genesis 15 and gave Abraham the covenant promising Isaac
        - And what day was that? The 14th of Aviv
            - The Passover day
            - Now we see an even more impressive display of God's sovereignty
            - He worked to bring Israel out of bondage just as He promised Abraham on the day of redemption
            - Exactly 430 years later
- We still need to make sense of the Lord's statement made in Gen 15 promising that Israel would be in a foreign land for 400 years? How does this fit? SLIDE 13-12

Gen. 15:13 God said to Abram, "Know for certain that your descendants will be strangers in a land that is not theirs, where they will be enslaved and oppressed four hundred years.

- First, notice that the Lord's promise begins with Abraham's descendants
    - So the Lord isn't starting the clock until Abraham has a descendant
        - At the moment God gives Abraham this declaration, we are 11 years away from Abraham receiving Ishmael

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        - But we have to remember that the Lord's statement to Abraham in Genesis 15 was part of God's promises in His covenant
            - And the Bible tells us that these promises were spoken not of Ishmael but of Isaac
                - And we are 25 years away from Isaac's arrival
            - So If Abraham's descendants will be oppressed for 400 years, then we must add 25 more years that Abraham spent waiting for that descendant to arrive
    - Secondly, the Lord's statement in Genesis 15:13 must be understood in light of the Hebrew grammar
        - The Lord says that Abraham's descendants will be strangers in a land, enslaved and oppressed for found hundred years
        - What does the time period "400 years" describe?
            - Is this the time they were strangers having left Ur?
            - Is it the time they were wanderers in Canaan?
            - Is it the time they were enslaved in Egypt?
            - Is it the time they were oppressed in slavery?
        - The grammar of the sentence indicates that 400 years describes all these things
            - So Abraham's descendants will be subjected to a period of 400 years of wandering as strangers in a land that is not their own
            - And a part of that time will include slavery and oppression
- So the 400 years ends when Israel leaves slavery in Egypt
    - And it goes back to the time Israel wandered in Canaan, which was a strange land that was not their own
        - Abraham, Isaac and Jacob's wanderings were a sign of faith in this promise
        - They lived a nomadic lifestyle as a matter of choice to demonstrate their faith in this promise

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- But when we place the 400 years on our timeline and add the 25 years Abraham waited for Isaac's birth, we still come up 5 years short

SLIDE 13-13

  - Where are the extra fives years to be found?
  - Let's go back to Galatians to find the answer

SLIDE 13-14

Gal. 4:22 For it is written that Abraham had two sons, one by the bondwoman and one by the free woman.
Gal. 4:23 But the son by the bondwoman was born according to the flesh, and the son by the free woman through the promise.

- First, we remember that Abraham had two sons, as we said
  - And the one we are using for our count is the child of the promise, Isaac
  - When Isaac was born, Ishmael was already 13 years old
  - And though God considered Isaac to be Abraham's heir, Abraham was still assuming Ishmael would share in his inheritance
- So from Abraham's point of view, the true descendant was still unclear
  - Only after the true heir was identified does the 400 year count begin
  - For the first few years of Isaac's life, that clarity was lacking
  - So the 400 year count didn't start with Isaac's birth
- When did it start then?

Gal. 4:29 But as at that time he who was born according to the flesh persecuted him who was born according to the Spirit, so it is now also.
Gal. 4:30 But what does the Scripture say? "CAST OUT THE BONDWOMAN AND HER SON, FOR THE SON OF THE BONDWOMAN SHALL NOT BE AN HEIR WITH THE SON OF THE FREE WOMAN."

- After Isaac's was weaned, the Lord appears to Abraham and instructs him to send Ishmael away because Ismael was not to be an heir
  - This was the moment when Abraham finally learned that Isaac alone was to be his descendant according to the promise in Genesis 15

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- Genesis tells us that the moment of this separation was on the occasion of Isaac's weaning

SLIDE 13-15

Gen. 21:8 The child grew and was weaned, and Abraham made a great feast on the day that Isaac was weaned.
Gen. 21:9 Now Sarah saw the son of Hagar the Egyptian, whom she had borne to Abraham, mocking.
Gen. 21:10 Therefore she said to Abraham, "Drive out this maid and her son, for the son of this maid shall not be an heir with my son Isaac."
Gen. 21:11 The matter distressed Abraham greatly because of his son.
Gen. 21:12 But God said to Abraham, "Do not be distressed because of the lad and your maid; whatever Sarah tells you, listen to her, for through Isaac your descendants shall be named.

- Children were weaned in the ancient world with a feast on their fifth birthday

SLIDE 13-16

  - So we take the 400 years in God's promise for Abraham's descendants and add 25 years of waiting and another 5 years for the weaning
    - After the additional 30 years God clearly identified to Abraham who would be the descendant
    - At this point the 400 years begins to count
    - And these dates reconcile perfectly with the rest of our timeline

- So to summarize, Abraham and his descendants wandered in Canaan for 215 years, and then sojourned in Egypt for another 215 years
  - And during the second period of 215, the nation was enslaved and oppressed
    - But after 430 years, God's promise to redeem Israel was fulfilled
    - In fact, Moses says that it was exactly 430 years to the day that God's promise to Abraham was fulfilled
    - Such exactness demonstrates that God is so careful in keeping his promises, that He doesn't even round off the numbers
    - The Lord's uncompromising faithfulness is reflected in His perfect precision and timing
  - One more thought on God's timing...

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- Moses's says the nation left precisely on the same day as the day God gave Abraham the promise
- We know the day Israel left Egypt was the 14th of Aviv, Passover
- So that means the Lord delivered His promise to Abraham on the 14th of Aviv, the future day of Passover

- The Lord's promise was to free Israel from bondage in Egypt
  - But it also included the promise that the Lord would bring a Seed through Abraham to bless the entire world
    - Paul tells us in Galatians that the "seed" refers to Christ
  - These promises were spoken on the 14th of Aviv (or Nisan) and both of these promises are fulfilled on the 14th of Nisan
    - Israel received freedom on the 14th of Nisan, 430 years later
    - And the world received it's Passover Lamb on the 14th of Nisan when Jesus died on the cross
  - God's sovereignty and precision are stunning

- Finally, the Lord reminds Israel of the sanctity of the Passover celebration

Ex. 12:42 It is a night to be observed for the LORD for having brought them out from the land of Egypt; this night is for the LORD, to be observed by all the sons of Israel throughout their generations.
Ex. 12:43 The LORD said to Moses and Aaron, "This is the ordinance of the Passover: no foreigner is to eat of it;
Ex. 12:44 but every man's slave purchased with money, after you have circumcised him, then he may eat of it.
Ex. 12:45 "A sojourner or a hired servant shall not eat of it.
Ex. 12:46 "It is to be eaten in a single house; you are not to bring forth any of the flesh outside of the house, nor are you to break any bone of it.
Ex. 12:47 "All the congregation of Israel are to celebrate this.
Ex. 12:48 "But if a stranger sojourns with you, and celebrates the Passover to the LORD, let all his males be circumcised, and then let him come near to celebrate it; and he shall be like a native of the land. But no uncircumcised person may eat of it.
Ex. 12:49 "The same law shall apply to the native as to the stranger who sojourns among you."

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Ex. 12:50 Then all the sons of Israel did so; they did just as the LORD had commanded Moses and Aaron.
Ex. 12:51 And on that same day the LORD brought the sons of Israel out of the land of Egypt by their hosts.

- Forevermore, the nation is to observe the night of the Passover as a memorial to the work of God in fulfilling His promise
    - This is the memory the Lord wants Israel to have from their time in Egypt
        - Though 430 years have passed and many events have transpired in the lives of Israel since the giving of the promise, the Lord only wants this moment to be memorialized
        - The faithfulness of God to passover Israel and bring them out of bondage
        - That moment is the one to remember
    - This is yet another another parallel to the last days of Tribulation, when God brings His ultimate fulfillment of His promises to Israel
        - The Exodus pictures the way the Lord will one free Israel from her bondage to sin and disobedience
        - The Lord will use great judgments to free the nation, but ultimately the nation's freedom comes by way of their Passover, the Messiah
        - And after that moment, the nation will enter into the glory of the Kingdom
    - At that point, the only memory the nation will carry will be the memory of the Lord's redemption
        - The Passover, that is Christ, will be the memory Israel carries into the Kingdom
        - They will not remember the years of wandering when they were scattered among the nations
        - They will not remember their years of oppression at the hands of their enemies
    - As Isaiah says

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Is. 65:16 "Because he who is blessed in the earth
Will be blessed by the God of truth;
And he who swears in the earth
Will swear by the God of truth;
Because the former troubles are forgotten,
And because they are hidden from My sight!
Is. 65:17 "For behold, I create new heavens and a new earth;
And the former things will not be remembered or come to mind.
Is. 65:18 "But be glad and rejoice forever in what I create;
For behold, I create Jerusalem for rejoicing
And her people for gladness.
Is. 65:19 "I will also rejoice in Jerusalem and be glad in My people;
And there will no longer be heard in her
The voice of weeping and the sound of crying.

- Furthermore, the Lord commands that only those who are truly apart of Israel may enjoy the Passover
    - Foreigners may not participate unless they have become a part of Israel by circumcision
        - If they have not adopted the sign of the covenant, than they may not enjoy the fellowship of that covenant
        - The sign of the Abrahamic covenant was circumcision, while the Passover was a memorial of that same covenant
        - So is a person had not taken the sign, they were not free to participate in the memorial
            - Notice in v.49 this rule applied equally to both native (jew) and stranger
            - Women were always under the spiritual authority of a man, whether a father, uncle, brother or husband
            - If the man was circumcised, then all the women under his spiritual authority were also covered
    - Our New Covenant in Christ follows a similar test
        - The sign of our covenant is water baptism
        - And the memorial of God's faithfulness to the covenant is our communion meal

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- The meal remembers the Lord's faithfulness to His covenant by dying in our place on the cross

- If we haven't been water baptized - even if we are a believer - then we are not permitted to participate in the communion meal

- These are the only two ordinances of the church found in scripture, and they are linked in this way

- Before the nation begins their dash across the desert, in chapter 13 the Lord gives Moses one more command associated with the Passover observance

Ex. 13:1 Then the LORD spoke to Moses, saying,
Ex. 13:2 "Sanctify to Me every firstborn, the first offspring of every womb among the sons of Israel, both of man and beast; it belongs to Me."
Ex. 13:3 Moses said to the people, "Remember this day in which you went out from Egypt, from the house of slavery; for by a powerful hand the LORD brought you out from this place. And nothing leavened shall be eaten.
Ex. 13:4 "On this day in the month of Abib, you are about to go forth.
Ex. 13:5 "It shall be when the LORD brings you to the land of the Canaanite, the Hittite, the Amorite, the Hivite and the Jebusite, which He swore to your fathers to give you, a land flowing with milk and honey, that you shall observe this rite in this month.
Ex. 13:6 "For seven days you shall eat unleavened bread, and on the seventh day there shall be a feast to the LORD.
Ex. 13:7 "Unleavened bread shall be eaten throughout the seven days; and nothing leavened shall be seen among you, nor shall any leaven be seen among you in all your borders.
Ex. 13:8 "You shall tell your son on that day, saying, 'It is because of what the LORD did for me when I came out of Egypt.'
Ex. 13:9 "And it shall serve as a sign to you on your hand, and as a reminder on your forehead, that the law of the LORD may be in your mouth; for with a powerful hand the LORD brought you out of Egypt.
Ex. 13:10 "Therefore, you shall keep this ordinance at its appointed time from year to year.

- The Passover memorial also includes a requirement that Israel sanctify (or set apart) the firstborn of every womb, whether man or beast

- The requirement was limited to the sons of Israel

- This is not a requirement for Gentiles

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- The requirement is tied to the redemption of Israel by the Lord taking the first born of Egypt while preserving the firstborn of Israel

- The Lord will give more explanation for this requirement later in the chapter

- First, He reiterates the importance of observing the restrictions on leaven in the week following the Passover

    - Leaven could not be used in bread during the Exodus because of the rapid exit

    - So this will be memorialized in the absence of leaven in Israelite homes in the week following the Passover

        - We studied last week why the Lord orchestrated a rapid exit for Israel thus necessitating no leaven

        - He wanted to create a picture of the absence of sin in the lives of His people, and leaven is a symbol for sin

- Finally, the Lord explains that this memorial will occur annually so that no one in Israel will ever forget the work of the Lord in keeping His word

    - In fact, the repeating of this memorial will result in the nation of Israel declaring the Law of the Lord every year

    - That Law is a reference to the word of the Lord and His promises to Abraham

        - And while Israel will be remembering an event in their past, they will also be declaring prophetically the work of God in Christ

        - Even if they didn't always understand the picture, the Gospel was still being preached through the memorial

- Here we see a powerful example of how God works through memorials and observances

    - He gives us observance to ensure we never forget His promises and His faithfulness

    - He also wants us to declare His Law, that is His word, in the way He has prescribed

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- When we practice the Lord's Supper, we follow a pattern prescribed by the Lord in His word
- We are not free to modify it nor experiment with it
- We proclaim it in the specific way it was given (which Paul affirms in 1Cor 11) so that the picture will be clear and the purpose fulfilled
- We are called to preach the Lord's word in all it's forms so that the Lord will be see and glorified through it

- Now the Lord gives additional explanation for why the first born will be consecrated to the Lord

Ex. 13:11 **"Now when the LORD brings you to the land of the Canaanite, as He swore to you and to your fathers, and gives it to you,**
Ex. 13:12 **you shall devote to the LORD the first offspring of every womb, and the first offspring of every beast that you own; the males belong to the LORD.**
Ex. 13:13 **"But every first offspring of a donkey you shall redeem with a lamb, but if you do not redeem it, then you shall break its neck; and every firstborn of man among your sons you shall redeem.**

- The Lord points forward to the years when Israel will spend living in the land of the Canaanites, in keeping with the Lord's promise
    - At that time, the nation will devote the first born male of every womb (every mother) to the Lord
        - However, the consecrated animal must be a clean (or kosher) animal
        - Donkeys (and by extension, other unclean animals) could not be sacrificed
        - So a clean animal, a lamb, was substituted
        - If there was no lamb to substitute, the donkey's life would be taken by a breaking of the neck
    - God has given Israel a clear illustration of substitutionary atonement in through this practice
        - He is teaching that God only accepts perfect, clean sacrifices

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- If we are unclean (that is, sinful), then we are not acceptable before God
- Yet a clean, sinless lamb can be sacrificed in our place
  - If we do not accept the sinless substitute in our place, then we will die for the sake of our own sins

- This is the essence of the Gospel
  - Since we are sinful, we cannot please God in ourselves and we are under penalty of death
  - Since Christ was sinless, therefore He can be an acceptable sacrifice to God in our place so as to satisfy God's wrath against sin
    - If we accept that sacrifice, we will be spared
    - If we do not accept it, we will die for our sins

- Now in v.14 we come to understand why God wants the firstborn animals killed in this way and it explains why the Lord took the first born of every animal in Egypt during the Passover

Ex. 13:14 **"And it shall be when your son asks you in time to come, saying, 'What is this?' then you shall say to him, 'With a powerful hand the LORD brought us out of Egypt, from the house of slavery.**
Ex. 13:15 **'It came about, when Pharaoh was stubborn about letting us go, that the LORD killed every firstborn in the land of Egypt, both the firstborn of man and the firstborn of beast. Therefore, I sacrifice to the LORD the males, the first offspring of every womb, but every firstborn of my sons I redeem.'**
Ex. 13:16 **"So it shall serve as a sign on your hand and as phylacteries on your forehead, for with a powerful hand the LORD brought us out of Egypt."**

- The Lord expects that sons in every generation will ask the obvious question of their parents of why the first born male was always sacrificed to God
  - In the judgment of Passover, the Lord killed both the first born of animals and men in Egypt
    - But the Lord spared both animal and men in Israel
    - Now the first born male of animals and children are consecrated or set apart to remember that event

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- Children are observant and bright, and so God's expects the sons of Israel to ask why first born make animals are to be killed but first born male children are spared
    - Obviously, the Lord never permits nor desires human sacrifice
    - So the Lord tells Israel to answer such a question by saying that this is a reminder of the way the Lord brought us out of Egypt
    - The Pharaoh stubbornly refused to let Israel go so the Lord killed every first born in the land, both of man and beast
        - But Israel was spared
- Therefore, Israel now sets apart both firstborn males of man and beast
    - The animals are sacrificed to represents the judgment against Egypt
        - This is why animals were included in the judgment against Egypt
        - They provide the opportunity to memorialize the event through an annual sacrifice
        - Clearly, if the Lord wants to memorialize the event, He couldn't expect to repeat the killing of children every year
        - So animals become the substitute sacrifice
    - So the firstborn children also serve as a picture by the way they are spared every yeat - or as the Lord says "redeemed"
        - They represent the mercy shown to Israel
        - So both God's judgment and His mercy are illustrated through this memorial
        - The animals serve the person of illustrating judgment while the sons illustrate mercy

- In this explanation, we have a foreshadowing of the sacrificial system which will be presented at the mountain through the Law given to Moses
    - The sacrificial system of the Law uses animals in various ways to picture the judgment and penalty for sin as well as the redemption offered through substitutionary atonement

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- God uses animals because human sacrifice is murder and not in keeping with God's heart
- Yet He wanted to present to men a clear picture of His redeeming work in Christ
- Therefore, animals become a means to creating that picture
  - They are living creatures that experience death
  - They have blood in their bodies and the breath of life as do people
- So they can serve as useful illustrations of life and death

- But as we'll study more in depth later, the spilling of the blood of these animals is never more than a picture and sign of faith for the participants
  - It does not actually provide cover for personal sin
  - We'll look more closely at this relationship in the giving of the Law later in Exodus

- So now the Exodus is ready to begin

Ex. 13:17 Now when Pharaoh had let the people go, God did not lead them by the way of the land of the Philistines, even though it was near; for God said, "The people might change their minds when they see war, and return to Egypt."
Ex. 13:18 Hence God led the people around by the way of the wilderness to the Red Sea; and the sons of Israel went up in martial array from the land of Egypt.
Ex. 13:19 Moses took the bones of Joseph with him, for he had made the sons of Israel solemnly swear, saying, "God will surely take care of you, and you shall carry my bones from here with you."
Ex. 13:20 Then they set out from Succoth and camped in Etham on the edge of the wilderness.
Ex. 13:21 The LORD was going before them in a pillar of cloud by day to lead them on the way, and in a pillar of fire by night to give them light, that they might travel by day and by night.
Ex. 13:22 He did not take away the pillar of cloud by day, nor the pillar of fire by night, from before the people.

SLIDE 13-17

- Moses says the route the nation took was not straight north as we might expect

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- Such a route would have brought the nation into direct conflict with the Philistines
    - Though God would be with them and was powerful enough to defeat the Philistines, nevertheless the Lord decided not to force that upon Israel
    - Had they encountered such a fight so early in their wanderings, they would have given up and returned to their homes in Egypt
        - This departure was a big step
        - Though they desired freedom, they were leaving the only home any of them had ever known
- So instead, the Lord lead them around by the way of the wilderness to the Red Sea

SLIDE 13-18

    - They first move to Etham from Succoth
    - Then heir journey is around, by way of a wilderness ending at the Red Sea
    - Note that the Red sea make two gulfs on either side of the Sinai peninsula
        - Both are considered the Red Sea
- Also, they are leaving Egypt, or as we will read next week, they go "out of Egypt"
    - As we glance at a map of ancient Egypt, we note that Egypt controlled a large part of the Sinai peninsula

SLIDE 13-19

    - In fact, historically Sinai has always been considered a part of Egypt and still is today

- As we study the Red Sea crossing next week, we will follow the Biblical commentary carefully and watch an interesting video explaining the likely Red Sea crossing
- Finally, we hear that Moses carries Joseph's bones in the camp
    - Joseph was not left behind in Egypt but was carried with the nation to be buried in the Promised Land
        - This was done because Joseph made the nation swear to him before they died that he would leave with them

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        - The fact that Joseph required such a promise is evidence to us that Joseph believed in the word of the Lord given to Abraham

    - When the Lord spoke to Abraham in Genesis 15, He promised that the nation would leave Egypt in the fourth generation

        - Joseph believed in this promise, and his faith is reflected in his request to be taken out of the land and reburied in Canaan

Heb. 11:22 **By faith Joseph, when he was dying, made mention of the exodus of the sons of Israel, and gave orders concerning his bones.**

- Next week, we begin the study of the Exodus itself

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Exodus 14

SLIDE 14-1

- Tonight we study the first stage of the Exodus, that is Israel's flight from Egypt and the Egyptians' pursuit
    - The Israelites have already begun to move eastward out of Egypt SLIDE 14-2
        - They moved from Rameses to Succoth and then again to Etham
    - You may notice on my map or a map in your Bible that these places are marked with a question mark in many cases
        - The question mark reflects scholars' uncertainty about where the locations mentioned in the Exodus were actually located
        - This is an important detail to remember tonight in our study
            - As we go deeper into the events of the Exodus, it will be increasingly the case that the locations mentioned in the text are shrouded in mystery
            - We simply don't know for sure where they are, though there are clues in many cases to help us get close
        - Even though your maps may suggest the locations of these places, that doesn't mean those locations are correct
            - The maps in your Bible aren't inspired like the text of scripture
            - Most of the places mentioned in Exodus 14 and later including Etham, the various stopping points in the wandering, the Red Sea crossing and even Mt Sinai itself are all guesses
            - And those guesses are almost certainly wrong
    - As we study the events, I will also suggest approximate locations for some events while leaving other locations unmarked
        - Obviously, I may be wrong as well, but I think you'll agree (at least in a few cases) that the conventional wisdom about certain places in the Exodus story are more legend than fact
        - And yet there are strong clues leading us to other locations, ones that traditional scholars may disagree about

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        - Just remember the scholars' guesses are not inherently better than any other

        - Especially since there is no archeological evidence to support any of the current locations claimed for the major events of the Exodus

- Tonight's lesson will include an examination of one those mysterious locations: the crossing of the Red Sea

    - I will enlist the help of a video presentation at the end of the lesson to examine a possible location for the crossing

        - The video is one researcher's opinion on the place of the Red Sea crossing

        - I think the video is provocative and personally convincing

            - It lines up with the Biblical text

            - And it provides some powerful circumstantial evidence

        - In the end, the video is still only one perspective

    - So I am leaving the video until the end of tonight's lesson simply as food for thought

        - But I want to be clear that the teaching for the night will come from scripture as usual

        - The video is for entertainment purposes only

    - Since I cannot make this copyrighted video available as part of the materials on our website, I am including a link to Amazon where you can purchase the video for less than $9

http://www.amazon.com/The-Exodus-Revealed-Searching-Crossing/dp/B00005AUE2

- Last week we saw the nation preparing to leave on the week-long Exodus

    - The Angel of the Lord (the Second Person of the Godhead) was leading the nation forward as a cloud by day and fire by night

        - The Lord's presence will accompany the nation in this manner for the entire 40 years they spend wandering in the desert

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Ex. 13:21 The LORD was going before them in a pillar of cloud by day to lead them on the way, and in a pillar of fire by night to give them light, that they might travel by day and by night.
Ex. 13:22 He did not take away the pillar of cloud by day, nor the pillar of fire by night, from before the people.

- Some scholars suggest that the cloud had the effect of covering the nation from the effects of the hot sun during the day
  - While the fire gave light and warmth during the cold evenings
- We also noted last week that these two objects made it possible for Israel to travel for seven straight days nonstop
  - Remember, the seven days of the feast of unleavened bread was given specifically to remember Israel's flight out of Egypt in haste
  - That flight was seven days
  - And in 13:21 we're told they traveled "by day and by night"

- How could 2+ million people travel for seven straight days?
  - Only by the supernatural provision of God
    - God enables this remarkable feat
    - Just as He enables many remarkable things in this story
  - Why does God insist that their travel happen so quickly?
    - The events of chapter 14 give us that answer

SLIDE 14-3

Ex. 14:1 Now the LORD spoke to Moses, saying,
Ex. 14:2 "Tell the sons of Israel to turn back and camp before Pi-hahiroth, between Migdol and the sea; you shall camp in front of Baal-zephon, opposite it, by the sea.
Ex. 14:3 "For Pharaoh will say of the sons of Israel, 'They are wandering aimlessly in the land; the wilderness has shut them in.'
Ex. 14:4 "Thus I will harden Pharaoh's heart, and he will chase after them; and I will be honored through Pharaoh and all his army, and the Egyptians will know that I am the LORD." And they did so.

- The nation moves into the wilderness under the Lord's direction

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- As the nation moves out, the Pharaoh has sent spies to follow the people and report back their location to Pharaoh
  - So the Lord tells Israel even as they begin their trek that Pharaoh will be watching
  - And what he sees will convince him that Israel is lost and trapped and vulnerable
- But then in v.4 the Lord reveals to Moses that Pharaoh's perception is intentionally created by the Lord to cause Pharaoh to chase after Israel
  - In fact, the Lord is not finished hardening Pharaoh's heart
  - The Lord will once again cause Pharaoh to think he can defeat Israel and their God with his army
  - But the Lord is using Pharaoh's sin to glorify Himself through a display of His power
    - Remember what the Lord told Moses in the very beginning concerning Pharaoh
    - The Lord raised Pharaoh up for the very purpose of displaying His power in Egypt
    - Pharaoh existed for one reason: to be defeated by God

- In these first verses of Exodus 14, we're already given numerous place names to indicate the place where Israel camped in the desert after leaving Egypt

SLIDE 14-4

  - But as I mentioned at the start this evening, the location of these places are a mystery to us today
    - Even if your Bible or a map suggests a location, be aware that they are guessing and are likely wrong
    - We have no archeological evidence to support the supposed locations of these places
  - So can we determine an approximate location for them from scripture alone? Perhaps
    - Let's begin by simply noting the geographical boundaries of the event

SLIDE 14-5

    - First, they are moving into the wilderness

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- This refers to the Sinai Peninsula

- The event happened east of Egypt next to the sea and opposite some location on the opposite side of the sea

  - If we look at the geography of the Sinai peninsula, we can immediately narrow down the possibilities

- The Sinai has the Red Sea on either side

  - And we know that Israel is fleeing from Egypt, so they must be traveling eastward

  - It makes no sense to assume they crossed the Red Sea in a westwardly direction, because that would send them back in the direction of Egypt

- Some of suggested that Israel was backed up against some other body of water, like the Reed Sea

  - These suggestions are not consistent with scripture

  - The Hebrew words for Red Sea (yam sup) are not translated "Reed Sea" despite sounding similar in English

  - Secondly, the descriptions of the cross itself don't fit with a shallow marshy body of water like the Reed Sea or similar locations

  - We are talking about the depths of the Red Sea, either the Gulf of Suez or the Gulf of Aqaba

- So if Israel wandered to a point that they were backed up against the sea and assuming they were attempting to move east away from Egypt, that leaves only two places they could be

  - Either they were trapped on the western side of the Gulf of Suez or the western side of the Gulf of Aqaba

  - Let's consider the possibility they crossed from the western side of the Suez

    - Could they Red Sea crossing have been from the western bank to the eastern bank of the Suez?

    - There is two serious problems with this possibility

  - First, Israel would not be wandering in the wilderness

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- Rather they would still be sojourning in Egypt
- They would not have gone out of Egypt

SLIDE 14-6

- Secondly, if they were to cross the Red Sea at the Gulf of Suez, they would still have been in Egypt when they made it to the other side!
  - Remember, the Egyptians largely controlled the Sinai Peninsula, as they still do today
  - So crossing from the western side of the Suez to the eastern side would have left Israel still in Egypt

- This leaves us with only one likely location for the Jewish encampment described in Exodus 14

SLIDE 14-7

  - The western side of the Gulf of Aqaba is the only location that fits all the data we find in scripture
    - It's in the wilderness, not in Egypt
    - It is hemmed in by the Red Sea
    - And it provides for an escape by crossing the Red Sea from the West to the east away from Egypt
  - With this conclusion comes an important implication
    - If the nation crossed the Red Sea at the Gulf of Aqaba, then it would mean that Mt. Sinai is not actually located in the Sinai Peninsula
    - It would have to be located in present-day NW Saudi Arabia
    - Could this be possible?
  - We are going to examine the location of Mt. Sinai later in a few chapters,
    - Including watching another video that examines the archeological evidence for the location of the mountain
    - For now, let's see if the Bible leaves room for this possibility
  - First, let's remember what we've already read back in Exodus 3 concerning the location of this mountain
    - Mt. Sinai is the same mountain where Moses first heard from the Lord in the burning bush

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Ex. 3:1 Now Moses was pasturing the flock of Jethro his father-in-law, the priest of Midian; and he led the flock to the west side of the wilderness and came to Horeb, the mountain of God.

SLIDE 14-8

- This mountain, also called Mt. Horeb, is said to be located in the land of Midian, on the western side of the land
- If we look at a map, we find that ancient Midian is the ancient strip of land located to the east of the Gulf of Aqaba
  - And the mountain is located in the western part of Midian, that is near the Red Sea

- Later in that chapter, we read this:

Ex. 3:12 And He said, "Certainly I will be with you, and this shall be the sign to you that it is I who have sent you: when you have brought the people out of Egypt, you shall worship God at this mountain."

- The Lord commanded Moses to bring the nation of Israel back to this very same place to worship
- This mountain in the land of Midian will be the place that Israel will worship the Lord and receive the Law

SLIDE 14-9

  - Therefore, the Biblical text seems to support the conclusion that the nation crossed the Red Sea at the Gulf of Aqaba
  - From this point, they would have moved eastward into the land of Midian

- Thirdly, we have Paul's description of the mountain of Moses from Galatians 4

SLIDE 14-10

Gal. 4:24 This is allegorically speaking, for these women are two covenants: one proceeding from Mount Sinai bearing children who are to be slaves; she is Hagar.
Gal. 4:25 Now this Hagar is Mount Sinai in Arabia and corresponds to the present Jerusalem, for she is in slavery with her children.

- Paul says that Mt. Sinai is located in Arabia
- The land of Arabia has always been identified with present day Saudi Arabia

SLIDE 14-11

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        - This further confirms that the Jews would have crossed into Midian to meet God at the mountain

- So from these details in scripture, we can construct a theoretical exodus path for Israel

    - They left Etham headed east into the Sinai wilderness SLIDE 14-12

        - They probably started by following the desert trading route that wandered through the Sinai

        - At some point, the Lord led the nation off that path toward the south and into the rugged mountains of the southeastern tip of the peninsula

    - Could Israel really travel so far in just seven days?

        - The distance is about 180 miles as the crow flies

        - If we add another 30 miles for the back and forth wandering we arrive at 210 miles traveled in seven days

            - If the Jews walked day and night stopping only occasionally, we could assume 20 hours of travel per day

            - That would mean they only needed to walk at about 1.5 miles per hour on average

        - The average person walks at 3-3.5 miles per hour

            - So if we were to increase their average walking speed to 3.5 miles per hour, the Jews would only have needed to travel about 9 hours per day over that week

        - So this is a very reasonable distance to walk, and they could do it at a leisurely pace given the Lord's leading them day and night

    - Eventually, they landed most likely at a large flat beachhead on the western bank of the Gulf of Aqaba SLIDE 14-13

        - This is the only place along the gulf that could sustain millions of people under the conditions mentioned in the Bible SLIDE 14-14

        - Backed up to the sea, shut in by the wilderness

        - And there is only a single way in and out through a narrow channel

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- As Pharaoh's spies reported to Pharaoh that the Israelites had left the trade route and were headed south, the Pharaoh thought he had an opportunity
    - He knew that there was no escape from the southern tip of Sinai, since the Red Sea prevented the Jews from preceding further

SLIDE 14-15

        - Once they had entered into the steep mountain terrain of the Sinai, they lost the ability to maneuver freely
        - They would have been like rats in a maze with no way out
    - From that point, Pharaoh would only have to drive his chariots into the mountains and then let the mountains hold the Jews until his army crushed them
        - This was exactly the idea God intended Pharaoh to have, so that Pharaoh would lead the charge against Israel
        - In the end, the nation would escape Pharaoh's army through the sea crossing

Ex. 14:5 When the king of Egypt was told that the people had fled, Pharaoh and his servants had a change of heart toward the people, and they said, "What is this we have done, that we have let Israel go from serving us?"
Ex. 14:6 So he made his chariot ready and took his people with him;
Ex. 14:7 and he took six hundred select chariots, and all the other chariots of Egypt with officers over all of them.
Ex. 14:8 The LORD hardened the heart of Pharaoh, king of Egypt, and he chased after the sons of Israel as the sons of Israel were going out boldly.
Ex. 14:9 Then the Egyptians chased after them with all the horses and chariots of Pharaoh, his horsemen and his army, and they overtook them camping by the sea, beside Pi-hahiroth, in front of Baal-zephon.

- God hardens Pharaoh's heart once again, but notice the people join him in this change of heart
    - Now that Egypt has lost it's source of free labor, the work of building will have to be done by the people of Egypt
        - Once this realization sinks in, the Egyptian people decide that maybe letting Israel go wasn't such a good idea after all
    - So Pharaoh readies his own chariot and six hundred more of his army
        - And they set out after Israel

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- By this point, Israel is already camped at the edge of the Red Sea
- And in v.9 we're told that the Egyptian army overtakes Israel by the sea
  - At the point where Israel is encamped and trapped by the sea and the mountains

- The chariots of the eighteenth dynasty of Egypt were feared throughout the ancient world

SLIDE 14-16

  - They were fast and nimble, enabling a warrior to quickly overtake an adversary, dodge any attack, and turn quickly for a second pass
    - The design of chariots in Egypt evolved over the centuries
  - At this time, two designs were common
    - A four spoked wheel and a larger six-spoked wheel

Ex. 14:10 As Pharaoh drew near, the sons of Israel looked, and behold, the Egyptians were marching after them, and they became very frightened; so the sons of Israel cried out to the LORD.
Ex. 14:11 Then they said to Moses, "Is it because there were no graves in Egypt that you have taken us away to die in the wilderness? Why have you dealt with us in this way, bringing us out of Egypt?
Ex. 14:12 "Is this not the word that we spoke to you in Egypt, saying, 'Leave us alone that we may serve the Egyptians'? For it would have been better for us to serve the Egyptians than to die in the wilderness."
Ex. 14:13 But Moses said to the people, "Do not fear! Stand by and see the salvation of the LORD which He will accomplish for you today; for the Egyptians whom you have seen today, you will never see them again forever.
Ex. 14:14 "The LORD will fight for you while you keep silent."
Ex. 14:15 Then the LORD said to Moses, "Why are you crying out to Me? Tell the sons of Israel to go forward.
Ex. 14:16 "As for you, lift up your staff and stretch out your hand over the sea and divide it, and the sons of Israel shall go through the midst of the sea on dry land.
Ex. 14:17 "As for Me, behold, I will harden the hearts of the Egyptians so that they will go in after them; and I will be honored through Pharaoh and all his army, through his chariots and his horsemen.
Ex. 14:18 "Then the Egyptians will know that I am the LORD, when I am honored through Pharaoh, through his chariots and his horsemen."

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- In a sign of things to come, the people of Israel begin to complain to Moses at the first sight of the approaching Egyptian army
    - We certainly can't blame the Israelites for being scared
        - The sight of the world's strongest army bearing down on you with your backs to the Red Sea would scare anyone
        - But they have also seen the power of God unlike anyone else to that point in history
        - And so their words are completely unreasonable in light of what they have seen God do on their behalf
            - They turn against Moses and declare that Moses is at fault for freeing them from slavery
            - In a sarcastic statement, they ask Moses if there weren't enough graves in Egypt for all Israel, so is that why you brought us out here to die?
            - Besides being an exaggeration, the statement is ironic since Egypt was known worldwide for its elaborate graves, the pyramids
    - Remember earlier in our study when we studied the way God called Moses into leadership
        - Among other things we noted that God was prepared to give Moses what he needed to succeed
        - And we also noted that God would make clear to His people that Moses was their appointed leader
        - Well, here we see the reality of life as a spiritual leader among God's people
            - As much as we like to think we are mature and reasonable, the truth is we're all sheep
            - And like sheep, we are prone to stray, to get lost, to run in fear and to follow the herd
        - Moses is getting his first taste of what's in store for him in leading a stubborn and stiff-necked people

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- The Israelites possess two of the worst personality flaws combined together: incredibly short memories and no appreciation for irony
- That's the only explanation for some of the things they say to Moses

- Here they ask Moses if he freed them because he felt this was a better place to die than in Egypt
    - As if to suggest that it was Moses alone who imagined the whole caper and orchestrated the plan by himself
        - Have they already forgotten how the Lord was the One running the show?
    - Anytime we are called to lead God's people, in any capacity, be prepared for a similar response
        - Even our best people might let fear and doubt cloud their memories and leave them vulnerable to saying dumb things
        - Not every decision we make will lead to stunning success, and sometime our apparent defeats are outcomes God intended to achieve some greater purpose
            - God lets events fail, programs fail, ministries fail, churches fail so that His purposes may be met
            - Human accomplishment and satisfaction is never God's purpose
            - Spiritual growth and holiness in His people and the increase of His glory are the only imperatives driving His purposes
            - And trials and disappointments are some of the best experiences to achieve those outcomes
- In response, Moses says exactly the right things
    - First, he orders the people not to fear
        - The fear of the Israelites is obvious in this situation, but I think fear drives more conflict in the church than most people realize
            - Fear of rejection, fear of judgment, fear of change, Fear of failure, fear of success

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- Certainly, there are other causes of conflict like envy, but fear is a key driver
- And fear is ultimately the result of a failure to trust in the Lord to respond in a crisis, to meet needs, to bring loose ends together

- So Moses orders the people not to fear, and we have a similar responsibility
  - Remind people, exhort people not to behave out of fear
  - Remind them to trust the Lord to direct the activities in His church
  - Don't fear; trust in the Lord

- Secondly, Moses tells Israel to watch for the work of the Lord in saving them from Egypt
  - The call to watch for the work of the Lord is the necessary corollary to the call not to fear
  - We conquer fear best when we remember that the Lord is always at work around us, and His work will be the solution to our problem
  - Always be ready to echo Moses words in the face of fear and doubt:
    - Take note of God's work and be prepared to see Him show up and address the needs of His people
  - Don't be so consumed by your doubts and fears that you fail to take note of the way the Lord is already working
    - Like Abraham's servant at the well
    - Or the mourners at Lazarus' tomb

- Thirdly, Moses tells the people to be quiet
  - Discontent breeds discontent
  - The more the people grumbled, the more they tested God and provoked His anger with their unbelief

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        - This pattern will grow much worse over the coming months, but even now Moses recognizes that the people are their own worst enemies in this battle

        - There comes a time to remind people to stop grumbling, stop testing the Lord with our sinful doubts and questioning

        - Instead, be quiet and let God work

- Though the text doesn't record Moses' words to the Lord, we can tell by the Lord's response in v.15 that Moses appeals to God for help

    - In a fascinating response, the Lord asks Moses why are you crying to Me?

        - God's answer to Moses is I made you the leader, I gave you my staff, and the answer to your dilemma is obvious

        - Raise your staff, the waters will part, and then order the people to go forward

    - How was Moses supposed to know to drive the people forward into the sea?

        - Because God had already told Moses in the burning bush that he was to return to the mountain and to worship him

            - And Mt Horeb, lies directly across from the gulf

            - In fact, Moses would have known that land well after living there for 40 years

        - And have you noticed how Moses' staff plays a prominent role in many of the supernatural acts of God?

        - Obviously, the staff is not special except that God has purposed to work through it

    - The obviously point God is making to Moses is that I've already equipped you to lead this people, I've given you clear instructions, the path forward is obvious...but it requires a step of faith

        - Yet here you stand crying out to Me?

        - It's as if God is telling Moses that if you aren't going to use the things I've given you for the your mission, why do you return to Me for more?

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- This is a fundamental principle of Scripture that comes up over and over again
    - God has equipped us in faith to do many great things according to His will
        - If we step out in faith and take advantage of those gifts we've already received, then we can meet every test successfully
            - Chief among those tools is God's word
        - But if we haven't availed ourselves fully of what God has given us, why should we be surprised when get stuck and God doesn't seem to answer our cries
    - Furthermore, the Lord says He would be working along side Moses, but in unexpected ways
        - The Lord will once again harden Pharaoh's heart so he would pursue the people
        - If you had taken a poll of the Israelites in that moment, I'm sure the option for the Egyptians to go straight home would have won in landslide
        - While the option for God to cause the army to chase them into the sea would have run a distant second
    - But in the end, God's purpose is that Pharaoh's army drown in the sea
        - So that the Lord's might is shown all the more
        - The story of Israel's flight from Egypt wouldn't be half as memorable if it were not for the Red Sea crossing
        - It is a crescendo that puts to rest any question of what produced Israel's freedom - it was God's might
    - What a great example of how we work with the Lord in accomplishing His purposes
        - He puts us on a path that is aligned with His will and purposes
        - He asks us to follow the plan He gives us and use the tools He provides
        - And then He works in strange and unexpected ways to make the most of our meager efforts

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- Moses raised a stick in the air, the Israelites ran like scared children

- But those steps of obedience created the backdrop upon which God worked a great display of power and glory

Ex. 14:19 The angel of God, who had been going before the camp of Israel, moved and went behind them; and the pillar of cloud moved from before them and stood behind them.
Ex. 14:20 So it came between the camp of Egypt and the camp of Israel; and there was the cloud along with the darkness, yet it gave light at night. Thus the one did not come near the other all night.
Ex. 14:21 Then Moses stretched out his hand over the sea; and the LORD swept the sea back by a strong east wind all night and turned the sea into dry land, so the waters were divided.
Ex. 14:22 The sons of Israel went through the midst of the sea on the dry land, and the waters were like a wall to them on their right hand and on their left.
Ex. 14:23 Then the Egyptians took up the pursuit, and all Pharaoh's horses, his chariots and his horsemen went in after them into the midst of the sea.
Ex. 14:24 At the morning watch, the LORD looked down on the army of the Egyptians through the pillar of fire and cloud and brought the army of the Egyptians into confusion.
Ex. 14:25 He caused their chariot wheels to swerve, and He made them drive with difficulty; so the Egyptians said, "Let us flee from Israel, for the LORD is fighting for them against the Egyptians."
Ex. 14:26 Then the LORD said to Moses, "Stretch out your hand over the sea so that the waters may come back over the Egyptians, over their chariots and their horsemen."
Ex. 14:27 So Moses stretched out his hand over the sea, and the sea returned to its normal state at daybreak, while the Egyptians were fleeing right into it; then the LORD overthrew the Egyptians in the midst of the sea.
Ex. 14:28 The waters returned and covered the chariots and the horsemen, even Pharaoh's entire army that had gone into the sea after them; not even one of them remained.
Ex. 14:29 But the sons of Israel walked on dry land through the midst of the sea, and the waters were like a wall to them on their right hand and on their left.
Ex. 14:30 Thus the LORD saved Israel that day from the hand of the Egyptians, and Israel saw the Egyptians dead on the seashore.
Ex. 14:31 When Israel saw the great power which the LORD had used against the Egyptians, the people feared the LORD, and they believed in the LORD and in His servant Moses.

- This narrative stands almost unparalleled in all the Bible

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- Why is it that the most memorable scenes in Scripture revolve around great displays of God's power through water
    - Noah, Jonah, Elijah, Jesus on the Galilee
    - None are more powerful than this scene
- The timeline of the event is a little more complex than the movie portrays
    - First, the army arrives shortly before nightfall, and they are met by the pillar of fire to hold them back
    - Secondly, the Lord brings an east wind to move the water back and to dry the sea bed
        - This was essential to allow the people to walk without getting stuck in the mud
    - Third, after the land was dry, perhaps some hours later, the people began to cross over the dry land
- The crossing is about 12 miles at this point, so if we assume a hurried 3.5 mile pace, it still took one person about 4 hours to cross the distance
    - Assuming we have 2 million people moving together, it probably added another hour or two to the travel time
    - During this time, the pillar of fire is holding back the army
    - But at the right time, the Lord let's them go, and they begin to chase

- The destruction of Egypt happens in several steps
    - First, the Lord awaits for morning to arrive to begin fighting against Egypt
        - The army is still moving through the Red Sea as Israel watches in fear from the opposite bank
    - Secondly, the Lord appears in the midst of the sea as a pillar of fire and cloud to confuse the Egyptian army
        - Chariot wheels mysteriously come off chariots, disabling the men and horses

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        - Fear enters the Egyptian army as they realize the Lord is fighting against them
            - But no one can retreat with their chariots and horses disabled
    - Finally, God orders Moses to raise the staff again
        - And with that, the waters close over the army
        - And the bodies wash ashore
    - While our attention is drawn to the sea opening and closing, I'm most fascinated by God's determination to use Moses and the staff to work the miracle
        - For example, why does God insist on having Moses raise the staff to close the waters?
        - The only plausible answer is to impress upon the people that Moses is their appointed representative and he works God's will
        - God is good to let leaders be seen to lead to encourage others to follow
- Rather than spend any more time on describing the scene we all know so well already, I thought it better to just show you the 2-minute version
    - [Show the Ten Commandments clip at this point...] SLIDE 14-17
    - We will return next week to a few of the details and images of this scene, including the pictures of Christ and baptism found in this story
- Finally, let's watch a video exploring the possible location of the Red Sea crossing... SLIDE 14-18

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Exodus 15

- Israel has finally and forever escaped the Pharaoh of Egypt
    - Just as the Lord promised Abraham, the nation of Israel came out of Egypt after 400 years
        - They have crossed the Gulf of Aqaba and entered into Midian
        - And they have just witnessed the destruction of the Egyptians army
    - At the end of chapter 14, Moses summarizes the moment

Ex. 14:30 Thus the LORD saved Israel that day from the hand of the Egyptians, and Israel saw the Egyptians dead on the seashore.
Ex. 14:31 When Israel saw the great power which the LORD had used against the Egyptians, the people feared the LORD, and they believed in the LORD and in His servant Moses.

- Moses says that Israel saw the destruction of Egypt, feared God, believed in the Lord and in Moses
    - While this testimony sounds encouraging, such is not the case
    - According to the Psalms, we read this

Psa. 106:4 ¶ Remember me, O LORD, in Your favor toward Your people;
Visit me with Your salvation,
Psa. 106:5 That I may see the prosperity of Your chosen ones,
That I may rejoice in the gladness of Your nation,
That I may glory with Your inheritance.
Psa. 106:6 We have sinned like our fathers,
We have committed iniquity, we have behaved wickedly.
Psa. 106:7 Our fathers in Egypt did not understand Your wonders;
They did not remember Your abundant kindnesses,
But rebelled by the sea, at the Red Sea.
Psa. 106:8 Nevertheless He saved them for the sake of His name,
That He might make His power known.
Psa. 106:9 Thus He rebuked the Red Sea and it dried up,
And He led them through the deeps, as through the wilderness.
Psa. 106:10 So He saved them from the hand of the one who hated them,
And redeemed them from the hand of the enemy.
Psa. 106:11 The waters covered their adversaries;

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Not one of them was left.
Psa. 106:12 Then they believed His words;
They sang His praise.
Psa. 106:13 They quickly forgot His works;
They did not wait for His counsel,

- What Israel saw and what they believed was not what it first appeared to be
    - The Psalmist tells us that the people rebelled at the Red Sea
        - Nevertheless the Lord rescued the nation, but not because they were deserving of such rescue
        - Rather, the Lord rescued Israel for His own name
            - What this means is God rescued Israel because He has promised Abraham He would do so
            - Had the Lord allowed Israel to perish in their unbelief, the Lord would have gone against His word
    - Therefore, we see that God's actions in saving men, whether physically or spiritually, are based upon what produces the greatest glory for His name
        - His saving power is reserved for His name sake, not for our sake
        - We were save for His glory
- Throughout the story of Israel in the desert, this theme repeats itself
    - The people of Israel are portrayed repeatedly as disobedient, unbelieving and ones who test the Lord's patience and goodness
        - The writer of Hebrews sums up the dispossession of this generation of Israel in this way

Heb. 3:16 For who provoked Him when they had heard? Indeed, did not all those who came out of Egypt led by Moses?
Heb. 3:17 And with whom was He angry for forty years? Was it not with those who sinned, whose bodies fell in the wilderness?
Heb. 3:18 And to whom did He swear that they would not enter His rest, but to those who were disobedient?
Heb. 3:19 So we see that they were not able to enter because of unbelief.

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Heb. 4:1 Therefore, let us fear if, while a promise remains of entering His rest, any one of you may seem to have come short of it.
Heb. 4:2 For indeed we have had good news preached to us, just as they also; but the word they heard did not profit them, because it was not united by faith in those who heard.

- Exodus shows us the early stages of Israel's disobedience in the desert
  - Most notably, we'll witness the rebellion while Moses meets God on the mountain
  - And it's helpful for us to remember that this generation of Israel is described in Scripture as an unbelieving generation of Israel
  - And as a result of unbelief, they are not permitted to enter the promised land
    - Symbolically, the promised land is a picture of the kingdom
    - So this generation pictures the rebellion of unbelieving Israel

- From there, we proceed to Chapter 15, which is set in the same moment, immediately after the army of Pharaoh is swallowed up in the sea
  - This chapter completes the third section for the book
  - The people of Israel amazed as they see the Lord's work
  - And under the influence of the Spirit, Moses and Miriam, Aaron's sister' lead the nation in a song of prophecy

- Chapter 15 is dominates by these two songs, the song of the Moses and the song of Miriam
  - These are victory hymns sung to celebrate the Lord's great victory
    - To this day, these hymns are still part of worship in many synagogues
    - These songs are a form of poetry, and as we study them we need to understand something about Hebrew poetry
  - Western poetry is primarily focused on the sound of words: the rhyme and rhythm and alliteration

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- But Hebrew poetry is based on parallelism in the meaning of adjoining lines
    - In the most common arrangement, lines of text are paired up
    - Each line in the pair is saying the same thing in different ways
    - The art of Hebrew poetry is in finding different ways to express the same thought within a pair
- You see this pattern throughout the OT
- Poetry is formed in pairs of lines, in which each pair is a single thought

- The pairs of lines are then grouped into strophes, not unlike stanzas of poetry
    - Each strophe is a single topic or thought expressed in detail by each pair of lines
    - The song of Moses has three strophes
        - The first strophe runs from vs.1-5
        - The second from vs.6-10
        - And the final strophe from vs.11-18
- The song of Moses is prophetic, and it is a pivotal moment in Scripture
    - In fact, this song is so important, that Revelation 15 tells us it is sung immediately before the Bowl judgments are poured out on the Earth in the time of Tribulation
    - Obviously, the prophetic meaning of these verses extends all the way into the last days, days that are still yet in our future

Ex. 15:1 Then Moses and the sons of Israel sang this song to the LORD, and said,
"I will sing to the LORD, for He is highly exalted;
The horse and its rider He has hurled into the sea.
Ex. 15:2 "The LORD is my strength and song,
And He has become my salvation;
This is my God, and I will praise Him;
My father's God, and I will extol Him.

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Ex. 15:3 "The LORD is a warrior;
The LORD is His name.
Ex. 15:4 "Pharaoh's chariots and his army He has cast into the sea;
And the choicest of his officers are drowned in the Red Sea.
Ex. 15:5 "The deeps cover them;
They went down into the depths like a stone.

- Immediately, you can notice the parallelism of Hebrew poetry, the pairs of lines working together to complete a thought
    - The first strophe recounts the might of God to conquer Israel's enemy
        - The song begins with a praise of God fighting strength
        - He is Jehovah, which always means the covenant keeping God
        - He drowned the Pharaoh's men
    - The second strophe begins in v.6

Ex. 15:6 "Your right hand, O LORD, is majestic in power,
Your right hand, O LORD, shatters the enemy.
Ex. 15:7 "And in the greatness of Your excellence You overthrow those who rise up against You;
You send forth Your burning anger, and it consumes them as chaff.
Ex. 15:8 "At the blast of Your nostrils the waters were piled up,
The flowing waters stood up like a heap;
The deeps were congealed in the heart of the sea.
Ex. 15:9 "The enemy said, 'I will pursue, I will overtake, I will divide the spoil;
My desire shall be gratified against them;
I will draw out my sword, my hand will destroy them.'
Ex. 15:10 "You blew with Your wind, the sea covered them;
They sank like lead in the mighty waters.

    - God shattered the Pharaoh's army
        - He overthrew those who rise up
        - In His anger, He consumed them
        - When the Lord divided the waters, He provided an opportunity for Israel to escape

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- But this same escape also gave the enemy reason to believe Israel was weak and could be conquered
- And just as the enemy thought they were triumphant, the enemy was destroyed by God's hand

- The final strophe is starts in v.11

Ex. 15:11 "Who is like You among the gods, O LORD?
Who is like You, majestic in holiness,
Awesome in praises, working wonders?
Ex. 15:12 "You stretched out Your right hand,
The earth swallowed them.
Ex. 15:13 "In Your lovingkindness You have led the people whom You have redeemed;
In Your strength You have guided them to Your holy habitation.
Ex. 15:14 "The peoples have heard, they tremble;
Anguish has gripped the inhabitants of Philistia.
Ex. 15:15 "Then the chiefs of Edom were dismayed;
The leaders of Moab, trembling grips them;
All the inhabitants of Canaan have melted away.
Ex. 15:16 "Terror and dread fall upon them;
By the greatness of Your arm they are motionless as stone;
Until Your people pass over, O LORD,
Until the people pass over whom You have purchased.
Ex. 15:17 "You will bring them and plant them in the mountain of Your inheritance,
The place, O LORD, which You have made for Your dwelling,
The sanctuary, O Lord, which Your hands have established.
Ex. 15:18 "The LORD shall reign forever and ever."

- Having destroyed Israel's enemy, Moses asks who is like the Lord?
  - He has defended Israel and redeemed His people
  - And the peoples of the earth have heard of this deliverance, Moses declares
    - Those of Philistia and Edom and Canaan
    - Their hearts have melted away at the news that God is fighting for Israel
  - These people have terror at the prospect of Israel's victory
    - The Lord's people will passover into their lands

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- Ultimately, Israel will reach God's holy mountain and will receive their inheritance in the sanctuary of the Lord
  - And in that place, the Lord will reign forever and ever

- Moses ends his song with a summary of the events of chapter 14

Ex. 15:19 **For the horses of Pharaoh with his chariots and his horsemen went into the sea, and the LORD brought back the waters of the sea on them, but the sons of Israel walked on dry land through the midst of the sea.**

- Before we examine Moses' song in detail, let's also note the second song of the chapter, that of Miriam, Moses' sister

Ex. 15:20 **Miriam the prophetess, Aaron's sister, took the timbrel in her hand, and all the women went out after her with timbrels and with dancing.**
Ex. 15:21 **Miriam answered them,**
"Sing to the LORD, for He is highly exalted;
The horse and his rider He has hurled into the sea."

- Here song repeats the essential theme of Moses' song
  - Notice that Miriam is called the sister of Aaron
  - But that would also make her Moses' sister, of course
- She is a prophetess, and she is the first woman in the Bible to carry that title
  - This means that the song she sings is also are also divinely inspired
  - Her statement in v.21 seems to be nothing more than a repetition of Moses' song
    - But in reality, her offers us something much more profound

- To examine this song properly, I first need to establish a framework or construct
  - As we've already noted, the song of Moses is divided into three parts
    - The first part recounts is very specific to the events of the Exodus

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        - It mentions the Red Sea and Pharaoh and chariots
    - The second part beginning in v.6 starts to change
        - There is still mention of seas piling up and the deep so we know that Moses is still talking about the same event
        - But the song begins to describe the event in a more general way
            - Moses talks about God shattering Israel's enemy
            - Overthrowing those who rise up against God
            - Consuming enemies with burning wrath
            - The enemy thinks it has won right before it is defeated
    - Finally, the third part becomes almost entirely divorced from the context of the Exodus
        - The earth swallows the enemies of God
        - While God has redeemed His people
        - The world has seen God's power and trembles
        - God's people meet God at Zion, the holy Mountain
        - While God resides forever in His sanctuary
- Notice the progression in the song
    - It moves from more to less specific concerning the Exodus
        - By this progression, we can see that Moses is speaking not only about the events of that day but also of future events in Israel
        - In fact, this prophecy is speaking of the times of Tribulation, when Israel will be redeemed ultimately from the Antichrist
    - We have already established how the Exodus story is a picture of the end times
        - Israel in bondage and set free by a redeemer
        - The redeemer must conquer Israel's enemies, first through a series of judgments and plagues
        - Ultimately, Israel is set free through a sacrifice of the Lamb

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        - And once the nation is freed, it is led to worship God at His holy mountain

    - Now Moses is prophetically making that connection for us

        - The first third of the song establishes the fact of God's deliverance of Israel from Egypt

        - The second third of the song begins to move us away from the events of Exodus and toward the future work of God in Tribulation

    - The real switch occurs in the third strophe

        - Moses begins to describes events that are future to his day

        - In v.13 Moses says that God's people will be redeemed while the world will fear what they see

            - Says various nations will tremble in fear of God's work

            - The event was just completed, yet Moses is already talking about the effect it had on the world

Josh. 2:8 ¶ Now before they lay down, she came up to them on the roof,
Josh. 2:9 and said to the men, "I know that the LORD has given you the land, and that the terror of you has fallen on us, and that all the inhabitants of the land have melted away before you.
Josh. 2:10 "For we have heard how the LORD dried up the water of the Red Sea before you when you came out of Egypt, and what you did to the two kings of the Amorites who were beyond the Jordan, to Sihon and Og, whom you utterly destroyed.
Josh. 2:11 "When we heard it, our hearts melted and no courage remained in any man any longer because of you; for the LORD your God, He is God in heaven above and on earth beneath.

Josh. 2:24 They said to Joshua, "Surely the LORD has given all the land into our hands; moreover, all the inhabitants of the land have melted away before us."

- So we know that the third strophe is looking into the future, and that future extends much farther than Joshua

    - The Lord will lead Israel into their inheritance, to the mountain, where the Lord will reign forever and ever

        - Is this mountain Mt Sinai in Midian?

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- Is it Mt Moriah in David's day
- Or is it another mountain?

Heb. 12:18 For you have not come to a mountain that can be touched and to a blazing fire, and to darkness and gloom and whirlwind,
Heb. 12:19 and to the blast of a trumpet and the sound of words which sound was such that those who heard begged that no further word be spoken to them.
Heb. 12:20 For they could not bear the command, "IF EVEN A BEAST TOUCHES THE MOUNTAIN, IT WILL BE STONED."
Heb. 12:21 And so terrible was the sight, that Moses said, "I AM FULL OF FEAR and trembling."
Heb. 12:22 But you have come to Mount Zion and to the city of the living God, the heavenly Jerusalem, and to myriads of angels,
Heb. 12:23 to the general assembly and church of the firstborn who are enrolled in heaven, and to God, the Judge of all, and to the spirits of the righteous made perfect,
Heb. 12:24 and to Jesus, the mediator of a new covenant, and to the sprinkled blood, which speaks better than the blood of Abel.
Heb. 12:25 See to it that you do not refuse Him who is speaking. For if those did not escape when they refused him who warned them on earth, much less will we escape who turn away from Him who warns from heaven.
Heb. 12:26 And His voice shook the earth then, but now He has promised, saying, "YET ONCE MORE I WILL SHAKE NOT ONLY THE EARTH, BUT ALSO THE HEAVEN."
Heb. 12:27 This expression, "Yet once more," denotes the removing of those things which can be shaken, as of created things, so that those things which cannot be shaken may remain.
Heb. 12:28 Therefore, since we receive a kingdom which cannot be shaken, let us show gratitude, by which we may offer to God an acceptable service with reverence and awe;
Heb. 12:29 for our God is a consuming fire.

- The writer of Hebrews taught that the mountain the nation of Israel was brought before was a mountain of gloom and darkness
  - This mountain is where Moses delivered the law, and it was a mountain that generated fear and gloom
    - This fear and dread was representative of the effect God's law has to condemn sinful men
    - Even Moses trembled
  - But believers have been led into a different kingdom, one of light and angels and God Himself

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        - The Zion that will descend to earth once all that has been created has been removed and something unshakeable replaces it

        - This is the mountain Moses is describing, the place where the Lord reigns forever and ever

- But before the nation of Israel will enter into that kingdom at the conclusion of the Tribulation, they will first endure the wrath of the antichrist and his forces

    - For an in-depth understanding of these days, please refer to our Revelation course online

        - The Tribulation comes to an end when the Lord returns, slays the antichrist, receives Israel in faith and ushers in the Kingdom age

        - Then the Lord will plant Israel in their inheritance in the land, as Moses declares in v.17

        - Meanwhile, the Lord will occupy the temple and reign forever, as Moses says in v.18

    - Moses song speaks of God's work in the Exodus, but he uses that story to draw a picture to the work of God in the time of Tribulation

        - This method of drawing prophetic pictures is consistent with Hebrew poetry in general

            - Just as poetry involves pairs of statements that echo the same thought in different but complimentary ways

            - So does prophecy often pair together a near term event with a far term event

                - The earlier event pictures the later event

                - And by understanding the earlier, we come to understand what will happen in the future

- Finally, I mentioned that Miriam's prophecy added an intriguing detail to this prophetic picture

    - She says that the Lord hurled the horse and rider into the sea

        - We understand how this statement is connected to Exodus, obviously

        - Pharaoh's horsemen were consumed by the Red Sea

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- But curiously, her statement is spoken in the singular
  - A rider and a horse is thrown into the sea
  - The use of the singular gives us the clue to understand how this statement is both speaking of Egypt and prophetically speaking of the last days
    - In Revelation 6, the arrival of the antichrist at the start of Tribulation is described this way

Rev. 6:1 ¶ Then I saw when the Lamb broke one of the seven seals, and I heard one of the four living creatures saying as with a voice of thunder, "Come."
Rev. 6:2 I looked, and behold, a white horse, and he who sat on it had a bow; and a crown was given to him, and he went out conquering and to conquer.

  - The man riding this horse in Revelation 6 is the antichrist, depicted as arriving to conquer the world
  - At the end of Tribulation, he is defeated by God, in the last minute, just as the antichrist is about to crush Israel in Jerusalem
    - Like the Exodus, the the Lord provides Israel an escape westward away from the advance of the enemy
    - As Israel fees, the enemy advances
    - And the Lord fights the battle for Israel, saving them at the last minute

Zech. 14:1 Behold, a day is coming for the LORD when the spoil taken from you will be divided among you.
Zech. 14:2 For I will gather all the nations against Jerusalem to battle, and the city will be captured, the houses plundered, the women ravished and half of the city exiled, but the rest of the people will not be cut off from the city.
Zech. 14:3 Then the LORD will go forth and fight against those nations, as when He fights on a day of battle.
Zech. 14:4 In that day His feet will stand on the Mount of Olives, which is in front of Jerusalem on the east; and the Mount of Olives will be split in its middle from east to west by a very large valley, so that half of the mountain will move toward the north and the other half toward the south.
Zech. 14:5 You will flee by the valley of My mountains, for the valley of the mountains will reach to Azel; yes, you will flee just as you fled before the earthquake in the days of Uzziah king of Judah. Then the LORD, my God, will come, and all the holy ones with Him!

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Zech. 14:6 In that day there will be no light; the luminaries will dwindle.
Zech. 14:7 For it will be a unique day which is known to the LORD, neither day nor night, but it will come about that at evening time there will be light.
Zech. 14:8 And in that day living waters will flow out of Jerusalem, half of them toward the eastern sea and the other half toward the western sea; it will be in summer as well as in winter.
Zech. 14:9 And the LORD will be king over all the earth; in that day the LORD will be the only one, and His name the only one.

- Miriam says this rider and horse will be hurled into the sea
  - The word for hurled is literally the word cast, as in cast into the sea
  - And the sea is a common metaphor in the Bible for the depths of hell or God's judgment
- So Miriam's song describes both the riders of Exodus while also picturing the antichrist meeting his judgment in Tribulation
- This is why the final judgments of Tribulation are prefaced in Revelation with this statement

Rev. 15:1 Then I saw another sign in heaven, great and marvelous, seven angels who had seven plagues, which are the last, because in them the wrath of God is finished.
Rev. 15:2 And I saw something like a sea of glass mixed with fire, and those who had been victorious over the beast and his image and the number of his name, standing on the sea of glass, holding harps of God.
Rev. 15:3 And they sang the song of Moses, the bond-servant of God, and the song of the Lamb, saying...

- Before we leave the song, I want to show something even more interesting in these accounts
  - In the story of Exodus, we noted that God made clear He was judging not only the people of Egypt, but also the Egyptian gods
    - Each plague was designed to assault a god and render it impotent before the eyes of the people
    - We also noted that God changed the calendar 180 degrees to reflect that God's ways of redemption are the opposite of man's ways

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- While man weighs his deeds expecting to get credit for good works
- God cares nothing for works for the sake of redemption, and instead provides a sacrificial Lamb for men

- Finally, in the songs of the crossing of the Red Sea, once final pagan myth is destroyed

- The cult of Baal was the basis for all Canaanite religion
  - Baal is the god of Canaan and his name means "Lord"
  - The Hebrews always considered Baal to be the false god of this world, that is Satan
    - The NT uses Beelzebub meaning Lord of the flies as a term for Satan

- The Canaanite religion had a false mythology of creation centered on the false god Baal
  - Their creation myth begins with Baal and another character called Yamm (which is a word meaning sea) in conflict and struggle
    - Yamm or sea was a force of confusion or formless chaos
    - While Baal was a force of order, and Baal was threatened by Yamm
      - Baal conquers Yamm thereby setting the rest of creation into motion
    - Having conquered Yamm, Baal sets up a kingdom and and a palace and he begins to reign over the world, according to the Canaanite myth
  - Throughout the lands Israel sojourned, this story was as central to the pagan understanding of creation
    - As common as the myth of evolution is today, this myth was accepted and understood equally widely then
    - And we can recognize Satan's counterfeit tactics in this myth, which he brought to the Canaanite peoples
      - He declares himself to be the god of order, while the formless deep of God's creation was his enemy

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- He conquered the creation and began to reign over it, which references the fall in the Garden

- So how does this relate to the songs of Moses and Miriam?
    - This account reads like the Canaanite creation myth only in reverse
    - If we were to read this song in Hebrew, we would be struck by two things
        - First, the word in Hebrew for sea is yam
        - So throughout the narrative, the poet explains to the reader that the sea is conquering God's enemies
            - The sea destroys the armies opposed to God
            - The sea destroys the antichrist in a future day
        - Secondly, the concluding statement in v.18 says that the Lord will reign
            - In Hebrew this is Yahweh malakh
            - In the Canaanite religion , the celebratory statement of Baal as he conquers Yamm was Baal malakh

- While the story of Exodus is first about Israel leaving slavery, it is also a creation story in that it explains the creation of Israel as a nation
    - The song of Moses is written in such a way that it testifies to the superiority of God's creation in contrast to the creation myth of Satan
        - Though the connection may not be readily apparent to us, the construction of this poem and the carefully chosen words in Hebrew create that connection
            - The God of Israel is the Creator and has power over all creation
            - Baal didn't destroy Yamm; Yamm will destroy Baal
    - Since the song of Moses introduces us to the way the Exodus story is a creation account of sorts, it leads us to see the following pattern
        - In the first creation story, the world was created, being formed out of water

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        - In the Exodus story, the nation of Israel is created, born out of the water of the Red Sea
            - The Red Sea is widely understood to be a baptism of the nation as a whole (not of each individual in the nation)
        - In our personal redemption by faith, we are made new creatures in Christ having been born again through the baptism of spirit and water
        - And in the final days, the nation of Israel is born again in faith, residing in the kingdom with rivers of flowing water
    - Each of these moments is a triumph of God over Satan and his forces
    - Further supporting the creation motif is the connection of each creation to the Sabbath
        - After the six days of creation, God rested
        - After the Exodus, God will command Israel to rest for one day each week
        - After our personal salvation, we come to rest in our Sabbath, Christ, perpetually
        - After the nation of Israel is saved, the world enters into eternal rest in the kingdom
            - Each Sabbath is greater than the one that preceded it
            - We will look at the issue of the Sabbath in much greater detail in future chapters
- So to summarize the Songs of Moses and Miriam
    - Moses and Miriam spoke as prophets
        - They declared the mighty works of God in Egypt and in times to come
        - They testified to God's defense of Israel in Egypt and God's defense of Israel in Tribulation
        - They spoke of Pharaoh's defeat in the Red Sea and the antichrist's eventual defeat at Christ's return to rule

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- Furthermore, the poetry was constructed carefully to invite comparisons to Canaanite creation mythology
  - And with that comparison, we see a pattern linking several creation moments

- We will have more to say about these symbolic connections in the future, but for now let's finish the chapter

Ex. 15:22 Then Moses led Israel from the Red Sea, and they went out into the wilderness of Shur; and they went three days in the wilderness and found no water.
Ex. 15:23 When they came to Marah, they could not drink the waters of Marah, for they were bitter; therefore it was named Marah.
Ex. 15:24 So the people grumbled at Moses, saying, "What shall we drink?"
Ex. 15:25 Then he cried out to the LORD, and the LORD showed him a tree; and he threw it into the waters, and the waters became sweet. There He made for them a statute and regulation, and there He tested them.
Ex. 15:26 And He said, "If you will give earnest heed to the voice of the LORD your God, and do what is right in His sight, and give ear to His commandments, and keep all His statutes, I will put none of the diseases on you which I have put on the Egyptians; for I, the LORD, am your healer."

- After the crossing, the began to travel westward into the land of Midian
  - After three days of travel, they had yet to find water
    - This isn't surprising
    - The region gets less than an inch of rain per year
  - At about this point, they reach a source of water, but the water was bitter and undrinkable
    - The bitterness indicates foul and likely poisonous water
      - The placed is called Marah, which means bitter
    - So the people begin to grumble asking what shall they drink?
      - It's remarkable that the nation would find cause to grumble so soon after the crossing
      - Here we see a spiritual truth playing out
      - Even after witnessing great signs and wonders, the people are still hard hearted and unable to trust in God

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- The mind can be influenced by what we see and experience, but the heart (the spirit) cannot

- Moses asks God for relief, and God gives Moses a solution
  - Throw a tree into the water and it will become drinkable
  - And with that solution, comes a new statute and regulation and a test for the people of Israel
    - These things are coming upon the nation because they are sinning so readily after having seen the Lord deliver them
    - With that sin comes rules and regulations and tests
    - This is merely a foretaste of the Law to come

- God directs that if the nation would heed his voice and do what is right and keep all his statues and commandments, they will not receive the Lord's judgments
  - By extension, if Israel does anything other than obey, they will experience God's judgment
    - God says He is the healer of Israel, meaning God can turn bitter water to sweet
  - Ultimately, this requirement is repeated in the Law itself
    - This ends the third section of the book and sets up a new theme that runs through the rest of Exodus and through the remaining books of Moses
    - The nation that left Egypt is unbelieving yet God saved them for His name sake
      - Their unbelief is a cause for them to test God ten times
      - To show them their unbelief and sin and to cause them to seek after Him, the Lord gives the nation laws and statues
      - They fail in keeping these laws, necessitating God's judgment

- We will begin chapter 16 next time with the final verse of chapter 15

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Exodus 16-17

- Israel turns their back on Egypt and Pharaoh and the Red Sea and begins to move eastward SLIDE 16/17-1
    - Reflecting on their entire time in Egypt and the Exodus, it's truly a remarkable story
        - Surely, God could have accomplished His purposes with less drama and special effects
        - Therefore, the drama had a purpose and was part of God's purposes
    - The manner of God's work was designed to communicate an eternal message
        - The details of the drama were carefully crafted by the Lord to create pictures for coming events
        - For example, we've already noted how the judgments on Egypt and redemption of Israel picture the coming salvation of Israel in the last days of Tribulation
        - And how the Passover pictures Christ
        - And last week we added another picture created by the Red Sea crossing
            - God redeems those in bondage to sin through a call to leave the world and come to the holy mountain of God, that is Zion
            - And along the way to that meeting, we experience a baptism through water
        - These pictures haven't ended
            - Far from it...they are just beginning
            - In fact, they continue until the very end of Deuteronomy
            - The drama of the Exodus and the 40 years of wandering are absolutely stuffed with pictures of later events in God's prophetic plan
        - We will see still more tonight

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- The nation is now moving from the seashore of the Gulf of Aqaba to Elim, their first stopping point on the way to Mt Horeb, the mountain of God

SLIDE 16/17-2

Ex. 15:27 Then they came to Elim where there were twelve springs of water and seventy date palms, and they camped there beside the waters.

- The mention of Elim gives us an opportunity to revisit something I taught in the lesson on the Red Sea crossing concerning place names in the Exodus story
  - The exact locations of most of the place names in the Exodus story have been lost to history
  - In a few cases, we have some geographical basis for estimating their location
  - But in many cases the generally accepted sites associated with the Exodus are fiction
- For example, the locations mentioned after the crossing like Marah and Elim are traditionally place on Egypt's eastern border with Sinai

SLIDE 16/17-3

  - Mt Sinai itself is either located in extreme northern Sinai or southern Sinai, depending on which traditional view of the crossing location you ascribe to
  - The very reason the Sinai Peninsula is called Sinai is because tradition has placed the mountain of Moses there
  - Historically, the entire peninsula was called Paran, not Sinai

SLIDE 16/17-4

  - In other words, the mountain didn't take it's name from the peninsula; the peninsula took it's name from the mountain
    - And the mountain was assigned this location through guesswork and tradition
- The point to remember is that as we study through this account, you may decide to consult a map, which is fine
  - But understand that the locations should be taken with a large dose of salt
  - Since I have already expressed my point of view on the location of the Red Sea crossing, then naturally I'm going to locate these places accordingly

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        - For example, we learned a couple of lessons ago that Israel crossed into Midian as they left Egypt
            - So naturally, I believe the location of Elim was somewhere directly east of the gulf of Aqaba in Midian
            - Don't be surprised if Bible maps tell you otherwise, but just be aware that there is no archeological evidence to support any location...it is entirely speculation
            - I have based my speculation on my best understanding of scripture

- As Israel walks into the desert, their attentions shifts from fear of Pharaoh and his army to more mundane concerns
    - They reach a resting place in the desert where they came for sometime
        - At this point they find twelve springs and seventy date palms
        - The word for Elim is the plural for tamerisk tree, which can be a cedar or palm tree
            - The Israelites name the location for the trees in this area
    - When we hear the numbers 12 and 70, we can't help but notice the Biblical significance
        - Both 12 and 70 are too perfect to be coincidence; it testifies to God's provision
        - Moses led the people to this oasis, which the Lord prepared
        - I assume Moses knew where to find this garden spot, based on his previous years in Midian
            - The precise number of springs and trees communicates that God had prepared Moses for his role as leader
            - Even ensuring Moses knew where to find water in the desert for Israel
        - The message to Israel was simple: the God that rescued you will continue to provide for your needs
    - The very fact that Moses chose to count the trees and springs and report his count in scripture tells us that the number had significance to Moses

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- Both numbers are associated with God ruling through men
- Moses recognized that his leadership was God directed and God had Moses' back

- Israel camps here for about three weeks before setting out again, still traveling to the mountain of Moses

Ex. 16:1 **Then they set out from Elim, and all the congregation of the sons of Israel came to the wilderness of Sin, which is between Elim and Sinai, on the fifteenth day of the second month after their departure from the land of Egypt.**
Ex. 16:2 **The whole congregation of the sons of Israel grumbled against Moses and Aaron in the wilderness.**
Ex. 16:3 **The sons of Israel said to them, "Would that we had died by the LORD'S hand in the land of Egypt, when we sat by the pots of meat, when we ate bread to the full; for you have brought us out into this wilderness to kill this whole assembly with hunger."**

- One month from their exodus from Egypt, the nation sets out from Elim and enter the wilderness of Sin, and never has a place been more aptly named
  - It is located between Elim (on the west) and Sinai, that is Mt. Horeb
    - Here we find Israel grumbling again
    - The word grumbling means to murmur, a form of complaining that is done behind the leader's back
    - This is worse than direct confrontation, since it can lead to organized opposition and insurrection
  - The irony is obvious to us
    - A few days earlier, the Lord had demonstrated by providing 12 springs and 70 shady palms that He would make provision for Israel through the leadership of Moses
    - Now here's Israel murmuring against Moses' leadership
    - They see God but forget; they hear His words, but do not believe
  - They say if they have to die, they would have rather died as slaves in Egypt with meat and bread than to die with freedom but nothing to eat
    - The nation is longing for their past life, the life they had prior to God's redemption of the nation

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- Jesus taught concerning this principle of disciples longing for the former life

Luke 9:57 As they were going along the road, someone said to Him, "I will follow You wherever You go."
Luke 9:58 And Jesus said to him, "The foxes have holes and the birds of the air have nests, but the Son of Man has nowhere to lay His head."
Luke 9:59 And He said to another, "Follow Me." But he said, "Lord, permit me first to go and bury my father."
Luke 9:60 But He said to him, "Allow the dead to bury their own dead; but as for you, go and proclaim everywhere the kingdom of God."
Luke 9:61 Another also said, "I will follow You, Lord; but first permit me to say good-bye to those at home."
Luke 9:62 But Jesus said to him, "No one, after putting his hand to the plow and looking back, is fit for the kingdom of God."

- Each protest was self-evidently a pathetic excuse hiding a more serious barrier to following Jesus: unbelief
  - Jesus draws a conclusion from these three excuses using the analogy of working the field on a farm
  - Working the plow behind a team of oxen was unpleasant and demanding work
    - It was far easier to stay in the farm house, where the world offered comfort
    - But follow the Lord in His work meant leaving the comforts of that life behind
  - If someone walked to the field, placed his hand on the plow, but longed for the chance to return to the farm house, they were revealing themselves to be posers
    - They may have walked out to the field, but their heart wasn't in the work
- So it is for this generation of Israel
  - The Lord has freed a nation, but the individual members of that nation are not responding in faith to God's work
  - And their repeated longing for life in Egypt is proof they are not fit for the kingdom of God

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Ex. 16:4 Then the LORD said to Moses, "Behold, I will rain bread from heaven for you; and the people shall go out and gather a day's portion every day, that I may test them, whether or not they will walk in My instruction.
Ex. 16:5 "On the sixth day, when they prepare what they bring in, it will be twice as much as they gather daily."
Ex. 16:6 So Moses and Aaron said to all the sons of Israel, "At evening you will know that the LORD has brought you out of the land of Egypt;
Ex. 16:7 and in the morning you will see the glory of the LORD, for He hears your grumblings against the LORD; and what are we, that you grumble against us?"
Ex. 16:8 Moses said, "This will happen when the LORD gives you meat to eat in the evening, and bread to the full in the morning; for the LORD hears your grumblings which you grumble against Him. And what are we? Your grumblings are not against us but against the LORD."

- In response, the Lord alerts Moses that He will answer their need with a provision that will include a test
    - The Lord will rain bread down from heaven - a miraculous provision for the people
        - This provision will come in a certain way and with special restrictions
        - And by these restrictions God will place a test upon the people
        - Will they follow the Lord's commands and instructions?
    - This is the second time we've heard the Lord mention testing the people
        - When the Lord uses the word test, it carries the same meaning as when we use the word
        - A test is something that determines whether something is true and right
            - We test precious metal to know if it is pure
            - We test students to know if they have the right knowledge
            - We test water to know if it is pure
        - And the Lord tests hearts to show whether they have the faith they claim

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- The test is that the nation can only gather a day's worth of bread each day
    - On the sixth day the nation will gather twice what is needed, and this will last through the seventh day of the week
        - This double provision will eliminate the need to gather on the seventh day
    - So the test is whether Israel has a heart to trust the Lord's word and therefore refrains from gathering on the seventh day?

- The curious thing about the Lord testing man's hearts is that we know the Lord Himself doesn't need these tests in order to know a man's heart
    - The Lord already knows everything about every heart, so why does He bother to devise a test?
        - The answer is that the test isn't for His benefit; it's for the benefit of the people themselves and for us the reader
            - The nation of Israel will see for themselves that they fail the Lord's test while they sojourned in the desert
            - Likewise, later Jews can look back upon these moments and gain a proper perspective on the nature of these people
        - Altogether, this generation of Israel will fail a total of ten tests, and the number ten represents testimony
            - This generation leaves behind a testimony that they were an unbelieving generation
        - After they fail the tenth test, the Lord condemns this generation of Israel to wander in the desert for 40 years until death
    - We can know that the Lord anticipated their disobedience and the resulting period of wandering by the way He provided bread from heaven
        - When the nation left Egypt, it had plenty of food to sustain them if they had only needed to stay in the desert for a short time
        - They left Egypt with thousands of goats and sheep
            - These herds could have sustained the nation with milk and meat for a long time

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- The nation might have lacked for other food types, but they were in no danger of starving so long as their sojourning was relatively brief

- But because the Lord anticipated the long wandering period, , He provided for a long-term source of food

- This is our evidence that the Lord isn't testing the people for His own sake...He knows where this is going

  - He is testing them to reveal their hearts to you and me

Ex. 16:9 Then Moses said to Aaron, "Say to all the congregation of the sons of Israel, ' Come near before the LORD, for He has heard your grumblings.'"
Ex. 16:10 It came about as Aaron spoke to the whole congregation of the sons of Israel, that they looked toward the wilderness, and behold, the glory of the LORD appeared in the cloud.
Ex. 16:11 And the LORD spoke to Moses, saying,
Ex. 16:12 "I have heard the grumblings of the sons of Israel; speak to them, saying, 'At twilight you shall eat meat, and in the morning you shall be filled with bread; and you shall know that I am the LORD your God.'"
Ex. 16:13 So it came about at evening that the quails came up and covered the camp, and in the morning there was a layer of dew around the camp.
Ex. 16:14 When the layer of dew evaporated, behold, on the surface of the wilderness there was a fine flake-like thing, fine as the frost on the ground.
Ex. 16:15 When the sons of Israel saw it, they said to one another, "What is it?" For they did not know what it was. And Moses said to them, "It is the bread which the LORD has given you to eat.
Ex. 16:16 "This is what the LORD has commanded, 'Gather of it every man as much as he should eat; you shall take an omer apiece according to the number of persons each of you has in his tent.'"
Ex. 16:17 The sons of Israel did so, and some gathered much and some little.
Ex. 16:18 When they measured it with an omer, he who had gathered much had no excess, and he who had gathered little had no lack; every man gathered as much as he should eat.
Ex. 16:19 Moses said to them, "Let no man leave any of it until morning."
Ex. 16:20 But they did not listen to Moses, and some left part of it until morning, and it bred worms and became foul; and Moses was angry with them.
Ex. 16:21 They gathered it morning by morning, every man as much as he should eat; but when the sun grew hot, it would melt.

- Notice that Moses is still using Aaron to speak for him to the congregation

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- Moses directs Aaron to call the nation together to see the Lord's response
    - The Lord's glory appears in the cloud and the Lord spoke to Moses with His instructions
    - He promises meat in the evening and bread in the morning
        - The meat would come in the form of quail the nation would catch in the evening when the birds fly
        - And the bread would be a unique, supernatural provision from heaven each morning
- The bread comes with the dew of the morning and is deposited on the surface of the desert ground
    - Moses takes time to describe it to us, which suggests strongly this is a unique substance unlike anything else found in nature
    - He describes it as a fine, flake-like thing, but the word in Hebrew is used only here in all scripture and is a bit of a mystery
        - It is fine in the sense that is small and delicate
            - Round and about twice the size of a pea
        - If left out in the hot sun, it eventually melted
- When the nation first set eyes on it, they reacted like a 3-year old shown brussel sprouts
    - They asked "What is it?"
        - The Hebrew words for "What is it?" are "man na"
        - Hence, the nation gives it the name manna
    - Moses answers by telling the nation this is the bread the Lord has provided
        - Notice the Lord always calls it bread
        - In fact, it can be fashioned and boiled or baked, just like any other grain
        - So truly the Lord is providing the nation with a grain that supplies them with the basic ingredient for bread

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- It's important we dispel a myth concerning God's provision for Israel in the desert years
    - Israel didn't survive on manna alone
        - At this time they had quail in the evenings
            - They didn't always have quail, later books tell us, but they did at times
        - And they also have their livestock, which produce milk and can supply an occasional roast
    - Furthermore, the nation didn't live in isolation
        - They interact with other cultures during their wanderings
        - For example, in Deut 2 the nation trades with the Edomites while they wander in Seir
        - Through that trade, they enjoy a variety of foods to supplement their diet of quail and manna
    - So if you wondered how someone could live on a single food for 40 years, the answer is that they didn't
        - The Lord was good to provide the nation with a varied diet
        - And He did so despite their grumbling and unbelief
- The gatherings process itself was living proof of the Lord's goodness, wisdom and power
    - God instructs Israel to collect an omer of bread for each person in the household
        - An omer is 2 quarts or about 1.9 liters
        - The allotted amount of bread per person per day was 2 quarts
    - And during the gathering, some seemed to gathered more than others
        - But when the family returned home and measured out an omer for each person, they found that everyone had exactly what they needed
        - Most likely, the one who gathered too much made up for those who gathered too little

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        - It all measured out evenly in the end
            - Such precision is testimony of God's handiwork and loving provision
    - Finally, having gathered their daily bread, the nation was told not to hoard it or store it for the next day
        - But in v.20 the nation ignored God's instructions
            - They stored it, or at least they tried to store it
        - If they stored it, it became worm infested and foul
            - It became pointless to store it
        - Understandably, Moses was angry with the nation when he learned of their disobedience
            - Moses knows what's at stake, and his anger is righteous
- The hoarding was a sin, but it wasn't the test God designed for the nation
    - The true test was the seventh day requirement

Ex. 16:22 Now on the sixth day they gathered twice as much bread, two omers for each one. When all the leaders of the congregation came and told Moses,
Ex. 16:23 then he said to them, "This is what the LORD meant: Tomorrow is a sabbath observance, a holy sabbath to the LORD. Bake what you will bake and boil what you will boil, and all that is left over put aside to be kept until morning."
Ex. 16:24 So they put it aside until morning, as Moses had ordered, and it did not become foul nor was there any worm in it.
Ex. 16:25 Moses said, "Eat it today, for today is a sabbath to the LORD; today you will not find it in the field.
Ex. 16:26 "Six days you shall gather it, but on the seventh day, the sabbath, there will be none."

- Moses explains that the seventh day of each week was now to be a sabbath for the nation of Israel
    - On the sixth day of each week, the nation would find it possible to gather twice as much bread from the ground
        - This provision would last the nation for two days
        - Thus it eliminated the need to gather on the seventh day

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- Thereby giving the nation the opportunity to rest from their gathering on the seventh day

- The test was would be whether the nation would trust the Lord's word and remain in their homes rather than gather
  - There would be no bread on the ground, but would the people look anyway?
  - The test was whether their hearts desired to store up treasure in heaven so much that they would trade obedience to God's word for earthly gain
  - Since they already had enough for the day, would they desire more?

- God's supply of bread from heaven conveys a beautiful picture of God's provision for His children
  - First, God will meet our physical needs
    - Scripture tells us that He will meet our needs in a daily way
      - The Lord's prayer reminds us of God's heart meet our need for daily bread
      - Jesus taught of how the Lord knows our needs and like lilies in the field or the birds in the trees, He will ensure we have what we need
      - God's daily provision to Israel came in a similar way
  - Secondly, that supply comes as a daily provision sufficient for our needs...never a lack nor an excess
    - God is faithful in that provision, and we can trust that each day will bring us what we need
  - Finally, when we live in faith to that promise, we relieve ourselves from much of the burden of seeking for our needs
    - When we store beyond our need or strive beyond what's required, we are beginning to move away from living in faith
    - By our actions we reveal a lack of trust in our heart for God to bring more provision tomorrow

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- Why did God institute such a supernatural provision for the nation of Israel? Bread from Heaven seems unnecessarily dramatic
    - As we said earlier, the method was part of the message
        - God was creating a powerful picture He intended to draw from later in history and scripture
        - Bread from Heaven becomes a powerful picture of Christ
    - Bread is a staple of physical life
        - Without daily food, the body eventually dies
        - By sending bread down from Heaven, the Lord established an indelible picture of Christ, the Bread of life, descending from Heaven
            - He is the staple of spiritual life
            - We must eat this spiritual food to survive spiritually
            - Moreover, Jesus gave His flesh to us as a sacrifice to ensure our spiritual life
    - John's Gospel is the quintessential book of scripture that endeavors to explain how OT pictures are fulfilled in Christ
        - Each chapter takes one of the OT pictures and connects then them to our Lord's life and words
        - In this case, John 6 is the chapter is devoted to revealing Jesus as the Bread of Life
    - In the beginning of the chapter, Jesus feeds the five thousand with a few loaves of bread and fish
        - Obviously, this miracle impresses the people and leaves many desiring for more of the same
        - After the miracle, Jesus and the disciples go to the other side of the sea of Galilee
        - As He arrives on the other side, the crowd appears to greet them, having traveled all the way around the lake

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John 6:24 So when the crowd saw that Jesus was not there, nor His disciples, they themselves got into the small boats, and came to Capernaum seeking Jesus.
John 6:25 When they found Him on the other side of the sea, they said to Him, "Rabbi, when did You get here?"
John 6:26 Jesus answered them and said, "Truly, truly, I say to you, you seek Me, not because you saw signs, but because you ate of the loaves and were filled.
John 6:27 "Do not work for the food which perishes, but for the food which endures to eternal life, which the Son of Man will give to you, for on Him the Father, God, has set His seal."
John 6:28 Therefore they said to Him, "What shall we do, so that we may work the works of God?"
John 6:29 Jesus answered and said to them, "This is the work of God, that you believe in Him whom He has sent."
John 6:30 So they said to Him, "What then do You do for a sign, so that we may see, and believe You? What work do You perform?
John 6:31 "Our fathers ate the manna in the wilderness; as it is written, 'HE GAVE THEM BREAD OUT OF HEAVEN TO EAT.'"
John 6:32 Jesus then said to them, "Truly, truly, I say to you, it is not Moses who has given you the bread out of heaven, but it is My Father who gives you the true bread out of heaven.
John 6:33 "For the bread of God is that which comes down out of heaven, and gives life to the world."
John 6:34 Then they said to Him, "Lord, always give us this bread."
John 6:35 Jesus said to them, "I am the bread of life; he who comes to Me will not hunger, and he who believes in Me will never thirst.
John 6:36 "But I said to you that you have seen Me, and yet do not believe.

- The crowd was an unbelieving crowd
    - They sought for physical food, not spiritual food
        - When Jesus points out their unbelief, they counter by saying they are willing to believe if only they receive a sign
        - Nevermind they had already witnessed the miracle of the feeding of the five thousand
        - The fact they demanded yet more signs proves what Paul taught in 1Cor

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1Cor. 1:22 For indeed Jews ask for signs and Greeks search for wisdom;
1Cor. 1:23 but we preach Christ crucified, to Jews a stumbling block and to Gentiles foolishness,
1Cor. 1:24 but to those who are the called, both Jews and Greeks, Christ the power of God and the wisdom of God.

- These people would never believe in Jesus no matter how many signs they witnessed
  - They weren't believing because they had not experienced the call of God and the power of God in their hearts
  - Ironically, they point to Moses and the manna as reason for their doubts
    - The reason they mention Moses and manna is to imply that if Jesus wanted them to follow Him, He should be prepared to provide bread on a daily basis
    - Moses gave Israel manna on a regular daily basis, so they require Jesus to continue turning loaves into miraculous meals as a test or condition of their allegiance
    - That's why in v.34 they ask Jesus to always give them bread
- In response, Jesus draws their attention to the spiritual meaning of manna, that is it pictures God's provision of the Messiah, the Bread of life
  - In v.32 Jesus says it wasn't Moses who brought the bread, but the Lord
  - More over, the Lord wasn't intending to sustain Israel or the world with manna, but Himself
  - And those who come to Jesus will not hunger or thirst, spiritually speaking (and ultimately physically in the kingdom)
- So the Lord delivered bread to Israel from heaven to illustrate a higher spiritual message
  - The message is that God is the provider of life, and that life can be made eternal through the provision of Jesus, the bread of life
  - Only those who accept Him will be fed with this bread
  - As Jesus told the crowd

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John 6:47 "Truly, truly, I say to you, he who believes has eternal life.
John 6:48 "I am the bread of life.
John 6:49 "Your fathers ate the manna in the wilderness, and they died.
John 6:50 "This is the bread which comes down out of heaven, so that one may eat of it and not die.
John 6:51 "I am the living bread that came down out of heaven; if anyone eats of this bread, he will live forever; and the bread also which I will give for the life of the world is My flesh."
John 6:52 Then the Jews began to argue with one another, saying, "How can this man give us His flesh to eat?"
John 6:53 So Jesus said to them, "Truly, truly, I say to you, unless you eat the flesh of the Son of Man and drink His blood, you have no life in yourselves.

- Moving back to Exodus 16, we also notice the arrival of a Sabbath ordinance
    - This moment is also the first moment that a sabbath requirement is given to men
        - It comes before the giving of the Law formally at the mountain, but it comes as part of the instructions and ordinances that God delivers to Israel in the desert
        - These ordinances are formally conveyed in the covenant at the mountain
        - But Israel is already now being introduced to God's ordinances in small steps
    - We'll study the Sabbath more in a future lesson
        - But for now it's important to understand that observing a Sabbath day rest was not a requirement for men before this moment
        - And even now that it has arrived, God delivered it only to this group of people: the nation of Israel
- So how did Israel respond to the Lord's test?

Ex. 16:27 It came about on the seventh day that some of the people went out to gather, but they found none.
Ex. 16:28 Then the LORD said to Moses, "How long do you refuse to keep My commandments and My instructions?

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Ex. 16:29 "See, the LORD has given you the sabbath; therefore He gives you bread for two days on the sixth day. Remain every man in his place; let no man go out of his place on the seventh day."
Ex. 16:30 So the people rested on the seventh day.

- Unsurprisingly, the nation fails the test of faith
    - They go out the gather on the seventh day anyway
        - Of course they find nothing as Moses told them
        - Consider what kind of heart has God's provision promised on a daily basis, yet still feels compelled to seek more?
        - The Lord knew their hearts, and by His test, we can see it too
    - The scripture's testimony concerning this generation of Israel is crystal clear

Heb. 3:7 Therefore, just as the Holy Spirit says,
| "TODAY IF YOU HEAR HIS VOICE,
Heb. 3:8 DO NOT HARDEN YOUR HEARTS AS WHEN THEY PROVOKED ME,
AS IN THE DAY OF TRIAL IN THE WILDERNESS,
Heb. 3:9 WHERE YOUR FATHERS TRIED Me BY TESTING Me,
AND SAW MY WORKS FOR FORTY YEARS.
Heb. 3:10 "THEREFORE I WAS ANGRY WITH THIS GENERATION,
| AND SAID, 'THEY ALWAYS GO ASTRAY IN THEIR HEART,
| AND THEY DID NOT KNOW MY WAYS';
Heb. 3:11 AS I SWORE IN MY WRATH,
| 'THEY SHALL NOT ENTER MY REST.'"

- Meanwhile, the Lord gives Moses instructions concerning how the nation shall memorialize His faithfulness

Ex. 16:31 The house of Israel named it manna, and it was like coriander seed, white, and its taste was like wafers with honey.
Ex. 16:32 Then Moses said, "This is what the LORD has commanded, 'Let an omerful of it be kept throughout your generations, that they may see the bread that I fed you in the wilderness, when I brought you out of the land of Egypt.'"
Ex. 16:33 Moses said to Aaron, "Take a jar and put an omerful of manna in it, and place it before the LORD to be kept throughout your generations."

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Ex. 16:34 As the LORD commanded Moses, so Aaron placed it before the Testimony, to be kept.
Ex. 16:35 The sons of Israel ate the manna forty years, until they came to an inhabited land; they ate the manna until they came to the border of the land of Canaan.
Ex. 16:36 (Now an omer is a tenth of an ephah.)

- Moses gives us another detail describing the nature of this mysterious bread from Heaven
    - It's like a coriander seed, white, with a taste like sweet crackers SLIDE 16/17-5
        - Knowing it was used for making bread, we can assume it contained all the ingredients needed for making bread
        - Grain, sugar, salt, and perhaps yeast
        - It would have also contained the nutrients needed for healthy living
            - Sounds a lot like beer
    - Then Moses tells the nation to follow God's instructions by placing an omer in a jar and preserving it for generations
        - God prevented the grain in the jar was from spoiling
        - Moses then gives a few interesting details that help us date the writing of this book and all the books of Moses
            - He says that the jar was to be kept before the Testimony
            - The Testimony refers to the tablets of the Law
        - But at this point in the wanderings, the nation has yet to receive the Law
            - Clearly, Moses is writing of this event from a later point in the history of Israel
    - Furthermore, Moses comments that the manna fed Israel for 40 years in the desert
        - This statement means that Moses wrote this book near the end of the nation's time in the desert
        - Notice Moses says the provision continued until they were on the border of Canaan

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- Mose never knew anything past that point, as he died at that time
- This tells us Moses was writing these books at the very end of his life

- The next chapter presents a similar scenario, only now the concern is water

Ex. 17:1 **Then all the congregation of the sons of Israel journeyed by stages from the wilderness of Sin, according to the command of the LORD, and camped at Rephidim, and there was no water for the people to drink.**
Ex. 17:2 **Therefore the people quarreled with Moses and said, "Give us water that we may drink." And Moses said to them, "Why do you quarrel with me? Why do you test the LORD?"**
Ex. 17:3 **But the people thirsted there for water; and they grumbled against Moses and said, "Why, now, have you brought us up from Egypt, to kill us and our children and our livestock with thirst?"**
Ex. 17:4 **So Moses cried out to the LORD, saying, "What shall I do to this people? A little more and they will stone me."**

- They journey in stages, we're told, until they reach Rephidim, a place with no water supply
    - As we'll see in v.6, this place is immediately next to the mountain of Horeb
        - In fact, Rephedim is the encampment of Israel around the mountain
            - They will spend the better part of a year living in this location
            - Yet the location has no water supply
        - Once again, we don't know where this place was exactly
            - Depending on where you believe the nation crossed the sea and where Mt Horeb stands will determine where you place this location

SLIDE 16/17-6

            - As I'll show in coming weeks, I believe this location sits in the region of a mountain in NW Saudi Arabia, called Jabal al Lawz

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- As the nation camps here, a familiar pattern repeats itself
    - The people want for some basic need, they grumble and blame Moses, failing to trust God to provide
        - Moses says they may be grumbling against him, but they are testing the Lord with their unfaithfulness
        - While the Lord may test our hearts, it is sin for us to test the Lord
            - To test the Lord is to ask the Lord to prove Himself, but He does not honor such tests
        - This is different than a Gideon-style test where the intent is to clearly discern God's will
            - These people knew the Lord's will to provide, and yet they continued to assume otherwise
    - Again, the people make ridiculous claims of coming death and blame Moses
        - So Moses asks God to save him from the people's wrath
        - The Lord responds again with a miraculous provision in answer to Moses' intercession

Ex. 17:5 Then the LORD said to Moses, "Pass before the people and take with you some of the elders of Israel; and take in your hand your staff with which you struck the Nile, and go.
Ex. 17:6 "Behold, I will stand before you there on the rock at Horeb; and you shall strike the rock, and water will come out of it, that the people may drink." And Moses did so in the sight of the elders of Israel.
Ex. 17:7 He named the place Massah and Meribah because of the quarrel of the sons of Israel, and because they tested the LORD, saying, "Is the LORD among us, or not?"

- Moses is told to strike a rock at the base of Horeb
    - And from that place water poured forth for the people
        - In fact, it pours forth with such force that it creates a small lake in the desert, according to Psalm 78
        - Psalm 78 also tells us about the significance of Massah and Meribah, two more places we can't locate precisely on a map

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- In this place, the people of Israel constantly questioned whether the Lord was truly with them or not
  - How can we not be stunned by this question?
  - They saw unprecedented displays if God's power and goodness, and yet they still find reason to question God's presence
    - I wonder if they asked this question as they stooped down each morning to collect their supernatural provision of bread?
    - It's a powerful proof of the depravity and deadness of an unbelieving heart
    - Only an unbeliever could witness what they witnessed on a daily basis and still ask whether God was with them
- The psalmist echoes this conclusion:

Psa. 78:15 He split the rocks in the wilderness
And gave them abundant drink like the ocean depths.
Psa. 78:16 He brought forth streams also from the rock
And caused waters to run down like rivers.
Psa. 78:17 Yet they still continued to sin against Him,
To rebel against the Most High in the desert.
Psa. 78:18 And in their heart they put God to the test
By asking food according to their desire.
Psa. 78:19 Then they spoke against God;
They said, "Can God prepare a table in the wilderness?
Psa. 78:20 "Behold, He struck the rock so that waters gushed out,
And streams were overflowing;
Can He give bread also?
Will He provide meat for His people?"
Psa. 78:21 Therefore the LORD heard and was full of wrath;
And a fire was kindled against Jacob
And anger also mounted against Israel,
Psa. 78:22 Because they did not believe in God
And did not trust in His salvation.

- And again in Psalm 95:

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Psa. 95:8 Do not harden your hearts, as at Meribah,
As in the day of Massah in the wilderness,
Psa. 95:9 "When your fathers tested Me,
They tried Me, though they had seen My work.
Psa. 95:10 "For forty years I loathed that generation,
And said they are a people who err in their heart,
And they do not know My ways.
Psa. 95:11 "Therefore I swore in My anger,
I Truly they shall not enter into My rest."

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Exodus 18

- Israel is camped a short distance from the mountain of God
    - We're building toward the moment when Moses will reach Sinai and ascend the mountain to meet with God
        - Until that moment, we're still watching the Lord bring Israel experience after experience
        - The experiences are teaching opportunities for Israel
    - They are being introduced to their Lord in stages
        - They've seen His wonders and powers of destruction in Egypt
        - And they've seen His faithfulness to provide for His people
            - Last week we saw the Lord providing food and water
            - Manna and water pouring from a rock
- These provisions were designed to create pictures of the Lord
    - The food from Heaven was intended to draw comparisons to Jesus, the Bread of Life from Heaven
        - He sustains us spiritually, making possible eternal life
        - We studied in John 6 how Jesus compared Himself to the manna
            - The manna God delivered left Israel hungry later
            - And they eventually died despite that manna
            - So it wasn't the ultimate solution to their need
        - But it pictured a great solution, that is Christ
            - Jesus also comes from Heaven and must be taken in
            - But when we accept Him, we receive a new life that will never die
    - We also looked at the water from the Rock, but our study ended before we had time to make a connection between the water from the Rock and Jesus

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- The water came from a rock that was split in two when Moses struck it with his staff
- Then water gushed forth creating a river that eventually made a lake of fresh water for Israel's encampment

- The rock itself is a picture of Christ

1Cor. 10:1 **For I do not want you to be unaware, brethren, that our fathers were all under the cloud and all passed through the sea;**
1Cor. 10:2 **and all were baptized into Moses in the cloud and in the sea;**
1Cor. 10:3 **and all ate the same spiritual food;**
1Cor. 10:4 **and all drank the same spiritual drink, for they were drinking from a spiritual rock which followed them; and the rock was Christ.**

- The rock at Horeb was real, and real water poured out of it in a supernatural way
- But God determined to provide water in this unique way to create this picture of Christ for later generations
  - We should understand Jesus as the One Who gives us living water, that is a living spirit
  - And from that new spirit, living water will spill out of us

John 7:38 **"He who believes in Me, as the Scripture said, 'From his innermost being will flow rivers of living water.'"**

- In fact, a rock in some form is the most common symbol used to depict Christ
  - At various times Christ is described symbolically as a rock, stone, block, mountain, or cornerstone
    - These symbols often have unique features that teach us things about Jesus
      - Stones that have not be cut by human hands
      - Stones that have been tested
      - Stones that are foundations or cornerstones of a building
      - A stone or rock of offense that some stumble over
  - Furthermore, the rock was struck by the staff God gave Moses

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- Moses' staff has already become a symbol of the Father's authority
    - All the major miracles the Lord performed through Moses were performed using Moses' staff
    - The message has become clear to the people of Israel that the work done through that rod is the work of God through Moses
- So as Moses struck the rock, a picture is formed of God the Father ordering that the Rock, His Son, be struck for the benefit of the people
    - By striking Christ, the Father will bring a river of life flowing to His people

Is. 53:4 Surely our griefs He Himself bore,
And our sorrows He carried;
Yet we ourselves esteemed Him stricken,
Smitten of God, and afflicted.
Is. 53:5 But He was pierced through for our transgressions,
He was crushed for our iniquities;
The chastening for our well-being fell upon Him,
And by His scourging we are healed.
Is. 53:6 All of us like sheep have gone astray,
Each of us has turned to his own way;
But the LORD has caused the iniquity of us all
To fall on Him.
Is. 53:7 He was oppressed and He was afflicted,
Yet He did not open His mouth;
Like a lamb that is led to slaughter,
And like a sheep that is silent before its shearers,
So He did not open His mouth.

- So Christ was struck (or afflicted) for our sake, just as the rock was struck by the rod God gave Moses
- God wanted the rock struck (as opposed to some other method) so that this picture would be available

- Finally, this moment also parallels one of the stories of John's Gospel

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- In chapter 4, Jesus meets a woman at a well, and the discussion turns to the importance of water from the well

John 4:7 ¶ There came a woman of Samaria to draw water. Jesus said to her, "Give Me a drink."
John 4:8 For His disciples had gone away into the city to buy food.
John 4:9 Therefore the Samaritan woman said to Him, "How is it that You, being a Jew, ask me for a drink since I am a Samaritan woman?" (For Jews have no dealings with Samaritans.)
John 4:10 Jesus answered and said to her, "If you knew the gift of God, and who it is who says to you, 'Give Me a drink,' you would have asked Him, and He would have given you living water."
John 4:11 She said to Him, "Sir, You have nothing to draw with and the well is deep; where then do You get that living water?
John 4:12 "You are not greater than our father Jacob, are You, who gave us the well, and drank of it himself and his sons and his cattle?"
John 4:13 Jesus answered and said to her, "Everyone who drinks of this water will thirst again;
John 4:14 but whoever drinks of the water that I will give him shall never thirst; but the water that I will give him will become in him a well of water springing up to eternal life."

  - The woman talks about the need for physical water, water that our flesh thirsts for
  - Meanwhile, Jesus talks about a different kind of water, spiritual refreshment that leads to everlasting life

- Isn't it interesting that our descriptions of Hell always include images of heat and burning
  - Where the sufferers long for a drop of water
  - And in contrast, the believer is told that faith brings eternal flowing rivers of water that bring everlasting refreshment

- Moving forward in the story, we turn back to the end of chapter 17 to find the nation still moving toward the mountain of God
  - And as they move into place, they come under attack

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Ex. 17:8 **Then Amalek came and fought against Israel at Rephidim.**

- The nation of Israel comes under attack for the first time since leaving Egypt, and really for the first time ever
    - The attacker is a man called Amalek, and he leads a tribe called the Amalekites
        - They attack at Rephidim, which is an encampment of Israel near the mountain of God
    - Amalek is the great grandson of Isaac through Esau
        - So he is essentially a distant cousin with the Israelites
        - We must assume he was threatened by the sudden appearance of 2+ million people entering into his land
- We aren't given the details of the attack in this chapter, but later the Lord reminds Moses of this event in Deut 25 and gives a consequence to the Amalekites

Deut. 25:17 **"Remember what Amalek did to you along the way when you came out from Egypt,**
Deut. 25:18 **how he met you along the way and attacked among you all the stragglers at your rear when you were faint and weary; and he did not fear God.**
Deut. 25:19 **"Therefore it shall come about when the LORD your God has given you rest from all your surrounding enemies, in the land which the LORD your God gives you as an inheritance to possess, you shall blot out the memory of Amalek from under heaven; you must not forget.**

- Apparently, Amalek chose to attack Israel from the rear as they were moving into the camp
    - The people of Israel were weary after a day of travel
    - And there were stragglers at the back of the assembly who were vulnerable to the attack
        - This was a cowardly way to attack Israel
- Moreover, Amalek showed no fear of God in his attack
    - We must remember that people everywhere had heard of the Lord's destruction of Egypt and His rescue of Israel

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- They would have also learned of the Pharaoh's destruction at the Red Sea crossing
- Nevertheless, Amalek was still willing to attack God's people, thus showing no fear of God

- Then a battle ensues

Ex. 17:9 So Moses said to Joshua, "Choose men for us and go out, fight against Amalek. Tomorrow I will station myself on the top of the hill with the staff of God in my hand."
Ex. 17:10 Joshua did as Moses told him, and fought against Amalek; and Moses, Aaron, and Hur went up to the top of the hill.

- To lead the fight, Moses turns to a young man named Joshua
  - This is the first mention of Joshua in the Bible
    - He becomes a major Biblical character
    - One book of scripture is named for him
  - His name was not originally Joshua
    - In the genealogy of Numbers 13, we see his name given as Hoshea
      - Hoshea means savior
    - Later, Moses changes his name to Joshua
      - Joshua means the Lord is savior
    - When the Hebrew word "Joshua" is translated into Greek and then from Greek into English, it becomes Jesus
      - In other words, Jesus and Joshua are the same name, which means the Lord saves
  - Joshua will become a private servant to Moses
    - In Ex 24 we learn that Joshua has been given this role
    - He also becomes Moses' successor who leads Israel into Canaan
- It's no accident that Joshua would be mentioned in the same chapter where the rock is struck for water

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- As we studied earlier in this chapter, Moses was instructed to strike a rock and water came out
    - And as we noted, the rock itself pictures Jesus
    - The striking of the rock reflects Jesus' having been "struck" (i.e., dying) on the cross for the sins of men
    - So the first part of Exo 17 taught us that just as Moses struck the rock to save Israel, so did God the Father strike His Son to save God's children from sin
- Later in Numbers 20, there will come yet another time when God will produce water from a rock in response to Israel's complaints
    - In that future incident, God will instruct Moses to speak to the rock and water will come forth
    - In his disgust and anger at Israel's grumbling, Moses impatiently strikes the rock with his rod just as he had done before in Ex 17
        - This action was not in keeping with God's instructions
        - And so the Lord becomes angry at Moses for his disobedience
- How are these events related to Joshua's appearance in the second half of Ex 17?
    - As a result of Moses' disobedience later in Number, Joshua is appointed as Israel's leader
    - Furthermore, as a result of Moses' disobedience, God disciplined Moses by denying him opportunity to enter into the Promised Land
        - Moses would die in the desert
    - In his place, Joshua was to lead Israel into the Promised Land
    - So Joshua is introduced in connection with the striking of the rock because in a later day, Joshua will supplant Moses in connection with a similar incident
    - The rock of water and Joshua become closely connected by that later incident
        - One explains the rise of the other

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- You might wonder why was God so upset at Moses' disobedience?
    - When Moses struck the rock a second time, Moses was distorting the picture the Lord was intent on creating through the rock
        - Moses' actions were suggesting that the Messiah Himself would need to be struck a second time by God the Father to save Israel
        - In truth, Jesus must die only once for our sins and will never again be struck in that way
            - When the Messiah comes again, He comes in power and glory, not to be struck by a rod but to rule with a rod of iron
        - Yet Moses' disobedience potentially corrupted that picture, forcing God to discipline Moses in order to make clear that his actions were wrong
    - This fact makes possible an even more powerful understanding of Joshua's connection to the rock of water
        - Moses brings Israel the Law, and as a result Moses comes to represent the Law in scripture
            - We even call it the Law of Moses
        - The purpose of the Law according to scripture is to act as a witness against the people of Israel
            - Paul tells us that Law was not given to produce righteousness
            - The Law was given to reveal unrighteousness by showing us to be guilty of disobedience
        - Therefore, no man will be saved by works of Law, Paul tells us
    - So when the man who represents the Law is himself shown to be a lawbreaker, he forms an unintentional picture that God uses for His own purposes
        - Moses, the Law giver, is not qualified to lead Israel into the Promised Land
        - In other words, the Law brings no one into the Promised Land, which is another term for the kingdom

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- Should we try to enter the kingdom by works of the Law, we will be found to be a sinner and thereby be disqualified and prevented from entering
- So Moses' failure pictures the Law's failure to bring us to righteousness and into the Kingdom

- Instead of Moses, it was Joshua who leads Israel into the Promised Land
  - Joshua, as you know, is the same name as Jesus
- Jesus is the One Who leads us into salvation and into the Kingdom
  - He is the door by which we enter the kingdom of God
  - Jesus called Himself that door

John 10:7 So Jesus said to them again, "Truly, truly, I say to you, I am the door of the sheep.
John 10:8 "All who came before Me are thieves and robbers, but the sheep did not hear them.
John 10:9 "I am the door; if anyone enters through Me, he will be saved, and will go in and out and find pasture.

- So as Joshua led Israel into the Promised Land, so does Jesus lead us into salvation and the Kingdom

- So Moses introduces us to Joshua at this point to emphasize that Joshua will be the future leader of Israel

- Turning to the battle itself, as Joshua takes some of the people of Israel and begins to engage the Amalekites, Moses stations himself on a hill overlooking the battle
  - With him are his brother, Aaron, and Hur
    - Hur was said to the be Moses' brother-in-law,, the husband of Miriam, according to Josephus
  - Israel had strength in numbers, while the Amalekites probably had the benefit of better equipment and experience in battle
    - But Israel had an even more powerful advantage
    - They had Charlatan Heston's underarms

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Ex. 17:11 So it came about when Moses held his hand up, that Israel prevailed, and when he let his hand down, Amalek prevailed.
Ex. 17:12 But Moses' hands were heavy. Then they took a stone and put it under him, and he sat on it; and Aaron and Hur supported his hands, one on one side and one on the other. Thus his hands were steady until the sun set.
Ex. 17:13 So Joshua overwhelmed Amalek and his people with the edge of the sword.

- As Moses watches the battle, he finds that he has an ability to intercede on behalf of Israel
    - When Moses raises his hands to the Lord, the battle goes Israel's way, but when his hands drop, Amalek begins to win the battle
        - We don't know how Moses came to discover this connection
        - We assume he was naturally directed to pray on behalf of Israel, and he raised his hands when he prayed
            - At some point he grew weary and ceased praying
            - That's when he noticed that his intercession was crucial to the battle
    - Once Moses and his companions notice the connection, they immediately understand what they must do
        - They must remain in constant prayer until the battle is won
        - To achieve this physically straining endeavor, they assist Moses by holding his hands when his own arm muscles give out
- We know that the Lord didn't need Moses's hands to be raised in order to defend Israel, so why did God insist on such a contrived method?
    - Once again, God's purpose is to teach Israel and later generations concerning the Lord
    - First, remember this is the first military battle for Israel, and therefore it's the first time Israel will experience the Lord fighting for them in human combat
        - The men of Israel are the ones physically engaged in the fighting
        - But the Lord will steer the events of the battle to His desired outcome

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- This is the same way Gideon defeats a huge army with only 300 men

- In fact, battles will occur frequently in Israel's wanderings and conquest of Canaan, and all the battles will be fought under Joshua's leadership
  - So this first battle will set an important precedent for the nation
    - When Israel prevails, who will they credit?
    - Joshua? Moses? The Lord? Who is responsible for the outcome?
- So to ensure the nation appreciates the Lord's grace and provision of victory, the Lord chooses to work through Moses' staff in a very visible way
  - As Moses holds his staff skyward with hands raised in full view of all the nation, Joshua prevails
    - The staff continues to serve as a symbol of God's power and authority
    - So the message to Israel is that the Lord was the One earning Joshua his victory
  - When Moses drops the staff by the lowering of his hands, the nation ceases to prevails
    - In that way the people understand that Joshua and the men are not strong enough by their own power to win the battle
    - Human ability is not the deciding factor...the Lord is their secret weapon
      - Credit goes not to the man Joshua, but to the Lord

- These scene is often thought to be one of the best picture of intercessory prayer available in scripture
  - This account never says explicitly that Moses was praying, but it seems a reasonable assumption he may have offered prayer on behalf of Joshua
    - Even if Moses never prayed himself, the entire scene remains a beautiful example of men seeking God's intercession
  - First, it reflects the true purpose of prayer

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- Too often we assume that prayer is an attempt on our part to persuade God to do our bidding
    - But God's will doesn't bend to the hearts of men
    - God's heart is to bend the will of men
- The true purpose of prayer is to bring our needs before God in the hope of receiving His grace and mercy in some way
    - Perhaps we will receive exactly what we request
    - Maybe the Lord will give us a different solution or nothing at all
        - Whatever He does, it will be the best thing we could receive
    - In the meantime, we will know it came from the Lord

- In fact, our prayer life will become the means to glorify God in the same way Moses' hands glorified the Lord
    - His intercession gave opportunity for Moses and the people to see the Lord working and give Him glory for it
    - Without the intercession, the work would still happen, but would we have known to credit the Lord?
    - Perhaps we would have wasted time praising Joshua for being such a great warrior
        - Prayer is a billboard God will use to tell the world of His work on behalf of His children
        - When we spend time seeking Him, then we have opportunity to connect the dots between our desires and His goodness
    - This is why James says:

James 4:2 You lust and do not have; so you commit murder. You are envious and cannot obtain; so you fight and quarrel. You do not have because you do not ask.
James 4:3 You ask and do not receive, because you ask with wrong motives, so that you may spend it on your pleasures.

- James isn't teaching that we always get what we ask

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        - But he is teaching that until we become proficient in seeking God for our needs, we can't mature into the person who asks for the right things in the right ways and thereby sees the fruit of God's provision

    - We could make further comparisons to the role of partners in prayer, as illustrated by Aaron and Hur

        - And to the need to pray constantly and not just sporadically

        - But the points are obvious

- So Joshua prevails

Ex. 17:14 Then the LORD said to Moses, "Write this in a book as a memorial and recite it to Joshua, that I will utterly blot out the memory of Amalek from under heaven."
Ex. 17:15 Moses built an altar and named it The LORD is My Banner;
Ex. 17:16 and he said, "The LORD has sworn; the LORD will have war against Amalek from generation to generation."

- The Lord commands Moses to begin writing a book

    - This is the first time of five time we hear the Lord telling Moses to write something

        - It's interesting - but probably not meaningful - that Moses eventually wrote five books in the Torah

        - Nevertheless, this is the first time Moses begins to write and sets Moses on the path to record God's word

    - In this case, Moses is told to record this event with a promise from God to blot out the memory of Amalek under Heaven

        - Furthermore, the Lord will war with Amalek in the meantime

        - Joshua later encounters the Amalekites in Canaan when Israel enters the land

            - At that time, the Lord orders Joshua to exterminate this people at that time

            - Nonetheless, some live on but are eventually destroyed under Hezekiah

    - Amalek's fate is another teaching moment for Israel

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        - Just as God has given Israel promises of future eternal glory, peace and possession of an inheritance, He is also promising eventual end to Israel's enemies

    - Notice Moses is told to repeat these words in Joshua's hearing, indicating that God wants this moment to be clearly understood by Joshua

        - Joshua and Israel are to have confidence to know that Israel's enemies will not only be defeated, but they will cease to exist one day

            - This is still true today

            - The enemies of Israel still have the upper hand, but in a future day, they will be exterminated from the earth

- Finally, a memorial is erected to the Lord's victory

    - Moses builds an altar at the base of the mountain of Horeb

        - He names it the Lord is my banner, which refers to a military victory

        - So Moses declares that the Lord is the One Who gives victory in battle

    - Mose declares what the Lord instructed

        - The Lord has sworn to battle against Amalek, and this battle will last for generations

        - In fact, it lasts for four centuries before the people are wiped out

            - For a time in Judges, the Amalekites manage to win victories over parts of Israel until Gideon defeats them again

            - Later Saul defeats the Amalekites so badly they never again have national status or strength

- After they win the battle, Israel settles in for a time at the mountain, giving opportunity for Moses' family to arrive for a visit from elsewhere in Midian

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Ex. 18:1 Now Jethro, the priest of Midian, Moses' father-in-law, heard of all that God had done for Moses and for Israel His people, how the LORD had brought Israel out of Egypt.
Ex. 18:2 Jethro, Moses' father-in-law, took Moses' wife Zipporah, after he had sent her away,
Ex. 18:3 and her two sons, of whom one was named Gershom, for Moses said, "I have been a sojourner in a foreign land."
Ex. 18:4 The other was named Eliezer, for he said, "The God of my father was my help, and delivered me from the sword of Pharaoh."
Ex. 18:5 Then Jethro, Moses' father-in-law, came with his sons and his wife to Moses in the wilderness where he was camped, at the mount of God.
Ex. 18:6 He sent word to Moses, "I, your father-in-law Jethro, am coming to you with your wife and her two sons with her."
Ex. 18:7 Then Moses went out to meet his father-in-law, and he bowed down and kissed him; and they asked each other of their welfare and went into the tent.
Ex. 18:8 Moses told his father-in-law all that the LORD had done to Pharaoh and to the Egyptians for Israel's sake, all the hardship that had befallen them on the journey, and how the LORD had delivered them.
Ex. 18:9 Jethro rejoiced over all the goodness which the LORD had done to Israel, in delivering them from the hand of the Egyptians.
Ex. 18:10 So Jethro said, "Blessed be the LORD who delivered you from the hand of the Egyptians and from the hand of Pharaoh, and who delivered the people from under the hand of the Egyptians.
Ex. 18:11 "Now I know that the LORD is greater than all the gods; indeed, it was proven when they dealt proudly against the people."
Ex. 18:12 Then Jethro, Moses' father-in-law, took a burnt offering and sacrifices for God, and Aaron came with all the elders of Israel to eat a meal with Moses' father-in-law before God.

- Jethro, Moses' father-in-law heard of everything happening to Moses and the people, and so he travels to visit Moses
    - He brings Moses' wife and boys to visit Moses
        - Remember, Zipporah was sent back to Midian at the incident of the circumcision
        - She wasn't a part of the work of Moses in Egypt
            - It's worth remembering that she missed the chance to witness all of God's miraculous work

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- She missed it because of her unwillingness to support Moses in obeying God's word

- We also learn the names of Moses' sons
  - The first name, Gershon, was known already
  - But now we know the second son was named Eliezer, meaning the Lord is my help

- Jethro sends word ahead of his arrival, so Moses shows Jethro respect by going out to meet him and welcomes Jethro into his tent
  - Moses then relates the entire event of the Exodus to Jethro
    - It must have been an incredible story
    - Jethro must have been wide-eyed throughout the account
    - This was better than any Hollywood movie...well, almost better than any Hollywood movie
  - Jethro responds in some important ways
    - First, he rejoices over Israel's deliverance in v.9
      - This tell us that he had a heart to bless those the Lord has blessed and to love those the Lord loves
    - Secondly, he praises the Lord and credits Him with this work in v. 10
      - This suggests to us that Jethro is now convinced in the power and faithfulness of the Hebrew God
    - Then, he makes a confession in v.11
      - He declares that God was above all other gods
    - Finally, in v.12 Jethro makes a sacrifice to the Lord and an offering of thanks
  - What do we make of Jethro's actions?
    - Some believe this proves Jethro either was a priest of the Jehovah or becomes a follower of God at this point
    - Others point out that In Num 25:17-18 Midianites were described as pagans and worshippers of many gods

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- You can find support for both views in the text

- Then Jethro makes a contribution to Moses' work

Ex. 18:13 It came about the next day that Moses sat to judge the people, and the people stood about Moses from the morning until the evening.
Ex. 18:14 Now when Moses' father-in-law saw all that he was doing for the people, he said, "What is this thing that you are doing for the people? Why do you alone sit as judge and all the people stand about you from morning until evening?"
Ex. 18:15 Moses said to his father-in-law, "Because the people come to me to inquire of God.
Ex. 18:16 "When they have a dispute, it comes to me, and I judge between a man and his neighbor and make known the statutes of God and His laws."
Ex. 18:17 Moses' father-in-law said to him, "The thing that you are doing is not good.
Ex. 18:18 "You will surely wear out, both yourself and these people who are with you, for the task is too heavy for you; you cannot do it alone.
Ex. 18:19 "Now listen to me: I will give you counsel, and God be with you. You be the people's representative before God, and you bring the disputes to God,
Ex. 18:20 then teach them the statutes and the laws, and make known to them the way in which they are to walk and the work they are to do.
Ex. 18:21 "Furthermore, you shall select out of all the people able men who fear God, men of truth, those who hate dishonest gain; and you shall place these over them as leaders of thousands, of hundreds, of fifties and of tens.
Ex. 18:22 "Let them judge the people at all times; and let it be that every major dispute they will bring to you, but every minor dispute they themselves will judge. So it will be easier for you, and they will bear the burden with you.
Ex. 18:23 "If you do this thing and God so commands you, then you will be able to endure, and all these people also will go to their place in peace."
Ex. 18:24 So Moses listened to his father-in-law and did all that he had said.
Ex. 18:25 Moses chose able men out of all Israel and made them heads over the people, leaders of thousands, of hundreds, of fifties and of tens.
Ex. 18:26 They judged the people at all times; the difficult dispute they would bring to Moses, but every minor dispute they themselves would judge.
Ex. 18:27 Then Moses bade his father-in-law farewell, and he went his way into his own land.

- Jethro observes as Moses take on the duties of a judge in Israel
    - It is understandable to see Moses assume this role
        - Israel consists of 2 million people but without lines of authority or government

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        - They are living in a commune and taking orders from Moses, who receives them from the Lord
        - Inevitably, a group of 2 million people will encounter disputes, various forms of lawlessness, etc.
        - Someone must judge over these matters, and Moses naturally assumes he must accomplish this work
    - Furthermore, Moses was receiving instructions from God on a regular basis, and these instructions were handed down to the people by Moses
        - Since there was no email, and no megaphones, Moses was literally communicating instructions to all 2 million people
        - Evidently, he passed out instructions to one group and then another
    - In v.13 we learn that Moses was forced to serve in this way from morning until evening
        - And Jethro correctly determines that this won't work for long
        - Moses is hoping he can hold out, but Moses needs a plan, and hope is not a plan

- So Jethro takes it upon himself to point out the flaws in Moses' system
    - First, he says this is not good, or beneficial
        - It is not beneficial for Moses or for the people
        - Moses has too much burden to bear and must include others in the work
    - Secondly, the work Moses chooses for himself must be the work he alone is qualified to handle, that is the work of a prophet
        - Moses is to act as God's representative, since this is the role God assigned to Moses
        - His work should focus on teaching God's statutes and laws and exhorting them to walk in these ways
    - Finally, he is to appoint trustworthy men to work alongside him at lower levels of authority in a chain of command

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        - These lower officials will handle most issues and only bring the most serious ones before Moses

    - Jethro assures Moses that is he will benefit from this change as well the people

        - Moses will be able to endure and sustain his work

        - The people will receive quicker, easier resolution to their disputes

- It should be clear to us all that these instructions set a wise precedent for spiritual leaders in the church today

    - First, leaders are not supposed to go it alone in ministry

        - They should work within a plurality of leadership over congregations

        - If one man tries to do it all, he repeats Moses' mistake

    - Secondly, leaders should know their spiritual gifts and calling, and then remain focused on them while resisting the temptation to do other things

        - The senior leader(s) has a primary responsibility to train up the body in the word of God and to exhort our people to live according to it

        - If leaders let other duties come between them and teaching the word, they begin to fail the Acts 6 test

            - They forsake the teaching of God's word to feed the widows

        - If our people learned the Bible and lived by it, every other issue we face as leaders would diminish if not disappear altogether

    - Thirdly, we should establish some degree of hierarchy of leadership in the church

        - Multiple levels of leadership support the efficient operation of the body

        - Remembering that levels of leadership doesn't imply a bunch of employees and staff receiving support from the congregation

- Next week we move with Israel to the mountain of Sinai

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Exodus 19

- Tonight we study chapter 19 and an introduction to the giving of the Law, which begins in chapter 20
    - Technically, we've been in the third part of the book for the past three chapters
        - The third part chronicles the giving of the Law to Israel
        - We count it from chapter 16 and not chapter 20 because God has already begun to instruct Israel
        - He's already begun to demand their obedience to His commands and statutes
    - But those early mentions of statutes and regulations were simply the warm up for the main act, when Moses receives the entire Law of God
        - That main event begins in chapter 20
            - The giving of the Law is more properly understood as the giving of a covenant, which obligates Israel to keep the Law
            - Before we get there, we study the nation's arrival at the mountain
        - So the nation's arrival at the mountain includes preparations for entering into a covenant with the Lord
        - And those preparations include rules and regulations for how the nation is to regard the mountain itself

Ex. 19:1 In the third month after the sons of Israel had gone out of the land of Egypt, on that very day they came into the wilderness of Sinai.
Ex. 19:2 When they set out from Rephidim, they came to the wilderness of Sinai and camped in the wilderness; and there Israel camped in front of the mountain.

- As Moses tells us, it's been three months since the nation left Egypt
    - Once again the date of their arrival is precise in a way that reminds us that God is guiding their every step

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- Exactly three months after the nation exited Egypt, they arrive at the mountain in Midian, sometime in May or June
- They had been camped in Rephidim, which we know is a part of the mountain range of Horeb and near Sinai
    - But now they move directly to the base of the mountain Sinai

- We've seen the names Horeb and Sinai used interchangeably throughout the story
    - To be more specific, Horeb refers to the mountain range in Midian
    - The name Sinai is the name of the mountain peak in the Horeb range
    - Like Pikes Peak is a mountain in the Rocky Mountain Range
        - Israel has been moving alongside the Horeb range almost since they came up out of the Red Sea
        - But now they have reach the base of SInai
    - And here the nation comes to a rest

Ex. 19:3 **Moses went up to God, and the LORD called to him from the mountain, saying, "Thus you shall say to the house of Jacob and tell the sons of Israel:**
Ex. 19:4 **'You yourselves have seen what I did to the Egyptians, and how I bore you on eagles' wings, and brought you to Myself.**
Ex. 19:5 **'Now then, if you will indeed obey My voice and keep My covenant, then you shall be My own possession among all the peoples, for all the earth is Mine;**
Ex. 19:6 **and you shall be to Me a kingdom of priests and a holy nation.' These are the words that you shall speak to the sons of Israel."**

- As the nation camps, Moses receives his first instructions from God
    - Moses we're told goes "up to God" but God called to Moses "from the mountain"
        - Moses walked some distance away from the people to approach the glory of God
        - But he didn't climb the mountain, not at this point

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- Then the Lord begins to speak to Moses concerning what He was going to deliver to the people
  - In vs. 3-6 we find the heart and purpose of Law
    - Some has called these verses the most theologically significant text in all Exodus
    - It has been called a linchpin between the covenant to Abraham and the covenant to all Israel
  - And we learn several important points about the Law

- First, the law was given to the house of Jacob and the sons of Israel
  - Obviously, the house of Jacob and the sons of Israel are one and the same
    - This covenant and the law it contains is an agreement between the Lord and the people of Israel
    - The terms of this agreement are only binding to that group of people
    - This is a common misperception among Christians
      - Especially if we've been mis-taught that the Law is a binding set of rules upon believers
      - The reality is very different
  - Only the Jewish people are bound by the terms of the Law given through Moses
    - Gentiles are not party to this covenant
    - Paul teaches us in Romans 2:14 that Gentiles "do not have the law"
    - And again in Rom 2:17 Paul identifies the Jew as the one who has the Law
      - Nevertheless, all men, both those with the law and those without the law, will be judged by the Law of God

Rom. 2:12 **For all who have sinned without the Law will also perish without the Law, and all who have sinned under the Law will be judged by the Law;**

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- Through this covenant, God gave Israel a preview of the standard that all men face at their judgment day
    - And it bound them to following it in this life or else face certain penalties
    - But the covenant did not establish God's right to judge Israel
- On the contrary, all men were already under the penalty of God's Law even before He revealed to Israel
    - Though Gentiles are not parties to this covenant, they are still judged according to the Law

- But once we come to faith in Messiah, whether Jew or Gentile, we are no longer under the penalty of the Law
    - Jesus take our place in that judgment, and He fulfilled the Law's requirements perfectly
    - So at our judgment, we are found vindicated because Christ's perfect life is credited to us through faith
    - For those who have not received that propitiation before they die will stand for judgment on the basis of their own works
        - And they will not survive that judgment

- Secondly, God enacted this covenant having delivered Israel out of Egypt
    - This statement is a direct reference to the covenant to Abraham
        - Remember I said that these verses are a linchpin between the Abrahamic Covenant and the Sinai covenant
        - By linchpin, we mean that the covenant of Abraham foretold certain events in the lives of Abraham's descendants
            - Specifically, the Lord told Abraham that his descendants would be numerous
            - But that they would wander and be enslaved for 400 years
            - And then they would be delivered out of Egypt
        - At this moment, the Lord has now done as He promised

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- So He first reminds the people that He is trustworthy and covenant-keeping

- This gives rise to what comes next in Israel's relationship with the Lord
  - And the answer is found in the Sinai covenant
  - This covenant will begin a new dispensation in God's plan of redemption
    - Rather than work through a patriarch and his family, now the Lord commits Himself to a people and nation
    - The covenant He is establishing in chapters 20 and beyond is the next chapter in His plan to bring the Seed, Christ
- So these verses are the linchpin to connect God's fulfillment of one covenant and the inauguration of a new covenant
  - But this transition between the Abrahamic Covenant and the Mosaic Covenant is not a matter of succession but rather of elaboration
  - God is not signaling that the Abrahamic Covenant is coming to an end and a new covenant is taking its place
    - On the contrary, the Abrahamic Covenant continues on perpetually
    - While the Mosaic covenant will merely come along side for a time

Gal. 3:17 **What I am saying is this: the Law, which came four hundred and thirty years later, does not invalidate a covenant previously ratified by God, so as to nullify the promise.**
Gal. 3:18 **For if the inheritance is based on law, it is no longer based on a promise; but God has granted it to Abraham by means of a promise.**
Gal. 3:19 **Why the Law then? It was added because of transgressions, having been ordained through angels by the agency of a mediator, until the seed would come to whom the promise had been made.**

- God has good reason for pairing these two covenants together for a time

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        - Abraham's inheritance - and by extension our share in that inheritance by the New Covenant - did not come by Law but by a promise
        - So the arrival of the Law didn't change or improve upon that earlier promise
        - Instead, the Law came to reveal our sin

- Third, God tells Moses that this covenant is about taking possession of Israel in a unique and special way
    - The Lord says all the earth is His, but He is prepared to designate Israel in a special way
        - Through His covenant, Israel will assume an unique identity
        - They will be set apart from all the other nations of the earth
        - Among all the people of Earth, Israel will forever have a special place
    - This distinction will serve a purposes in the current age and in the next
        - In this age, the nation will be entrusted with the oracles of God
        - It will be the place of the Lord's dwelling on Earth
        - And it will bring the Seed of Messiah into the world
        - In the Kingdom to come, Israel will serve the Lord in His temple and rule over all nations on earth

- Finally, God says that the opportunity to have this special relationship with the Lord is contingent upon Israel keeping the covenant
    - They are obey His voice and keep the covenant
        - This is a parity covenant, which is different than the suzerainty covenant God established with Abraham
            - The Abrahamic Covenant was a suzerainty covenant between a superior, the Lord, and a lessor, Abraham
            - The Lord set the terms and granted the covenant to Abraham without any agreement on Abraham's part
            - Abraham neither accepted nor refused it

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- Nor did it come with any condition or obligations for Abraham
- He did nothing to receive it and he does nothing to keep it, since it was dependent on God's promise alone

- The Sinai Covenant is a parity covenant between two parties
  - The two parties in this case are not equal of course
  - But both must agree to the terms of the covenant
  - And both assume obligations under the covenant
  - Both Israel and the Lord are committing to keep the terms

- I hope it doesn't ruin the ending of our story if I tell you that Israel doesn't succeed at this requirement
  - They often disobey, sometimes merely hours after having been given a command
  - So how does covenant manage to stand?

- In later books of the Law, we get our answer
  - The Lord constructs this covenant in such a way that the agreement will survive Israel's disobedience
  - In fact, the Lord places provisions in the Law for what would come upon the nation when they disobey the terms of the covenant
  - Though Israel violates the agreement, the covenant remains in force through a series of penalties and curses
  - Ultimately, those penalties take the form of the Tribulation judgments
    - As we studied in our Revelation class, this covenant becomes the basis for the Lord justly rejecting Israel at the Lord's first coming
    - In their place, the Lord sent the gospel to the Gentiles

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- This covenant, and more specifically the nation's disobedience to the covenant, gave the Lord a just basis for sending the Gospel to Gentiles in place of Jews for a time

- But after those penalties are enforced, as the covenant requires, the nation of Israel is brought into glory and faithfulness

  - Then as a result of the nation's compliance with the Law, they begin to receive the blessings

  - Notice in v.6 the Lord says that they will become a kingdom of priests and a holy nation

    - The reference to kingdom is the first use of the term in the Bible and is a reference to the THE Kingdom where Christ rules

  - This will be a time when the nation serves the Lord as a nation of priests

    - A priest is responsible for mediating between God and men

    - The nation will play this role in the Millennial Kingdom

    - This will also be the time when the nation as a whole becomes holy and without sin, glorified in the Kingdom

- So to summarize, these verses teach:

  - God is making a covenant with the nation of Israel

    - Never with Gentiles

    - And it no longer binds a believer once he has come under the New Covenant

  - Secondly, the covenant bridges the giving of the Abrahamic Covenant with the coming of the Messiah and the New Covenant

    - It does not replace the Abrahamic Covenant or even enhance it

    - Instead, the covenant serves as a contrast, revealing sin rather producing righteousness

  - Thirdly, it establishes a chief nation on earth, Israel

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- The nation is a unique possession of the Lord
- And He establishes it for His glory and purposes

- Finally, the covenant comes with terms for Israel
  - It's a parity covenant, so Israel must keep up their end of the agreement
  - Or else they suffer the penalties of the covenant
  - And by their failure to keep the covenant, the Lord creates an opening for Gentiles to be brought into the New Covenant

- That's a lot of theology to open our study tonight, so let's move through the rest of the chapter

Ex. 19:7 So Moses came and called the elders of the people, and set before them all these words which the LORD had commanded him.
Ex. 19:8 All the people answered together and said, "All that the LORD has spoken we will do!" And Moses brought back the words of the people to the LORD.
Ex. 19:9 The LORD said to Moses, "Behold, I will come to you in a thick cloud, so that the people may hear when I speak with you and may also believe in you forever." Then Moses told the words of the people to the LORD.
Ex. 19:10 The LORD also said to Moses, "Go to the people and consecrate them today and tomorrow, and let them wash their garments;
Ex. 19:11 and let them be ready for the third day, for on the third day the LORD will come down on Mount Sinai in the sight of all the people.
Ex. 19:12 "You shall set bounds for the people all around, saying, 'Beware that you do not go up on the mountain or touch the border of it; whoever touches the mountain shall surely be put to death.
Ex. 19:13 'No hand shall touch him, but he shall surely be stoned or shot through; whether beast or man, he shall not live.' When the ram's horn sounds a long blast, they shall come up to the mountain."
Ex. 19:14 So Moses went down from the mountain to the people and consecrated the people, and they washed their garments.
Ex. 19:15 He said to the people, "Be ready for the third day; do not go near a woman."

- Moses comes down and announces these terms to the elders of Israel
  - As they hear that what the Lord is granting to Israel, they are understandably excited and eager to receive this blessing
    - So they immediately agree to the terms

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        - They agree without truly knowing the details of the covenant
        - This is a rash decision, since they don't know what they're signing up for
    - Notice it says in v.8 that "all" the people answered in agreement
        - But the "all" in this case does not mean every single member of the 2+ million Jews in the encampment
        - There was no such need for every single person to agree
        - Because Moses had instituted Jethro's suggestion to appoint leaders, the nation was represented by their elders
        - If the elders agreed to the covenant, they were binding the entire nation
            - Much in the same way that our elected representatives in the United Stated can bind all citizens of the nation by their decisions
    - This same principle was at work in Jesus' day when the nation of Israel rejected Him and suffered the judgment of AD 70
        - Not every person in Israel personally rejected Jesus
        - But the elders of Israel rejected Him, and they spoke for the nation
- Moses delivers the report to the Lord, thus establishing agreement in the covenant
    - Next the Lord begins to teach Moses and Israel on how they may approach the Lord
        - First, the Lord tells Moses how the nation will experience the Lord on the mountain
            - He will descend on the mountain in a thick cloud
            - Then the people will hear His voice as He speaks with Moses
            - The Lord Himself will not be visible, since the cloud will conceal Him from the Moses and the people
            - But they will hear Him

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- The writer of Hebrews says this experience was a terrifying one for the nation gathered at the base of the mountain

Heb. 12:18 For you have not come to a mountain that can be touched and to a blazing fire, and to darkness and gloom and whirlwind,
Heb. 12:19 and to the blast of a trumpet and the sound of words which sound was such that those who heard begged that no further word be spoken to them.
Heb. 12:20 For they could not bear the command, "IF EVEN A BEAST TOUCHES THE MOUNTAIN, IT WILL BE STONED."
Heb. 12:21 And so terrible was the sight, that Moses said, "I AM FULL OF FEAR and trembling."

- The Lord wants to make this impression upon the people so that they will believe in Moses forever
  - That's a puzzling statement until we recognize what the Lord means by the people believing in Moses
  - The Lord doesn't mean He wants people to believe in Moses, the man
  - He means He wants all Israel and all people forever to believe in the word Moses delivered, that is the word of God delivered through Moses
    - In this case, we're talking about the Law and the rest of the Torah
    - Moses' writings were to last forever, since God's word will never pass away

- In preparation for the Lord's decent to the mountain in the cloud in three days, He tells the nation they must perform a ritual cleansing
  - The people must wash their clothes and remain consecrated for the arrival of the Lord
    - Consecration means to be holy and set apart from sin
    - Obviously, the nation could not separate themselves from sin
      - The people were sinful by nature and nothing short of the resurrection was going to correct for that issue
      - So holiness is to be understood in a lessor form
    - The people were to perform a ritual consecration

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- Ritual cleansing or consecration means performing symbolic actions that picture spiritual cleansing
- Like any picture, the ritual cleansing can't substitute for the greater reality
- It merely provides a substitute that serves as a reminder of the need for the reality in it's greater form

- In this case, they were to wash themselves and refrain from sexual activity to avoid bodily fluids
  - This greater reality pictured her is the spiritual cleansing that comes only from faith in the Messiah and His blood which cleanses us from all unrighteousness
  - And washing the body and clothing pictures the greater cleansing we receive by faith

- But the ritual doesn't take the place of the real thing
  - Even if the ritual was followed perfectly, the people were still sinful
    - Human works simply can't erase sin
    - We can see this clearly in v.12
      - Even after the nation had followed the Lord's commands regarding the ritual cleansing, they would still be subject to death if they so much as touched the mountain
      - The mountain was to be a temporary dwelling place for the Holy God
      - And if our sinfulness comes into contact with the just and holy God, death will immediately result
  - This is why the Lord is determined to appear in a dark cloud
    - This was to protect the people from God's wrath and holiness
    - This is the same reason why God gave Adam and Woman advance warning of His approach in the Garden after they sinned
    - He knew that if they came into His presence, they would die, so He gave them time to hide

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        - And they hid because they instinctively sensed jeopardy at the Lord's approach

    - So in v.13 the Lord states that anyone or any animal that even touches the mountain or crosses the border of the mountain will die

        - Only when a ram's horn is blown may they approach the mountain

            - The blowing of the horn is the sign that the Lord has arrived to meet His people

            - This feature also forms a picture on it's own

                - The Lord will use a horn to announce His arrival for His Church at the onset of the Rapture

- These setting offers us a useful understanding of how man approaches God

    - Since the Garden, men have tried to define their own path to finding God

        - The very existence of many religions is evidence that men love to design their own path to God

        - But God can only be approached according to His rules

            - The Lord defines who and how and when we will come near to Him

        - It must be this way, because man have no capacity to reach God much less survive the encounter

    - The reason the unbelieving world continues to delude itself into thinking it can discover it's own way to God is two fold

        - First, they create a god that is far less than the True God

            - He is less holy, less knowing, less just and less powerful

            - Only by defining god in lessor terms can we feel comfortable with our discovery

        - Secondly, they imagine themselves as without reason to fear God

            - They assume themselves to be far less sinful, far less in debt and under far less of a penalty than they really are

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- If they could only appreciate how much wrath they have stored up for themselves, they would hope to never see God

- The truth is that God is perfect, holy, and just and He will judge all sin completely
  - Nevertheless, in His love and mercy, He has made a way available for us to approach Him
  - He calls us, just as He called the nation of Israel
    - We don't find Him
    - He finds us
  - And then He sets the terms for our encounter
    - He defines the standard of holiness - His perfection is the standard
    - He provides the means for canceling our debt - His Son Jesus' death on the cross
    - He set the terms for our reconciliation - our faith in Christ's death on the cross in our place and His resurrection to make possible eternal life
    - He sets the timing for our encounter- upon our death and entrance into His presence
- The Lord drives the entire process, makes all the rules, and accomplishes all the work
  - We receive His grace and praise Him for it
  - But if we think we can rest on our own merits, define our own terms, or decide the timing of our encounter, we will find ourselves exposed for the fool we were

Ex. 19:16 **So it came about on the third day, when it was morning, that there were thunder and lightning flashes and a thick cloud upon the mountain and a very loud trumpet sound, so that all the people who were in the camp trembled.**
Ex. 19:17 **And Moses brought the people out of the camp to meet God, and they stood at the foot of the mountain.**

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Ex. 19:18 Now Mount Sinai was all in smoke because the LORD descended upon it in fire; and its smoke ascended like the smoke of a furnace, and the whole mountain quaked violently.
Ex. 19:19 When the sound of the trumpet grew louder and louder, Moses spoke and God answered him with thunder.
Ex. 19:20 The LORD came down on Mount Sinai, to the top of the mountain; and the LORD called Moses to the top of the mountain, and Moses went up.
Ex. 19:21 Then the LORD spoke to Moses, "Go down, warn the people, so that they do not break through to the LORD to gaze, and many of them perish.
Ex. 19:22 "Also let the priests who come near to the LORD consecrate themselves, or else the LORD will break out against them."
Ex. 19:23 Moses said to the LORD, "The people cannot come up to Mount Sinai, for You warned us, saying, 'Set bounds about the mountain and consecrate it.'"
Ex. 19:24 Then the LORD said to him, "Go down and come up again, you and Aaron with you; but do not let the priests and the people break through to come up to the LORD, or He will break forth upon them."
Ex. 19:25 So Moses went down to the people and told them.

- As the writer of Hebrews explained, the arrival of the Lord on the third day to the top of the mountain brings great terror to the people
    - All the people stood at the base of the mountain and watches the Lord's glory arrive
        - Atop the mountain, the Lord descends in a fire that burns continuously atop the mountain
        - The cloud is produced by the smoke of the burning
        - And from the cloud also comes lightening, with all the sound of thunder when lightening flashes nearby
        - And if that weren't enough, the mountain quaked violently
            - The earthquakes weren't destructive in the sense that people lost their lives
            - But they brought terror to the people nonetheless
        - Furthermore, the trumpet sound grew louder and louder, indicating that the Lord was near
            - Then Moses spoke to the Lord and the Lord answered with a voice like thunder

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- The fire and burning and smoke and other signs inducing terror produced a display of God's refining and purifying judgment
    - The scene instilled great fear of the Lord in the people
    - If the approach of the Lord instills this kind of fear into God's own people, including Moses, what kind of fear will the world as a whole experience in future days of judgment?
    - For that matter, what will we individually experience when we face the Lord in our judgment day, especially if we have not lived a life that pleases the Lord?
    - The writer of Hebrews gives us that answer as well

Heb. 10:26 **For if we go on sinning willfully after receiving the knowledge of the truth, there no longer remains a sacrifice for sins,**
Heb. 10:27 **but a terrifying expectation of judgment and THE FURY OF A FIRE WHICH WILL CONSUME THE ADVERSARIES.**

- The fear of the Lord is a common term in Scripture, and the writer is explaining its full meaning
    - Too often I've heard it said that the fear of the Lord simply means respect for God
        - There is no biblical basis for such an interpretation
    - The word for fear in Hebrew is yare, which means to be afraid, to become frightened, to be dismayed, and occasionally to show reverence
    - Here's an example of how the word is used, as Jacob prays to God

Gen. 32:11 **"Deliver me, I pray, from the hand of my brother, from the hand of Esau; for I fear him, that he will come and attack me and the mothers with the children.**

- Jacob feared Esau, because he thought he and his family would die
    - That's the meaning of fear, and it's used to describe our attitude toward the Creator

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        - To the extent that we diminish the true meaning of fearing the Lord, we run the risk of making it easier for ourselves to sin
            - We remove any concerns that God may respond to our provocations
            - We forget how much God hates sin

- And we have good reason to fear the Lord, even as believers
    - Our sin is so great and He is so holy and powerful that fear is the natural and right response when we approach the Lord
        - Making it all the more remarkable and necessary that the Son of God take the form of man in order to live among us, Emmanuel, God with us
        - He took a form that allowed Him to live and eat with men without generating fear or dread among those He visited
        - He lowered Himself for that purpose, and so that He might take our place on the cross
    - Notice in v.21 that after Moses ascended to meet with God in the cloud for the first time on the mountain, the Lord warns Moses not to allow the people to cross past the barriers
        - God knew that in time, the people would lose their fear
        - Should they lose that fear, they might wander up the mountain and die
        - If they break through those barriers, the Lord says He will break out against them
            - There is a play on Hebrew in these statements
            - The Lord uses two Hebrew terms for break out
            - The first use of the Hebrew word means to cross or pass through a barrier, while the second means to destroy or break apart
    - Therefore, the Lord tells us Moses that from this point forward, only Aaron, the priests and he can approach the Lord
        - The holiness of God places a necessary barrier between Himself and His people

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- Only the Lord's chosen representatives may approach Him

- These chosen representatives will intercede on behalf of the people

  - First Moses, who pictures Christ, the one who talks with God on behalf of the people

  - Also Aaron, the companion of Moses who speaks for Moses to the people

  - And finally the priests, who have yet to even be named, will have opportunity to serve God in the tabernacle which will be built

- These barriers to direct contact and fellowship with God are made necessary by the grace of God in response to the sin of men

  - Our sin is THE problem driving our relationship with God

  - The Lord is holy and perfect in all ways

    - The word holy means "set apart"

    - The Lord is utterly set apart from sin

      - In the way that light and dark cannot exist at the same moment and in the same place, neither can the Lord be in the presence of sin

      - He is set apart from it as light is from dark

    - Moreover, He is perfect in justice

      - He must be righteous in all things

      - If sin were to enter into His presence, He must bring immediate justice against it

      - And the penalty for sin must be death, absence from the presence of God

  - Following the fall in the Garden, man entered into a state of sin

    - Our spiritual nature was contaminated by sin, leaving us in jeopardy of God's judgment and the death that always follows

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        - So as grace to men, God has remained outside our presence since the Garden
        - Men cannot enter into His presence in a full way
        - Men can only enter His presence through a mediator, like Moses
    - And if that mediator is another sinful man, like Moses, then he is also in jeopardy for his own sin
        - But God will permit His chosen representative of the people to enter while still concealing Himself sufficiently to protect the person from death in God's presence
            - In the Law, the one who entered the holy of holies did so only after the room is filled with smoke
            - And God has also brought a cloud upon the mountain to obscure Himself from Moses
    - What the Lord is teaching Israel is that men approach the Lord only on His terms and through mediation
        - We cannot define our own road to Heaven or to finding God
            - The Lord defines the way
            - The Lord sets the rules
            - The Lord brings penalty if we ignore the rules
        - And we must approach through a mediator who represents us
            - You don't get to pick that person
            - God assigns His representatives
            - In each age, they have taken different forms
                - The patriarchs, later the priesthood of the law
                - Later the prophets
                - Today, God's representatives on earth is the church, the holy priesthood of all believers
- Ultimately, the representative for all men is the Lord Himself
    - He is the High Priest that bridges us to the Father

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Exodus 20A

SLIDE 20-1

- The book of Exodus moves into a new section today
    - The next eleven chapters recounts the law spoken to Moses and recorded for the people of Israel
        - The Lord has been slowly preparing the people to receive the Law as they made they way from Egypt to Sinai
        - The Lord told the nation on several occasions that as God's people will be required to keep the Lord's statutes
        - And now we have those statutes spelled out and incorporated into a covenant binding the nation to keep them
    - As we mentioned last week, the Law of God was incorporated into the covenant at Sinai
        - The covenant didn't establish the law
            - God's Law is eternal and reflects God's holiness
            - It is the standard for fellowship with God
            - If men cannot live up to His holiness, we must face the penalty for sin, which is the second death
        - Nor was it necessary for God to enter into a covenant before He could judge Israel by His law
            - As we studied last time, Paul taught in Romans that all men are judged according to God's law
            - Those who have the Law and those who are without the Law will be judged according to the same Law
            - Since we all have sin, we all fail that test
            - Only if we accept Christ's payment under the Law on our behalf will we escape this second death
- So the Law of God is one thing, and the covenant God gave to Israel is another and the two work together for God's purposes in Israel
    - Most of the details of the covenant itself are given in the remaining books of Leviticus, Numbers and particularly Deuteronomy

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- Obviously, we aren't going to study those books in this class
- So our study from this point forward will be focused on to studying the Law itself, the tabernacle, and some interesting moments within the camp of Israel
  - Including one incident in particular that involves a golden bovine

- Before we study the Law, we need to spend one lesson on an introduction
  - First, we're going to cover three guiding principles for understanding and interpreting the Law
  - Secondly, we're going to learn the ten reasons for God giving Israel the Law
  - Finally, we're going to examine how a Christian is to view the Law today in the age of the Church

- Let's begin by reviewing some general principles for understanding and interpreting the Law SLIDE 20-2
  - The First Principle: the Law consists of 613 commandments, given to Israel by a covenant, which only function as an indivisible unit
    - A total of 248 positive and 365 negative statutes, as the Jewish rabbis counted them
    - The first ten of these 613 are the best known, but they are not different from the rest nor can they be separated from the rest
  - There is no basis in Scripture for separating any of the commandments in the Law from the rest
    - When the Bible speaks of the "law" of God, it always views all 613 laws as a single entity
    - As James says:

James 2:10 **For whoever keeps the whole law and yet stumbles in one point, he has become guilty of all.**

- God defines keeping the Law successfully as keeping all His commandments and statutes without breaking a single one

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- No law is more important than another; no law is dispensable; all must be kept or else we are lawbreakers
- In short, it's all or none, according to scripture

- We'll return to this principle later in the study

- The Second Principle: The Law is not a means to obtaining righteousness (salvation) for anyone.
  - The Law of Moses was given to a redeemed people, not to redeem a people, as Dwight Pentecost once wrote
    - If there were any doubts concerning this point, we need only read Paul's letters to gain a proper understanding, as Paul said

Gal. 3:11 Now that no one is justified by the Law before God is evident; for, "THE RIGHTEOUS MAN SHALL LIVE BY FAITH."
Gal. 3:12 However, the Law is not of faith; on the contrary, "HE WHO PRACTICES THEM SHALL LIVE BY THEM."

  - The Law was given to Israel for specific purposes, which we'll study in a moment, but personal salvation was never one of those purposes
    - But scripture is utterly clear that the Law made nothing perfect, as Hebrews 7:19 states
    - Paul calls the Law a ministry of death in 2Cor 3
    - And in Romans 3:20 Paul says that by the works of the Law no flesh will be justified, that is declared righteous

- The Third Principle: Keeping the Law did not, by itself, yield greater holiness in the OT saint (sanctification)
  - The OT saint was called to live a life of holiness, one that reflects the holiness of the Lord Himself
    - They were commanded to keep the law
    - And when that command met a faithful and obedient heart, it produced sanctification for the the saint seeking to please the Lord
  - But that sanctification was made possible because a faithful heart was seeking to obey God's word by doing what was commanded

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- That same faithful heart understood that God would provide a Messiah to remove sin
- That same faithful saint never lost sight of his own unworthiness, since the Law served as a constant reminder of sin
- So sanctification was a product of faith seeking to obey God's word
  - The keeping of the Law was merely the test of faith provided to the OT saint in Israel
  - It didn't by itself produce sanctification

- We'll also return to this topic later in tonight's lesson

- Moving to our next topic for the night, let's examine the ten purposes for the giving of the Law to Israel SLIDE 20-3
  - These purposes can be divided into three groups: theological, national and individual purposes
    - First, the theological purposes...teaching concerning holiness and sin
  - (1) The Law reveals the holiness of God, which is the standard of righteousness SLIDE 20-4

Lev. 11:44 'For I am the LORD your God. Consecrate yourselves therefore, and be holy, for I am holy. And you shall not make yourselves unclean with any of the swarming things that swarm on the earth.
Lev. 11:45 'For I am the LORD who brought you up from the land of Egypt to be your God; thus you shall be holy, for I am holy.'"

SLIDE 20-5

  - (2) By contrast, the law also reveals and condemns the sinfulness of man

Rom. 3:20 because by the works of the Law no flesh will be justified in His sight; for through the Law comes the knowledge of sin.

Rom. 4:15 for the Law brings about wrath, but where there is no law, there also is no violation.

  - (3) Therefore, the Law sets the standard for fellowship with God (i.e., the holiness men must obtain for entrance into Heaven) SLIDE 20-6

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Psa. 24:3 Who may ascend into the hill of the LORD?
And who may stand in His holy place?
Psa. 24:4 He who has clean hands and a pure heart,
Who has not lifted up his soul to falsehood
And has not sworn deceitfully.
Psa. 24:5 He shall receive a blessing from the LORD
And righteousness from the God of his salvation.

SLIDE 20-7

- (4) By setting such an impossible standard, the Law meets its ultimate theological purpose in leading men to recognize the need for a Messiah

Gal. 3:24 Therefore the Law has become our tutor to lead us to Christ, so that we may be justified by faith.

- The second group of purposes in the law are national purposes for Israel

SLIDE 20-8

- (5) The Law (and the covenant that delivered it) was God's instrument for establishing Israel as God's chosen nation of people on earth

Ex. 19:5 'Now then, if you will indeed obey My voice and keep My covenant, then you shall be My own possession among all the peoples, for all the earth is Mine;

SLIDE 20-9

- (6) The Law, by its strict rules and unique provisions, caused Israel to be set apart from other nations and to remain forever distinct in identity and culture

Lev. 20:24 'Hence I have said to you, "You are to possess their land, and I Myself will give it to you to possess it, a land flowing with milk and honey." I am the LORD your God, who has separated you from the peoples.

Lev. 20:26 'Thus you are to be holy to Me, for I the LORD am holy; and I have set you apart from the peoples to be Mine.

SLIDE 20-10

- (7) The Law instituted national worship observances, including certain festivals and the temple services

Lev. 23:4 'These are the appointed times of the LORD, holy convocations which you shall proclaim at the times appointed for them.

- Finally, the Law purposes for the individual within Israel, as a standard of conduct for the OT saint (it didn't create a saint; it regulated the life of a saint)

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SLIDE 20-11

- (8) First, the Law regulated individual conduct to yield blessing and promote well-being

Psa. 1:1 How blessed is the man who does not walk in the counsel of the wicked,
Nor stand in the path of sinners,
Nor sit in the seat of scoffers!
Psa. 1:2 But his delight is in the law of the LORD,
And in His law he meditates day and night.
Psa. 1:3 He will be like a tree firmly planted by streams of water,
Which yields its fruit in its season
And its leaf does not wither;
And in whatever he does, he prospers.

  - This was a tool the Lord used to promote holiness in the lives of OT saints

- As we mentioned earlier, the Law BY ITSELF does not produce sanctification
  - But during the dispensation of Law, the OT saint was guided into holiness through the commandments and instruction of the Law
    - Notice the Psalmist says that he delights in meditating on God's law
    - This is another way of saying "studying God's word"
    - The Law was God's word for the OT saint, and therefore it provided the same fuel for sanctification that the word of God does for the NT saint now
  - In fact, the giving of the Law to Israel occurs exactly 50 days after the crossing of the Red Sea, when the Jews were freed from Pharaoh's army
    - The Feast of Weeks was given to Israel to commemorate this time of escape from the Red Sea and the arrival at the mountain
    - The Feast of Weeks goes by another name in the New Testament: the Feast of Pentecost, where the word pentecost means 50 days in Greek
      - In the book of Acts, we read that on Pentecost the Holy Spirit arrives to indwell all believers in the Church
      - This moment is the fulfillment of the earlier moment of Israel in the desert

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- In Acts we read (NKJV):

Acts 2:1 **When the Day of Pentecost had fully come, they were all with one accord in one place.**

  - So the Law came to Israel 50 days after they were freed from Egypt
    - It was written on stone
    - And it was given to Israel so they might have a guide for righteous living
    - That day was intended as a picture of a greater fulfillment for the Church, when it received a law written on hearts by the Holy Spirit
      - The Spirit came 50 days after believers were freed from slavery to sin
      - And He was given to all men so that we might truly become righteous by grace

SLIDE 20-12

- (9) Secondly, the Law served as a test for whether a person was part of the kingdom of God (i.e., the theocracy of Israel)

Num. 15:30 **'But the person who does anything defiantly, whether he is native or an alien, that one is blaspheming the LORD; and that person shall be cut off from among his people.**
Num. 15:31 **'Because he has despised the word of the LORD and has broken His commandment, that person shall be completely cut off; his guilt will be on him.'"**

  - This is the OT equivalent of fruit of the Spirit, showing by a person's actions whether they were a follower of God's word
    - Those who failed to abide by the Law were to be removed from the nation of Israel, cut off from the people
  - In that way, it also serves as a picture of what will happen in the eternal kingdom
    - Only those who are righteous (in Christ) will enjoy life in the kingdom

SLIDE 20-13

- (10) Finally, the Law's sacrificial system provided for personal atonement and restoration of fellowship in the aftermath of unintentional sin

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Lev. 5:17 "Now if a person sins and does any of the things which the LORD has commanded not to be done, though he was unaware, still he is guilty and shall bear his punishment.
Lev. 5:18 "He is then to bring to the priest a ram without defect from the flock, according to your valuation, for a guilt offering. So the priest shall make atonement for him concerning his error in which he sinned unintentionally and did not know it, and it will be forgiven him.

- By observing the sacrificial system of the Law, the OT saint was commanded to confess their guilt and paying a personal price in the form of an animal
  - This process required the priesthood to officiate
  - And through this ritual atonement, the person experience a tangible example of God's
- We should also remember that the Law made no provision for willful sin
  - Only unintentional sin could be covered by atoning sacrifices
  - Intentional sin was punishable by death
- Furthermore, ritual sacrifice under the Law didn't obtain God's forgiveness or produce righteousness in the individual
  - The Lord's forgiveness for sin was a matter of faith made possible by the atonement of Christ on the cross
  - But during the dispensation of Law, prior to the sacrifice of Christ, the rituals of the Law served an important purpose in foreshadowing Christ's work
  - Through these rituals, the OT saint was demonstrating personal repentance and showing evidence of faith
  - Meanwhile, their obedience to the Law produced a picture of God's work through Christ

- On a personal level, the individual also experienced the assurance of God's forgiveness
  - Participating in the ritual atonement under the Law was a grace given to the OT saints, since it provided for a cleansing of the conscience

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- The saint would experience a relief at knowing he was acceptable to God despite his sin, an acceptance made possible by faith only
- So the sacrifices of the Law regulated an OT saint's relationship with God while the world awaited the Messiah

SLIDE 20-14

Gal. 3:19 **Why the Law then? It was added because of transgressions, having been ordained through angels by the agency of a mediator, until the seed would come to whom the promise had been made.**

- Today, we have no need for such rituals to regulate our relationship with the Lord since the greater sacrifice of Christ has been made for us
  - We have the Holy Spirit indwelling every saint, providing conviction of sin and assurance of forgiveness
  - Christ's sacrifice gives makes possible a new spirit and a clear conscience without need for repeated sacrifices

SLIDE 20-15

Heb. 9:13 **For if the blood of goats and bulls and the ashes of a heifer sprinkling those who have been defiled sanctify for the cleansing of the flesh,**
Heb. 9:14 **how much more will the blood of Christ, who through the eternal Spirit offered Himself without blemish to God, cleanse your conscience from dead works to serve the living God?**

- The final topic of our introduction is the question of how we as Christians are to relate to the Law now that we are under the New Covenant
  - First, as we studied already, the Law was given by way of a covenant made with Israel
    - Only Jews were a party to this covenant, so only Jews were obligated to keep the Law
    - Gentiles were never under the Law unless they attached themselves to Israel
  - Once Christ inaugurated the New Covenant in His blood, this wall of separation between Jew and Gentile was broken down
    - Specifically, the elimination of the Law itself removed this barrier

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Eph. 2:11 Therefore remember that formerly you, the Gentiles in the flesh, who are called "Uncircumcision" by the so-called "Circumcision," which is performed in the flesh by human hands —
Eph. 2:12 remember that you were at that time separate from Christ, excluded from the commonwealth of Israel, and strangers to the covenants of promise, having no hope and without God in the world.
Eph. 2:13 But now in Christ Jesus you who formerly were far off have been brought near by the blood of Christ.
Eph. 2:14 For He Himself is our peace, who made both groups into one and broke down the barrier of the dividing wall,
Eph. 2:15 by abolishing in His flesh the enmity, which is the Law of commandments contained in ordinances, so that in Himself He might make the two into one new man, thus establishing peace,

- Notice Paul says in v.15 that the dividing wall between Jew and Gentiles was the Law of commandments
    - The Law was given as part of a covenant, and the covenant was only given to Israel
        - This caused Israel to be set apart from all other nations
        - No Gentile had opportunity to enjoy a relationship with God unless they became part of Israel
            - Some Gentiles did attach themselves to Israel, like Ruth
            - But otherwise, the existence of the Law created a barrier for Jews and Gentiles to join together
    - So if God was going to open up the family of God to all men, then He had to first do away with this barrier
        - Therefore the Law was abolished for those who believe
        - So the NT believer is not commanded to keep the Law
        - This is why Paul teaches in Romans and Galatians and elsewhere that the believer is not under the Law, but is under grace instead
- The Law of God was not abolished; it was fulfilled SLIDE 20-16
    - As Jesus Himself testified

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Matt. 5:17 "Do not think that I came to abolish the Law or the Prophets; I did not come to abolish but to fulfill.

- Christ met all the holiness requirements of the Law
  - As a Jew Himself, Jesus was subject to the terms of the covenant
  - Therefore, He had to keep all the statutes of God's Law,
  - And He did so by living a sinless life
- Christ also bore the punishment for our sin under the Law
  - Christ took upon Himself the curse of the Law
    - As the Law itself says

Deut. 21:22 "If a man has committed a sin worthy of death and he is put to death, and you hang him on a tree,
Deut. 21:23 his corpse shall not hang all night on the tree, but you shall surely bury him on the same day (for he who is hanged is accursed of God), so that you do not defile your land which the LORD your God gives you as an inheritance.

  - So Jesus fulfilled the Law's requirements for righteousness
  - And He fulfilled the penalties prescribed in the Law for sin, though He had not sinned

2Cor. 5:21 He made Him who knew no sin to be sin on our behalf, so that we might become the righteousness of God in Him.

- So even though believers are no longer judged by the Law because the Law's terms have been fulfilled totally in Christ, the covenant and the Law still exists
  - The covenant is still in effect for unbelieving Israel
  - The terms of the covenant continue into the Millennial Kingdom (see Revelation study to learn how)
- Meanwhile, for every believer whether Jew or Gentile the Law has been fulfilled (or we could say completed) on our behalf by Christ

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        - There is nothing more we could accomplish by our attempts to keep the Law that would improve upon what Christ has already done on our behalf

        - In fact, since breaking even one law means breaking the entire law, our fruitless efforts to keep the law amount to nothing but greater condemnation

        - Instead, we are told not to keep law but to rest in Christ's work and accept His righteousness credited to us by faith

- But when we hear that believers are not to observe the Law, we reach a point of difficulty for many Christians

    - Some might assume I am teaching that a Christian is free to do whatever they please

        - Without law, won't people run amok in sin?

        - Aren't at least the Ten Commandments still requirements for Christians?

    - In an attempt to prove their point, someone will inevitably throw out the question "Does this mean a Christian can murder?"

        - The question is clearly ridiculous, since we know the answer is no...murder is sin

        - And no Christian would feel free to murder simply because someone tells them they are not under the Law

- The question is useful for our discussion because it exposes two common false assumptions

    - First, the question assumes that the Ten Commandments can be treated differently than the rest of the 613 Laws of Moses

        - But we have already established that the Law is a single, indivisible entity, and we established that the NT believer is not under Law

        - All the law - all 613 laws - have been fulfilled by Christ on our behalf, so we are not judged according to those laws today

    - Therefore, if someone thinks they should keep the first ten commandments of the Law, they are also arguing for observing the remaining 603 laws as well

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        - Obviously, no Christian I know advocates for keeping all 613 commandments of the Law

    - As Paul says to the Galatians:

Gal. 4:21 **Tell me, you who want to be under law, do you not listen to the law?**

        - Those who feel the need to preserve some or all of the Law as part of Christian experience show their ignorance of that very law

        - Many of the laws require performing animal sacrifice at a temple that no longer exists!

        - So it's literally impossible to keep the Law today...and if you break even one of the laws, you've broken them all!

    - Nevertheless, some Christians try to preserve the ten commandments (and sometimes other laws) apart from the rest of the Law

        - But we can no more choose to selectively observe some laws of God than we can selectively obey some of the laws of our nation

        - It's all or none, just as James says

    - So the first wrong assumption we make in trying to preserve the ten commandments is thinking can preserve some of the Law without the rest

        - If you think there is no way God wanted us to put aside the Ten Commandments, then you are also insisting that you keep the other 603 laws

        - But we know the NT explicitly says we are not under Law, but under grace

- Secondly, the question assumes that the purpose of the Ten Commandments was to compel righteous behavior

    - Let's take murder, for example

    - When someone asks "Is it not OK for a Christian murder?" they are implying that Christians refrain from murdering today because of the Ten Commandments

        - If we agree that the Ten Commandments are no longer in force, we are giving Christians license to murder

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- Well, perhaps we should start by asking how many Christians routinely commit murder today? Answer: all of us

Matt. 5:21 "You have heard that the ancients were told, 'YOU SHALL NOT COMMIT MURDER' and 'Whoever commits murder shall be liable to the court.'
Matt. 5:22 "But I say to you that everyone who is angry with his brother shall be guilty before the court; and whoever says to his brother, 'You good-for-nothing,' shall be guilty before the supreme court; and whoever says, 'You fool,' shall be guilty enough to go into the fiery hell.

- Have you ever called hated someone, even for only a second? Have you ever insulted someone, even just by calling them a "fool?"
- If so, then you have committed an offense no different than murder according to Jesus
- A lot of good those commandment did then

- If we think the Ten Commandments are needed to keep Christians from sinning, then we need to reset our perspective on sin and law
  - The Law never stopped anyone from sinning
  - On the contrary, the Law amplifies sin, in that it highlights our transgressions and enflames our flesh to violate it all the more

Rom. 5:20 The Law came in so that the transgression would increase; but where sin increased, grace abounded all the more,

- So giving me ten commandments didn't serve the purpose of reducing sin

- On the contrary, it caused transgressions to increase, Paul says
  - It showed us where sin existed
  - And the Law triggers a natural response in fallen flesh, which is to intentionally do whatever the Law prohibits
    - You can observe this principle in action in any four year old child or teenager
    - Tell them what they can't do, and watch what they desire most

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- The point is it's a myth to think Christians have been protected from sin by the existence of the Ten Commandments
    - There is not a single commandment that every Christian has not broken in spirit if not in fact
        - We have all used the Lord's name in vain, whether in speech or thought
        - We have all broken the Sabbath
        - We have all lied or been dishonest in some way
        - We have all dishonored our parents at some point
        - We have all lusted in our hearts or been sexually impure at some point
        - We have all taken something that is not ours at some point, even it's just leaving early from work
        - We have all coveted another person's property or harbored desires for another person's spouse, even if only for a second
        - We have all served idols in various ways and at various times
    - The Ten Commandments never kept anyone out of sin much less out of hell, so preserving them serves absolutely no purpose
        - The Law does not makes us holy
            - It can only reveals how sinful we truly are
            - The words may look nice on a plaque on the courthouse steps
            - But when we reverse the Ten Commandments, we're idolizing the very thing that condemns us, not a thing that makes us holy
    - As Hebrews sums up, contrasting the Law and the Old Covenant with the New Covenant in Christ

Heb. 7:18 For, on the one hand, there is a setting aside of a former commandment because of its weakness and uselessness
Heb. 7:19 (for the Law made nothing perfect), and on the other hand there is a bringing in of a better hope, through which we draw near to God.

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Exodus 20B

- Last week we took a pause in our study of Exodus to understand the purpose of Law in God's plan for Israel and the believer in general
    - We learned three general principles for understanding and interpreting Law
        - The Law is a single entity given to Israel as part of a covenant
        - The Law was not given to provide personal salvation
        - The Law by itself cannot produce sanctification in the life of a saint
    - Secondly, we studied the ten purposes for the giving of the Law to Israel
        - Theological purposes
        - National purposes
        - Individual purposes
    - Lastly, we examined how a Christian should understand and apply the Law knowing we are living under grace
        - Because the Lord fulfilled the Law on our behalf, we are no obligated to keep the Law ourselves
        - Christ's perfect obedience under the Law is credited to us on the basis of faith
        - And therefore, we cannot improve on Christ's perfection, and are therefore under liberty instead of the burden of the Law
- It was at this point that I addressed an objection we commonly hear from Christians taught to believe the Ten Commandments still have authority over Christians
    - The objection was that if the entire Law were set aside, are we suggesting Christians are permitted to murder, steal, lie etc.?
        - The question tries to make a point by showing that since it's ridiculous to suggest murder is now OK, then the question by itself proves the Ten Commandments are still in effect
    - My response offered three arguments against this logic

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- First, no Christian has ever felt a license to murder simply because they learn they are not under the OT Law
- Christians still know instinctively that these things are wrong
- So this tells us that we don't rely on the Ten Commandments simply to understand what is sin

- Secondly, I repeated one of our guiding principles, that the Ten Commandments cannot be separated from the other 603 Laws
  - Therefore if we argue that the Ten Commandments are still required, then we must also be willing to live by all 613 laws
  - As Paul said to the Galatians

Gal. 3:12 However, the Law is not of faith; on the contrary, "HE WHO PRACTICES THEM SHALL LIVE BY THEM."

- Clearly, no Christian would argue for a return of the entire Law

- Finally, I said that preserving the Ten Commandments does nothing to prevent Christians from committing murder or sinning in any other way
  - In fact, scripture teaches the opposite

Rom. 5:20 The Law came in so that the transgression would increase; but where sin increased, grace abounded all the more,

- Every Christian has broken every one of the Ten Commandments repeatedly in one form or another, whether by thought or action
- So we can't claim the Ten Commandments are key to leading Christians away from sin and toward righteousness
  - Laws by themselves only serve to name our sins, not reduce them

- Now as we move forward into the Law itself, we must set a framework for how we will study the Law
  - With 613 laws, the question naturally comes how will we study all of them in a timely fashion?
    - My approach will be methodical, though a bit unique

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- First, we will address the law in sections grouped by purpose or theme
    - So in many cases we will read large sections at a time
    - Then we will summarize the requirements and purpose of these statues in Israel's day
- Secondly, we will examine the text for its symbolic meaning,
    - In many cases, the OT Law provides pictures of Christ and His work of redemption
    - In other cases, we will see symbolic meaning in the way the OT Law foreshadows the greater sanctification available in the New Covenant

- In order to understand that last point, we need to cover one final preparatory topic: if Christians are not bound by the Law of Moses, how does God regulate our behavior today? What is the framework of our sanctification?
    - We find the answer in 1Cor 9, in a passage where Paul soeaks about changing his lifestyle to accommodate the expectations of different groups of people

1Cor. 9:20 To the Jews I became as a Jew, so that I might win Jews; to those who are under the Law, as under the Law though not being myself under the Law, so that I might win those who are under the Law;
1Cor. 9:21 to those who are without law, as without law, though not being without the law of God but under the law of Christ, so that I might win those who are without law.

- When Paul lived among Jews, he acted as one who was "under the Law" (meaning under the Mosaic Law) because this was expectation of a God-fearing Jew
    - Jews were bound by their covenant to live under the Law of Moses
    - So Paul returned to a lifestyle of living according to the Law so he could be acceptable to Jews and gain a hearing for the Gospel
    - Nevertheless, notice that Paul says even when he lived this way, he still understood he wasn't required to keep the Law of Moses
        - It was a choice to further the needs of the Gospel

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- He was choosing to live "as if under the Law"

- But then Paul says when he lived among Gentiles, he stopped living under the Law
  - This statement is further proof that Paul understood he had no requirement as a Christian to keep the law
  - If Paul had believed that Christians were bound to keep the Jewish Law, he would never have set it aside even for the sake of Gentiles
- But then Paul gives us a key point to remember
  - He clarifies that even though he wasn't living under the Law of Moses when around Gentiles, Paul wasn't without any law at all
  - As a Christian, Paul was always under the law of Christ

- All Christians are subject to a new spiritual law that regulates our behavior just as the OT Law regulated the life of an OT saint
  - Our law is called the law of Christ, Paul says in 1Cor 9:21
    - For believing Jews, this new law replaces the Mosaic Law
    - And for believing Gentiles, the Law of Christ is our first exposure to law and holiness
  - The Law of Christ is a better law than the OT Law, which we can summarize in three primary ways

- First, the Law of Christ was delivered in a better way
  - The Law of Moses came as part of a covenant mediated by angels
    - It was written on tablets of stone
    - It was delivered to us by a man, Moses
    - And because of the way it was delivered, the content of the Law was limited to the 613 commands written by the finger of God
  - But the Law of Christ came as part of a new and better covenant, mediated by Christ Himself
    - It is a code written on our hearts
    - It was delivered by God Himself, in the form of the Holy Spirit

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- This new law written on hearts is the fulfillment of a promise God made to Israel and to every believer in the New Covenant

Jer. 31:33 **"But this is the covenant which I will make with the house of Israel after those days," declares the LORD, "I will put My law within them and on their heart I will write it; and I will be their God, and they shall be My people.**

- Secondly, the Law of Christ is greater than the OT law in scope
    - The Law of Christ incorporates every expectation of the old but then goes far beyond it regulating things the OT Law never addressed
        - For example, the OT Law said we cannot murder
            - But Jesus said that true holiness requires not even harboring hate for another person
            - The OT Law said nothing about hate
        - The OT Law forbid adultery
            - But the NT Law of Christ says that lusting in the heart is also sin
            - The OT Law said nothing about lusting
        - And the OT laws for sabbaths and sacrifices and other rituals are also represented in the Law of Christ, but in new and better ways (which we will learn as we examine the law in detail)
    - This is why the Law of Christ has never been written down or enumerated entirely
        - It is literally impossible for the Law of Christ to be completely written out on stones or otherwise
            - It's statutes are too vast, too numerous; in fact its statutes are infinite
            - We can no more write out the Law of Christ than we could write down every possible number

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- The Law of Christ has an infinite list of statutes because human experience - and therefore, the potential for human sin - is also limitless
  - While we can't catalog the Law of Christ, we can rely on the broad strokes reflected in Jesus' teaching and the Apostles letters
  - As John wrote:

1John 3:24 **The one who keeps His commandments abides in Him, and He in him. We know by this that He abides in us, by the Spirit whom He has given us.**

- Jesus did summarize his Law when asked

Matt. 22:37 **And He said to him, "'YOU SHALL LOVE THE LORD YOUR GOD WITH ALL YOUR HEART, AND WITH ALL YOUR SOUL, AND WITH ALL YOUR MIND.'**
Matt. 22:38 **"This is the great and foremost commandment.**
Matt. 22:39 **"The second is like it, 'YOU SHALL LOVE YOUR NEIGHBOR AS YOURSELF.'**
Matt. 22:40 **"On these two commandments depend the whole Law and the Prophets."**

- Finally, the Law of Christ is superior to the Law of Moses because it is accompanied with the spiritual power to compel our obedience
  - Our new new law is administered by the Holy Spirit, Who indwells us from the moment of faith
    - First he educates us concerning what is righteous

John 14:26 **"But the Helper, the Holy Spirit, whom the Father will send in My name, He will teach you all things, and bring to your remembrance all that I said to you.**

- And secondly, He gives us the power to overcome our flesh

Rom. 8:2 **For the law of the Spirit of life in Christ Jesus has set you free from the law of sin and of death.**
Rom. 8:3 **For what the Law could not do, weak as it was through the flesh, God did: sending His own Son in the likeness of sinful flesh and as an offering for sin, He condemned sin in the flesh,**
Rom. 8:4 **so that the requirement of the Law might be fulfilled in us, who do not walk according to the flesh but according to the Spirit.**

- Finally, He convicts us of sin, which causes us to conform ourselves to the Law of Christ

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- The OT Law existed only as a witness to condemn men for their sin
  - And it did not have power to compel righteous behavior
  - It acted like a finish line that no man could ever reach, serving to remind us of our failures
- But the Law of Christ is like a wind to our back as we run
  - It pushes us along in the direction of holiness
  - This is the process of sanctification that produces fruit in a believer's life
- Ironically, the Law of Moses could be read and understand by anyone, but it was powerless to create righteousness in anyone
  - While the Law of Christ has the power to bring righteousness, but it cannot be seen and is only understood by a faithful heart

- Because the Law of Christ is experienced through faith by the Spirit rather than by following a list of commandments and rules, it is often called a law of liberty

2Cor. 3:17 **Now the Lord is the Spirit, and where the Spirit of the Lord is, there is liberty.**

- We have liberty in ways the OT saint never experienced
  - Since we are covered by the blood of Christ, we need not concern ourselves with animal sacrifices again
  - The temple, the priesthood, the tithes and the sabbaths of the OT Law are replaced with better things under the Law of Christ
  - Therefore, many restrictions of life imposed by the OT Law are removed by the Law of Christ
  - Moreover, this new Law of Christ, being accompanied by the Holy Spirit, affords us the power to act righteously
    - Whereas the old Law had no power except to reveal and condemn sin
    - The new law possess true power to bring sanctification

- So as we study the Law, we will take time to seek parallels in the NT Law of Christ

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- We need to ask how does this holiness requirement translate into the life of a NT believer
    - For each stature of the OT Law, we will ask if the Law of Christ repeat the requirement?
    - Does it expand upon the requirement?
    - Or does it fulfill the requirement by transforming it into something new and better?

- With that background, we can move into the law itself, beginning with the first ten statutes, called the Ten Commandments
    - Moses has been standing at a distance from the people of Israel at the base of Mt. Sinai in the mountain range of Horeb
        - The Lord descended on the top of the mountain in a cloud with lightening and He speaks with a voice that sounds like thunder
        - In Exodus 19:24 the Lord told Moses to go down and tell the people of the warnings not to intrude past the barriers around the mountain
        - And then in that same verse, the Lord tells Moses to return up the mountain once he was done speaking to the people
        - That's where Moses stands as we enter chapter 20, at the top of the mountain with the people down below
    - As Moses enters into the presence of the Lord's Shechinah glory, he receives the first ten statures of the Law of God
        - The number ten means testimony, as so the first ten laws are given a special designation so they may testify
            - They testify to the holiness of God
            - And they ultimately testify to the sin of man
        - While the OT account doesn't specify how these Laws were delivered, our NT gives us that answer
            - The Lord used angels to deliver the Law to Moses, according to Galatians 3:19
            - Hebrews 2:2 also says the Law was spoken through angels to Moses

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- When the NT says the Law was delivered "through angels," it means that Moses took physical custody of the Law from an angel
    - Mostly likely, the physical tablets were created and transferred to Moses by angels
    - We're told this at the end of the giving of the Law to Moses

Ex. 31:18 When He had finished speaking with him upon Mount Sinai, He gave Moses the two tablets of the testimony, tablets of stone, written by the finger of God.

- The transfer of these stone tablets was from the Lord to angels and then to Moses
    - Hebrews teaches that God used angels as mediators for this covenant because someone had to stand between God and sinful man
    - So God used lessor mediators for the covenant of Law
    - He reserved for His Son the honor of serving as mediator for the New Covenant in His blood

- These first ten commands are the best known of the 613 statutes, and they are the most sweeping in scope
    - In fact, these laws are unique in all the ancient world, in particularly because they are stated in the second person
        - All other ancient laws we know were expressed in the third person
            - "A man shall..." or "no man shall..."
        - The third person tense reflects the way such laws were usually the product of a community of people or tradition
        - The laws were a reflection of what society itself considered best
    - But these laws were expressed in the second person, reflecting that they were authored by One in authority over those who must abide by them
        - They read "you shall" or "you shall not"
        - The laws themselves are not subject to the scrutiny of men

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        - Men didn't create them, so men are not free to change them or ignore them

- Let's read the first ten laws

Ex. 20:1 Then God spoke all these words, saying,
Ex. 20:2 "I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of slavery.
Ex. 20:3 "You shall have no other gods before Me.
Ex. 20:4 "You shall not make for yourself an idol, or any likeness of what is in heaven above or on the earth beneath or in the water under the earth.
Ex. 20:5 "You shall not worship them or serve them; for I, the LORD your God, am a jealous God, visiting the iniquity of the fathers on the children, on the third and the fourth generations of those who hate Me,
Ex. 20:6 but showing lovingkindness to thousands, to those who love Me and keep My commandments.
Ex. 20:7 "You shall not take the name of the LORD your God in vain, for the LORD will not leave him unpunished who takes His name in vain.
Ex. 20:8 "Remember the sabbath day, to keep it holy.
Ex. 20:9 "Six days you shall labor and do all your work,
Ex. 20:10 but the seventh day is a sabbath of the LORD your God; in it you shall not do any work, you or your son or your daughter, your male or your female servant or your cattle or your sojourner who stays with you.
Ex. 20:11 "For in six days the LORD made the heavens and the earth, the sea and all that is in them, and rested on the seventh day; therefore the LORD blessed the sabbath day and made it holy.
Ex. 20:12 "Honor your father and your mother, that your days may be prolonged in the land which the LORD your God gives you.
Ex. 20:13 "You shall not murder.
Ex. 20:14 "You shall not commit adultery.
Ex. 20:15 "You shall not steal.
Ex. 20:16 "You shall not bear false witness against your neighbor.
Ex. 20:17 "You shall not covet your neighbor's house; you shall not covet your neighbor's wife or his male servant or his female servant or his ox or his donkey or anything that belongs to your neighbor."

- As chapter 20 opens, Moses says the Lord

    - As commonly as people may say the "ten" commandments, in reality there isn't universal agreement on what the ten commandments actually are or even how they were distributed on the two stone tablets

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- The Jewish historical view saw the first commandment to be the statement in v.2 "I am the Lord your God"
    - This was considered a commandment in the sense that it was a truth to be remembered and honored
    - Then the second commandment runs from vs.3-6 and encompasses both not having other gods and prohibiting the worshipping of graven images
- The rest of commandments follow until the tenth commandment in v.17
    - In that verse, two forms of coveting are combined into a single commandment
- Furthermore, Jewish tradition holds that the first five commandments were written on the first stone while the second tablet contained the remaining five laws

- The Catholic tradition sees the first commandment as starting in v.3 and incorporating everything through v.6
    - So the instructions against idolatry and worshipping graven images are seen as a single commandment
    - Then to still arrive at ten commandments, Catholics divide v.17 into two separate commandments
        - Coveting a neighbor's wife is the ninth
        - Coveting a neighbor's property is the tenth
    - The problem with this approach is that it often results in truncating the first commandment
        - In any list of the ten, the first commandment is often abbreviated to simply state "have no gods before me"
        - The prohibition against graven images is omitted
        - Therefore, many Catholics never learn that God considers worshipping statues of saints or even of Jesus Himself to be a sin
    - Catholics also hold that each tablet contained five commandments each

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- Finally, most Protestant traditions see v.3 to be a commandment of its own
    - Then the second commandment is the prohibition of worshipping images
    - And the tenth command is all of v.17, as in the Jewish tradition
    - Regarding the split of the commandments on the tablets, many Protestants see the first three laws on the first tablet and the remaining seven on the second tablet
        - The first three laws regulate our relationship with God
        - The next seven regulate man's relationship with man
- It is also possible that each tablet held a complete copy of the ten commandments
    - The Bible tells us that the tablets were written on both sides, front and back
    - Therefore, perhaps each tablet had all ten commandments
    - In that case, Moses was given two identical tablets so that by the testimony of two witnesses, all sin will be confirmed
    - The two tablets serve as two witnesses, so to speak, of man's sin

- We will follow the Protestant tradition in the course of examination of the tablets, so we will study the first commandment as v.3 alone
    - Israel is told to have no other gods before the Lord
        - The term "before" was not intended to suggest we can have multiple gods so long as Jehovah is first among them
        - The phrase means to have no gods apart from the Lord
            - Israel was commanded to be monotheistic
            - God was appointing a single people, and in return He demanded they acknowledge Him as the only true living God
        - Throughout their history, Israel has repeated violated this commandment
            - They have worshipped pagan gods of various kinds

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- They have even sacrificed children to these false gods
- The Lord says Israel played the harlot in prostituting themselves to many suitors, though the Lord was husband to Israel

Hos. 4:12 **My people consult their wooden idol, and their diviner's wand informs them;**
For a spirit of harlotry has led them astray,
And they have played the harlot, departing from their God.

- The second commandment follows closely from the first in vs. 4-6
  - Israel was to make no image that could substitute for the Lord
  - Notice in v.4 the prohibition is against making any idol in the likeness of anything in heaven, on earth or under earth or in the water
    - That means Israel could not create idols to resemble God Himself or angels for the purpose of worship
    - And neither could a likeness of any earthly creature or created thing could be made for worship
    - Images themselves are not wrong, since Israel was later commanded to create images of angels
    - But these images were not to be worshipped
- Incorporating images in worship is related to the first commandment, because it is another form of idolatry
  - In the case of the first commandment, the issue was Who a man worships
  - In the second commandment, the issue is how a man worships
  - In v.5 the Lord adds that worshipping such things would invoke God's jealous anger
    - The Lord knew that incorporating manmade objects in worship necessarily diminished the Creator
    - And it opened the door to violating the first commandment by replacing the Lord altogether

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- Christians have been given similar prohibitions in the Law of Christ, according to Christ's own teaching, but our standards reach even more demanding levels
    - First, we are told to love the Lord with all our heart, soul, mind and strength
        - The word "all" emphasizes the exclusive nature of our relationship with Christ
            - If all our heart, soul, mind and strength is devoted to Christ, then there is nothing remaining for other gods
    - Secondly, we are told not to serve other masters, like money
        - And we are to guard ourselves from such things if they become idols, things that substitute for a dependence upon the Lord
        - John repeats this command in the New Testament

1John 5:21 **Little children, guard yourselves from idols.**

- It's possible to trivialize the concept of an idol by calling any distraction or temptation an "idol"
    - It's true that many pleasures and worries of life can become stumbling blocks for Christians, as Jesus said

Luke 21:34 **"Be on guard, so that your hearts will not be weighted down with dissipation and drunkenness and the worries of life, and that day will not come on you suddenly like a trap;**
Luke 21:35 **for it will come upon all those who dwell on the face of all the earth.**

    - But it's another thing altogether to be taken away by an idol
- An idol is something that substitutes for the Lord in our life
    - That's a serious matter
    - Though many (all?) Christians fall prey to temptations and stumble at times in their walk with Christ, relatively few succumb to genuine idolatry
- We have one example in Paul's first letter to Timothy

1Tim. 1:18 **This command I entrust to you, Timothy, my son, in accordance with the prophecies previously made concerning you, that by them you fight the good fight,**

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1Tim. 1:19 keeping faith and a good conscience, which some have rejected and suffered shipwreck in regard to their faith.
1Tim. 1:20 Among these are Hymenaeus and Alexander, whom I have handed over to Satan, so that they will be taught not to blaspheme.

- They rejected keeping the faith and suffered shipwreck
- They committed idolatry, as evidenced in their blaspheming

- So the first commandment of the OT Law has a clear parallel in the Law of Christ for Christians

- The bigger challenge for most Christians, however, is the second commandment
  - According to the Law of Moses, men could never pray to a statue, even a statue of the Lord
    - Even paintings of Jesus would be outlawed by the Law of Moses for the same reason
    - But as we determined, the Christian is not under this Law
    - But what does the Law of Christ say on the matter of graven images?
  - The Law of Christ declares that we are not to rely on the physical - even physical locations - to focus our worship of the Lord

John 4:19 The woman said to Him, "Sir, I perceive that You are a prophet.
John 4:20 "Our fathers worshiped in this mountain, and you people say that in Jerusalem is the place where men ought to worship."
John 4:21 Jesus said to her, "Woman, believe Me, an hour is coming when neither in this mountain nor in Jerusalem will you worship the Father.
John 4:22 "You worship what you do not know; we worship what we know, for salvation is from the Jews.
John 4:23 "But an hour is coming, and now is, when the true worshipers will worship the Father in spirit and truth; for such people the Father seeks to be His worshipers.

- The greater Law of Christ takes the second commandment regarding images and broadens the requirement to move worship entirely into the spiritual realm

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- The Old Law prohibited graven images, and then it stipulated the days and places and even the manner of worship for the OT saint
    - The Law of Christ says that worship requires nothing more than the Spirit and the Truth
    - And in this way, worship becomes a daily activity and ever-present expression of every believer's heart
    - Days, places and even the form of worship make little difference in the age of the Spirit
- This is why Paul wrote:

Col. 2:16 **Therefore no one is to act as your judge in regard to food or drink or in respect to a festival or a new moon or a Sabbath day –**
Col. 2:17 **things which are a mere shadow of what is to come; but the substance belongs to Christ.**

- But when we regress back to placing form of worship above spirit and truth, we are moving in the direction of incorporating graven images into worship
    - We might not erect statutes in our sanctuaries or put pictures on the walls
    - But when we demand certain musical styles or liturgy programs in order to worship, we are committing a sin equal to worshipping graven images
        - We have taken the physical and placed it above the spiritual
        - We are worshipping manmade structures or the traditions of our denomination rather than worshipping the Lord through His Spirit and by His truth
        - And we are at risk of provoking a jealous God

- Finally, the second commandment includes an interesting statement from the Lord concerning the consequences of idolatry in Israel
    - When Israel committed idolatry, they were violating the covenant and turning their back on the Lord

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- When Israel commits this sin, the Lord promises to visit this iniquity upon later generations
- This is a promise unique to the first and second commandments, insofar as it relates to idolatry

- Idolatry in all its forms is a sin so grievous that it will provoke the Lord to visit the consequences of that sin through multiple generations of families
  - This was a promise contained in the Law of Moses, so it is limited to the nation of Israel
    - We can see plenty of evidence of this promise played out in the history of Israel
    - Idolatrous generations of Israel were generally followed by generations that suffered the Lord's judgment
  - There is no direct parallel found in the New Testament
  - Nevertheless, we shouldn't test my conclusions

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Exodus 20C

- We have begun our study of Law in Exodus
    - Specifically, we are studying the first ten laws or commandment
        - Though the Bible teaches that the entire Law of Moses is indivisible, nevertheless the first ten laws are distinctive
        - They deserve to be considered separately from the rest in the sense that they are very different in scope and style
        - They are at the beginning for a reason, and we do well to acknowledge and understand that reason
    - However, their distinctiveness is not an argument for divorcing these commandments from the rest of the law and expecting believers to keep them today
        - As we learned last week, the believer in the New Covenant receives a new and better law written on their hearts by the Holy Spirit
        - This new law replaces the old by incorporating all of the requirements found in the old yet in better ways
        - And it adds an infinite number of additional commands in keeping with holiness
    - The sanctification of a NT saint is accomplished by two principle forces
        - First, the Spirit of God indwells every believer as an agent of change, teaching, convicting and empowering believers into righteousness
        - Secondly, the word of God is fuel for the Spirit to use in accomplishing His work
            - Without a steady diet of the word of God, the NT saint will find his spiritual growth stunted
        - Yet even with Bible study, it still falls to the believer to respond to the work of the Spirit and follow Him into sanctification
            - This is why the writer of Hebrews calls the word of God the "sword of the spirit"

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- So far we have examined the first two commandments
    - They were commands to have no other gods beside the Lord and to not make graven images or idols that substitute for worship of the Lord
        - As we said, both are closely related
        - Together they demand that we follow God with our whole heart
        - This expectation is also present in the NT law of Christ, which demands that we love and obey God without challenge or reservation
    - Today we move forward into the third commandments and beyond
        - Let's re-read the third commandment in Exodus 20

Ex. 20:7 "You shall not take the name of the LORD your God in vain, for the LORD will not leave him unpunished who takes His name in vain.

- This command is directed at restricting Israel's speech or communication concerning the name of God
    - The name of God was spoken to Moses and repeated within Israel
        - As we learned earlier, the name was I AM and has a certain sound in the Hebrew language
        - However, the nation became so concerned with the possibility of violating the third commandment, they adopted a practice of never speaking His name at all
        - And in written form, they removed the vowels of God's name in the Hebrew language to prevent the pronunciation of His name
        - After the vowels were removed, God's name became YHWH, which has become known as the "tetragrammaton"
        - This shortened form of God's word is commonly pronounced Yahweh, but in reality we do not know how God's name was pronounced
    - As a result of this tradition, it became impossible to take God's name in vain within Israel, at least in the literal sense of a misuse of the actual name of God
        - But that didn't prevent men from violating the spirit of this Law

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- Jesus condemned the Pharasees for thinking they were holy by avoiding swearing by things they felt had spiritual significance while avoiding other things that they thought ran afoul of this commandment

Matt. 23:15 "Woe to you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites, because you travel around on sea and land to make one proselyte; and when he becomes one, you make him twice as much a son of hell as yourselves.
Matt. 23:16 "Woe to you, blind guides, who say, 'Whoever swears by the temple, that is nothing; but whoever swears by the gold of the temple is obligated.'
Matt. 23:17 "You fools and blind men! Which is more important, the gold or the temple that sanctified the gold?
Matt. 23:18 "And, 'Whoever swears by the altar, that is nothing, but whoever swears by the offering on it, he is obligated.'
Matt. 23:19 "You blind men, which is more important, the offering, or the altar that sanctifies the offering?
Matt. 23:20 "Therefore, whoever swears by the altar, swears both by the altar and by everything on it.
Matt. 23:21 "And whoever swears by the temple, swears both by the temple and by Him who dwells within it.
Matt. 23:22 "And whoever swears by heaven, swears both by the throne of God and by Him who sits upon it.

- Notice they were willing to swear by the temple but if they swore by the gold in the gold in the temple, they were sinning according to their own rules
- Likewise, they would allow themselves to swear by the altar but not the offering
    - Jesus pointed out that their rules were stupid and contradictory

- If they desired to take an oath by binding themselves to some representation of God, then they were effectively binding themselves to God Himself, in violation of the third commandment
    - They were swearing by God, which was a diminishment of God's name
    - And it as presumptuous to expect that God would honor such pledges anyway
    - As Jesus said

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Matt. 5:33 "Again, you have heard that the ancients were told, 'YOU SHALL NOT MAKE FALSE VOWS, BUT SHALL FULFILL YOUR VOWS TO THE LORD.'
Matt. 5:34 "But I say to you, make no oath at all, either by heaven, for it is the throne of God,
Matt. 5:35 or by the earth, for it is the footstool of His feet, or by Jerusalem, for it is THE CITY OF THE GREAT KING.
Matt. 5:36 "Nor shall you make an oath by your head, for you cannot make one hair white or black.
Matt. 5:37 "But let your statement be, 'Yes, yes' or 'No, no'; anything beyond these is of evil.

- So merely forgetting the literal name of God isn't a barrier to violating this commandment
    - Like all the commandments of the Law, this commandment is present in the Law of Christ in a greater way
        - Besides Jesus instructions not to swear oaths on God's name, the NT writers expand the intent of this commandment to include any speech that is degrading

James 3:5 So also the tongue is a small part of the body, and yet it boasts of great things. See how great a forest is set aflame by such a small fire!
James 3:6 And the tongue is a fire, the very world of iniquity; the tongue is set among our members as that which defiles the entire body, and sets on fire the course of our life, and is set on fire by hell.
James 3:7 For every species of beasts and birds, of reptiles and creatures of the sea, is tamed and has been tamed by the human race.
James 3:8 But no one can tame the tongue; it is a restless evil and full of deadly poison.
James 3:9 With it we bless our Lord and Father, and with it we curse men, who have been made in the likeness of God;
James 3:10 from the same mouth come both blessing and cursing. My brethren, these things ought not to be this way.

    - The Law of Christ teaches us that when we speak ill of another person, who was created in the image of God, we are violating the spirit of the third commandment
        - The OT Law stipulated that we ought not to diminish the name of God in any way

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- But the NT Law extends this commandment to its full purposes
- The name of God is more than a word
  - Names in scripture are the embodiment of a person, their character, reputation and their work
  - The Lord's name represents His goodness and the perfection of His work
- So when we speak degrading things about another person, someone created in the likeness of God, we are degrading the Lord's work and therefore the Lord Himself

- The fourth commandment is found in vs. 8-11

Ex. 20:8 "Remember the sabbath day, to keep it holy.
Ex. 20:9 "Six days you shall labor and do all your work,
Ex. 20:10 but the seventh day is a sabbath of the LORD your God; in it you shall not do any work, you or your son or your daughter, your male or your female servant or your cattle or your sojourner who stays with you.
Ex. 20:11 "For in six days the LORD made the heavens and the earth, the sea and all that is in them, and rested on the seventh day; therefore the LORD blessed the sabbath day and made it holy.

- The Lord commands the nation to observe a sabbath day on the last day of each week, which is Saturday in the Jewish calendar
  - The occasion for this commandment is the Creation itself
    - The Lord asks Israel to repeat the actions the Lord took following the complete of Creation
    - After the Lord spent six days creating all things, He ceased from His work on the seventh day
    - That final day was therefore set apart from the other days in that it was different from the rest of the days
      - The first seven days were days in which work was done
      - But the seventh day was a day in which only rest from work took place
    - Therefore that day is holy, the Lord declares

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- The word holy simply means set apart from sin
- So the final day of each week is set apart from the rest, just as the Lord Himself is set apart from sin

- The nature of this command is simply to abstain from any form of work
  - The word "work" in this case means common labors
  - The ordinary ways men work to sustain their lives
    - The Law itself expounds on various ways in which work must be curtailed
    - We've already seen the Lord tell Israel not to gather manna on the sabbath
    - Later Israel will be told not to gather wood, kindle fires, or bear heavy burdens among others
    - But overall the expectation is that men simply rest in the work that had already been done during the prior days, as did God
  - The Pharisees and lawyers took this commandment and greatly increased its burdens on Israel over the centuries
    - These added restrictions grew and grew to the point of ridiculous
    - Today, orthodox Jews who observe a sabbath will refrain from even turning on a light switch in the home
    - So on Friday afternoon, they will turn on all lights in the home to preclude the need to turn them on during the sabbath day

- Like the rest of the Law, this commandment no longer applies for the NT saint today
  - Though the Lord's sabbath existed from the days of Creation, the Law of Moses was the first time the Lord mandated men follow His example
    - Some teachers argue that since the sabbath existed from Creation, then it is a law that didn't go away when the Law of Moses was fulfilled by Christ

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        - So, believers today should observe a strict sabbath on Saturdays as did the Jews under the Law

    - But there is no example in scripture of God ordering any man to observe a sabbath prior to the giving of the Law, nor do we see any man practicing a sabbath prior to the giving of the Law

        - Even the order concerning gathering manna is considered to be an early preview of the delivering of the law to Israel

        - Furthermore, God has never required Gentiles to observe a sabbath

        - And the NT teaching specifically states that no sabbath day exists for the Christian

Rom. 14:5 **One person regards one day above another, another regards every day alike. Each person must be fully convinced in his own mind.**
Rom. 14:6 **He who observes the day, observes it for the Lord, and he who eats, does so for the Lord, for he gives thanks to God; and he who eats not, for the Lord he does not eat, and gives thanks to God.**

    - The believer is free to observe a sabbath day or not

        - But we do not sin if we work seven days a week

        - Nor do we sin if we observe a sabbath day on Sunday or any other day of the week

        - Paul teaches that each should do as they feel convicted, because the Law of Christ does not demand such an observance

- Nevertheless, this law is stil found in the Law of Christ in a new and better way, as are all the Laws of the Old Covenant

    - Paul teaches how in Colossians

Col. 2:16 **Therefore no one is to act as your judge in regard to food or drink or in respect to a festival or a new moon or a Sabbath day –**
Col. 2:17 **things which are a mere shadow of what is to come; but the substance belongs to Christ.**

    - Paul says that the commandments of the OT Law like the dietary restrictions and festivals and seasonal observances and even the Sabbath Day itself were all shadows

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        - A shadow is anything in scripture given in a lessor form to represent a something of greater spiritual significance coming in the future

        - In this case, Paul says the greater spiritual significance is Christ Himself

    - So dietary rules and festivals and the Sabbath Day were carefully constructed by God to teach about Christ

        - During the Creation account, the Lord takes a day to rest, which is a strange statement when you think about it

        - Why would the Lord need rest? Surely, He never tires, since He is all spirit

        - Now we understand that His rest wasn't a matter of physical rest for God...it was to teach us about Christ

- So what do we learn about Christ from the Sabbath?

    - The Sabbath in the Law teaches that a man's work can end

        - And that rest from work is a good thing, something that men look forward to each week

        - But under the Law, that rest had a limit

            - Before long, the sabbath ended and the work resumed

            - It was a temporary rest and therefore it was one that could never truly satisfy

            - The kind of rest men long for is that which never ends

    - On the other hand, the Lord has never gone back to work

        - His sabbath continues to this day

        - He is still resting from His work of Creation

        - So it leads men to a question...how can we share in THAT rest?

        - How can we share in the Lord's rest, the one that never ceases?

    - Hebrews gives us that answer

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Heb. 4:1 Therefore, let us fear if, while a promise remains of entering His rest, any one of you may seem to have come short of it.
Heb. 4:2 For indeed we have had good news preached to us, just as they also; but the word they heard did not profit them, because it was not united by faith in those who heard.
Heb. 4:3 For we who have believed enter that rest, just as He has said,
"AS I SWORE IN MY WRATH,
THEY SHALL NOT ENTER MY REST,"
although His works were finished from the foundation of the world.
Heb. 4:4 For He has said somewhere concerning the seventh day: "AND GOD RESTED ON THE SEVENTH DAY FROM ALL HIS WORKS";
Heb. 4:5 and again in this passage, "THEY SHALL NOT ENTER MY REST."
Heb. 4:6 Therefore, since it remains for some to enter it, and those who formerly had good news preached to them failed to enter because of disobedience,
Heb. 4:7 He again fixes a certain day, "Today," saying through David after so long a time just as has been said before,
"TODAY IF YOU HEAR HIS VOICE,
DO NOT HARDEN YOUR HEARTS."
Heb. 4:8 For if Joshua had given them rest, He would not have spoken of another day after that.
Heb. 4:9 So there remains a Sabbath rest for the people of God.
Heb. 4:10 For the one who has entered His rest has himself also rested from his works, as God did from His.

- The writer was concerned for some within the church who hadn't come to faith but were merely hanging around the crowd
    - And the writer uses the term "rest" as a description of coming to faith in Christ
        - In v.3 he teaches that by believing in Christ we can enter (or share in) the Lord's rest
        - The Lord speaks about disobedient not entering "His" rest
        - The Lord's rest is the rest He established when He ceased from all works
    - This is the permanent rest that everyman longs for
        - A rest that never ends and allows men to cease from all their works

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- But in Hebrews we learn that the ultimate intent of the Sabbath was to picture a spiritual rest, not merely an earthly rest from labor
- As the writer says in v.10, we cease from our works when we believer
- By entering into the New Covenant, we enter into the Lord's sabbath, never again bearing a burden of works for salvation
- We rest in the work of Christ on the cross

- So the Law of Christ also has a sabbath law requiring rest
  - We keep that law through our faith and reliance in Christ's work
  - And therefore, NT believers do not observe the shadow of the sabbath, that is a physical rest on Saturday
  - Instead, we observe the greater Sabbath, which is to rest in Christ everyday

- Now to the fifth commandment

Ex. 20:12 **"Honor your father and your mother, that your days may be prolonged in the land which the LORD your God gives you.**

- The fifth commandment requires that Israel show respect for their parents
  - The word for honor literally means something weighty or burdensome, but it can also be used euphemistically to mean something of honor and significance
    - I think both sense are applicable here
    - As children we are to honor our parents authority
      - This honor means obeying, respecting and trusting them for no reason beside the fact they are our parents
      - Then as we become adults and they come to depend on us at some point, we bear that burden gladly
      - We honor them by continuing to respect and defend them

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- We may not always agree with what they think or say, but as much as possible we show deference and respect for their views and their needs

- This commandment is the first to include a promise of blessing for obedience
  - Since the commandment was given to Israel by the Covenant, the promise is limited to Israel as well
  - If Israel continues to observe this command, their obedience will prolong their time in their land
- This promise is interesting for two reasons
  - First, the fact that the Lord is promising to "prolong" Israel in their land implies that He knew Israel would one day be required to leave the land
    - The nation was eventually dispossessed from the land
    - They were scattered into the nations as a result of idolatry and disobedience under the Law
  - Secondly, the Lord says the key to Israel avoiding that punishment was strong, godly families
    - Therefore, we conclude that a breakdown in the family was the starting point for the sin and idolatry of Israel
    - And this eventually leads to the nations judgment under the Old Covenant
- The family structure is the lowest common denominator within society from which God rules over the hearts of people
  - When the family unit becomes weak by tolerating disrespect, disobedience, rebellion, and dishonor, the stage is set for a corruption of society as a whole
  - This was Israel's fate and it's certainly happening in our world today, as Paul predicted

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2Tim. 3:1 But realize this, that in the last days difficult times will come.
2Tim. 3:2 For men will be lovers of self, lovers of money, boastful, arrogant, revilers, disobedient to parents, ungrateful, unholy,
2Tim. 3:3 unloving, irreconcilable, malicious gossips, without self-control, brutal, haters of good,
2Tim. 3:4 treacherous, reckless, conceited, lovers of pleasure rather than lovers of God,

- As with the earlier commandments, the Pharisees preached obedience to this commandment while disobeying it in practice
  - And Jesus called them out for it

Matt. 15:4 "For God said, 'HONOR YOUR FATHER AND MOTHER,' and, 'HE WHO SPEAKS EVIL OF FATHER OR MOTHER IS TO BE PUT TO DEATH.'
Matt. 15:5 "But you say, 'Whoever says to his father or mother, "Whatever I have that would help you has been given to God,"
Matt. 15:6 he is not to honor his father or his mother.' And by this you invalidated the word of God for the sake of your tradition.
Matt. 15:7 "You hypocrites, rightly did Isaiah prophesy of you:
Matt. 15:8 'THIS PEOPLE HONORS ME WITH THEIR LIPS,
BUT THEIR HEART IS FAR AWAY FROM ME.
Matt. 15:9 'BUT IN VAIN DO THEY WORSHIP ME,
TEACHING AS DOCTRINES THE PRECEPTS OF MEN.'"

- The Pharisees recognized that honoring parents meant providing for their financial need when circumstances warranted
  - But to avoid parting with their money, the Pharisees made an exception if the money had been given to the temple instead
  - Jesus said this was a hypocritical rule contrived to avoiding doing one's duty because the law required that both parents and God be honored, not one or the other

- How has this commandment been improved upon in the the Law of Christ for the NT believer?
  - First, it's simply repeated in several places

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Eph. 6:1 Children, obey your parents in the Lord, for this is right.
Eph. 6:2 HONOR YOUR FATHER AND MOTHER (which is the first commandment with a promise),
Eph. 6:3 SO THAT IT MAY BE WELL WITH YOU, AND THAT YOU MAY LIVE LONG ON THE EARTH.

- And a promise has been extended to the NT saint as well, though in a new form
  - Believers are promised to enjoy a long life rather than time in the land
  - How would disobedience to this commandment lead to a shorter life?
  - First, there is always the possibility that the Lord might execute supernatural judgment against us for disobeying our parents
    - Like my mom used to say to me when I misbehaved, "I hope you have twins just like you!"
  - But even natural experience tells us how rebellion to parental authority can lead to a shorter life
    - Not respecting a parent's wisdom can lead to accident, injury, danger, disease, and assorted calamities
    - Like Adam in the garden, when we set aside the instructions of a wise parent, we set ourselves on a road to destruction
  - As Mark Twain once said:
    - When I was a teenager, I was amazed at how little my father knew and when I turned twenty, I was amazed at how much he had learned

- The Law of Christ also broadens this commandments
  - Jesus taught that believers become part of a new family, the Body of Christ, and we gain new relationships we must honor and obey
    - And these relationships take precedence over even our natural family relationships

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Mark 10:28 Peter began to say to Him, "Behold, we have left everything and followed You."
Mark 10:29 Jesus said, "Truly I say to you, there is no one who has left house or brothers or sisters or mother or father or children or farms, for My sake and for the gospel's sake,
Mark 10:30 but that he will receive a hundred times as much now in the present age, houses and brothers and sisters and mothers and children and farms, along with persecutions; and in the age to come, eternal life.

- Notice that Jesus speaks of the disciples being forced to leave natural family behind for the sake of the Gospel
  - Jesus is speaking about priorities, not absolutes
  - No believer is automatically required to turn their back on their natural family in order to be a disciple of Jesus
  - But if the natural family makes an ultimatum and the believer is required to choose, then the believer should choose Jesus
- And when this happens, the believer will inherit a new family, the family of believers in the body of Christ
  - This new family must be honored just as we do our best to honor our natural family
  - We obey our elders and authorities over us in the church
  - We respect and share the burdens older members of the fellowship just as we might our own parents
  - And if pushed to choose, we must honor the family of God over our earthly family

- The sixth commandment comes next

Ex. 20:13 "You shall not murder

- This command prohibits the unlawful taking of a human life
  - This commandment says nothing about the killing of animals
  - Murder is, by definition, the unlawful taking of a human life by another human
  - Animals can't "murder" one another and we can't "murder "an animal

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        - So this commandment deals specifically with a man taking another man's life

    - Some think the sixth commandment outlaws all forms of killing, including capital punishment and acts of war

        - But there is a difference between lawful and unlawful killing both in scripture and in our laws, which descend from the Law of God

            - Murder is the unlawful taking of human life

            - The word murder is ratsach in Hebrew

        - But Hebrew uses another word for lawful killing: harag

            - Lawful killing is a taking of human life in keeping with the rules of law

        - For example, God's law provides for the taking of human life when certain serious crimes have been committed

        - And in war, God prescribes for the killing of combatants - and even entire cities - to further His purposes in establishing Israel or eradicating sin

    - So when we act under the rule of law to carry out justice or to participate in war, we are not automatically committing murder

        - However, if government has become corrupt or cruel

        - Or if war is conducted in unjust ways, then killing can become murder again

        - The question is whether our act of killing is justified and proper according to law

- If the Jew was commanded not to murder, then why did individual men kill in war and why did the Law itself allow a person to take another person's life at other times?

    - The confusion comes in conflating the rights and responsibilities of governments with those of individuals

        - An individual has the right to take another human life <u>only</u> in defense of self or others, according to law

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- The NT echoes this right for men to be prepared to defend oneself with deadly force if need be, even Christians
- This is how Jesus encouraged the disciples to be prepared for rough times after His crucifixion

Luke 22:36 And He said to them, "But now, whoever has a money belt is to take it along, likewise also a bag, and whoever has no sword is to sell his coat and buy one.
Luke 22:37 "For I tell you that this which is written must be fulfilled in Me, 'AND HE WAS NUMBERED WITH TRANSGRESSORS'; for that which refers to Me has its fulfillment."
Luke 22:38 They said, "Lord, look, here are two swords." And He said to them, "It is enough."

- The Greek word for sword in this passage refers to a small dagger, which was common carried by an individual for self-defense purposes

- Apart from that case, however, an individual has no right to take life
  - If we take life other than in self-defense, we do it unlawfully
  - Therefore we commit murder and violate this commandment

- When people act as governing authorities, however, they have the power to take human life as punishment for crimes or in times of war
  - The key to understanding the difference is to remember that God is the giver of life
    - Therefore He also has the authority to determine when it may be taken
    - And God has authorized human governments to take human life at times according to His specific instructions.
  - For example, beginning in Genesis 9 after the flood, the Lord delegated authority to human government to take life for capital crimes

Gen. 9:6 "Whoever sheds man's blood,
By man his blood shall be shed,
For in the image of God
He made man.

- As Paul explains as well in the New Testament:

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Rom. 13:3 For rulers are not a cause of fear for good behavior, but for evil. Do you want to have no fear of authority? Do what is good and you will have praise from the same;
Rom. 13:4 for it is a minister of God to you for good. But if you do what is evil, be afraid; for it does not bear the sword for nothing; for it is a minister of God, an avenger who brings wrath on the one who practices evil.

- When Paul reminds us that governments "bear the sword," he is speaking about the right to execute men for crimes
  - This right was given by God to government so it may act as a minister of good
  - Not that all governments act properly toward their citizens, of course, but the institution of government is something GOd established for good
  - Imagine what kind of world it would be if evil men were not restrained by governments with their courts and judges and jails and even executioners
- Secondly, we know that God commanded Israel at times to prosecute war against ungodly peoples who stood in the way of God's purposes in Israel
  - Remember, all men die and the day and manner of death is appointed by God
  - If you die in your sleep, God took your life
  - If you die on a battlefield at the hands of a soldier whom God sent to kill you, God took your life
  - God is no more guilty of a crime when he takes your life in your bed than when He employs the services of a soldier
  - So when Israel waged war in Canaan according to God's direction, they were acting lawfully (not murdering) because the Giver and Taker of life had directed their actions

- Nevertheless, Jesus' words and the Law of Christ do broaden the prohibition against murder in challenging ways
  - Perhaps Jesus' most famous speech broadens this commandment, though is a subtle way
    - In the Beatitudes, Jesus said

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Matt. 5:21 "You have heard that the ancients were told, 'YOU SHALL NOT COMMIT MURDER' and 'Whoever commits murder shall be liable to the court.'
Matt. 5:22 "But I say to you that everyone who is angry with his brother shall be guilty before the court; and whoever says to his brother, 'You good-for-nothing,' shall be guilty before the supreme court; and whoever says, 'You fool,' shall be guilty enough to go into the fiery hell.

- The NT Law of Christ prohibits unlawful killing just as the OT Law did, but Jesus takes that law considerably further
    - He says that the intent of the sixth commandment was to require respect and love for all persons
        - So that even if we refrain from killing someone, yet if we still hate them in our hearts, our physical restraint buys us nothing
        - We are still convicted just by our thoughts and desires
        - The Law of Christ demands that we take control of even our attitudes toward other people
        - Even a careless word spoken against someone is a harm that violates this commandment
    - Then a few verses later, we read

Matt. 5:38 "You have heard that it was said, 'AN EYE FOR AN EYE, AND A TOOTH FOR A TOOTH.'
Matt. 5:39 "But I say to you, do not resist an evil person; but whoever slaps you on your right cheek, turn the other to him also.
Matt. 5:40 "If anyone wants to sue you and take your shirt, let him have your coat also.
Matt. 5:41 "Whoever forces you to go one mile, go with him two.
Matt. 5:42 "Give to him who asks of you, and do not turn away from him who wants to borrow from you.
Matt. 5:43 "You have heard that it was said, 'YOU SHALL LOVE YOUR NEIGHBOR and hate your enemy.'
Matt. 5:44 "But I say to you, love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you,
Matt. 5:45 so that you may be sons of your Father who is in heaven; for He causes His sun to rise on the evil and the good, and sends rain on the righteous and the unrighteous.
Matt. 5:46 "For if you love those who love you, what reward do you have? Do not even the tax collectors do the same?

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- While the OT Law prohibited murder, in other places it permitted certain types of nonlethal retribution for crimes committed against persons
    - The purpose of this forms of justice under the Law was NOT to encourage retribution but to <u>limit</u> the degree of retribution
        - For example, a man was blinded by the negligence of another, he had the right (but not the requirement) to demand that the offender lose his eye as well
        - The intent of this rule was to ensure that any punishment fit the crime
        - Our 8th amendment to the Constitution is built upon a similar principle
    - But the Law didn't require that the injured person take every opportunity for retribution
        - The victim could forgo taking retribution, which the Law of Christ says is the way to imitate the Father
        - Jesus says forgiveness and mercy are the more perfect way that mirrors our Father in Heaven
    - The NT Law demands that we be perfect like the Father by showing mercy and forgiveness for personal attacks rather to seeking retribution
        - This doesn't mean we may not participate in the criminal justice system or defend our lives in self-defense
            - Notice in v.44 Jesus is speaking about those who persecute us
            - The point is that when we are singled out for our faith, we should expect mistreatment but shouldn't hold it against the person
            - Just as Jesus said nothing against those who persecuted Him
- So the Christian is commanded in to guard ourselves in personal relationships from showing malice or disrespect
    - Instead, we show forgiveness and mercy, even in situations where we might have right to retribution

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        - Nevertheless we may act within the framework of government to take human life lawfully
        - And we retain a right to self-defense or to defend others from harm
    - But as with the OT Law, we always have the option to forge the opportunity for retribution
        - When persecuted for our faith, we may even decline to defend our own lives
        - Martyrdom can be an appropriate response to persecution, as many disciples have chosen over the years
        - Yet self-preservation is also reasonable, just as Paul chose to flee from Jewish persecution on more than one occasion
- Next week we finish the first ten laws and move on to the other laws

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Exodus 20D

- We dive back into the first ten laws called the Ten Commandments
    - We're spending more time on each of these laws than we will on later laws because the ten commandments warrant the attention
        - We want to understand what each commandment meant to Israel, who was bound to this Law by their covenant
        - Secondly, we have spent time with each commandment learning how the Law of Christ incorporates and expands on these same statutes
    - So far, we've covered six of the ten
        - Last week we looked at taking the Lord's name in vain, the Sabbath, honoring parents and murder
        - In each case, we considered how the Lord expanded the intent of the Law to encompass the full spirit of God's intent in these laws
            - Speaking in vain includes all forms of harmful speech
            - Honoring parents includes honoring church family
            - Murder includes hateful thoughts, etc.
        - Frankly, we could teach for a month of Sundays on each commandment, so there are topics we have left unaddressed by necessity
            - But we welcome your questions, just as many have already written with their questions the teaching has raised
- Tonight we cover the final four commandments and then finish out the chapter
    - Let's read the next commandment found in v.14

Ex. 20:14 **"You shall not commit adultery.**

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- First, let's define the word "adultery" as it was commonly understood in Israel
    - Adultery under the Law of Moses is sexual intercourse when one or both partners are married
        - Under Jewish law, to be betrothed was equal to marriage
        - So sexual relations with someone betrothed to another was also adultery
    - The purpose of the Law in Israel is two-fold
        - First, the sanctity of marriage was to be honored and preserved
            - Once a commitment has been made to one person in marriage, that commitment must be honored
            - Do you think the Lord believed that marriage was important?
            - Consider that among the first ten laws, three commandments address the strength and sanctity of the family
            - Honoring parents, honoring your spouse, and honoring other marriages
            - Clearly, maintaining the health of the family was a priority for the Lord
        - Secondly, God has appointed Israel to a people called out from the world, and the people of Israel must protect the family lines God created
            - If marriage were not sacrosanct, then the bloodline of Israel would be at risk
            - More importantly, the seed promise might be corrupted
                - God promised that through Abraham's seed would come the Messiah
                - If the seed line was compromised by infidelity, then the promise couldn't be verified
- It's also important to note what adultery is not
    - First, adultery is not a state of being

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- It is a sexual act
- The offense happens in that moment
- Afterward, the person might be labeled an adulterer in the same way that someone can be called a murderer because of a prior act of murder
- But they are not continuing in adultery unless the sexual act is repeated

- Secondly, sexual conduct outside marriage (fornication) is not the same offense
  - Adultery was punishable by death under the Law
  - But fornication was a different crime and carried a different penalty
    - In Exodus 22 we'll learn that the penalty involves restitution
    - And the requirement to marry if her father permits

- While the Law promoted the sanctity of marriage, the Law also made provision for divorce
  - That provision is found in Deut 24

Deut. 24:1 "When a man takes a wife and marries her, and it happens that she finds no favor in his eyes because he has found some indecency in her, and he writes her a certificate of divorce and puts it in her hand and sends her out from his house,
Deut. 24:2 and she leaves his house and goes and becomes another man's wife,
Deut. 24:3 and if the latter husband turns against her and writes her a certificate of divorce and puts it in her hand and sends her out of his house, or if the latter husband dies who took her to be his wife,
Deut. 24:4 then her former husband who sent her away is not allowed to take her again to be his wife, since she has been defiled; for that is an abomination before the LORD, and you shall not bring sin on the land which the LORD your God gives you as an inheritance.

- The Law provided for a man to send his wife away with a certificate of divorce if he found some indecency in her
  - With that certificate of divorce in hand, the woman had a chance to remarry

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- Without such a certificate, a married woman could never convince another man to marry her
- Because that man would be concerned about violating the law against adultery and face a penalty of death

- Notice also that the Law forbid a woman married a second time from returning to her first husband
  - The reason given is because she has been defiled
  - This is our first clue that God doesn't see a divorce as the clean break we may think it is

- Later in Jeremiah, God draws a lesson from this Law in passing judgment on Israel

Jer. 3:1 God says, "If a husband divorces his wife
And she goes from him
And belongs to another man,
Will he still return to her?
Will not that land be completely polluted?
But you are a harlot with many lovers;
Yet you turn to Me," declares the LORD.

- The Lord draws from the Law to make a spiritual point to unfaithful Israel
- The Lord called Himself a Husband to Israel, who He called His wife
- But the nation was unfaithful to the Lord, so the Lord gave the nation a certificate of divorce, spiritually speaking
- Then Israel entered into a new relationship with Baal worship and other idolatry

- So the Lord determines to send the the ten northern tribes into exile
  - And here Lord warns through the nation will call to the Lord and ask to return to Him, He won't listen
  - The Lord asks if it would be right for a Husband to accept His wife back when she finally begs to return to Him after she has married herself to another?

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- The Law prohibited this possibility
- Until the Law has been fulfilled, these tribes have no possibility of returning to the Lord
    - You can study more about how that happens in the Revelation study

- Turning to the New Testament and the Law of Christ guiding believers, we see this commandment clearly continued and expanded
    - First, Jesus spoke these words concerning the matter of adultery

Matt. 5:26 "Truly I say to you, you will not come out of there until you have paid up the last cent.
Matt. 5:27 "You have heard that it was said, 'YOU SHALL NOT COMMIT ADULTERY';
Matt. 5:28 but I say to you that everyone who looks at a woman with lust for her has already committed adultery with her in his heart.

- Jesus He broadens the law just as He has in previous commandments
- Just as the prohibition against unlawful killing was broadened to include hateful thoughts, now adultery was broadened to include even lustful desires

    - Jesus is not saying that lustful thoughts are adultery
        - He's saying that they are the moral equivalent under God's law
        - If you've never committed adultery but you have entertained lustful thoughts, you are no less guilty before God than the person who acted on their lust
    - Our modern world is desperately trying to create lustful thoughts in your head at every turn
        - Advertisers seek your attention with sexy models
        - Entertainers and celebrities provoke lust for attention and profits
        - Young teens seek approval, acceptance and love by dressing provocatively
        - Websites, books, music and movies push the limits and throw away the limits to sell lust to an eager audience

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- Everywhere you look, the world is ready to provoke lust in your heart
    - But the upward call of Christ demands that we wouldn't fall for that temptation any more easily than we might commit adultery
    - Some of us may fall to both
    - But most of us treat one very differently than the other, leaving us far more willing to entertain lust than adultery
    - It ought not to be this way

- If that weren't challenging enough, Jesus goes even further in defining what is adultery

Mark 10:2 Some Pharisees came up to Jesus, testing Him, and began to question Him whether it was lawful for a man to divorce a wife.
Mark 10:3 And He answered and said to them, "What did Moses command you?"
Mark 10:4 They said, "Moses permitted a man TO WRITE A CERTIFICATE OF DIVORCE AND SEND her AWAY."
Mark 10:5 But Jesus said to them, "Because of your hardness of heart he wrote you this commandment.
Mark 10:6 "But from the beginning of creation, God MADE THEM MALE AND FEMALE.
Mark 10:7 "FOR THIS REASON A MAN SHALL LEAVE HIS FATHER AND MOTHER,
Mark 10:8 AND THE TWO SHALL BECOME ONE FLESH; so they are no longer two, but one flesh.
Mark 10:9 "What therefore God has joined together, let no man separate."
Mark 10:10 In the house the disciples began questioning Him about this again.
Mark 10:11 And He said to them, "Whoever divorces his wife and marries another woman commits adultery against her;
Mark 10:12 and if she herself divorces her husband and marries another man, she is committing adultery."

- Secondly, Jesus declares that when we dissolve a marriage through divorce and enter into new marriages, we also commit adultery
    - From God's point of view, a new marriage piles on top of the prior marriage
        - It doesn't replace the first marriage...they coexist

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- And therefore, the sexual union that forms that marriage is adultery
- Again, the new marriage begins with an act of adultery, but adultery is an act, not a state of being
- The new marriage isn't a continual act of adultery, but it is founded on a sinful basis

- The Pharisees challenged Jesus on this interpretation by reminding Him that the Law of Moses included a provision for a certificate of divorce
  - But Jesus sets the Pharisees straight concerning how they should have understood that provision
- First, Jesus returns to the origins and definitions of marriage itself
  - Marriage is a union of two into a single flesh
  - And once that union has been created, no man can declare it separated
  - So the Law of Moses couldn't change that reality, coming after the institution of marriage was established by God
- Secondly, even in the Law itself, we see evidence that even though the Law included a provision for divorce, nevertheless God still considered the divorce to be wrong
  - For example, there is no Law that actually authorizes the writing of a certificate of divorce
    - Even in the Law we read in Deuteronomy, chapter 24 never gives permission for a certificate to be written
    - It simply sets rules for what happens to a wife after a husband chooses to divorce her
    - It only deals with the aftermath of divorce
  - Furthermore, the law says that a woman who has remarried after a divorce can't return to her first husband because she has been defiled
    - If God considered a remarried woman to be defiled by that remarriage, then clearly a certificate of divorce didn't permit the woman to remarry

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        - On the contrary, God states plainly in Malachi 2:16 that He hates divorce

- So if God hates divorce and never permitted divorce in the Law, why does Moses reference such a certificate in Deuteronomy in chapter 24?

    - Jesus explains that this provision was made because of the hardness of men's hearts

        - The Lord knew that sinful men would divorce their wives without God's permission

            - And certainly God never gave men that permission

        - But in that culture, a woman who had been sent away by her husband would be without hope to find support

            - She couldn't work

            - She wouldn't have any possessions or wealth

            - So she would likely starve to death

            - Therefore, God made provision for the woman by making reference to a certificate of divorce

                - He didn't permit it

                - He simply acknowledged it

            - But by that acknowledgment, the Lord ensured that men would give their ex-wives proof that they were no longer married and could find a new source of support

    - But now we learn that those new marriages were created by an act of adultery

        - This is why the first husband could never take his wife back under his roof once she had remarried

        - And likewise today, a man or woman who remarries after leaving a marriage, commits adultery

- Furthermore, the Law of Christ demands patience, love and understanding from both the man and the woman so that marriage may be strong

    - The OT Law offered little in the way of marriage counseling

        - It merely set the expectation that the marriage remain intact

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        - But the NT writers give considerable advice to both husbands and wives to acts in ways to hold marriages together

    - Our relationship with Christ is pictured by marriage in scripture

        - He is called our Groom and the Church is the Bride of Christ

            - Our union is understood to be a betrothal

        - And therefore, if God decided to borrow imagery from human marriage to describe our relationship with Christ, then it tells us how indivisible the marriage covenant must be in reality

            - Just as nothing can separate us from our Groom, Christ

            - Similarly, nothing can separate a marriage

- The Law of Christ raises the bar on the seventh commandment for every Christian

    - Save yourself for marriage

        - Once you marry, see that marriage the way the Lord sees it:

        - You are married until death do you part

    - Work on your marriage, making its preservation your highest goal

        - See it as your witness to the world of the relationship you enjoy in Christ

        - Protect it knowing that as you honor your spouse and your marriage, you reflect your faith

    - Should one member of the marriage give up and leave or even file for a legal divorce, remember you still remain married in God's eyes

        - Remain single forevermore hoping the spouse reconsiders and returns

        - If one remarries, then they commit adultery on the other

    - In summary, there is no going back on any marriage

        - If you have remarried, stay married

        - Adultery is an act, not a state of being

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        - Just as the Law prevented men from taking back a twice married woman, so are we not to repeat our mistakes

- Moving on to the next commandment

Ex. 20:15 **"You shall not steal.**

- The very fact that God's law forbid taking another's property teaches us something about God's economic point of view
    - God is not a communist
        - He believes in private property ownership rights
        - A man can possess property and expect that he might never be denied access to it
    - As we'll study more later, the Law expands private properly law considerably, establishing tort law for how private property crimes are to be adjudicated
        - If you deprive someone of something, you had an obligation to return it or compensate them for it
        - That our modern civil law is based on God's law will become self-evident as we read through the Law
- How did Jesus carry over this law and it expand for the believer?
    - First, it is restated plainly, both in the Gospels and through the NT Epistles

Eph. 4:28 **He who steals must steal no longer; but rather he must labor, performing with his own hands what is good, so that he will have something to share with one who has need.**

    - Secondly, the sin of stealing is also equated with desires heart, particularly greedy gain, fraud, dishonest business dealings, slothful dependence, and the general love of money
        - For example, Jesus says:

Luke 12:15 **Then He said to them, "Beware, and be on your guard against every form of greed; for not even when one has an abundance does his life consist of his possessions."**

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- In fact, Paul says greed can lead to idolatry in Colossians 3:5 and denounces sordid gain in 1Tim 3:8

- In other words, the purpose of the eighth commandment was merely to prohibit the active taking of something in another's possession

  - It intended to put to an end any action intended to enrich ourselves in an unloving way at someone else's expense

    - Whether we trick someone into spending too much

    - Or scheme in business or conduct shading business dealings

    - Or misuse our employer's time or misrepresent our goods for sale, etc.

  - Remember, even forms of business that may be legal according to the nations laws can still violate the standards of the NT Law of Christ

    - Just like the laws of our nation may permit remarriage, Jesus says it is adultery

    - Likewise, the laws of our nation may permit some business practices that Jesus has taught are actually sinful acts of stealing

  - In fact, just a greedy desire for possessions is itself a violation of this commandment in the NT Law of Christ

1Tim. 6:7 For we have brought nothing into the world, so we cannot take anything out of it either.
1Tim. 6:8 If we have food and covering, with these we shall be content.
1Tim. 6:9 But those who want to get rich fall into temptation and a snare and many foolish and harmful desires which plunge men into ruin and destruction.
1Tim. 6:10 For the love of money is a root of all sorts of evil, and some by longing for it have wandered away from the faith and pierced themselves with many griefs.
1Tim. 6:11 But flee from these things, you man of God, and pursue righteousness, godliness, faith, love, perseverance and gentleness.

- How does greed qualify as a form of stealing?

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- Well, consider that the Lord is the owner of all that the earth contains
  - And scripture teaches that the Lord assigns to each according to His will
  - So that when we allow our greedy hearts to rule over us and drive us to seek after things the Lord has not assign for us, we are stealing from the Lord in a sense
    - We are taking for ourselves something that the Lord, the owner of all things, has not given into our hands
- If you want the best possible perspective on this question, you should consult the man who knew better than anyone how it feels to seek after everything: Solomon
  - Read the second chapter of Ecclesiastes
  - It begins with Solomon saying

Eccl. 2:3 **I explored with my mind how to stimulate my body with wine while my mind was guiding me wisely, and how to take hold of folly, until I could see what good there is for the sons of men to do under heaven the few years of their lives.**

  - And ends this way

Eccl. 2:26 **For to a person who is good in His sight He has given wisdom and knowledge and joy, while to the sinner He has given the task of gathering and collecting so that he may give to one who is good in God's sight. This too is vanity and striving after wind.**

- Notice that God does believe in the redistribution of wealth
  - He has appointed to the person who is good to have spiritual wisdom, knowledge and joy - things you can't buy
  - But to the sinner, the Lord has appointed the task of working to gather the material of the world
    - Ultimately, the wealth collected by that sinner will find its way to bless the righteous in God's sight
  - Therefore, when a believer tries to gain wealth by imitating the sinner's methods, they circumvent God's purposes
  - And they violate the spirit of the eighth commandment

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- Now the ninth commandment

Ex. 20:16 "You shall not bear false witness against your neighbor.

- In strict legal terms, the commandment instructs Israel not to testify falsely against someone else in a matter of justice
    - In broad terms, however, the Law was commanding truth telling in all situations
        - In fact, in Leviticus 19:11, the Law plainly states that no one may lie to another
        - Furthermore, the Law also precluded slandering
    - At the root of this commandment is preservation of truth
        - Truth is an absolute, and all that is true comes from the Lord
        - While all that is false comes from the enemy
            - For example, when we lie even about a little thing, we are showing evidence of sin in us
            - And that sin originated with a lie that Satan told to Woman in the garden
            - In effect, our lies are an ever-present reminder that sin began with a lie, and the effect of that first lie is still playing out in our bodies today
        - This commandment endeavors to promote Truth and to diminish lies in the people of Israel
- In the Law of Christ, we see this commandment represented and expanded once again
    - Beyond lying and false witness, which are specifically prohibited, the NT saint is likewise prohibited from a long list of sins of speech
        - Flattering speech
        - Gossip
        - Slander
        - Deceit

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        - Abusive speech
        - Arrogant speech
    - How do these other forms of speech relate to lying?
        - Lying is the simplest description for promoting something that is false, not the truth, and therefore not from God
        - These other forms of prohibited speech are each falsehood in some manner
            - Gossip is taking an unhealthy interest in another's situation or discussing it without their consent
            - But it usually involves passing along information that is wrong or incomplete
            - Slander is fictitious accusations
            - Abusive speech is speaking so as to cause harm, which is not truthful speech
            - Etc.
    - The Christian is called to guard our tongues and season our speech to make sure that everything we speak is edifying
        - The standard is not merely to avoid saying the wrong thing
        - But the true test of love for a NT saint is to endeavor to always say an edifying thing

- Finally, the tenth commandment

Ex. 20:17 **"You shall not covet your neighbor's house; you shall not covet your neighbor's wife or his male servant or his female servant or his ox or his donkey or anything that belongs to your neighbor."**

- To covet can be defined as wanting something we can't (or shouldn't) have, or in some cases, wanting more of something we already have enough of
    - In the Law, the Lord lists six specific examples of coveting and then adds a seventh general prohibition

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- Since the Lord includes the seventh general statement, we know that the six earlier things were not intended to be the limit of the Law
- They were merely representative of the things men typically covet
- These six represent the six most valuable items any many would typically possess in Moses' day, listed in descending order of value according to man's standards (not God's)
    - A man's desires usually correspond to the perceived value of things
    - The list includes representations of wealth, power, status, and well-being

- Coveting is a particularly dangerous sin in that it can be experienced inwardly though never expressed outwardly
    - Men secretly (or not so secretly) desire what other men have, and that is a form of selfishness
    - Coveting is an attitude more than an action, though it can certainly lead to sinful actions
        - Coveting can lead to jealousy, lying, stealing, murder and a host of other sinful behaviors
        - Fo this reason, the Lord prohibited even our desiring for other things
    - There is a difference, however, between wanting something and coveting something
        - A newly married couple can want for a child, while a childless couple covets another's newborn baby
        - One hard working employee can want for a promotion, while his colleague covets his boss' position
        - One man can have desire for a woman, while another covets his roommate's girlfriend
        - A child can want a special toy for his birthday, while another covet's his brother's bike

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- The point is that coveting isn't defined by the item in question or even the extent of our desire
    - Coveting is wanting for things that already belong to another and have not been appointed for us by God
    - Wanting becomes coveting when our desires turn from things that might become ours to things that shouldn't become ours

- The principle behind this commandment is incredibly important to understanding how the Jew was to live according to it
    - It begins with an understanding of Who owns all things to begin with

Psa. 24:1 **The earth is the LORD'S, and all it contains,**
The world, and those who dwell in it.

- Everything that exists is property of the Lord
    - And not merely the natural things in the world
    - But also the things men create with their hands still belong to the Lord
- He is the Creator and all that is created traces its origins to Him

- Furthermore, the Lord designated a portion of creation to each man according to His will

1Sam. 2:7 **"The LORD makes poor and rich; He brings low, He also exalts.**
Prov. 22:2 **The rich and the poor have a common bond, The LORD is the maker of them all.**

- This truth is especially evident in the life of the nation of Israel

Deut. 32:7 **"Remember the days of old,**
Consider the years of all generations.
Ask your father, and he will inform you,
Your elders, and they will tell you.
Deut. 32:8 **"When the Most High gave the nations their inheritance,**
When He separated the sons of man,
He set the boundaries of the peoples
According to the number of the sons of Israel.

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- Moses explains that the Lord had given to each tribe and person within Israel a portion of an inheritance that the Lord designated
- His will is reflected in this allotment, so when a Jew coveted what another had received, he was indirectly challenging God's will

- So coveting wasn't merely a sin because it leads to sinful thoughts or sinful actions against other people
  - It is sin because it indicts God's goodness and His wisdom
  - It suggests that we know better what we should have than does God
  - It repeats the sin of Adam when he chose to eat the fruit that God said wasn't given to Adam
  - Just as lying repeats the sin of Satan, coveting repeats the sin of Woman and Adam

- How does the NT challenge Christians to follow this command?
  - First, the NT writers frequently call Christians to contentment

Heb. 13:5 Make sure that your character is free from the love of money, being content with what you have; for He Himself has said, "I WILL NEVER DESERT YOU, NOR WILL I EVER FORSAKE YOU,"

- Once again, the NT reasoning for calling us to contentment is God's goodness in deciding what we should have
- The writer says be content with what you have, because the Lord has said that He will always be with us
- How does this explain the need for contentment?
  - Because if the Lord is always with us, then we can safely assume He is fully aware of our circumstances and our needs
  - And in light of that knowledge, He has made a certain provision available
  - That provision should not be challenged

- Secondly, the Law of Christ commands us recognize that the Lord controls our possessions and so seek the Lord for everything we desire

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- James addresses this problem in particular in his letter

James 4:1 What is the source of quarrels and conflicts among you? Is not the source your pleasures that wage war in your members?
James 4:2 You lust and do not have; so you commit murder. You are envious and cannot obtain; so you fight and quarrel. You do not have because you do not ask.
James 4:3 You ask and do not receive, because you ask with wrong motives, so that you may spend it on your pleasures.
James 4:4 You adulteresses, do you not know that friendship with the world is hostility toward God? Therefore whoever wishes to be a friend of the world makes himself an enemy of God.
James 4:5 Or do you think that the Scripture speaks to no purpose: "He jealously desires the Spirit which He has made to dwell in us"?
James 4:6 But He gives a greater grace. Therefore it says, "GOD IS OPPOSED TO THE PROUD, BUT GIVES GRACE TO THE HUMBLE."
James 4:7 Submit therefore to God. Resist the devil and he will flee from you.
James 4:8 Draw near to God and He will draw near to you. Cleanse your hands, you sinners; and purify your hearts, you double-minded.

- James points out that our desires cross the line and become sinful when they are driven by the lust of the flesh
    - Murder, envy, fights are all the result of a desire that is centered in the flesh
        - This is the opposite of desires of heart that arise out of the Spirit's leading
        - If the Spirit is leading us to a desire, then the natural response should be to pray and ask the Lord to deliver the thing we desire
            - By that prayer, we acknowledge that all good things come from the Lord, as James also teaches
            - And we ask knowing that the Lord will grant it if it is the right thing for us
        - These are the right motives that James says we must have to receive something from the Lord
    - By contrast, wrong motives are desires that originate in our flesh and lead to sinful thoughts and actions
        - We want something we can't have, so we kill for it

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- Or we are envious of what another has, so we quarrel with them

- So the Christian's call under the Law of Christ isn't merely not to covet something we shouldn't have
    - It includes commands to ask the Lord for everything we want
        - It isn't merely a matter of guarding against wanting the wrong thing in the wrong way
        - It has become a command to be content, to recognize that the Lord provides us with what He chooses, and to seek Him for anything else we want
    - The annals of the Christian faith are filled with stories of men who sought God for their needs, and then waited to see how God would respond
        - But the best example as usual is Jesus Himself
        - He declared that He had no where to lay His head
            - Jesus was homeless during his adult ministry
            - Never in the three years of His life recorded in the Gospels do we see Jesus ever go to a place considered his home
            - He had no income, He had no possessions from what we can tell
        - And when He was asked to pay tax, this is what He did

Matt. 17:27 **"However, so that we do not offend them, go to the sea and throw in a hook, and take the first fish that comes up; and when you open its mouth, you will find a shekel. Take that and give it to them for you and Me."**

        - Furthermore, the Lord found food by multiplying fish and loaves
        - And at other times He depended on the kindness of others
    - The point is that Jesus acted as if He owned nothing because He owned everything
        - He had everything at His disposal, so He didn't toil to separate out some for Himself at the expense of others
        - Likewise, our Father in Heaven has ownership of everything

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- So we are called to live without undue interest in other's goods and without the distraction of lustful desires leading to greater sin
- Instead, ask the Lord for what you desire, with a motive to serve Him, knowing that everything in the world is at His disposal
- And then when you see what comes, be content knowing that this is the Lord's choice for us

- Perhaps this is best summed up in Proverbs

Prov. 30:7 Two things I asked of You, Do not refuse me before I die:
Prov. 30:8 Keep deception and lies far from me, Give me neither poverty nor riches; Feed me with the food that is my portion,
Prov. 30:9 That I not be full and deny You and say, "Who is the LORD?" Or that I not be in want and steal, And profane the name of my God.

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Exodus 21

- Now that the Law have been delivered, the narrative returns to describing the state of the people gathered around the mountain

Ex. 20:18 All the people perceived the thunder and the lightning flashes and the sound of the trumpet and the mountain smoking; and when the people saw it, they trembled and stood at a distance.
Ex. 20:19 Then they said to Moses, "Speak to us yourself and we will listen; but let not God speak to us, or we will die."
Ex. 20:20 Moses said to the people, "Do not be afraid; for God has come in order to test you, and in order that the fear of Him may remain with you, so that you may not sin."
Ex. 20:21 So the people stood at a distance, while Moses approached the thick cloud where God was.

- It's important to assemble an accurate timeline concerning the events of chapter 20
    - This scene began in chapter 19 after Moses had met the Lord on the mountain, when the Lord said

Ex. 19:9 The LORD said to Moses, "Behold, I will come to you in a thick cloud, so that the people may hear when I speak with you and may also believe in you forever." Then Moses told the words of the people to the LORD.

- Following this, Moses descended to the base of the mountain where the people were waiting, and we learned this...

Ex. 19:16 So it came about on the third day, when it was morning, that there were thunder and lightning flashes and a thick cloud upon the mountain and a very loud trumpet sound, so that all the people who were in the camp trembled.
Ex. 19:17 And Moses brought the people out of the camp to meet God, and they stood at the foot of the mountain.
Ex. 19:18 Now Mount Sinai was all in smoke because the LORD descended upon it in fire; and its smoke ascended like the smoke of a furnace, and the whole mountain quaked violently.
Ex. 19:19 When the sound of the trumpet grew louder and louder, Moses spoke and God answered him with thunder.

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- Then in chapter 20, we have the content of what the Lord spoke to Moses and the people, that is the Ten Commandments
    - It appears the people didn't perceive the content of God's words so much as they were simply terrified of the whole experience
        - They heard thunder, see lightning, hear the sound of a trumpet and see the mountain smoking
        - And the thunder grew every louder as the conversation progressed
    - And then we see the effect God's words had upon the people
        - They are so afraid from having heard the voice of God, they turn to Moses and demand to hear no more
        - They say they want him to carry out all further communication with the Lord
        - And then Moses will relate it to them
- Moses calms the people by reassuring them that they won't have to hear the Lord's voice any longer
    - But it was necessary to hear from Him directly at least this one time so that the people could personally experience the fear of the Lord
    - And by their fear, they would be encouraged not to sin
    - But as we learn later, the fear of the Lord isn't enough to ensure proper behavior

- After that, Moses leaves the people and approaches the cloud, where he will receive the rest of the Law
    - The thick cloud hid God's glory from the people
        - But the Lord allowed Moses to see His glory in some form
        - We'll learn more about this later in Ex 34
    - Now we move forward in the Law to Moses
        - The next laws God delivers relate to the altar of worship and the Jewish Bill of Rights, as it is known

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Ex. 20:22 Then the LORD said to Moses, "Thus you shall say to the sons of Israel, 'You yourselves have seen that I have spoken to you from heaven.
Ex. 20:23 'You shall not make other gods besides Me; gods of silver or gods of gold, you shall not make for yourselves.
Ex. 20:24 'You shall make an altar of earth for Me, and you shall sacrifice on it your burnt offerings and your peace offerings, your sheep and your oxen; in every place where I cause My name to be remembered, I will come to you and bless you.
Ex. 20:25 'If you make an altar of stone for Me, you shall not build it of cut stones, for if you wield your tool on it, you will profane it.
Ex. 20:26 'And you shall not go up by steps to My altar, so that your nakedness will not be exposed on it.'

- The Lord is about to prescribe instructions on how He should be worshipped corporately, but He prefaces these instructions with a warning in vs.22-23
    - As the nation endeavors to worship the Lord, they must be careful never to violate the second commandment by creating idols to represent God
        - The Lord knew this would be a persistent temptation for Israel
        - Whenever their minds turn to worshipping the Lord, Who is all Spirit, the tendency is to create something physical in His place
            - Israel long struggled with this problem
            - And men still struggle with it today
    - When we engage in worship, men want "bells and smells" as the saying goes
        - We exist in the physical world, so we try to bring God closer to us by creating a physical representation of God, which is a graven image and an idol
        - There were pagan idols, there were Jewish idols, and we have American idols today
        - Today our graven images may be more sophisticated but they are equally corrupting
            - Ancient idols took the form of figurines of wood or stone
                - Some still erect statues in church
            - But more often, our spiritual crutches come in the form of crosses, or altars, or even the buildings themselves

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- Like figures made of wood, we assign man-made objects with greater spiritual significance than they deserve

- Confining the spiritual to the physical is a constant struggle for our flesh, and it is a sin
  - But Jesus told us that the day had come when the Lord's followers would worship in Spirit and Truth
  - He was referring to a true worship that happens completely divorced from physical relics or any other substitutes for the Spirit
    - Today, we have no physical temple...the Lord dwells in us
    - No assigned priests...we are all priests
    - No altars...no more sacrifice is required
    - No basins, no incense, nothing physical required under the Law is required today for us to approach and worship
  - Neither should be endeavor to replace them with new physical relics

- Speaking of worshipping under the Law, the Lord gives the instructions constructing an altar in vs.24-26
  - Most of the sacrificial and ceremonial rules for worship are provided in Leviticus, since Leviticus deals with the priesthood
    - But in Exodus we receive the instructions on the altar
    - And later the construction of the tabernacle
  - God instructed the Jews to build two different types of altars
    - The Lord directs both the place and the style of altars which may be built for worship
    - First, God assigns the locations for every altar
      - Before the Law, the patriarchs would set up altars wherever they wished
      - Usually, they built altars on the occasion of God's revelation or great work in their life

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- So formal worship was a response to God revealing Himself

- Now, worship was to become an institution of everyday life

- And therefore, the manner and place of worship is determined by the Lord

- There is a message embedded in this change

- The message is that men must approach the Lord on His terms, not ours

- The formality of the Law creates a structure in which our approach is regulated

- As Paul said, the Law kept men under custody until Christ came

- The design of the altar is also intended to communicate how sinful men approach the Lord

  - First, altars could be earth or stone

    - The altars would be a place of sacrifice

      - A table where an animal or other offering place placed on top and burned

    - Altars are places of sacrifices

      - They are not religious objects decorating houses of worship

      - They certainly shouldn't be a substitute for a table

      - Churches should never feature altars, since doing so implies a need for sacrifice

      - And Christ's sacrifice was sufficient for all time, so that no new sacrifice will ever be necessary nor acceptable to the Lord

  - If a stone altar was to be built, the stone could not be cut or shaped by tools

    - Canaanite altars used in their pagan worship practices were typically elaborate and artfully constructed

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- So this law had the effect of separating Israel from the surrounding people
- Which is one of the ten purposes of the Law we studied

- But there is a spiritual message in this requirement
  - The altar is a place where men address the sin that separates them from God
  - So our worship of God depends on having something appease God's wrath for our sin
  - Our sin separates us from God, so until something addresses the problem of our sin, worship isn't possible
  - That's the reason that worship took place at an altar
    - Atonement for sin was the means for entering into worship
    - And it was the means by which the Lord could entertain our worship
- Now consider what it would mean if the object designated for sacrifice was constructed by men using tools to work the stone into shape
  - It would send a message that by our work, men participated in atoning our sin
  - The altar would stand as a testimony to man's work, with craftsmen reflecting in pride upon their handiwork
  - They could boast of how they contributed to make possible the atonement that permitted men to worship God
    - This was the problem Paul was talking about in Ephesian 2 when he wrote about the God's manner of salvation

Eph. 2:8 For by grace you have been saved through faith; and that not of yourselves, it is the gift of God;
Eph. 2:9 not as a result of works, so that no one may boast.
Eph. 2:10 For we are His workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared beforehand so that we would walk in them.

- The Lord has done all the work of salvation, so the altar must reflect that spiritual truth

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- The stones were to be left as they were in nature, just as God formed them
- Men can not participate in their own salvation
- And the construction of the altar reflected that truth

- Finally, the altar couldn't have stairs leading up to it, meaning the altar wasn't position in an exalted place
  - The reason for this prohibition, according to the Lord, was to prevent the priests' backsides to be exposed when they walked up stairs
  - Men wore rubes and tunics, and like ladies' dresses today, if you walk high enough, you expose yourself
  - This was also different from the pagan priests of the day
    - Some cultures demanded that their priests or ministry leaders officiate entirely in the nude
    - I'm grateful the Lord changed that rule!
- There is another picture formed in the way God forbids the priests' nakedness from being exposed at the altar
  - The ultimate purpose of sacrificial atonement is to cover the nakedness of man's sin
    - Remember, when Adam sinned, he discovered his physical nakedness
    - This new awareness was the awakening of a sinful conscience
  - The awareness Adam experienced was his jeopardy before God because of his sin
    - Adam's sin was exposed before God leaving Adam vulnerable to judgment
    - His conscience reflected this change in his spiritual nature
    - And it manifested itself as a fear of being naked, of physical exposure
  - God programmed our conscience to reflect our spiritual state

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- When we are innocent before God, we carry no sense of shame or vulnerability
- When we are guilty, we feel the instinctive need to hide ourselves

- So God commands the priests to hide their nakedness

- Chapters 21-23 begin the next section of the Law
  - This section is called the section ordinances, as the opening verse of chapter 21 tells us
    - It concerns the basic civil rights of Jewish society
      - In these laws you have the rights of individuals
      - And the consequences for the violation of those rights
    - Many of these laws are reflected in our laws today
  - As we move through this section, we will take time in places to examine the laws in details, especially as they may relate to Christ or NT Law
    - But we will not stop and study each law in equal detail

Ex. 21:1 **"Now these are the ordinances which you are to set before them:**
Ex. 21:2 **"If you buy a Hebrew slave, he shall serve for six years; but on the seventh he shall go out as a free man without payment.**
Ex. 21:3 **"If he comes alone, he shall go out alone; if he is the husband of a wife, then his wife shall go out with him.**
Ex. 21:4 **"If his master gives him a wife, and she bears him sons or daughters, the wife and her children shall belong to her master, and he shall go out alone.**
Ex. 21:5 **"But if the slave plainly says, 'I love my master, my wife and my children; I will not go out as a free man,'**
Ex. 21:6 **then his master shall bring him to God, then he shall bring him to the door or the doorpost. And his master shall pierce his ear with an awl; and he shall serve him permanently.**

- The first section of the ordinances deal with the rights of slaves in Jewish society
  - Immediately, we are struck by an apparent contradiction over how rights could be expressed in the context of slavery

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- Isn't slavery wrong to begin with and therefore, why does God seem to condone here?
- The answer is that our notion of slavery and the kind of slavery that is in view here are totally different

- First, notice that the slavery discussed here involves a Hebrew slave, according to v.2
  - One Hebrew is "bought" by another Hebrew and becomes a slave
  - How does one Hebrew come up for sale within the nation of Israel?
    - The answer provides our first distinction between slavery in the Law and the form of slavery practiced in our nation and elsewhere
    - The Hebrew becomes a slave because he places himself up for sale
    - In other words, the person volunteers to become a slave (or servant) of another Hebrew
- Why would a Hebrew sell himself to another man as a servant?
  - In most cases, it was to settle a debt
  - If a Hebrew had indebted himself so much that he could not pay the debt with his assets, then he had to work off his debt
  - Since his debtors demanded immediate payment of the debt, the man couldn't wait to earn the money through normal employment
  - So instead, he sold himself as a slave
    - In a sense, he was taking his wages in advance and then received no paid for his work
    - But he also gave up his rights as a free man
- A Hebrew slave was the property of his owner, since he was bought with a price
  - He worked for free because his wages had already been paid up front when he was purchased

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        - Obviously, such an arrangement could be easily abused
            - A desperate debtor might agree to very unfair terms
        - So the Law stepped in to limit the number of years someone could remain a slave
        - At the end seven years, the slave must be set free
            - Obviously, this law also limited how much someone could sell themselves for, since the buyer was limited to seven years of labor

- The Law further clarified that families were not be broken up
    - If a man entered with a wife, he left with his wife
        - If the man took an interest in one of the masters daughters or other servants, then he could marry
        - But if he did so, he could not automatically take those people with him when he left slavery
            - The slave must redeem his new family by paying a bride price to the master
            - Or he could leave them behind to work off that price, just as he had worked off his own debt
            - Or he could stay with them and remain a permanent member of the household with his family
    - Now if this doesn't sound fair, give careful thought to how this circumstance would play out
        - First, a slave new these rules existed
        - So when he decided to accept a wife from the master, he knew he was setting himself up for a difficult decision at the seven year point
            - He was a slave, so he likely wouldn't be able to pay the bride price
            - So essentially, he was taking on more debt by accepting the wife

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- This meant he was marrying knowing he would need to leave his wife and children behind until he could redeem them

- Obviously, this would be a severe hardship, so having a family would be a strong incentive to remain in the master's house

- So a master had incentive to offer a good slave a wife

- He knew this would make it less likely that the servant would leave after seven years

- So in vs.5-6, the Lord makes a provision for a slave to voluntarily becoming a permanent servant in the household

  - He would announced his intentions to stay permanently

    - Essentially, the man was applying for permanent, life-long employment

    - He would have the care of his master

    - He would never worry again about housing, food, or unemployment

  - This was a decision that couldn't be reversed

    - So a permanent mark was made by piercing his ear with an awl nailed through the ear to a doorpost

    - This designation makes this servant a "bondservant" or bondslave

  - This is why the NT epistles authors frequently refer to themselves as bondservants of Christ

    - We have been bought with a price to become slaves of Christ

      - But in our walk as disciples of Christ, we are also voluntarily committing ourselves to following serving and obeying Jesus forever

      - We are slaves, in the sense that we can never again be released from our relationship with Jesus

      - But we are bondslaves because our service to Jesus is a conscious choice we make in our walk

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- These rules applied to male slaves, but female slaves had different rights
    - So the ordinances regarding female slaves differed

Ex. 21:7 "If a man sells his daughter as a female slave, she is not to go free as the male slaves do.
Ex. 21:8 "If she is displeasing in the eyes of her master who designated her for himself, then he shall let her be redeemed. He does not have authority to sell her to a foreign people because of his unfairness to her.
Ex. 21:9 "If he designates her for his son, he shall deal with her according to the custom of daughters.
Ex. 21:10 "If he takes to himself another woman, he may not reduce her food, her clothing, or her conjugal rights.
Ex. 21:11 "If he will not do these three things for her, then she shall go out for nothing, without payment of money.

- To understand this passage, once again we need to appreciate what the words mean and what the customs expected
    - In v.7 we hear of a father selling his daughter, as a female slave, and this sale would also have been done for similar economic reasons
        - He was in debt, and his daughter was of marrying age
        - So he sells her as a servant to another man to cancel a debt
        - Why would a father do this? Well, in reality he was doing what any father would do with his daughter, at least in a sense
        - He was finding his daughter a husband
    - Marriages were a two part process in ancient times
        - First, every bride was "bought"
        - A price was paid to the father for the privilege of taking his daughter as bride
            - Commonly, fathers bought brides for their sons
            - Sometimes, a groom bought a bride for himself, as in cases when his father had already passed away
        - Later, the wedding night occurs, and the marriage is consummated

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- The two events were usually separated by months or years
- But in the meantime, After the price was paid, the girl was betrothed to her groom and belonged to the one who bought her
- We see this situation play out in the story of Isaac and Rebekah
    - Abraham's servant goes to Haran and buys Rebekah for Isaac
    - At that point, Rebekah belongs to Abraham until she marries Isaac

- So there was always money exchanged in some form when a bride was taken
    - In this case, the Law is speaking of a situation when a master takes a woman in exchanged for the cancellation of debt
        - He doesn't pay for the woman with a cash payment
        - And because she is taken in this way, her status in the new household is different
        - She is a slave girl or servant in the house, not a daughter
        - Because the girl was received in forgiveness of debt, she carries a lower status
        - On the other hand, if she marry's the master's son rather than another servant, then the Law says in v.9 that she is to be treat as a daughter in the family
    - So while the servant girl waits to marry, she serves as a slave girl or handmaiden in the household
        - But what if the girl is never given in marriage? What are here rights?
        - The law in v.7 addresses the rights of a slave girl who is not permitted to marry
            - If the delay stretches to seven years, the freedom rule doesn't apply according as it does for a male servant
            - The woman can't leave her servant status

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        - This may sound harsh, until we remember that a woman was always under the authority of either a father or husband
            - Since her father sold her, she was now under the authority of her master and future husband, so there was no divorce possible
    - But in v.8, the Law says that if the master is displeased with her and won't allow her to marry, then he must allow another man to purchase her for marriage
        - But he cannot sell her to a foreign husband
        - The woman must be married to another member of Israel
        - If he will not marry her or sell her into marriage, then she must be released without a payment required so she can marry someone
        - In summary, an unmarried woman cannot be held in limbo indefinitely
            - She must be married to the one who paid the bride price
            - Or the master must allow someone else to purchase her
- Finally, the culture considered this slave wife to carry a different status than a free woman
    - Like Hagar and Sarah, the slave wife (or concubine) was considered secondary to a free wife
        - So a man who took a slave girl as wife would often seek for a second wife who was free
        - And when he took a second free wife, the slave wife was considered less valuable to the husband
        - Both the husband and the free wife would look down on the slave wife
    - So in vs.10-11 the Law addresses how a husband must treat his servant wife (a concubine) if he took another free wife
        - The slave wife must continue to receive all necessary provision, like food and clothing

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        - And the man must continue to do his duty as a husband to her and not deny her conjugal rights
        - Clearly, these laws were intended to protect the slave wife from a vindictive free wife
            - We see these sins evident in the way Jacob's four wives quarreled with one another

- The Law is regulating the way men cared for concubines, but it isn't endorsing the practice of multiple marriages
    - The God's law is acknowledging the reality of multiple marriages without endorsing it or approving of it
        - This is one of the purposes of the Law
        - To regulate the sinful hearts of men
    - We might ask why God doesn't outlaw multiple marriages directly in His word
        - In fact, He does when He defines marriage as one husband, one wife, on flesh
        - And in the testimony of scripture, multiple marriages are consistently portrayed as negative and harmful to the family
        - Furthermore, NT teaching reinforces the importance of taking only one wife when it declares an elder must be "a man of one wife"
        - However, when a man chooses to take a second wife, his sin doesn't render the second marriage invalid
            - Like in the case of divorce, the second marriage is formed through an act of adultery, but it is still a one flesh relationship
            - Therefore, the man must honor his second marriage just as he should honor his first
            - Once again, we're not saying that multiple marriages are appropriate...they're not
            - But once a marriage is formed, it must be honored

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- And so the Law addresses how to make the best of a sinful situation, once that situation has developed
  - We saw this principle at work in Deuteronomy 24
  - God acknowledged the reality of divorce and made grace available for the abandoned woman to minimize the negative effects of the husband's sin
  - But that accommodation wasn't an endorsement of the practice
  - Nor is this acknowledgment intended to be an endorsement of multiple marriages
  - In fact, by the time of Jesus day, multiple marriages were no longer permitted in Jewish society even though this provision still existed in the Law

- Finally, it's worth reiterating that the rights of slaves in Israel far exceeded the rights that other nations afforded to their slaves
  - The institution of slavery as defined in the Bible isn't sin, so long as we are talking about a very specific form of slavery
    - Biblical slavery practiced under the Law in Israel was a voluntary state, in which a man chose to enter to avoid paying a debt or to ensure life-long employment
    - Their prior choices put them in a position where slavery was their only escape, and they were grateful for the option
    - Today, we have a concept of bankruptcy, which brings its own consequences in our society
  - Scripture teaches that debt to others brings consequences, and when we have debt we are essentially the slave of another
    - Today we mean that euphemistically, but in the OT times, it was meant literally
  - Furthermore, slavery in the Biblical sense didn't involve mistreatment
    - If a slave was mistreated, the master was guilty of a crime (which we will see in v.20)
    - This is very different to slavery as it was practiced in the early years of our country or in many other places in the world

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- Slaves didn't enter slavery voluntarily
- They weren't set free after seven years
- And they were mistreated terribly
- This form of slavery is never allowed in scripture and is sinful

- So these laws are a reflection of God's grace in the way He provided for the slave's interests
  - And that's why the BIble acknowledges the reality of slavery as an institution
  - Under the Law's regulation of slavery, it becomes more of a job or employment opportunity than the thing we typically think of today

- The next section of the ordinances runs until v.32 and deals with personal injury

Ex. 21:12 "He who strikes a man so that he dies shall surely be put to death.
Ex. 21:13 "But if he did not lie in wait for him, but God let him fall into his hand, then I will appoint you a place to which he may flee.
Ex. 21:14 "If, however, a man acts presumptuously toward his neighbor, so as to kill him craftily, you are to take him even from My altar, that he may die.
Ex. 21:15 "He who strikes his father or his mother shall surely be put to death.
Ex. 21:16 "He who kidnaps a man, whether he sells him or he is found in his possession, shall surely be put to death.
Ex. 21:17 "He who curses his father or his mother shall surely be put to death.
Ex. 21:18 "If men have a quarrel and one strikes the other with a stone or with his fist, and he does not die but remains in bed,
Ex. 21:19 if he gets up and walks around outside on his staff, then he who struck him shall go unpunished; he shall only pay for his loss of time, and shall take care of him until he is completely healed.
Ex. 21:20 "If a man strikes his male or female slave with a rod and he dies at his hand, he shall be punished.
Ex. 21:21 "If, however, he survives a day or two, no vengeance shall be taken; for he is his property.
Ex. 21:22 "If men struggle with each other and strike a woman with child so that she gives birth prematurely, yet there is no injury, he shall surely be fined as the woman's husband may demand of him, and he shall pay as the judges decide.

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Ex. 21:23 "But if there is any further injury, then you shall appoint as a penalty life for life,
Ex. 21:24 eye for eye, tooth for tooth, hand for hand, foot for foot,
Ex. 21:25 burn for burn, wound for wound, bruise for bruise.
Ex. 21:26 "If a man strikes the eye of his male or female slave, and destroys it, he shall let him go free on account of his eye.
Ex. 21:27 "And if he knocks out a tooth of his male or female slave, he shall let him go free on account of his tooth.
Ex. 21:28 "If an ox gores a man or a woman to death, the ox shall surely be stoned and its flesh shall not be eaten; but the owner of the ox shall go unpunished.
Ex. 21:29 "If, however, an ox was previously in the habit of goring and its owner has been warned, yet he does not confine it and it kills a man or a woman, the ox shall be stoned and its owner also shall be put to death.
Ex. 21:30 "If a ransom is demanded of him, then he shall give for the redemption of his life whatever is demanded of him.
Ex. 21:31 "Whether it gores a son or a daughter, it shall be done to him according to the same rule.
Ex. 21:32 "If the ox gores a male or female slave, the owner shall give his or her master thirty shekels of silver, and the ox shall be stoned.
Ex. 21:33 "If a man opens a pit, or digs a pit and does not cover it over, and an ox or a donkey falls into it,
Ex. 21:34 the owner of the pit shall make restitution; he shall give money to its owner, and the dead animal shall become his.
Ex. 21:35 "If one man's ox hurts another's so that it dies, then they shall sell the live ox and divide its price equally; and also they shall divide the dead ox.
Ex. 21:36 "Or if it is known that the ox was previously in the habit of goring, yet its owner has not confined it, he shall surely pay ox for ox, and the dead animal shall become his.

- The first section in this passage regards homicide
    - Various kinds of homicide are addressed here
        - First, premeditated murder always results in death
        - The death penalty for murder is a legitimate and required penalty under the Law of God
        - In v.14 we're told that this penalty should apply to everyone, even if you find the guilty party serving before the Lord's altar
    - If the act was not premeditated, which we call manslaughter, then a different penalty applies

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        - That person would be sent to a city of refuge
            - It was refuge in the sense that it was a refuge from the death penalty
        - Don't think these cities were a way to avoid punishment; on the contrary
            - The people in these cities never left, or else they could be rightly killed by their victim's families
        - As long as they stayed in the city, they could remain alive
            - But they were isolated from family and the world forever
            - They were serving a sentence of life in prison
- From vs.18-27 we read a fascinating list of personal injury law, and the general theme throughout is "do the right thing by your neighbor"
    - When you harm someone, make restitution
        - If you fight and hurt someone, you compensate then for what they lost
        - And you care for them until they are well again
        - Unless they die, in which case see v.13
- Then the Law lists other capital offenses
    - Striking parents and cursing parents was punishable by death
        - The Hebrew word for strike means to attack
        - Any attack against a parent was cause for death
            - Striking another adult carried a lessor penalty
        - There was no provision in Jewish law for treating minors differently than adults
            - If the child was mature enough to attack a parent in a deadly way, then he was old enough to pay the penalty
            - We can safely assume that these penalties were effective in discouraging such crimes
        - And kidnapping punished by death

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- We can see how man's penalties for these offenses have eroded from where God established them
    - Perhaps this is why Paul says in 2Tim 3 that the last days will experience an outbreak of unprecedented evil including "disobedience to parents"
    - When Paul includes disobedience to parents in the same list as unholy, treacherous, haters of good, brutal, and others, then we know how serious the Lord views disobedience to parents

- In v.20-21, the rights of injured slaves is covered
    - Slaves couldn't be murdered but they could be disciplined by the master for rebellion or criminal acts
        - If the discipline resulted in immediate death, the master was punished like any other murderer
        - If the person doesn't die right away, then law looked upon the injuries differently
            - The master's penalty would only be loss of the slave
            - The presumption is that the master hadn't intend to kill his slave, or else he would have died right away
            - So the master's mistake is paid for in the loss of his servant
    - Remember, slaves became property of the master because they had entered into the arrangement voluntarily
        - Also, remember that Jesus Himself used the picture of slave to explain our relationship to Christ

Luke 12:42 And the Lord said, "Who then is the faithful and sensible steward, whom his master will put in charge of his servants, to give them their rations at the proper time?
Luke 12:43 "Blessed is that slave whom his master finds so doing when he comes.
Luke 12:44 "Truly I say to you that he will put him in charge of all his possessions.
Luke 12:45 "But if that slave says in his heart, 'My master will be a long time in coming,' and begins to beat the slaves, both men and women, and to eat and drink and get drunk;
Luke 12:46 the master of that slave will come on a day when he does not expect him and at an hour he does not know, and will cut him in pieces, and assign him a place with the unbelievers.

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Luke 12:47 "And that slave who knew his master's will and did not get ready or act in accord with his will, will receive many lashes,
Luke 12:48 but the one who did not know it, and committed deeds worthy of a flogging, will receive but few. From everyone who has been given much, much will be required; and to whom they entrusted much, of him they will ask all the more.

- Before we judge God's word for its willingness to accommodate slavery in scripture, consider that He allowed the institution so that we might have an accurate picture of our relationship with Him
  - WIthout the institution of slavery, we would struggle to understand how bound we are to Christ
  - And how we are obligated to obey Him
  - And of what the penalties will be for disobedience

- In v.22 the law addresses the rights of a mother who is injured and forced to give birth prematurely
  - If the baby survives, the woman is compensated for the injury and the premature delivery
    - If the child is injured or dies, then a proportion punishment follows
      - If the child dies, the person is to die as well
      - If the child was injured, then the person was to lose use of a similar function in the body
    - The exact punishment was decided by the husband, but it must be approved by a judge
      - In all cases, a man guilty of injuring someone could avoid the physical punishment if they paid a ransom as explained in v.30
      - But either way, they lost something of value for taking something of value from the other
  - These rules on harm to unborn children give rise to a couple of interesting observations
    - First, an unborn baby has standing apart from his mother

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- The child is not considered an extensions of the woman's body
- The child is a separate life protected under law
- This counters arguments by abortion proponents that the unborn child is merely part of the woman's body until birth

- Secondly, if the baby is not delivered alive, the person causing the injury is guilty of murder

- The principle of proportion is summed up as "an eye for an eye"
  - This principle in the Law was intended to <u>limit</u> retribution, not encourage it
    - When someone is wronged, the wronged party should expect no more compensation than was lost in the injury
    - Masters how harm slaves lose their slave, for he is set free
    - Owners whose animals harm another person, lose their animal
      - And notice they don't get to enjoy the meat either
    - And if the owner knows the animal is dangerous and does nothing, then when it kills again the owner is guilty of murder and must pay a price
      - Either he dies himself
      - Or he pays a ransom as demanded
  - When negligence takes someone's property, you compensate them and you keep the property you damaged
    - But the compensation should not exceed what was lost
  - Our modern court system has lost this sense of proportion
    - We invented forms of loss like "pain and suffering" that the Law of God never recognizes
    - Life is full of pain and suffering, but demanding payment of a ransom doesn't erase the pain
    - Only if there was true loss was a payment required

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Exodus 22/23

- We continue studying Law in the section of ordinances, which is chapters 21-23
    - The section concerns the basic civil rights of Jewish society
        - Last time we covered the first chapter and the basic laws of life and property
        - Today we study chapters 22-23, which continue to address property rights, negligence, false testimony, and sundry issues of civil society
    - In fact, as you read through this list, consider that before this law was given to men, the nation of Israel lacked a comprehensive code of this type
        - While it's true that society in general was guided by law of the culture, this document is by far the most complete and ancient record of civil law in existence
        - And since it is God's law, it should be no surprise that modern law finds its roots in this law
            - Although in many ways we have departed from these principles
            - And as we have departed, we have diminished the value of what's provided

Ex. 22:1 "If a man steals an ox or a sheep and slaughters it or sells it, he shall pay five oxen for the ox and four sheep for the sheep.
Ex. 22:2 "If the thief is caught while breaking in and is struck so that he dies, there will be no bloodguiltiness on his account.
Ex. 22:3 "But if the sun has risen on him, there will be bloodguiltiness on his account. He shall surely make restitution; if he owns nothing, then he shall be sold for his theft.
Ex. 22:4 "If what he stole is actually found alive in his possession, whether an ox or a donkey or a sheep, he shall pay double.

- This section deals with the crimes of theft
    - When someone steals something, he will be required to pay back in a greater amount than he tried to take

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- If the animal is gone by the time the man is caught, then he owes 4 or 5 times as much as he took
- If the property is still in his possession, then the penalty is double
- If he can't afford the penalty, he was sold into slavery
    - Remember, slavery was a type in indentured servitude
    - So the person was working in slavery to pay off the debt
    - They wouldn't spend more than seven years in slavery
    - In that way, it was like a work release program

- The point of these penalties is to deter potential thieves from their crimes
    - If you stand to lose more than you gain, then it should influence your thinking
        - This is an important principle in God's law and should be a part of any effective law
        - The purpose of law is to expose and convict people of their sin
        - And to be effective in that regard, law must require a penalty significant enough to cause men to think twice before sinning

Rom. 13:1 **Every person is to be in subjection to the governing authorities. For there is no authority except from God, and those which exist are established by God.**
Rom. 13:2 **Therefore whoever resists authority has opposed the ordinance of God; and they who have opposed will receive condemnation upon themselves.**
Rom. 13:3 **For rulers are not a cause of fear for good behavior, but for evil. Do you want to have no fear of authority? Do what is good and you will have praise from the same;**
Rom. 13:4 **for it is a minister of God to you for good. But if you do what is evil, be afraid; for it does not bear the sword for nothing; for it is a minister of God, an avenger who brings wrath on the one who practices evil.**

    - The governing authorities are to be respected, Paul says, because the Lord has invested government with the power to punish
        - In fact, God gave government the right to take life if needed so that bad men might have an incentive to control their worst instincts

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        - That power should instill fear in men, and in so doing, society is better off
            - Obviously, government can become abusive and corrupt and harmful, because all government is administered by sinful men
            - But God is control of all government rulers
            - And we are told to respect government as a representative of God, at least until it comes into conflict with God's law
        - But if government is to play that role effectively, it must exact a price for sin that inhibits such acts
        - In this case, the price is pretty steep
            - If you steal, you lose as much as you tried to take
            - If you steal and deny the man the chance to recover his property, you will give at least four times as much

- But then the law goes further to disincentivize theft
    - In v.2 the law says that if the thief is caught breaking into a house in the night and he is caught in the act and killed by the property owner, his killer is guiltless
        - A property owner may defend his property with lethal force when in his home
        - But if the sun rises, and then the thief is caught at a later point, the property owner can't commit vigilante justice
            - The man may not be killed
    - The idea is that one who breaks into a house at night has a reasonable expectation of confronting the owner and presumably intended to harm him
        - So the killing is self-defense, and self-defense is a justified killing
        - In Texas today, we have exactly this same law
            - It's called the Castle Doctrine

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- If someone enters a home, they can be killed and the homeowner will not be charged

- The next section addresses property crimes of negligence or malfeasance

Ex. 22:5 "If a man lets a field or vineyard be grazed bare and lets his animal loose so that it grazes in another man's field, he shall make restitution from the best of his own field and the best of his own vineyard.
Ex. 22:6 "If a fire breaks out and spreads to thorn bushes, so that stacked grain or the standing grain or the field itself is consumed, he who started the fire shall surely make restitution.
Ex. 22:7 "If a man gives his neighbor money or goods to keep for him and it is stolen from the man's house, if the thief is caught, he shall pay double.
Ex. 22:8 "If the thief is not caught, then the owner of the house shall appear before the judges, to determine whether he laid his hands on his neighbor's property.
Ex. 22:9 "For every breach of trust, whether it is for ox, for donkey, for sheep, for clothing, or for any lost thing about which one says, 'This is it,' the case of both parties shall come before the judges; he whom the judges condemn shall pay double to his neighbor.
Ex. 22:10 "If a man gives his neighbor a donkey, an ox, a sheep, or any animal to keep for him, and it dies or is hurt or is driven away while no one is looking,
Ex. 22:11 an oath before the LORD shall be made by the two of them that he has not laid hands on his neighbor's property; and its owner shall accept it, and he shall not make restitution.
Ex. 22:12 "But if it is actually stolen from him, he shall make restitution to its owner.
Ex. 22:13 "If it is all torn to pieces, let him bring it as evidence; he shall not make restitution for what has been torn to pieces.
Ex. 22:14 "If a man borrows anything from his neighbor, and it is injured or dies while its owner is not with it, he shall make full restitution.
Ex. 22:15 "If its owner is with it, he shall not make restitution; if it is hired, it came for its hire.

- In this section, you can see the Lord's desire to emphasize responsibility, fairness and accountability

    - Men are to uphold their responsibilities to protect another man's property

        - If you damage his property through negligence or malfeasance, then you make restitution

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        - But if you are not culpable, then fairness dictates that you suffer no loss

    - These principles are best summed up as "love your neighbor as yourself"

        - Jesus said that this is one of the tenets upon which hang the entire Law

        - The Law sought to demonstrate a sense of love for other people

            - While it discusses how to handle theft or loss of farm animals, the same principles are true for any other situation

            - Borrowing a neighbors tools

            - Damaging a neighbor's fence

        - So when you reflect on Jesus' words, here in the Law we have tangible examples of what that looks like

    - Once again, notice there are consequences for failing to do the right thing under the Law

        - And we know today there are consequences in our nations' laws for damaging another's property, etc.

        - But what about our consequences with the Lord?

            - Since Christians are not under the OT Law, how does the Lord respond to us when we don't show love to our neighbors?

            - Are there consequences for failing to live up to this standard in the Law of Christ?

- In Hebrews, we're reminded that the Father will discipline His children when we fail to exhibit righteousness

Heb. 12:5 and you have forgotten the exhortation which is addressed to you as sons,
| "MY SON, DO NOT REGARD LIGHTLY THE DISCIPLINE OF THE LORD,
NOR FAINT WHEN YOU ARE REPROVED BY HIM;
Heb. 12:6 FOR THOSE WHOM THE LORD LOVES HE DISCIPLINES,
| AND HE SCOURGES EVERY SON WHOM HE RECEIVES."
Heb. 12:7 It is for discipline that you endure; God deals with you as with sons; for what son is there whom his father does not discipline?

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Heb. 12:8 But if you are without discipline, of which all have become partakers, then you are illegitimate children and not sons.
Heb. 12:9 Furthermore, we had earthly fathers to discipline us, and we respected them; shall we not much rather be subject to the Father of spirits, and live?
Heb. 12:10 For they disciplined us for a short time as seemed best to them, but He disciplines us for our good, so that we may share His holiness.
Heb. 12:11 All discipline for the moment seems not to be joyful, but sorrowful; yet to those who have been trained by it, afterwards it yields the peaceful fruit of righteousness.

- The writer says as children of God, we must expect to receive His discipline at times
  - If it were otherwise, we would would not be His sons truly
  - Just as a stranger cannot discipline another person's child, nor does God discipline those who are not His children
- Discipline is a corrective measure intended to compel obedience and deter future acts of disobedience
  - The unbeliever does not receive discipline
  - Instead, they will receive God's wrath in the day of judgment
- And that writer goes further to say that if believers are determined to disobey the Lord, the penalties under the Law of Christ are significant

Heb. 10:26 For if we go on sinning willfully after receiving the knowledge of the truth, there no longer remains a sacrifice for sins,
Heb. 10:27 but a terrifying expectation of judgment and THE FURY OF A FIRE WHICH WILL CONSUME THE ADVERSARIES.
Heb. 10:28 Anyone who has set aside the Law of Moses dies without mercy on the testimony of two or three witnesses.
Heb. 10:29 How much severer punishment do you think he will deserve who has trampled under foot the Son of God, and has regarded as unclean the blood of the covenant by which he was sanctified, and has insulted the Spirit of grace?
Heb. 10:30 For we know Him who said, "VENGEANCE IS MINE, I WILL REPAY." And again, " THE LORD WILL JUDGE HIS PEOPLE."
Heb. 10:31 It is a terrifying thing to fall into the hands of the living God.

- Willful sinning has remedy in the New Covenant
  - There are no temple sacrifices available to appease God

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- We remain exposed to His discipline

- And if the Law handed out a penalty of physical death for the one who violated the lessor Law of Moses, then what should we expect if we insult the Spirit of grace?

  - The writer offers only one thought: the Lord will judge His people

  - And it's a terrifying thing to face His judgment

- While this judgment is not a matter of salvation, it still has consequences and we must concerns ourselves with its outcome

Ex. 22:16 "If a man seduces a virgin who is not engaged, and lies with her, he must pay a dowry for her to be his wife.
Ex. 22:17 "If her father absolutely refuses to give her to him, he shall pay money equal to the dowry for virgins.

- Now the laws become increasingly general

  - We move away from crimes against an individual and toward crimes against the society at large

    - In this case, the crime was against another family

    - A daughter who has seduced has been defiled and is no longer considered fit for marriage

      - So in a sense, her father has lost the ability to gain a dowry for her

      - And so he is due a dowry

    - And the man must do the right thing by the woman and marry her

      - Yet the man must still have the father's permission

      - But if the father refuses, then the other man still pays the dowry anyway

  - This law makes abundantly clear that God's expectation is that men and women save their purity for marriage

    - And if that purity is given away before marriage vows are spoken, then the next best thing is to marry the partner

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Ex. 22:18 "You shall not allow a sorceress to live.
Ex. 22:19 "Whoever lies with an animal shall surely be put to death.
Ex. 22:20 "He who sacrifices to any god, other than to the LORD alone, shall be utterly destroyed.

- Next, the Lord condemns anyone who practices these particular practices
    - Each of these practices finds its source directly in the occult and the demonic world
        - Practicing black magic or sorcery is channeling the enemy's power, which demands death
        - Unnatural sexual behavior is an offense to the sanctity of procreation and God's purposes through it, and is abhorrent
            - Some pagan peoples practiced bestiality in their worship of false gods
        - And sacrificing anything to false gods is worshipping Satan and must be ended
            - In fact, this law provides for a penalty even more severe than it sounds
            - The word for destroyed in Hebrew literally means to be banned
            - It means that the person was untouchable and must be destroyed utterly
                - We see this same judgment applied to the city of Jericho
                - Not only were the people put to death, but everything in the city was to be destroyed
                - Except one of the men disobeyed the ban judgment

Josh. 7:1 But the sons of Israel acted unfaithfully in regard to the things under the ban, for Achan, the son of Carmi, the son of Zabdi, the son of Zerah, from the tribe of Judah, took some of the things under the ban, therefore the anger of the LORD burned against the sons of Israel.

- Ban judgment was the command of God for idol worshippers

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- These practices were often associated with the worst periods in Israel's history
    - They are barometers of the heart of the people
    - When depravity of this nature is accepted in the culture, it reflects the strength of the enemy's hold and the extent to which the people have abandoned the Lord
    - Therefore, the death penalty is an appropriate punishment to place a restraint on the enemy's influence in the culture

Ex. 22:21 "You shall not wrong a stranger or oppress him, for you were strangers in the land of Egypt.
Ex. 22:22 "You shall not afflict any widow or orphan.
Ex. 22:23 "If you afflict him at all, and if he does cry out to Me, I will surely hear his cry;
Ex. 22:24 and My anger will be kindled, and I will kill you with the sword, and your wives shall become widows and your children fatherless.
Ex. 22:25 "If you lend money to My people, to the poor among you, you are not to act as a creditor to him; you shall not charge him interest.
Ex. 22:26 "If you ever take your neighbor's cloak as a pledge, you are to return it to him before the sun sets,
Ex. 22:27 for that is his only covering; it is his cloak for his body. What else shall he sleep in? And it shall come about that when he cries out to Me, I will hear him, for I am gracious.

- These ordinances address the needs of the vulnerable and defenseless in Jewish society
    - A stranger refers to an immigrant or someone who is wandering through the land of Israel
        - This person must receive respect
        - Though he or she might not be Jewish, nonetheless they deserve the respect common to all people
        - And the Lord reminds Israel what it was like to be a wanderer in Egypt and to be oppressed
            - Therefore, don't repeat the sins that were brought against you
    - Widows and orphans must not be oppressed, which means they must be taken advantage of

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- Since these groups are defenseless in Jewish society, the Lord promises to be their defender
    - He promises to take the lives of their oppressors so that their wives become widows and their children become orphans

- This law reveals an important principle of scripture concerning our relationship with the Lord
    - He is our defender and will bring justice in His timing and according to His purposes
    - Notice He doesn't promise to prevent oppression of widows and orphans directly
        - They might suffer injustice from time to time, but the Lord promises to be watching
        - And when the injustice takes place, He will respond against the oppressor but in His own timing

Rom. 12:17 **Never pay back evil for evil to anyone. Respect what is right in the sight of all men.**
Rom. 12:18 **If possible, so far as it depends on you, be at peace with all men.**
Rom. 12:19 **Never take your own revenge, beloved, but leave room for the wrath of God, for it is written, "VENGEANCE IS MINE, I WILL REPAY," says the Lord.**
Rom. 12:20 **"BUT IF YOUR ENEMY IS HUNGRY, FEED HIM, AND IF HE IS THIRSTY, GIVE HIM A DRINK; FOR IN SO DOING YOU WILL HEAP BURNING COALS ON HIS HEAD."**

- Paul taught from the same Biblical principle when he said we should never repay evil with evil
    - And breaking the peace with other men, even with those who harm us, is an evil in God's sight
    - Leave room for the vengeance of God
- If we remain innocent, we give God room to bring judgment
    - But if we break the peace and bring our own sin into the equation, we circumvent the justice of God
    - This doesn't preclude self-defense

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- Then in v.25 Israel is commanded not to charge interest of one another when lending money
  - The point was to prevent Israel from profiting from the misfortune of another
    - Interest could be charged of Gentiles however
  - The Jews found a way around the letter of this law through other means, like over charging for goods bought on credit, etc.
  - The heart attitude is the key here: don't take advantage of another person's need
- Likewise, if a man gives up his outer garment as a pledge of repayment, then mercy must be shown
  - That garment was also the man's warmth at night, so he must not be denied it
    - The man denied his cloak would be at the mercy of the other man
    - And he would be in a vulnerable position and could be forced into accepting unreasonable terms
  - The point here is that any unfair advantage that could leave one man enslaved so to speak to another was to be avoided
    - God had freed Israel from slavery
    - So he didn't want the nation to enslave itself one man to another in these way
  - God promises to punish those who take advantage of other Jews in this way

- Finally, injustice against higher stations of Jewish society

Ex. 22:28 "You shall not curse God, nor curse a ruler of your people.
Ex. 22:29 "You shall not delay the offering from your harvest and your vintage. The firstborn of your sons you shall give to Me.
Ex. 22:30 "You shall do the same with your oxen and with your sheep. It shall be with its mother seven days; on the eighth day you shall give it to Me.
Ex. 22:31 "You shall be holy men to Me, therefore you shall not eat any flesh torn to pieces in the field; you shall throw it to the dogs.

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- In v.28, God demands respect for both Himself and for the rulers He places over Israel
    - This law has a direct parallel in the New Testament Law of Christ as well

1Pet. 2:13 **Submit yourselves for the Lord's sake to every human institution, whether to a king as the one in authority,**
1Pet. 2:14 **or to governors as sent by him for the punishment of evildoers and the praise of those who do right.**
1Pet. 2:15 **For such is the will of God that by doing right you may silence the ignorance of foolish men.**

        - The command to respect and obey leaders is not conditional on their worthiness to receive such respect
        - The Lord demands it irrespective of they personal behavior, because all human rulers reach their positions of power according to the Lord's will and hand
    - He places all rulers into power and they serve according to His purposes
        - Sometimes good rulers enter power and sometimes evil rulers reign
        - And God is working His plan through all of them
        - So if we resist a leader, we are resisting God's will, as Paul said in Romans

Rom. 13:2 **Therefore whoever resists authority has opposed the ordinance of God; and they who have opposed will receive condemnation upon themselves.**

- Finally, the Lord reminds Israel to keep the commandment of the first fruits, both of sons and animals and to avoid eating meat torn by a beast
    - These sundry laws continue into chapter 23

Ex. 23:1 **"You shall not bear a false report; do not join your hand with a wicked man to be a malicious witness.**
Ex. 23:2 **"You shall not follow the masses in doing evil, nor shall you testify in a dispute so as to turn aside after a multitude in order to pervert justice;**
Ex. 23:3 **nor shall you be partial to a poor man in his dispute.**
Ex. 23:4 **"If you meet your enemy's ox or his donkey wandering away, you shall surely return it to him.**

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Ex. 23:5 "If you see the donkey of one who hates you lying helpless under its load, you shall refrain from leaving it to him, you shall surely release it with him.
Ex. 23:6 "You shall not pervert the justice due to your needy brother in his dispute.
Ex. 23:7 "Keep far from a false charge, and do not kill the innocent or the righteous, for I will not acquit the guilty.
Ex. 23:8 "You shall not take a bribe, for a bribe blinds the clear-sighted and subverts the cause of the just.
Ex. 23:9 "You shall not oppress a stranger, since you yourselves know the feelings of a stranger, for you also were strangers in the land of Egypt.

- The theme in this section is in preserving justice
    - Act in accordance with truth and fairness
        - In repeating the first commandments, the Lord reminds Israel not to bear a false report or perjure oneself
        - And don't enter into a conspiracy
        - Moreover, don't follow the masses when they desire to do evil
            - We don't determine the right path based on it's popularity
            - In fact, given the sinful nature of flesh, any crowd should be
        - And when judging disputes between men, don't give an unfair advantage to a poor man simply because he is poor
    - Lost animals are to be returned and animals in distress are to be relieved of the stress
        - And in the spirit of justice, the Lord layers additional regulation on Israel in vs.4-5
        - They are to act in kindness and mercy for the sake of justice even when doing so means coming to the aid of one who is their enemy
        - We cannot use as an excuse for not being merciful the fact that someone has made themselves our enemy
    - In vs.7-9 the Lord once again commands men not to pervert justice by promoting injustice, oppression or by taking innocent life

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Ex. 23:10 "You shall sow your land for six years and gather in its yield,
Ex. 23:11 but on the seventh year you shall let it rest and lie fallow, so that the needy of your people may eat; and whatever they leave the beast of the field may eat. You are to do the same with your vineyard and your olive grove.
Ex. 23:12 "Six days you are to do your work, but on the seventh day you shall cease from labor so that your ox and your donkey may rest, and the son of your female slave, as well as your stranger, may refresh themselves.

- These verses were a command to give land rest every seventh year
    - This command is explained more fulling in Leviticus and repeated in Deuteronomy, and it provides for good husbandry of the land
        - Crops grow better when the land is given a chance to rest and replace the depleted nutrients in the soil
        - Crop rotation is still a practice today, though fertilizers have reduced the need
    - In this case, the purpose was also spiritual
        - Resting on the seventh year is tied to resting on the seventh day
        - The Lord took a Sabbath, as we learned in chapter 20, so He offers Christians the opportunity to enter in His rest by faith
        - In the meantime, the Jews were to observe a shadow in the form of a once a week rest
            - And the land was to participate in that shadow by observing a rest every seventh year
    - How would Israel have food in that seventh year?
        - As with the manna, the Lord would make a double provision available in the sixth year to hold the nation over through the seventh year
        - So no farming would be required in the seventh year
- At a point in Israel's history, the Jews decided to disobey this law and farm continuously through the seventh year
    - They enjoyed the benefit of having the double sixth year harvest plus still having a seventh year harvest as well

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- This was an act of greed and a disobedient act under the law
- This practice went on for 490 years in Israel until the Lord decided to take retribution
    - He declared through Jeremiah that the nation would have to replay Him for the 70 sabbaths they skipped over the 490 years
- So He told them this:

Jer. 25:9 behold, I will send and take all the families of the north,' declares the LORD, 'and I will send to Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon, My servant, and will bring them against this land and against its inhabitants and against all these nations round about; and I will utterly destroy them and make them a horror and a hissing, and an everlasting desolation.
Jer. 25:10 'Moreover, I will take from them the voice of joy and the voice of gladness, the voice of the bridegroom and the voice of the bride, the sound of the millstones and the light of the lamp.
Jer. 25:11 'This whole land will be a desolation and a horror, and these nations will serve the king of Babylon seventy years.
Jer. 25:12 'Then it will be when seventy years are completed I will punish the king of Babylon and that nation,' declares the LORD, 'for their iniquity, and the land of the Chaldeans; and I will make it an everlasting desolation.

- Then it came to pass in 2 Chr 36

2Chr. 36:11 Zedekiah was twenty-one years old when he became king, and he reigned eleven years in Jerusalem.
2Chr. 36:12 He did evil in the sight of the LORD his God; he did not humble himself before Jeremiah the prophet who spoke for the LORD.
2Chr. 36:13 He also rebelled against King Nebuchadnezzar who had made him swear allegiance by God. But he stiffened his neck and hardened his heart against turning to the LORD God of Israel.
2Chr. 36:14 Furthermore, all the officials of the priests and the people were very unfaithful following all the abominations of the nations; and they defiled the house of the LORD which He had sanctified in Jerusalem.
2Chr. 36:15 The LORD, the God of their fathers, sent word to them again and again by His messengers, because He had compassion on His people and on His dwelling place;
2Chr. 36:16 but they continually mocked the messengers of God, despised His words and scoffed at His prophets, until the wrath of the LORD arose against His people, until there was no remedy.

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2Chr. 36:17 Therefore He brought up against them the king of the Chaldeans who slew their young men with the sword in the house of their sanctuary, and had no compassion on young man or virgin, old man or infirm; He gave them all into his hand.
2Chr. 36:18 All the articles of the house of God, great and small, and the treasures of the house of the LORD, and the treasures of the king and of his officers, he brought them all to Babylon.
2Chr. 36:19 Then they burned the house of God and broke down the wall of Jerusalem, and burned all its fortified buildings with fire and destroyed all its valuable articles.
2Chr. 36:20 Those who had escaped from the sword he carried away to Babylon; and they were servants to him and to his sons until the rule of the kingdom of Persia,
2Chr. 36:21 to fulfill the word of the LORD by the mouth of Jeremiah, until the land had enjoyed its sabbaths. All the days of its desolation it kept sabbath until seventy years were complete.

- Then we move into basic principles of worship and religious observance

Ex. 23:13 "Now concerning everything which I have said to you, be on your guard; and do not mention the name of other gods, nor let them be heard from your mouth.
Ex. 23:14 "Three times a year you shall celebrate a feast to Me.
Ex. 23:15 "You shall observe the Feast of Unleavened Bread; for seven days you are to eat unleavened bread, as I commanded you, at the appointed time in the month Abib, for in it you came out of Egypt. And none shall appear before Me empty-handed.
Ex. 23:16 "Also you shall observe the Feast of the Harvest of the first fruits of your labors from what you sow in the field; also the Feast of the Ingathering at the end of the year when you gather in the fruit of your labors from the field.
Ex. 23:17 "Three times a year all your males shall appear before the Lord GOD.
Ex. 23:18 "You shall not offer the blood of My sacrifice with leavened bread; nor is the fat of My feast to remain overnight until morning.
Ex. 23:19 "You shall bring the choice first fruits of your soil into the house of the LORD your God. "You are not to boil a young goat in the milk of its mother.

- The section on worship opens with the third warning against idol worship and continues to a discussion of three mandatory festivals all Jewish men must observe
    - The requirement was for adult males age 20 and higher
        - The first feast was Passover and Unleavened Bread
            - They must come with a sacrifice for the Passover, not empty handed

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        - The second feast was Pentecost or First Fruits or Weeks
        - The third is the feast of Tabernacles, which is at the fall harvest
    - These three festivals were mandatory for every male Jew
        - It required that they traveled to the Lord's appointed place
        - First it was Shiloh in the early years of Israel
        - Later it becomes Jerusalem under David
    - Why were these three festivals mandated?
        - The answer is because of their unique symbolism in God's prophetic plan
        - The feast of Israel are all prophetic shadows of coming events in the program of God's people
            - The Passover and Unleavened Bread picture Christ's sacrifice and the sanctification of the believer made possible by that sacrifice
            - The Feast of Pentecost is a shadow of the coming of the Spirit to God's people and the writing of the Law on their hearts
            - And the Feast of Booths is a shadow of the arrival of Christ at His Second Coming and the inauguration of His Kingdom
                - You may remember at the Transfiguration that the Apostles offered to set up booths for Jesus, Moses and Elijah
                - They thought the Kingdom had arrived, and therefore it was time to set up booths

- The animals used in the sacrifice must be handled in a certain way
    - Sacrifices can't be combined with leavened bread
        - Leaven is a picture of sin
        - For obvious reasons, God doesn't want a sacrifice for sin mixed with a symbol for sin

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- These laws are intended to reinforce and preserve the pictures God is intent on creating
    - In passing, doesn't it encourage you to see God working so diligently within Israel to preserve these symbols of His Son?
    - It's so clear that the Lord wanted Israel to become a living symbol of things to come
    - By their very lives, the people of Israel were a living, breathing billboard announcing God's plan of redemption through Christ
    - If you knew how to interpret the signs and symbols embedded within Israel, you could tell the entire Gospel story by these commandments
- As Jesus Himself did to the men on the road to Emmaus

Luke 24:25 **And He said to them, "O foolish men and slow of heart to believe in all that the prophets have spoken!**
Luke 24:26 **"Was it not necessary for the Christ to suffer these things and to enter into His glory?"**
Luke 24:27 **Then beginning with Moses and with all the prophets, He explained to them the things concerning Himself in all the Scriptures.**

- Secondly, the fat of these animals was to be entirely used up in the sacrifice
    - Nothing was to be withheld from God
    - The sacrifice was total
        - Picturing the way Christ gave up everything for Creation
- Thirdly, the Lord receives the first fruits, the best of the harvest
    - God gets the best, not what we don't want for ourselves
    - Only after the Lord receives what He deserves do we have our portion
        - Picturing the way the Lord gave up His Son first
        - And Christ was resurrected first

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- Making Him the first born of creation, Paul says

- Finally, the young goat cannot be boiled in the milk of it's own mother
  - This law is important and is repeated three times in the Law
  - The reason for its importance is that it was a common practice in Canaanite culture to do this very thing
    - A young goat was killed and then it's mother was milked
    - Then the baby goat was boiled in the mother's milk
    - It was an important part of the Canaanite worship practices
  - So the Lord forbids it three times because He knew Israel would be living around Canaanites
    - So He didn't want Israel to engage in any of the Canaanite worship practices
    - Therefore, He specifically forbids this particular type of worship practice
- The rabbis of Israel took this law took far (which was their practice in general) and set up numerous related restrictions to the point of absurdity
  - As a result of these pharisaical rules, observant Jews even to this day will not mix meat and dairy products
    - Cheeseburgers are forbidden to Jews under orthodox rules
    - And orthodox homes will maintain two sets of dishes, pots, and pans
      - One set is only used for meat
      - One set is used for dairy
      - The two are never mixed
      - And if they are mixed accidentally, the dish is buried and never used again
  - This shows the absurdity of men run away with God's law absent a correct understanding of its purpose in developing holiness

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- The original purpose was to protect Israel against a Canaanite worship practice
- It has become a set of unnecessarily restrictive laws that heap burdens on the pious Jew

- As Jesus said

Matt. 23:2 saying: "The scribes and the Pharisees have seated themselves in the chair of Moses;
Matt. 23:3 therefore all that they tell you, do and observe, but do not do according to their deeds; for they say things and do not do them.
Matt. 23:4 "They tie up heavy burdens and lay them on men's shoulders, but they themselves are unwilling to move them with so much as a finger.

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Exodus 24

- Finally, the Lord gives Israel promises and instructions concerning their conquest of the Promised Land

Ex. 23:20 "Behold, I am going to send an angel before you to guard you along the way and to bring you into the place which I have prepared.
Ex. 23:21 "Be on your guard before him and obey his voice; do not be rebellious toward him, for he will not pardon your transgression, since My name is in him.
Ex. 23:22 "But if you truly obey his voice and do all that I say, then I will be an enemy to your enemies and an adversary to your adversaries.
Ex. 23:23 "For My angel will go before you and bring you in to the land of the Amorites, the Hittites, the Perizzites, the Canaanites, the Hivites and the Jebusites; and I will completely destroy them.

- The Lord promises to deliver the people into the Land safely by means of His Angel
    - This Angel will lead Israel in the desert and into the Land
        - The Angel will protect Israel
        - And He will ensure that Israel will enter into the land as promised
            - In other words, the Angel will deliver them
    - Obedience to this Angel is absolutely imperative
        - In fact, if the nation doesn't obey the Angel fully, if they provoke Him (meaning rebel against Him), the Angel will not forgive them of this sin
        - And this Angel has the Lord's name in Him
            - This is tells us that the Angel is pre-incarnate Jesus
            - Jesus is the One in the Godhead to forgive sins and to have the name of God
    - So the Lord has sent His Son to lead Israel into the Promised Land
        - But if Israel rejects the Son's leadership, they will be judged and not forgiven
        - We know that in Numbers, this very thing happens

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- The nation is led to the edge of the Promised Land, but the people believe the false report of the spies concerning the Promised Land
- And they fail to believe in the Angel of the Lord, Who has led Israel to that moment according to God's promises
  - So Israel failed to trust in Jesus and failed to believe in God's promises
  - So that generation of Israel is judged and barred from entering the Land
  - An entire generation of Israel is barred from forgiveness and from entering the land

- Hebrews makes the following commentary on that moment

Heb. 3:12 Take care, brethren, that there not be in any one of you an evil, unbelieving heart that falls away from the living God.
Heb. 3:13 But encourage one another day after day, as long as it is still called "Today," so that none of you will be hardened by the deceitfulness of sin.
Heb. 3:14 For we have become partakers of Christ, if we hold fast the beginning of our assurance firm until the end,
Heb. 3:15 while it is said,
"TODAY IF YOU HEAR HIS VOICE,
DO NOT HARDEN YOUR HEARTS, AS WHEN THEY PROVOKED ME."
Heb. 3:16 For who provoked Him when they had heard? Indeed, did not all those who came out of Egypt led by Moses?
Heb. 3:17 And with whom was He angry for forty years? Was it not with those who sinned, whose bodies fell in the wilderness?
Heb. 3:18 And to whom did He swear that they would not enter His rest, but to those who were disobedient?
Heb. 3:19 So we see that they were not able to enter because of unbelief.

- This moment has an interesting parallel to later days
  - When Jesus came to Israel in His first coming, He told them that if they blasphemed the Holy Spirit, then that generation could not be saved
    - And when the nation saw Jesus perform miracles and prove Himself to be the Messiah yet called Him Satan, they committed that sin
    - And that generation was not forgiven, and apart from the church it was judged as well

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- And when Jesus comes again in His second coming, it will be for the Jews of Tribulation
  - And they will cry out for Jesus according to Zechariah 12
  - So the generation of Moses' day was judged in the desert for rejecting Jesus
  - And the generation of Jesus day was judged for rejecting Jesus
  - But a future generation will be rescued when they finally call out in faith as required
    - Only by faith in Jesus can one enter into the Promised Land

Ex. 23:24 "You shall not worship their gods, nor serve them, nor do according to their deeds; but you shall utterly overthrow them and break their sacred pillars in pieces.
Ex. 23:25 "But you shall serve the LORD your God, and He will bless your bread and your water; and I will remove sickness from your midst.
Ex. 23:26 "There shall be no one miscarrying or barren in your land; I will fulfill the number of your days.
Ex. 23:27 "I will send My terror ahead of you, and throw into confusion all the people among whom you come, and I will make all your enemies turn their backs to you.
Ex. 23:28 "I will send hornets ahead of you so that they will drive out the Hivites, the Canaanites, and the Hittites before you.
Ex. 23:29 "I will not drive them out before you in a single year, that the land may not become desolate and the beasts of the field become too numerous for you.
Ex. 23:30 "I will drive them out before you little by little, until you become fruitful and take possession of the land.
Ex. 23:31 "I will fix your boundary from the Red Sea to the sea of the Philistines, and from the wilderness to the River Euphrates; for I will deliver the inhabitants of the land into your hand, and you will drive them out before you.
Ex. 23:32 "You shall make no covenant with them or with their gods.
Ex. 23:33 "They shall not live in your land, because they will make you sin against Me; for if you serve their gods, it will surely be a snare to you."

- These are the promises the Lord gave the people concerning their entry into the Land
  - We know from Numbers that this generation never makes it into the land
    - Their disobedience to God's word stops them

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- But in these promises we see that the Lord had prepared to grant them easy entry into the land
    - All that was required of the people was faith in God's word to carry out what he promised

- The Lord promised if they serve the Lord and do not worship other gods, then the Lord will be their strength to overthrow and occupy the land
    - By His power, they will have the strength to displace the people in the land
    - And the people will have physical strength to withstand the rigors of the work
        - No one will miscarry
        - No one will be without children
    - And the Lord will ensure the inhabitants of the land will flee in the face of Israel's advance
        - Like hornets that cause people to flee in fear, the Canaanites will run from the advancing Israelites
        - Israel will not even have to fight a battle
        - We can see the Lord's power to fulfill this promise in the story of Jericho
- The pace of this advance will be purposely slow and methodical
    - The land will not be vacated too quickly so that the land will not be injured by the lack of caretakers
    - The exiting people are plowing fields and restraining wild animals
    - This is a blessing to Israel that the land would not be abandoned too quickly
    - But this slow advance should not be interpreted to mean that the Lord was incapable of finishing the job
        - It means Israel shouldn't give up or lose heart
        - Allow the Lord the time to finish the work

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- Unfortunately, the people of Israel did lose heart and become distracted
  - They decided to settle in and live among the people in the land
  - They compromised and violated God's commands

- Finally, notice the boundary of the Land promised to Israel
  - The boundaries are much larger than any land Israel has ever held
    - They stretch from the Mediterranean Sea to modern day Iraq
    - And up to Damascus in the north
    - We learn in Joshua that the land extends in the south to the Brook of Egypt
  - Since this is a territory Israel has never held, then we know they are still to obtain it
    - The Lord's word cannot go out and not be fulfilled
    - So the this region will someday in the future belong to Israel
    - In that future day, the people of Israel will be able to keep the Lord's command to follow Him in their whole heart
      - That will be the glorified Israel that enters the Kingdom

- Thus ends the ordinances of the Law
  - Now having delivered the ordinances of the Law, the next division of the book of Exodus is about to begin
    - And it starts with the official covenant ceremony that brings the nation of Israel and the Lord into a power covenant

Ex. 24:1 Then He said to Moses, "Come up to the LORD, you and Aaron, Nadab and Abihu and seventy of the elders of Israel, and you shall worship at a distance.
Ex. 24:2 "Moses alone, however, shall come near to the LORD, but they shall not come near, nor shall the people come up with him."
Ex. 24:3 Then Moses came and recounted to the people all the words of the LORD and all the ordinances; and all the people answered with one voice and said, "All the words which the LORD has spoken we will do!"
Ex. 24:4 Moses wrote down all the words of the LORD. Then he arose early in the morning, and built an altar at the foot of the mountain with twelve pillars for the twelve tribes of Israel.

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Ex. 24:5 He sent young men of the sons of Israel, and they offered burnt offerings and sacrificed young bulls as peace offerings to the LORD.
Ex. 24:6 Moses took half of the blood and put it in basins, and the other half of the blood he sprinkled on the altar.
Ex. 24:7 Then he took the book of the covenant and read it in the hearing of the people; and they said, "All that the LORD has spoken we will do, and we will be obedient!"
Ex. 24:8 So Moses took the blood and sprinkled it on the people, and said, "Behold the blood of the covenant, which the LORD has made with you in accordance with all these words."

- In v.1, the Lord commands Moses to return up the mountain to meet with the Lord again
    - This will be the fourth time Moses has been called up to meet with the Lord
        - God calls for Moses to be accompanied by the seventy elders of Israel and Aaron and Aaron's two oldest sons
            - These additional men serve as witnesses
        - They were chosen for specific reasons
            - The seventy elders represent the people
            - As representatives, they can speak for the people and bind them in this covenant
        - Aaron are the beginning of the priesthood of Israel
            - They will be called to officiate in the tabernacle
            - And they will oversee the sacrificial system of the Law
            - Therefore, they are the agents of Israel to carry out the Law on behalf of the people
        - And they are present to serve as the first in an unbroken line of Israel to testify to the covenant
            - Even today, the only tribe of Israel we can still identify in the culture are descendants of Levi, the priestly tribe
            - Their names are the key to their identity: Levy, Levin, Levinson, Cohen, Kohn, etc.
            - These are Levite names

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- During the Tribulation to come, the tabernacle and sacrificial system will be reestablished according to this covenant
- And the priesthood will reemerge among the descendants of Levi

- So they are witnesses to the agreement along with Moses

- But Moses serves an unique role in Israel, since only Moses can approach the Lord

- We've watches as Moses has moved back and forth between the nation of Israel and the Lord in the cloud
- This moving back and forth from God to the people and back communicates through action that Moses was the mediator
  - God required the people to work through the services of a mediator
  - God would talk to Moses and Moses would talk to the people
- God worked through this restriction to teach men a lesson about how men obtain a relationship with God
  - Man's sin creates a necessary barrier between himself and the Lord, one man cannot cross by himself
  - He must have a mediator to bridge the distance
- Notice in v.2 that only Moses may come near to the Lord
  - Men may know of God and that He exists
  - Men may see physical manifestations of His presence and power, just as Israel saw in Egypt
  - And men may even hear from Him
  - But men may not come near to God, whether physically or spiritually, apart from a mediator

- Before Moses and the other men approach the Lord to worship, Moses first goes to the people in v.3 and delivers the entire words of the ordinances

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- At this point, the people all spoke as if with one voice declaring they will do all the words the Lord has spoken
    - With this declaration, the nation is committed to keep the Covenant at Sinai, which also included the Law
    - As we've discussed before, the people couldn't keep their own word, and so the penalties of the covenant were assured
    - But at this point, it has been established
        - And it is established for this generation and all generations to come in Israel
        - It is a covenant with a nation of people, not with a certain group of people
        - All who are born into that nation are already party to the covenant
- Now comes time to seal the covenant with a traditional ritual
    - First, the covenant is recorded
    - Secondly, Moses builds an altar and stands up twelve pillars
        - The pillars represent the twelve tribes of Israel
    - And as we discussed earlier, an altar has only one purpose
        - It is a place of sacrifice
        - So Moses is preparing to make a sacrifice
    - Covenants were agreements established in blood
        - The symbology of the blood was that a life has been poured out to establish this covenant
        - And should either party break this covenant, a life will be taken
    - Furthermore, the blood is applied to each person, marking them to indicate their agreement in the terms of the covenant
        - In the Abrahamic Covenant, the Lord alone moved through the blood

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- Showing that only the Lord was binding Himself to the terms of that covenant
- But in this scene, both Israel and the altar are sprinkled with the blood
- The people are obligated to keep their part, and the Lord is obligated, as signified by the place of worship

- Finally, once more Moses reads the covenant to the people
  - And once more, they agree to all that was written
  - And Moses declares that by this blood, the people have entered into a covenantal relationship with the Lord

- In this scene, we can find some powerful and important pictures of the covenant that God later brings to Israel and the Church in Christ
  - And the definitive commentary on this moment are found in the book of Hebrews

Heb. 9:11 But when Christ appeared as a high priest of the good things to come, He entered through the greater and more perfect tabernacle, not made with hands, that is to say, not of this creation;
Heb. 9:12 and not through the blood of goats and calves, but through His own blood, He entered the holy place once for all, having obtained eternal redemption.
Heb. 9:13 For if the blood of goats and bulls and the ashes of a heifer sprinkling those who have been defiled sanctify for the cleansing of the flesh,
Heb. 9:14 how much more will the blood of Christ, who through the eternal Spirit offered Himself without blemish to God, cleanse your conscience from dead works to serve the living God?
Heb. 9:15 For this reason He is the mediator of a new covenant, so that, since a death has taken place for the redemption of the transgressions that were committed under the first covenant, those who have been called may receive the promise of the eternal inheritance.
Heb. 9:16 For where a covenant is, there must of necessity be the death of the one who made it.
Heb. 9:17 For a covenant is valid only when men are dead, for it is never in force while the one who made it lives.
Heb. 9:18 Therefore even the first covenant was not inaugurated without blood.
Heb. 9:19 For when every commandment had been spoken by Moses to all the people according to the Law, he took the blood of the calves and the goats, with water and scarlet wool and hyssop, and sprinkled both the book itself and all the people,
Heb. 9:20 saying, "THIS IS THE BLOOD OF THE COVENANT WHICH GOD COMMANDED YOU."

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- For a complete explanation of this passage, I would direct you to our Hebrews study, but let's address a few points as they apply to Exodus 24
    - First, the writer draws a comparison between Moses and Christ as mediators of covenants
        - Moses' role as mediator was to bridge a physical gap between the people and the Lord
            - Moses went up the mountain to meet with God
            - And then he went back down to meet the people
        - How did the people gain the benefit of Moses' mediation?
            - First, Moses connected the people to God
            - He carried the people's agreement up to God
            - And he carried the Lord's assurances back to the people
        - Secondly, invited them into making a confession of agreement with the word of God
            - Moses commanded the people that if they agreed to the covenant, than they must keep the Law to be righteous
            - If they violated the Law, then they would have broken the covenant and would be judged unrighteous
            - And the people said they would obey all that the Lord spoke
            - Then they were joined with the Lord in a covenant
        - Lastly, Moses sprinkled both parties with blood, establishing the agreement in blood and giving it force
            - Moses applied the blood to both the people and the altar on earth, making the agreement binding on both
    - God intentionally chose a mountain on which to appear to the people, so that the imagery of separation of height and distance would be present
        - The Lord could have appeared to men on a flat plain
        - But the mountain served to reinforce the truth that men need a mediator to reach God Who is in Heaven

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- So it became apparent to all the people that Moses was a mediator who bridged a physical gap between God and Israel in order to form this covenant of Law
- But Moses couldn't bridge the spiritual gap that separates men and God
  - Moses couldn't go up to Heaven and sacrifice in the Heavenly tabernacle
  - That would require an even greater Mediator
    - Someone Who could pass the test of sinlessness required to enter that Holy Place

- So Hebrews tells us that Jesus acted as our Mediator for this greater covenant
  - How did we gain the benefit of Jesus' mediation?
    - First, He descended to earth to deliver the news of the covenant to the people
      - He traveled the distance from God's Heavenly place, where the Heavenly temple reside
      - Where a Heavenly altar has been established
      - Where the blood of much greater sacrifice can be applied
      - And then this Mediator made the trip back to the right hand of the Father to serve as our intercessor
      - As Paul explained

Eph. 4:8 Therefore it says,
"WHEN HE ASCENDED ON HIGH,
HE LED CAPTIVE A HOST OF CAPTIVES,
AND HE GAVE GIFTS TO MEN."
Eph. 4:9 (Now this expression, "He ascended," what does it mean except that He also had descended into the lower parts of the earth?
Eph. 4:10 He who descended is Himself also He who ascended far above all the heavens, so that He might fill all things.)

- So Jesus fulfilled the picture of a mediator moving between God on high and the people below

  - Secondly, the Lord delivers our agreement to the covenant

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- But unlike Moses, the Lord serves that purpose in a unique way
- Moses had to travel up to God and then back to men to complete the communication process
- But Jesus is the Word and His Spirit lives in us, so the process for us to communicate our agreement with the covenant is so simple, many people over look it

Rom. 10:5 For Moses writes that the man who practices the righteousness which is based on law shall live by that righteousness.
Rom. 10:6 But the righteousness based on faith speaks as follows: "DO NOT SAY IN YOUR HEART, 'WHO WILL ASCEND INTO HEAVEN?' (that is, to bring Christ down),
Rom. 10:7 or 'WHO WILL DESCEND INTO THE ABYSS?' (that is, to bring Christ up from the dead)."
Rom. 10:8 But what does it say? "THE WORD IS NEAR YOU, IN YOUR MOUTH AND IN YOUR HEART" – that is, the word of faith which we are preaching,
Rom. 10:9 that if you confess with your mouth Jesus as Lord, and believe in your heart that God raised Him from the dead, you will be saved;

- Can you see more clearly what Paul is talking about now in Romans 10?
  - He is refering to Moses' role as a mediator going up to God and coming back down to the people
  - In that earlier covenant, righteousness was defined as living the law perfectly
  - But in the New Covenant, righteousness is defined as faith alone
  - And Paul says we join in this new covenant not by seeking someone to enter Heaven or descend into Hell for us
    - That has already been done once for all men
  - So now we gain the benefit of Christ's mediation simply by a confession of our mouth
    - We enter the New Covenant through a Word that is near to us
    - By Christ, we are near to God already
    - We only need to say the word of faith and we enter the covenant
- Finally, Christ's blood enacted the covenant

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- Notice that a covenant (or testament, also called a will) is not in effect until the death of the One who makes it
    - Our Last WIll and Testament doesn't go into effect until we die
    - So the New Covenant (or new testament) required a a shedding of blood before it took effect
- Jesus' blood was sprinkled on the Heavenly tabernacle altar when Christ ascended
- Secondly, that blood is applied to us by the baptism of the Holy Spirit
    - And we re-enact that application of blood in the Lord's Supper observance

John 6:53 So Jesus said to them, "Truly, truly, I say to you, unless you eat the flesh of the Son of Man and drink His blood, you have no life in yourselves.
John 6:54 "He who eats My flesh and drinks My blood has eternal life, and I will raise him up on the last day.
John 6:55 "For My flesh is true food, and My blood is true drink.
John 6:56 "He who eats My flesh and drinks My blood abides in Me, and I in him.
John 6:57 "As the living Father sent Me, and I live because of the Father, so he who eats Me, he also will live because of Me.

Eph. 2:13 But now in Christ Jesus you who formerly were far off have been brought near by the blood of Christ.

- So the covenant of Law has been enacted between God and His people
    - The nation of Israel is now forever bound to the Lord in a special way
        - They are called to live a Law that will forever distinguish them from the rest of the people on earth
        - And they will be judged strictly by this Law
        - It will be the cause of their temporary downfall
        - And it will be the basis for their rise again
    - But this covenant is not the means of personal salvation for any Jew or any man at all
        - It is a covenant that establishes a nation

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- And through that nation, God intends to accomplish remarkable things

Ex. 24:9 Then Moses went up with Aaron, Nadab and Abihu, and seventy of the elders of Israel,
Ex. 24:10 and they saw the God of Israel; and under His feet there appeared to be a pavement of sapphire, as clear as the sky itself.
Ex. 24:11 Yet He did not stretch out His hand against the nobles of the sons of Israel; and they saw God, and they ate and drank.
Ex. 24:12 Now the LORD said to Moses, "Come up to Me on the mountain and remain there, and I will give you the stone tablets with the law and the commandment which I have written for their instruction."
Ex. 24:13 So Moses arose with Joshua his servant, and Moses went up to the mountain of God.
Ex. 24:14 But to the elders he said, "Wait here for us until we return to you. And behold, Aaron and Hur are with you; whoever has a legal matter, let him approach them."
Ex. 24:15 Then Moses went up to the mountain, and the cloud covered the mountain.
Ex. 24:16 The glory of the LORD rested on Mount Sinai, and the cloud covered it for six days; and on the seventh day He called to Moses from the midst of the cloud.
Ex. 24:17 And to the eyes of the sons of Israel the appearance of the glory of the LORD was like a consuming fire on the mountain top.
Ex. 24:18 Moses entered the midst of the cloud as he went up to the mountain; and Moses was on the mountain forty days and forty nights.

- Having signed the covenant, Moses and the other men ascend the mountain to meet with God as directed
    - There they see the God of Israel
        - The question immediately becomes what did they see
        - And as with any scripture, we must interpret this passage in light of all scripture
        - We can't assume an interpretation for this passage that contradicts other scripture
    - For example, we read this elsewhere:

1John 4:12 No one has seen God at any time; if we love one another, God abides in us, and His love is perfected in us.

- John declares that no man has even seen God at any time
- This must certainly include this time

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- Then later in Exodus we read

Ex. 33:20 But He said, "You cannot see My face, for no man can see Me and live!"
Ex. 33:21 Then the LORD said, "Behold, there is a place by Me, and you shall stand there on the rock;
Ex. 33:22 and it will come about, while My glory is passing by, that I will put you in the cleft of the rock and cover you with My hand until I have passed by.

- God Himself declares to Moses that Moses cannot see God's face and live
- If Moses couldn't see God's face and live, then certainly Moses never saw God's face, including in Exodus 24
- Finally, we remember that earlier in this chapter the Lord said to Moses that these men were permitted to worship from a distance
    - But only Moses could approach closely

- So these men saw something of God, but whatever they saw, we know they never saw God in any true sense, at least not His face, and they were never very close
    - We get a clue of what they did see in v.10 when we see a reference to His feet
        - We can safely assume that when these men found themselves in the presence of the Lord, even from a distance, that they had a reaction similar to reports we read elsewhere
        - They were prostrate on the ground in fear of their lives
        - And from that vantage point, the only thing they saw was God's "feet" and the pavement underneath
        - We can safely assume this was an appearance of the Shechinah glory
    - In v.11, the men are given a chance to eat and drink
        - This meal is another important moment in the covenant
        - Covenants were concluded with a meal using the meat sacrificed
        - The meal was a sign that these parties were now allies

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- At this point, the covenant ritual is ended, and the next phase of the giving of the Law is ready to begin
    - Moses escorts men back to the camp of Israel, and he instructs them to stay behind rest of the party return to the camp of Israel
        - The two men who held up Moses' arms in battle are placed in charge of the camp of Israel
        - And if anyone has something that requires judgment, these two men would handle it
    - Then Moses and Joshua head back up the mountain for the fifth time
        - Joshua will accompany Moses for part of the trip
        - But at v.15 and beyond the narrative only mentions Moses
        - So we can safely assume Joshua stops somewhere along the way
    - Moses waits up on the mountain for six days outside the cloud
        - On the seventh day the Lord calls Moses into the cloud on the seventh day
        - The glory of God in the cloud is like a consuming fire on the top of the mountain
        - Moses remains in the cloud for forty days and nights
            - The number forty is a number of testing in scripture
            - In this case, the test isn't for Moses
            - The test is for the people, a test they will fail badly when we join them in chapter 32
- For chapters 25-31, we will study the description of the tabernacle and the priestly duties in the tabernacle
    - The study will move fairly quickly through these chapters
        - We will look at the details long enough to get a good sense of the structure
        - But our main focus will be on the ways the tabernacle reflect Christ and the Heavenly tabernacle
    - Let's begin with chapter 25

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Ex. 25:1 Then the LORD spoke to Moses, saying,
Ex. 25:2 "Tell the sons of Israel to raise a contribution for Me; from every man whose heart moves him you shall raise My contribution.
Ex. 25:3 "This is the contribution which you are to raise from them: gold, silver and bronze,
Ex. 25:4 blue, purple and scarlet material, fine linen, goat hair,
Ex. 25:5 rams' skins dyed red, porpoise skins, acacia wood,
Ex. 25:6 oil for lighting, spices for the anointing oil and for the fragrant incense,
Ex. 25:7 onyx stones and setting stones for the ephod and for the breastpiece.
Ex. 25:8 "Let them construct a sanctuary for Me, that I may dwell among them.
Ex. 25:9 "According to all that I am going to show you, as the pattern of the tabernacle and the pattern of all its furniture, just so you shall construct it.

- Why does the Lord command Israel to build this structure?
    - It's purpose and function are intimately connected to the Law already given to Israel
        - The covenant Israel now finds itself in demands perfection to the ordinances
        - Those ordinances, including the first ten commandments, are strict and unforgiving
        - Even one violation of these laws results in a breaking of the covenant
        - And the breaking of a covenant meant the death of the one who broke it
    - So God provides for a place and a system by which Israel could address their sins under the covenant without facing destruction
        - The terms of the covenant itself provided for this manner of atonement
        - Were it not incorporated into the covenant, then there would have been no way to address the sin of the people
        - Notice that even in the giving of the covenant itself, first came the Law, then the agreement, then a provision for the eventual sin
            - God knew sin would come and was prepared to address it

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- So the tabernacle is a meeting place where God can dwell with men
- And men can address their sin under the covenant before God

- The opening of this chapter gives us a chance to note the supply for this project
    - The material for God's house would come from the people
        - God tells Moses to take a contribution
        - The contribution will be from every man whose heart is moved
            - What will "move" their heart?
            - Clearly, the Spirit will move men to provide for the work God intends to perform
        - This has always been the way God works
            - God's work will never languish due to a lack of hearts motivated to support the work
            - In fact, it's fair to say that we might fairly determine where God is working by where hearts are being moved to support the work
            - This is not a perfect rule, of course, because men may be prompted to fund works for other, ungodly reasons
            - But if you are endeavoring to conduct ministry and that ministry depends on the provision of others, then match your work to the support you receive
            - For it may be a fair measure of the Lord's intentions
    - In this case, the Lord desired to perform a significant work, one of great importance and wealth reflecting the glory of God
        - The list of materials is quite impressive
        - And we will look at each in detail as we move through the construction

- In v.9 we have the most important clue to understanding the intricate descriptions of the tabernacle in the following chapters

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- Everything we will study is a pattern
  - The tabernacle itself is built according to the pattern (or blueprint) that God is providing for Moses
- But the word also alludes to the way the tabernacle itself is a pattern or picture of other others
  - First, it is a picture of Christ and His work of redemption
    - You will be amazed at all the pictures of Christ contained in this structure
    - We will look at them as we move through the details of the building
  - Secondly, the tabernacle offers a pattern for salvation, for the way by which we may enter the Lord's presence, and for many other details of His plan for redemption
    - Included in the tabernacle are pictures of the Gospels
    - Pictures of the Church
    - Pictures of the Kingdom
  - Thirdly, the tabernacle is a pattern of what stands in Heaven
    - We will see how this small unimposing structure on earth mirrors a far greater structure in Heaven

- We will begin our study of the tabernacle construction in earnest next time we meet

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Exodus 25-26

SLIDE 25/26-1

- The next section of study in Exodus runs until chapter 31, and it consists of the instructions for the building of the Lord's sanctuary, called the tabernacle
    - The tabernacle was, for its size, perhaps the most expensive building every constructed
        - It was remarkably small, barely the size of a modest bedroom and an average living room
        - In fact, you will likely be surprised to learn how small most of the items in the tabernacle truly were
    - Yet despite it's modest size, it was constructed out of the most valuable materials of the day
        - Some have estimated it cost $2 million to build in Moses' day,
        - This would be an extraordinary amount in today's dollars
- The tabernacle is also a remarkable picture of Christ and God's work of redemption through His Son
    - Last week we heard the Lord tell Moses that he was to follow a precise pattern that the Lord would show Moses

Ex. 25:9 **"According to all that I am going to show you, as the pattern of the tabernacle and the pattern of all its furniture, just so you shall construct it.**

- Moses not only heard the instructions God gave him, Moses also saw an image of the finished building to guide him (see v.40)
- When finished, the tabernacle itself became a pattern

Heb. 9:8 **The Holy Spirit is signifying this, that the way into the holy place has not yet been disclosed while the outer tabernacle is still standing,**
Heb. 9:9 **which is a symbol for the present time...**

- The word for symbol in v.9 means type or picture
- So the tabernacle was a symbol for a time, a symbol of Christ

- So as we study the construction of the tabernacle and it's purpose, we will also study the design of the tabernacle as a type, specifically a type of Christ

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- A type is a divinely intended parallel between a lessor form and it's greater fulfillment
    - The building is so rich in details that it is easy to get carried away with typology and imagine everything to be a type of Christ
    - While there may be many illustrations of Christ, there are only a few types identified in scripture
- For example, we know that Isaac is a type of Christ in the way he was taken up to a mountain to be sacrificed by Abraham
    - We know this because Hebrews 11 tells us so
    - Because we know Isaac was a type of Christ, we might speculate that Abraham was a type of the Father in that story
        - Since the NT never specifically calls Abraham a type of the Father, we should not call Abraham a type
        - We can say that Abraham serves as an illustration of the way the Father sacrificed His Son
- Similarly, we will find many illustrations of Christ in the details of the tabernacle
    - And perhaps these <u>are</u> divinely-intended types of Christ, even though they are not called out in the NT
    - But I will play it safe and only use the term "illustration" to describe my extended comparisons

- FInally, it's worth noting that the pattern used to construct the tabernacle is itself based on another structure, a heavenly tabernacle
    - The writer of Hebrews tells us this

Heb. 8:1 **Now the main point in what has been said is this: we have such a high priest, who has taken His seat at the right hand of the throne of the Majesty in the heavens,**
Heb. 8:2 **a minister in the sanctuary and in the true tabernacle, which the Lord pitched, not man.**
Heb. 8:3 **For every high priest is appointed to offer both gifts and sacrifices; so it is necessary that this high priest also have something to offer.**
Heb. 8:4 **Now if He were on earth, He would not be a priest at all, since there are those who offer the gifts according to the Law;**

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Heb. 8:5 who serve a copy and shadow of the heavenly things, just as Moses was warned by God when he was about to erect the tabernacle; for, "SEE," He says, "THAT YOU MAKE all things ACCORDING TO THE PATTERN WHICH WAS SHOWN YOU ON THE MOUNTAIN."

- The design of the earthly tabernacle is based on the Heavenly one
- This heavenly tabernacle is a place that God - not man - erected

- So Israel is told to collect an offering from those who are moved (by the Spirit) to contribute to the building of the sanctuary
  - And from these materials, Moses is to build a very unique structure for the Lord
    - There are three primary purposes for the building of tabernacle, according to scripture

SLIDE 25/26-2

  - First, the tabernacle is to be the dwelling place of God on earth during the dispensation of Law
    - The Hebrew word for *dwell* in v8 is *shakan*, from which we also get the word shechinah
    - The Shechinah glory of God is the visible presence of God among His people
      - Since the fall of man in the Garden, God's presence has only been manifested for moments, in accordance with God's purposes to reveal Himself
      - But now the Lord desires a physical place in which His Schechinah glory will reside continuously
    - The tabernacle was not the only place God's presence might be found on earth
      - God is all spirit and therefore He can't be localized to a single place on earth
        - He is everywhere at all times
    - But the tabernacle was the one and only place where the the Lord chose to manifest His glory to men on a consistent basis

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- In the Old Testament law, the nation of Israel was warned that if a man attempted to sacrifice to the Lord outside of the tabernacle, He would be punished

Lev. 17:3 **"Any man from the house of Israel who slaughters an ox or a lamb or a goat in the camp, or who slaughters it outside the camp,**
Lev. 17:4 **and has not brought it to the doorway of the tent of meeting to present it as an offering to the LORD before the tabernacle of the LORD, bloodguiltiness is to be reckoned to that man. He has shed blood and that man shall be cut off from among his people.**

- In this detail, we find an illustration of Christ
- The New Testament teaches that Christ is the one and only manifestation of the Father's glory on earth

Acts 4:12 **"And there is salvation in no one else; for there is no other name under heaven that has been given among men by which we must be saved."**

- The message in these requirements are clear: God sets the manner by which men may find Him
  - Any attempt by men to seek God on their own terms or outside His provision will result in judgment
  - Just as Christ is the only way to the Father, as Jesus said

John 14:6 **Jesus said to him, "I am the way, and the truth, and the life; no one comes to the Father but through Me.**

- Secondly, The tabernacle was the Lord's sanctuary according to v.8
  - The word sanctuary means a holy or a place set apart
    - In this case, it is a place set apart from sin
      - It is holy ground, made so by the very presence of the Lord's glory
      - As when He told Moses that the ground on which Moses stood had become holy ground
    - So the tabernacle was a place set apart from the sin of the world
  - This is also an illustration of Christ

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- Christ was the sinless sanctuary of the Father on earth
- John says

John 1:14 **And the Word became flesh, and dwelt among us, and we saw His glory, glory as of the only begotten from the Father, full of grace and truth.**

- The Greek word for dwelt is the same word for tabernacle
  - Jesus was the glory of God tabernacling among His people
- And Paul says

Col. 1:19 **For it was the Father's good pleasure for all the fullness to dwell in Him,**

- All the fullness of the Father dwelled in Christ
- And John again

1John 3:5 **You know that He appeared in order to take away sins; and in Him there is no sin.**

- Jesus was the sinless sanctuary of the Father

- Finally, the tabernacle is sometimes called the tent of meeting, for that was its third purpose
  - The tabernacle became the place where God would condescend to meet with man
    - The men of Israel gathered in the tent according to God's ordinances
    - The tabernacle allowed Israel to draw near God through the High Priest of Israel, which interceded on behalf of the people
  - Once again, this is a type of Christ, as explained by the writer of Hebrews

Heb. 7:25 **Therefore He is able also to save forever those who draw near to God through Him, since He always lives to make intercession for them.**

  - The very fact that God called for a tent rather than a permanent structure points to the temporary purpose of this structure

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- It was temporary because it was to be replaced by the work of Christ
- Even the magnificent temple built by Herod was temporary, as Jesus alluded in speaking about the temple

Luke 21:5 **And while some were talking about the temple, that it was adorned with beautiful stones and votive gifts, He said,**
Luke 21:6 **"As for these things which you are looking at, the days will come in which there will not be left one stone upon another which will not be torn down."**

- So now we begin to examine the details of this elaborate yet temporary structure, starting with the key pieces of furniture held within the tabernacle
  - Altogether we will find seven pieces of furniture in the tabernacle, with some described here and others described later
    - As we read the description of this item and the other furnishing to follow, let's notice the order of the items described
    - The descriptions proceed outward from the most important part of the tabernacle, the Holy of Holies and with the most important furniture first, the ark at the center of the structure
  - The point in ordering the descriptions in this way was to emphasize that God presence was at the heart of the structure
    - And everything else is connected to that presence
    - Were God not present, the rest of the building would have no meaning or purpose

Ex. 25:10 **"They shall construct an ark of acacia wood two and a half cubits long, and one and a half cubits wide, and one and a half cubits high.**
Ex. 25:11 **"You shall overlay it with pure gold, inside and out you shall overlay it, and you shall make a gold molding around it.**
Ex. 25:12 **"You shall cast four gold rings for it and fasten them on its four feet, and two rings shall be on one side of it and two rings on the other side of it.**
Ex. 25:13 **"You shall make poles of acacia wood and overlay them with gold.**
Ex. 25:14 **"You shall put the poles into the rings on the sides of the ark, to carry the ark with them.**
Ex. 25:15 **"The poles shall remain in the rings of the ark; they shall not be removed from it.**
Ex. 25:16 **"You shall put into the ark the testimony which I shall give you.**

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Ex. 25:17 "You shall make a mercy seat of pure gold, two and a half cubits long and one and a half cubits wide.
Ex. 25:18 "You shall make two cherubim of gold, make them of hammered work at the two ends of the mercy seat.
Ex. 25:19 "Make one cherub at one end and one cherub at the other end; you shall make the cherubim of one piece with the mercy seat at its two ends.
Ex. 25:20 "The cherubim shall have their wings spread upward, covering the mercy seat with their wings and facing one another; the faces of the cherubim are to be turned toward the mercy seat.
Ex. 25:21 "You shall put the mercy seat on top of the ark, and in the ark you shall put the testimony which I will give to you.
Ex. 25:22 "There I will meet with you; and from above the mercy seat, from between the two cherubim which are upon the ark of the testimony, I will speak to you about all that I will give you in commandment for the sons of Israel.

SLIDE 25/26-3

- The first item described is the ark of the covenant
    - This is an item made even more famous (if that were possible) by the Indiana Jones movie

SLIDE 25/26-4

        - Like the rest of the structure, the ark itself was not very large but it was very ornate

SLIDE 25/26-5

        - The ark was made of wood and covered in pure gold
            - It was about 3'9" long and only 2'3" wide and high

SLIDE 25/26-6

            - And it had rings of gold on the corners
        - The rings were used in conjunction with rods of acacia wood covered in gold to carry the ark

SLIDE 25/26-7

            - The ark itself was never to be touched by human hands
            - In fact, one time a well-intentioned Israelite dared to touch it

2Sam. 6:4 So they brought it with the ark of God from the house of Abinadab, which was on the hill; and Ahio was walking ahead of the ark.
2Sam. 6:5 Meanwhile, David and all the house of Israel were celebrating before the LORD with all kinds of instruments made of fir wood, and with lyres, harps, tambourines, castanets and cymbals.

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2Sam. 6:6 But when they came to the threshing floor of Nacon, Uzzah reached out toward the ark of God and took hold of it, for the oxen nearly upset it.
2Sam. 6:7 And the anger of the LORD burned against Uzzah, and God struck him down there for his irreverence; and he died there by the ark of God.

- Inside the ark the Israelites eventually placed three items
  - Here God tells Moses to place the testimony in the ark
    - The testimony refers to the tablets holding the ten commandments, which represents the entire Law
    - Notice that the tablets themselves must have been fairly small to fit in a space only 3.5' by 2'
  - Later the Lord will instruct Israel to add a jar of manna and the budding staff of Aaron
  - All three of these elements picture Christ
    - The sinless Christ who will judge all men according to the Law
    - The bread of life that comes down from Heaven
    - The rejected branch that shoots forth from the stem of Jesse, returning from death to life

SLIDE 25/26-8

- On top of the ark was a lid
  - This lid, called a mercy seat, was the most important place in the entire tabernacle
    - It was made of pure gold (no wood for the lid)
    - It was the place of propitiation, a word which means to satisfy the wrath of God
    - Over the mercy seat, the High Priest sprinkled the blood of the goat on the Day of Atonement
    - This act satisfied the wrath of God against the sin of Israel under the covenant
  - But the Day of Atonement was not a permanent propitiation nor was it a propitiation for personal sin

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- It served to temporarily appease the wrath of God against the nation of Israel for their national sins under the Old Covenant
- But only the blood of Christ can fully satisfy the wrath of God against sin
- And only by personal faith in Christ's propitiation can a person receive the forgiveness of God made possible by Christ

- This is why there are two days in the Jewish calendar when national sacrifices are made under the Law
  - First, there is the sacrifice of a lamb on Passover
    - The lamb symbolizes the innocence of Christ
    - Christ died without sin so that He could serve as an atoning sacrifice on our behalf
  - Secondly, there was the sacrifice of a goat on the day of atonement
    - There are two goats: the scapegoat who is released from the city carrying the sins of the people and the one sacrificed on the altar
    - The goat sacrificed symbolizes the wrath of God poured out upon a substitute
    - This is why in scripture sheep and goats are the animals used to symbolize believers and unbelievers, respectively
  - And Christ is pictured by both animals in different ways
    - Christ was both the innocent lamb and the condemned goat
    - As Paul explains

2Cor. 5:21 He made Him who knew no sin to be sin on our behalf, so that we might become the righteousness of God in Him.

Gal. 3:13 Christ redeemed us from the curse of the Law, having become a curse for us – for it is written, "CURSED IS EVERYONE WHO HANGS ON A TREE" –
Gal. 3:14 in order that in Christ Jesus the blessing of Abraham might come to the Gentiles, so that we would receive the promise of the Spirit through faith.

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- So the mercy seat of the ark is a type of Christ's propitiation in the NT
  - John says:

1John 4:10 **In this is love, not that we loved God, but that He loved us and sent His Son to be the propitiation for our sins.**

  - The Greek word for propitiation is the same word translated as "mercy seat" in Heb 9:5

- So the mercy seat was the place where God's wrath was appeased, and it pictures Christ taking the wrath of God in our place

Rom. 5:9 **Much more then, having now been justified by His blood, we shall be saved from the wrath of God through Him.**

- On either end of the mercy seat are two gold cherubim with their wings outspread to cover the lid
  - It would here that the Shechinah glory of God appeared to Israel and spoke to the people
    - It appeared in this small space above the lid and under the wings of the cherubim
    - The glory of God was the only illumination in the Holy of Holies, since the room had no other lamp and no windows
      - Another illustration of Christ, Who is the Light of the world
      - And in the world to come, the glory of God will illuminate the earth according to Revelation 22:5
  - This glory of God remained on the ark until the years before the destruction of Jerusalem by Nebuchadnezzar
    - Ezekiel tells in chapters 8-11 of how the glory of the Lord first moved away from the Holy of Holies to the threshold of the temple illuminating the whole court yard
    - Then it moved to entrance to the east gate, and it was surrounded by real cherubim
    - Finally, it departs the temple altogether and moves briefly to the Mt of Olives

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- The creatures attending to the Shechinah glory of God are called cherubim, and they are the highest form of spiritual creatures in the heavenly realm
    - The Bible mentioned angels, seraphim and cherubim
        - These beings play different roles in the heavenly realm and have different appearances
        - The angelic realm are messengers of God ministering to His saints, as Hebrews tells us
            - And contrary to Hallmark cards and Victoria Secrets catalogs, angels don't have wings
    - Seraphim are the next rank above angels
        - They are only described in Isaiah 6
        - They are seen ministering to the Lord around His throne and giving Him praise
        - They have six wings
    - Finally, the highest order of spiritual creatures are cherubim
        - They are described in detail in Ezekiel
        - They are always associated with the appearance of God's Shechinah glory
        - These creatures are entrusted with His glory
            - The chief cherub was Lucifer, before he fell to become Satan
            - Perhaps this explains why Satan was so deceived to think he could be like God, since he was the closest to His glory
            - Just as it required someone close to Jesus, Judas, to betray Him
- Together, the ark and the mercy seat tell an integrated story about Christ
    - By His death and resurrection, Jesus is the giver of life
        - His sacrifice appease the wrath of God, making possible eternal life
        - Jesus is the bread of life, like manna coming down from Heaven

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- He is the glory of God, making possible the glorification of sinful men

- So the Holy of Holies represents Jesus as the Life of all men

- The next section describes furniture in the next room of the tabernacle, moving outward, that is the Holy Place

SLIDE 25/26-9

Ex. 25:23 "You shall make a table of acacia wood, two cubits long and one cubit wide and one and a half cubits high.
Ex. 25:24 "You shall overlay it with pure gold and make a gold border around it.
Ex. 25:25 "You shall make for it a rim of a handbreadth around it; and you shall make a gold border for the rim around it.
Ex. 25:26 "You shall make four gold rings for it and put rings on the four corners which are on its four feet.
Ex. 25:27 "The rings shall be close to the rim as holders for the poles to carry the table.
Ex. 25:28 "You shall make the poles of acacia wood and overlay them with gold, so that with them the table may be carried.
Ex. 25:29 "You shall make its dishes and its pans and its jars and its bowls with which to pour drink offerings; you shall make them of pure gold.
Ex. 25:30 "You shall set the bread of the Presence on the table before Me at all times.

- Next in order of importance is the table of the shewbread or the Table of the bread of the Presence

  - This table was constructed like the ark, that is of acacia wood with gold overlaid on top

    - It stood in the second chamber of the tabernacle, the Holy Place

    - It was also quite small

      - 3' X 1'6" X 2'3"

      - An average-sized coffee table

      - All dish ware on it were made of gold

SLIDE 25/26-10

  - It held a perpetual offering of bread, which the priests replaced every week

    - The bread was stacked in two stacks of six cakes each

    - The bread was called the bread of the presence, since it remained in the presence of God's glory

SLIDE 25/26-11

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        - At the end of each week, the old bread was consumed by the priests who served in that prior week

    - The bread itself pictures Christ, Who is called the bread of life in John 6

        - So the Holy Place is decorated by a symbol of Christ as the Bread of Life, referring to His life-giving word

Matt. 4:3 And the tempter came and said to Him, "If You are the Son of God, command that these stones become bread."
Matt. 4:4 But He answered and said, "It is written, 'MAN SHALL NOT LIVE ON BREAD ALONE, BUT ON EVERY WORD THAT PROCEEDS OUT OF THE MOUTH OF GOD.'"

        - Notice that the only food on the table for the priests of God was this bread

            - No other food was provided

            - Illustrating that the believer's spiritual diet should be the word of God exclusively

- Next we find the second item in the Holy Place, the lamp stand SLIDE 25/26-12

Ex. 25:31 "Then you shall make a lampstand of pure gold. The lampstand and its base and its shaft are to be made of hammered work; its cups, its bulbs and its flowers shall be of one piece with it.
Ex. 25:32 "Six branches shall go out from its sides; three branches of the lampstand from its one side and three branches of the lampstand from its other side.
Ex. 25:33 "Three cups shall be shaped like almond blossoms in the one branch, a bulb and a flower, and three cups shaped like almond blossoms in the other branch, a bulb and a flower — so for six branches going out from the lampstand;
Ex. 25:34 and in the lampstand four cups shaped like almond blossoms, its bulbs and its flowers.
Ex. 25:35 "A bulb shall be under the first pair of branches coming out of it, and a bulb under the second pair of branches coming out of it, and a bulb under the third pair of branches coming out of it, for the six branches coming out of the lampstand.
Ex. 25:36 "Their bulbs and their branches shall be of one piece with it; all of it shall be one piece of hammered work of pure gold.
Ex. 25:37 "Then you shall make its lamps seven in number; and they shall mount its lamps so as to shed light on the space in front of it.
Ex. 25:38 "Its snuffers and their trays shall be of pure gold.
Ex. 25:39 "It shall be made from a talent of pure gold, with all these utensils.
Ex. 25:40 "See that you make them after the pattern for them, which was shown to you on the mountain.

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- The lamp stand is described in this section

SLIDE 25/26-13

  - The lamp was the traditional seven branch menorah
    - It was solid gold made of one piece and weighed about 75 pounds

SLIDE 25/26-14

    - We can see a vivid depiction of what this lamp looked like by examining the famous Roman arch built to commemorate Titus' destruction of Herod's temple

SLIDE 25/26-15

    - The lamp burned continuously, since it was the only source of light in the Holy Place
      - No natural light could enter this place
      - Only the light made available by the instructions of God filled the tabernacle
  - By this we find another type or picture of Christ
    - Jesus is called the Light of the world by John 1
    - And in the Psalms we read

Psa. 119:105 Your word is a lamp to my feet
And a light to my path.

    - Of course, Jesus is also called the Word by John, so Jesus is pictured by the light-given lamp as the word of God

- Together, the table of the presence and the lamp tell a common story about Christ
  - Both the table with the bread and the lamp stand represent the word of God
    - The word of God, which is our spiritual food, sustains and grows us spiritually
    - And the word of God is the light that illuminates our walk of holiness, leading us into righteousness
    - So the Holy Place represents Jesus Christ as the Truth
  - There was one additional piece of furniture in the Holy Place, the table of incense, but it isn't covered until chapter 30

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- The reason the table of incense appears later in the text is because it symbolizes a different meaning and isn't connect to the picture of Jesus as the Word of God

- The next chapter describes the structure of the tabernacle itself

SLIDE 25/26-16

Ex. 26:1 "Moreover you shall make the tabernacle with ten curtains of fine twisted linen and blue and purple and scarlet material; you shall make them with cherubim, the work of a skillful workman.
Ex. 26:2 "The length of each curtain shall be twenty-eight cubits, and the width of each curtain four cubits; all the curtains shall have the same measurements.
Ex. 26:3 "Five curtains shall be joined to one another, and the other five curtains shall be joined to one another.
Ex. 26:4 "You shall make loops of blue on the edge of the outermost curtain in the first set, and likewise you shall make them on the edge of the curtain that is outermost in the second set.
Ex. 26:5 "You shall make fifty loops in the one curtain, and you shall make fifty loops on the edge of the curtain that is in the second set; the loops shall be opposite each other.
Ex. 26:6 "You shall make fifty clasps of gold, and join the curtains to one another with the clasps so that the tabernacle will be a unit.
Ex. 26:7 "Then you shall make curtains of goats' hair for a tent over the tabernacle; you shall make eleven curtains in all.
Ex. 26:8 "The length of each curtain shall be thirty cubits, and the width of each curtain four cubits; the eleven curtains shall have the same measurements.
Ex. 26:9 "You shall join five curtains by themselves and the other six curtains by themselves, and you shall double over the sixth curtain at the front of the tent.
Ex. 26:10 "You shall make fifty loops on the edge of the curtain that is outermost in the first set, and fifty loops on the edge of the curtain that is outermost in the second set.
Ex. 26:11 "You shall make fifty clasps of bronze, and you shall put the clasps into the loops and join the tent together so that it will be a unit.
Ex. 26:12 "The overlapping part that is left over in the curtains of the tent, the half curtain that is left over, shall lap over the back of the tabernacle.
Ex. 26:13 "The cubit on one side and the cubit on the other, of what is left over in the length of the curtains of the tent, shall lap over the sides of the tabernacle on one side and on the other, to cover it.
Ex. 26:14 "You shall make a covering for the tent of rams' skins dyed red and a covering of porpoise skins above.
Ex. 26:15 "Then you shall make the boards for the tabernacle of acacia wood, standing upright.
Ex. 26:16 "Ten cubits shall be the length of each board and one and a half cubits the width of each board.

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Ex. 26:17 "There shall be two tenons for each board, fitted to one another; thus you shall do for all the boards of the tabernacle.
Ex. 26:18 "You shall make the boards for the tabernacle: twenty boards for the south side.
Ex. 26:19 "You shall make forty sockets of silver under the twenty boards, two sockets under one board for its two tenons and two sockets under another board for its two tenons;
Ex. 26:20 and for the second side of the tabernacle, on the north side, twenty boards,
Ex. 26:21 and their forty sockets of silver; two sockets under one board and two sockets under another board.
Ex. 26:22 "For the rear of the tabernacle, to the west, you shall make six boards.
Ex. 26:23 "You shall make two boards for the corners of the tabernacle at the rear.
Ex. 26:24 "They shall be double beneath, and together they shall be complete to its top to the first ring; thus it shall be with both of them: they shall form the two corners.
Ex. 26:25 "There shall be eight boards with their sockets of silver, sixteen sockets; two sockets under one board and two sockets under another board.
Ex. 26:26 "Then you shall make bars of acacia wood, five for the boards of one side of the tabernacle,
Ex. 26:27 and five bars for the boards of the other side of the tabernacle, and five bars for the boards of the side of the tabernacle for the rear side to the west.
Ex. 26:28 "The middle bar in the center of the boards shall pass through from end to end.
Ex. 26:29 "You shall overlay the boards with gold and make their rings of gold as holders for the bars; and you shall overlay the bars with gold.
Ex. 26:30 "Then you shall erect the tabernacle according to its plan which you have been shown in the mountain.
Ex. 26:31 "You shall make a veil of blue and purple and scarlet material and fine twisted linen; it shall be made with cherubim, the work of a skillful workman.
Ex. 26:32 "You shall hang it on four pillars of acacia overlaid with gold, their hooks also being of gold, on four sockets of silver.
Ex. 26:33 "You shall hang up the veil under the clasps, and shall bring in the ark of the testimony there within the veil; and the veil shall serve for you as a partition between the holy place and the holy of holies.
Ex. 26:34 "You shall put the mercy seat on the ark of the testimony in the holy of holies.
Ex. 26:35 "You shall set the table outside the veil, and the lampstand opposite the table on the side of the tabernacle toward the south; and you shall put the table on the north side.
Ex. 26:36 "You shall make a screen for the doorway of the tent of blue and purple and scarlet material and fine twisted linen, the work of a weaver.
Ex. 26:37 "You shall make five pillars of acacia for the screen and overlay them with gold, their hooks also being of gold; and you shall cast five sockets of bronze for them.

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- This structure is measured in cubits, and a cubit is roughly 18" in length
    - To give you an idea how small the tabernacle was, here are the dimensions SLIDE 25/26-17
        - It was 45 feet long
        - 15 feet wide
        - 15 feet high SLIDE 25/26-18
        - The Holy of Holies was only 15 cubic feet, about the size of an average bedroom SLIDE 25/26-19
        - If you walk into a modern car parking lot and mark off four parking spaces arranged face to face, you have about the space the tabernacle occupied
    - The entire structure was accessed through a single door, which is a type of Christ SLIDE 25/26-20
        - Jesus called Himself the door by which we find access to the Father

John 10:9 **"I am the door; if anyone enters through Me, he will be saved, and will go in and out and find pasture.**

- The entire structure rested on two sockets of silver SLIDE 25/26-21
    - There were one hundred sockets, each weighing about 100 pounds
        - That's 10,000 pounds of silver or 5 tons SLIDE 25/26-22
        - And the wall boards had pegs protruding from the bottom that fitted into these sockets
    - This silver is collected in chapter 30
        - The amount collected per person was a very modest sum, but when all the children have contributed, the total equals five tons
        - Here is what the Lord commands of Israel

Ex. 30:12 **"When you take a census of the sons of Israel to number them, then each one of them shall give a ransom for himself to the LORD, when you number them, so that there will be no plague among them when you number them.**

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Ex. 30:13 "This is what everyone who is numbered shall give: half a shekel according to the shekel of the sanctuary (the shekel is twenty gerahs), half a shekel as a contribution to the LORD.
Ex. 30:14 "Everyone who is numbered, from twenty years old and over, shall give the contribution to the LORD.
Ex. 30:15 "The rich shall not pay more and the poor shall not pay less than the half shekel, when you give the contribution to the LORD to make atonement for yourselves.
Ex. 30:16 "You shall take the atonement money from the sons of Israel and shall give it for the service of the tent of meeting, that it may be a memorial for the sons of Israel before the LORD, to make atonement for yourselves."

- God says that anytime you number God's people, that census must be conducted in conjunction with the taking of atonement money
  - Before anyone can be numbered as among God's people, atonement must be made and a price must be paid for that person
    - Each person must pay the atonement price
    - No one can pay the price for someone else
  - And the silver is called the atonement in Exodus 30
  - So the tabernacle rests on silver, which pictures the atoning work of Christ's blood, by which we may be called God's people

1Pet. 1:18 knowing that you were not redeemed with perishable things like silver or gold from your futile way of life inherited from your forefathers,
1Pet. 1:19 but with precious blood, as of a lamb unblemished and spotless, the blood of Christ.

  - And Paul completes the picture when he taught

1Cor. 3:11 For no man can lay a foundation other than the one which is laid, which is Jesus Christ.

SLIDE 25/26-23

- The walls were boards held together with five wooden rods covered with gold running horizontally through loops to hold the boards together

SLIDE 25/26-24

  - The boards were made of acacia wood, known for being a type of wood that resists decay in the harsh desert heat

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- On top of the wood was laid pure gold

SLIDE 25/26-25

- The whole inside of the tabernacle would have gleamed in yellow gold reflecting the light of the yellow flames of the lamp

- This construction of wood overlaid with gold is also an illustration of Christ
  - The wood represented Jesus' fleshly body
  - It was born of the earth, out of the ground
    - Isaiah 53 again

Is. 53:2 For He grew up before Him like a tender shoot,
And like a root out of parched ground;
He has no stately form or majesty
That we should look upon Him,
Nor appearance that we should be attracted to Him.

- And when Jesus died, his earthly body did not decay, like the acacia wood

Psa. 16:10 For You will not abandon my soul to Sheol;
Nor will You allow Your Holy One to undergo decay.

- But the boards were also covered in pure gold, symbolizes divinity in scripture, hence the covering of gold throughout the design of the tabernacle
  - But that gold covered wood
  - Illustrating how Jesus was a man of flesh, but He was also a holy God

SLIDE 25/26-26

- Surrounding the outside walls were ten curtains of woven linen that were connected together to form a single unit that surrounded the walls
  - The linen curtains were woven with colors of blue, purple and scarlet
    - There were also images of cherubim in the fabric
    - The colors are said to stand for the heavenly origin of Christ, the royal authority of Christ and the blood of His atonement
  - There were ten curtains connected together into a single unit

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- These curtains covered the gold boards and also formed the ceiling of the tabernacle
  - They were draped across the top of the boards and down the outside walls

- Across the tops of these boards were draped three additional layers of materials to create a tent roof SLIDE 25/26-27
  - The second layer was woven goat hair
    - Goat hair symbolize the sin offering of Christ on the cross
  - The next layer was a ram's skin died red
    - This skin was a reminder of the goat that died on the day of atonement for the sins of Israel
    - And of course, it illustrates the sacrificial death of Christ and His red blood shed for the sins of men
  - The outermost layer was an animal skin
    - My translation says porpoise but others say badger skin
    - The point was it was a waterproof layer
    - It was relatively unattractive
      - This is an illustration of Christ as well, since scripture tells He was a man of plain and unadorned looks

Is. 53:2 **For He grew up before Him like a tender shoot,**
And like a root out of parched ground;
He has no stately form or majesty
That we should look upon Him,
Nor appearance that we should be attracted to Him.

  - Because of the curtains draped down the outside of the boards, only the priests saw the inner fabric covering of the tabernacle SLIDE 25/26-28
    - By this another illustration of Christ is formed
    - Unless you become a priest of God, you cannot see and understand the finer things of God
    - All believers are priests, according to the NT

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- Therefore, all believers have been granted access to the holy place and to know the things freely given of God

1Cor. 2:12 **Now we have received, not the spirit of the world, but the Spirit who is from God, so that we may know the things freely given to us by God,**

SLIDE 25/26-29

- But to the unbeliever, who has not entered through the door and come to Christ, they can only see the plain outside appearance
- And they cannot appreciate the beauty and majesty of God in the face of Christ

- Finally, there was a veil constructed to separate the Holy of Holies from the Holy Place

SLIDE 25/26-30

  - This veil was made of the same three colors as the curtains
    - It was also decorated with cherubim
    - The veil hung on a center wall constructed of four pillars of acacia wood
    - This design would have made it impossible to remove the ark from the holy of holies without first dismantling the entire structure
  - This veil is another picture of Christ from the NT

SLIDE 25/26-31

    - The Hebrews writer teaches that the veil was a partition between God and man signifying that the way to God had not yet been revealed to men

Heb. 9:8 **The Holy Spirit is signifying this, that the way into the holy place has not yet been disclosed while the outer tabernacle is still standing,**

- But once Christ came and died, His atonement made a way available to everyone

Heb. 10:19 **Therefore, brethren, since we have confidence to enter the holy place by the blood of Jesus,**
Heb. 10:20 **by a new and living way which He inaugurated for us through the veil, that is, His flesh,**

SLIDE 25/26-32

- And therefore, upon His death we're told in the Gospels that the veil was rent from top to bottom

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- From the top, signifying God's work, and to the bottom, meaning that it completely removed the division for men
- The way into the holy place has now been revealed

- So entry past the outer wall of the tabernacle symbolizes the entrance or way to find God
  - That way is obscured from the outside and can only be seen and appreciated by those who have been enlightened by the Spirit through faith
  - The way is based on Christ's work to remove the separation between God and men created by our sin

- So standing back and looking at the construction of the tabernacle, we find a three part quality to Christ

SLIDE 25/26-33

John 14:6 Jesus said to him, "I am the way, and the truth, and the life; no one comes to the Father but through Me.

- The way to God is through Christ, the door leading into the holy place
- The holy place is the truth, represented by the bread and lamp
- And the holy of holies is the life, made possible by the atoning work of Christ

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Exodus 27-28

SLIDE 27/28-1

- Continuing with our study of the tabernacle and its relationship to Christ
    - So far we've covered the construction of the tabernacle itself SLIDE 27/28-2
        - The foundation, the walls, the veil, the curtains, etc.
        - And we studied how each of these things pictures Christ
    - We also studied most of the furniture of the Holy of Holies, the Holy Place SLIDE 27/28-3
        - We looked at the ark, mercy seat, lamp stand, and table of the presence
        - We still need to examine one other article in the Holy Place, the altar of incense coming in chapter 30
    - Today we are going to study the outer courtyard and one piece of furniture in the courtyard
        - And we will learn about the priesthood
        - Most of the priesthood duties are recorded in Leviticus
        - But the garments and the consecrating of the priesthood are detailed in these chapters
- Tonight we start with the brass altar SLIDE 27/28-4

Ex. 27:1 "And you shall make the altar of acacia wood, five cubits long and five cubits wide; the altar shall be square, and its height shall be three cubits.
Ex. 27:2 "You shall make its horns on its four corners; its horns shall be of one piece with it, and you shall overlay it with bronze.
Ex. 27:3 "You shall make its pails for removing its ashes, and its shovels and its basins and its forks and its firepans; you shall make all its utensils of bronze.
Ex. 27:4 "You shall make for it a grating of network of bronze, and on the net you shall make four bronze rings at its four corners.
Ex. 27:5 "You shall put it beneath, under the ledge of the altar, so that the net will reach halfway up the altar.
Ex. 27:6 "You shall make poles for the altar, poles of acacia wood, and overlay them with bronze.
Ex. 27:7 "Its poles shall be inserted into the rings, so that the poles shall be on the two sides of the altar when it is carried.

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Ex. 27:8 "You shall make it hollow with planks; as it was shown to you in the mountain, so they shall make it.

- The altar was not designed in the way we tend to see altars today SLIDE 27/28-5
    - It was a square box made of wood overlaid with brass
        - The box was 7.5 ft square and 4.5 feet high
        - The corners of the altar had horns protruding outward
        - Inside the box halfway down was a grate made of brass which sat under a ledge running around the inside of the altar
        - The entire altar was carried using wood poles covered with brass
    - The altar is often portrayed as sitting on raised ground SLIDE 27/28-6
        - There is no prescription in scripture for raising the altar
        - Yet it is a consistent feature of ancient descriptions
        - In fact, the word altar means "high place"
    - The design of the altar was specifically made for sacrificial animals to be placed within the box of the altar to be consumed by fire SLIDE 27/28-7
        - The fire was left burning continually on the grate
        - The grate was designed to ensure that oxygen reached the burning fire from underneath
        - The pieces of meat were placed on top of the coals and burned with the wood until they became ash
    - The tools used to tend the fire and the altar were all made of brass as well SLIDE 27/28-8
        - There was a pails and shovels to remove the ashes from underneath the altar
        - There were forks to position the pieces of meat on the fire
        - There were basins to hold the blood of the sacrifice
        - And a firepot to more hot coals inside the tabernacle to light the fire at the altar of incense

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- The altar was positioned on the grounds of the tabernacle court directly in front of the entrance of the compound

SLIDE 27/28-9

  - The fire in the altar was never allowed out for as long as the tabernacle stood
    - And as the tabernacle was initially commissioned, the fire in the altar was first lit by God Himself, we're told
    - This same fire lit the fire in the altar of incense in the Holy Place
  - It was here that Jews brought their sacrifices as required under the Law
    - In addition to the sacrifices required by individuals for their, the priests conducted the daily sacrifices required by the Law
    - Every morning and every evening the priests would offer a sacrifice of a lamb
  - These sacrifices involved pouring out the life blood of an innocent animal and then burning the animal in fire
    - Depending on the sacrifice, the blood would either be applied to the horns of the altar or to the altar of incense in the tabernacle
    - If the blood was applied to the horns on the altar, then the priest was required to eat some of the sacrificial meat
    - If the blood was brought into the tabernacle, then the priest was prohibited from eating the sacrifice
    - One way or the other, the HP brought the sacrifice before the Lord, either by the blood or by his presence in the tabernacle
    - The rest of the blood was spilled out at the base of the altar
- So if we were to enter the gate of the tabernacle, we need to image a raised brass box continually burning

SLIDE 27/28-10

  - At the base of the altar would be literally a river of blood running away from it
    - And on the horns of the altar, are the dried smears of thousands of applications of blood

SLIDE 27/28-11

    - And the priests are continually bringing sacrifices to the altar and periodically removing the ashes

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        - When worshippers brought a sacrifice before the altar to atone for sin, they were required to kill the animal themselves

    - So the image you have of the altar is one of blood and death continually

        - Blood spilled for sin
        - The death of innocents cause by the sin of men
        - The burning of flesh to atone for sin
        - And this is the first thing you see as you enter the tabernacle

- The altar presents a clear illustration of Christ's sacrifice

    - First, nothing else of the tabernacle is even visible, much less available to a worshipper until that person has encountered the altar of God

        - Likewise, no one can enter the house of God unless and until they have encountered Christ on the cross
        - The cross was the place where the Lord made Himself to be a sacrifice for the sins of God's children

Heb. 7:26 For it was fitting for us to have such a high priest, holy, innocent, undefiled, separated from sinners and exalted above the heavens;
Heb. 7:27 who does not need daily, like those high priests, to offer up sacrifices, first for His own sins and then for the sins of the people, because this He did once for all when He offered up Himself.

    - And just like a visitor to the tabernacle couldn't bypass the altar on the way to the Holy Place, neither can we "get around" the cross in our effort to find God

1Cor. 1:18 For the word of the cross is foolishness to those who are perishing, but to us who are being saved it is the power of God.
1Cor. 1:19 For it is written,
I "I WILL DESTROY THE WISDOM OF THE WISE,
I AND THE CLEVERNESS OF THE CLEVER I WILL SET ASIDE."
1Cor. 1:20 Where is the wise man? Where is the scribe? Where is the debater of this age? Has not God made foolish the wisdom of the world?
1Cor. 1:21 For since in the wisdom of God the world through its wisdom did not come to know God, God was well-pleased through the foolishness of the message preached to save those who believe.
1Cor. 1:22 For indeed Jews ask for signs and Greeks search for wisdom;

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1Cor. 1:23 but we preach Christ crucified, to Jews a stumbling block and to Gentiles foolishness,
1Cor. 1:24 but to those who are the called, both Jews and Greeks, Christ the power of God and the wisdom of God.

- The materials of the altar represent the judgment poured out on Christ on the cross
    - The entire altar was wood covered by brass
        - Wood again denotes Christ's humanity, having been born on earth
        - While brass and fire are always a picture of God's judgment
    - Furthermore, though Christ received the judgment of God and experienced the fire of God's wrath, His body was not consumed
        - Just as the wood underneath the brass was not consumed by the fire
    - The horns represent Christ as well
        - Horns are often a picture of power and might in scripture
            - The power of God is demonstrated in Christ's power to cover all sin
            - And the power of Christ to conquer sin and death by His death
        - Horns were also the place the animals were secured while they were sacrificed
            - Just as Christ held Himself to the cross
            - Men built the altar according to God's direction, just as Romans built the cross that held Christ
            - But Jesus placed Himself on the cross
            - He is pictured buy the horns in the way they hold the sacrifice to the altar
    - Finally, the blood of Christ was shed at the cross, which is clearly pictured by the altar

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- His blood was poured out at the base of the cross when the soldier pierced His side with the sword
- Just as the animal's blood is spilled at the base of the altar
- Then there is the blood applied to the horns of the of the altar
- And in Heaven, we're told Christ applied His blood in the Heavenly Tabernacle

Heb. 9:11 **But when Christ appeared as a high priest of the good things to come, He entered through the greater and more perfect tabernacle, not made with hands, that is to say, not of this creation;**
Heb. 9:12 **and not through the blood of goats and calves, but through His own blood, He entered the holy place once for all, having obtained eternal redemption.**

- Just as the High Priest would take blood into the Holy Place on the Day of Atonement, so does Christ enter by His own blood

- Even the altar's raised posture pictures Christ raised up on the cross
  - In fact, we can more clearly understand another event in Israel's time in the desert when we compare it to the altar in the tabernacle
    - In Numbers 21 the Lord is angry with the Israelites for their grumbling against Moses
    - So He sends fiery serpents among the people, and the bite of the serpent causes them to die
  - Through Moses, the Lord gives the people a chance to live
    - Moses constructs a brass serpent and places it on a staff
    - He holes the staff in the air and all those who look upon the brass serpent would live
  - The Gospel of John tells us that the serpent on the staff pictures Christ lifted up on the cross and we can see the symbols clearly
    - First, the serpent is a picture of Satan's handiwork in the garden, bringing men into a state of sin
    - And the result of the serpent's work is death for all
    - But Christ became sin for us, as pictured by that serpent, and then hung on a cross

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- And the serpent was made of brass to signify God's judgment for sin resting on Christ
- And everyone who looks upon Christ in faith will receive eternal life

SLIDE 27/28-12

- Continuing in our outward movement from the center of the tabernacle, we reach the boundary of the tabernacle compound

Ex. 27:9 "You shall make the court of the tabernacle. On the south side there shall be hangings for the court of fine twisted linen one hundred cubits long for one side;
Ex. 27:10 and its pillars shall be twenty, with their twenty sockets of bronze; the hooks of the pillars and their bands shall be of silver.
Ex. 27:11 "Likewise for the north side in length there shall be hangings one hundred cubits long, and its twenty pillars with their twenty sockets of bronze; the hooks of the pillars and their bands shall be of silver.
Ex. 27:12 "For the width of the court on the west side shall be hangings of fifty cubits with their ten pillars and their ten sockets.
Ex. 27:13 "The width of the court on the east side shall be fifty cubits.
Ex. 27:14 "The hangings for the one side of the gate shall be fifteen cubits with their three pillars and their three sockets.
Ex. 27:15 "And for the other side shall be hangings of fifteen cubits with their three pillars and their three sockets.
Ex. 27:16 "For the gate of the court there shall be a screen of twenty cubits, of blue and purple and scarlet material and fine twisted linen, the work of a weaver, with their four pillars and their four sockets.
Ex. 27:17 "All the pillars around the court shall be furnished with silver bands with their hooks of silver and their sockets of bronze.
Ex. 27:18 "The length of the court shall be one hundred cubits, and the width fifty throughout, and the height five cubits of fine twisted linen, and their sockets of bronze.
Ex. 27:19 "All the utensils of the tabernacle used in all its service, and all its pegs, and all the pegs of the court, shall be of bronze.

- The court was framed by a fence constructed of linen and wood pillars

SLIDE 27/28-13

  - The pillars were set in bronze or brass
    - The linen curtains was suspended by silver hooks
    - The dimensions of the court were 150 feet by 75 feet
    - The wall rose 7.5 feet

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- There was a gate on the eastern wall, so that once you entered the tabernacle you moved east to west SLIDE 27/28-14
  - The gate was thirty feet across and consisted of another linen screen
  - The court created by this wall was the court of the Jews
- The entire structure of the tabernacle made a point of inclusion and exclusion and the wall reinforced this notion SLIDE 27/28-15
  - Only God's chosen people could enter the tabernacle grounds
    - Gentiles were forbidden to ever enter even the outer court
  - The Law of Moses established this barrier
    - The Law created a partition between Jew and Gentile
    - And there was no more visible reminder of that division than the outer wall of the tabernacle
  - And among Jews, only Levites could enter the Holy Place
  - And among Levites, only the High Priest could enter the Holy of Holies, and then only one day each year
    - During this one day event, the High Priest offered atonement for the sins of the entire nation under the covenant

- Jesus broke down these walls of partition by His sinless life and sacrifice on the cross
  - First, Paul says Jesus broke down the barrier of the Law separating the Jew and Gentile

Eph. 2:13 But now in Christ Jesus you who formerly were far off have been brought near by the blood of Christ.
Eph. 2:14 For He Himself is our peace, who made both groups into one and broke down the barrier of the dividing wall,
Eph. 2:15 by abolishing in His flesh the enmity, which is the Law of commandments contained in ordinances, so that in Himself He might make the two into one new man, thus establishing peace,
Eph. 2:16 and might reconcile them both in one body to God through the cross, by it having put to death the enmity.

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- Secondly, Jesus eliminated the division of priesthood among God's people by putting an end to the Law of the covenant

Heb. 7:11 Now if perfection was through the Levitical priesthood (for on the basis of it the people received the Law), what further need was there for another priest to arise according to the order of Melchizedek, and not be designated according to the order of Aaron?
Heb. 7:12 For when the priesthood is changed, of necessity there takes place a change of law also.
Heb. 7:13 For the one concerning whom these things are spoken belongs to another tribe, from which no one has officiated at the altar.
Heb. 7:14 For it is evident that our Lord was descended from Judah, a tribe with reference to which Moses spoke nothing concerning priests.
Heb. 7:15 And this is clearer still, if another priest arises according to the likeness of Melchizedek,
Heb. 7:16 who has become such not on the basis of a law of physical requirement, but according to the power of an indestructible life.

- The Law of Moses established a priesthood in the family of Aaron and his descendants
  - Those priests served the tabernacle of the Law
- But Jesus wasn't born of the family of Aaron
  - He was born of the tribe of Judah
  - So He wouldn't have even been qualified to serve as a priest under the Law

- By His death, He fulfilled and put to an end the Law
  - And therefore the change in law also brought about a change in priesthood
  - Because Jesus serves in a different order, one defined not by a physical characteristic but by His immortality, Hebrews says
  - So now all who are born again in Christ can share in His priesthood duties
    - And so we all can enter the Holy Place of God's word and prayer
    - And none of God's people excluded

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- This is why Peter says believers are part of a royal priesthood

1Pet. 2:9 But you are A CHOSEN RACE, A royal PRIESTHOOD, A HOLY NATION, A PEOPLE FOR God's OWN POSSESSION, so that you may proclaim the excellencies of Him who has called you out of darkness into His marvelous light;

- Thirdly, Jesus is our High Priest, Who has entered the Holy of Holies in the Heavenly tabernacle
  - And He lives there to make intercession for His children on a daily basis

Heb. 7:23 The former priests, on the one hand, existed in greater numbers because they were prevented by death from continuing,
Heb. 7:24 but Jesus, on the other hand, because He continues forever, holds His priesthood permanently.
Heb. 7:25 Therefore He is able also to save forever those who draw near to God through Him, since He always lives to make intercession for them.
Heb. 7:26 For it was fitting for us to have such a high priest, holy, innocent, undefiled, separated from sinners and exalted above the heavens;
Heb. 7:27 who does not need daily, like those high priests, to offer up sacrifices, first for His own sins and then for the sins of the people, because this He did once for all when He offered up Himself.

  - While the High Priest was excluded 364 days of the year, Jesus is present 365 days of the year
  - So we can all approach boldly to the throne of God since Christ brings those needs before the Father on our behalf everyday

- Now the Law transitions to a discussion of the priesthood garments and some of the duties
  - Keep in mind we still haven't described two pieces of furniture in the tabernacle
    - They have been left for later because of their significance
    - Remember everything is described from the center outward according to the purposes they serve
    - These remaining items of furniture have different purposes than everything else described so far

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Ex. 27:20 "You shall charge the sons of Israel, that they bring you clear oil of beaten olives for the light, to make a lamp burn continually.
Ex. 27:21 "In the tent of meeting, outside the veil which is before the testimony, Aaron and his sons shall keep it in order from evening to morning before the LORD; it shall be a perpetual statute throughout their generations for the sons of Israel.

- The last two verses of chapter 27 begin to introduce the duties of the tabernacle priests SLIDE 27/28-16
    - First, they were responsible for beating oils to create the oil for the lamps
        - And the oil lamp must burn continuously
        - It could never be extinguished
    - This instruction creates another illustration
        - We know the lamp is an illustration of the light of God's truth found in His word
        - As servants of God, we can (and should) put our effort into working with the HS to gain an understanding of God's word and share that light with others
            - But unless our HP ignites that oil, our efforts cannot produce illumination
    - Furthermore, the seven lamps represent the fullness of the HS resting upon Christ

Is. 11:1 Then a shoot will spring from the stem of Jesse,
And a branch from his roots will bear fruit.
Is. 11:2 The Spirit of the LORD will rest on Him,
The spirit of wisdom and understanding,
The spirit of counsel and strength,
The spirit of knowledge and the fear of the LORD.

- The lamp is perpetually lit, a sign of Christ's constant presence in the life of every believer by the presence of His Spirit in us

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Ex. 28:1 "Then bring near to yourself Aaron your brother, and his sons with him, from among the sons of Israel, to minister as priest to Me — Aaron, Nadab and Abihu, Eleazar and Ithamar, Aaron's sons.
Ex. 28:2 "You shall make holy garments for Aaron your brother, for glory and for beauty.
Ex. 28:3 "You shall speak to all the skillful persons whom I have endowed with the spirit of wisdom, that they make Aaron's garments to consecrate him, that he may minister as priest to Me.
Ex. 28:4 "These are the garments which they shall make: a breastpiece and an ephod and a robe and a tunic of checkered work, a turban and a sash, and they shall make holy garments for Aaron your brother and his sons, that he may minister as priest to Me.
Ex. 28:5 "They shall take the gold and the blue and the purple and the scarlet material and the fine linen.
Ex. 28:6 "They shall also make the ephod of gold, of blue and purple and scarlet material and fine twisted linen, the work of the skillful workman.
Ex. 28:7 "It shall have two shoulder pieces joined to its two ends, that it may be joined.
Ex. 28:8 "The skillfully woven band, which is on it, shall be like its workmanship, of the same material: of gold, of blue and purple and scarlet material and fine twisted linen.
Ex. 28:9 "You shall take two onyx stones and engrave on them the names of the sons of Israel,
Ex. 28:10 six of their names on the one stone and the names of the remaining six on the other stone, according to their birth.
Ex. 28:11 "As a jeweler engraves a signet, you shall engrave the two stones according to the names of the sons of Israel; you shall set them in filigree settings of gold.
Ex. 28:12 "You shall put the two stones on the shoulder pieces of the ephod, as stones of memorial for the sons of Israel, and Aaron shall bear their names before the LORD on his two shoulders for a memorial.
Ex. 28:13 "You shall make filigree settings of gold,
Ex. 28:14 and two chains of pure gold; you shall make them of twisted cordage work, and you shall put the corded chains on the filigree settings.
Ex. 28:15 "You shall make a breastpiece of judgment, the work of a skillful workman; like the work of the ephod you shall make it: of gold, of blue and purple and scarlet material and fine twisted linen you shall make it.
Ex. 28:16 "It shall be square and folded double, a span in length and a span in width.
Ex. 28:17 "You shall mount on it four rows of stones; the first row shall be a row of ruby, topaz and emerald;
Ex. 28:18 and the second row a turquoise, a sapphire and a diamond;
Ex. 28:19 and the third row a jacinth, an agate and an amethyst;
Ex. 28:20 and the fourth row a beryl and an onyx and a jasper; they shall be set in gold filigree.

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Ex. 28:21 "The stones shall be according to the names of the sons of Israel: twelve, according to their names; they shall be like the engravings of a seal, each according to his name for the twelve tribes.
Ex. 28:22 "You shall make on the breastpiece chains of twisted cordage work in pure gold.
Ex. 28:23 "You shall make on the breastpiece two rings of gold, and shall put the two rings on the two ends of the breastpiece.
Ex. 28:24 "You shall put the two cords of gold on the two rings at the ends of the breastpiece.
Ex. 28:25 "You shall put the other two ends of the two cords on the two filigree settings, and put them on the shoulder pieces of the ephod, at the front of it.
Ex. 28:26 "You shall make two rings of gold and shall place them on the two ends of the breastpiece, on the edge of it, which is toward the inner side of the ephod.
Ex. 28:27 "You shall make two rings of gold and put them on the bottom of the two shoulder pieces of the ephod, on the front of it close to the place where it is joined, above the skillfully woven band of the ephod.
Ex. 28:28 "They shall bind the breastpiece by its rings to the rings of the ephod with a blue cord, so that it will be on the skillfully woven band of the ephod, and that the breastpiece will not come loose from the ephod.
Ex. 28:29 "Aaron shall carry the names of the sons of Israel in the breastpiece of judgment over his heart when he enters the holy place, for a memorial before the LORD continually.
Ex. 28:30 "You shall put in the breastpiece of judgment the Urim and the Thummim, and they shall be over Aaron's heart when he goes in before the LORD; and Aaron shall carry the judgment of the sons of Israel over his heart before the LORD continually.
Ex. 28:31 "You shall make the robe of the ephod all of blue.
Ex. 28:32 "There shall be an opening at its top in the middle of it; around its opening there shall be a binding of woven work, like the opening of a coat of mail, so that it will not be torn.
Ex. 28:33 "You shall make on its hem pomegranates of blue and purple and scarlet material, all around on its hem, and bells of gold between them all around:
Ex. 28:34 a golden bell and a pomegranate, a golden bell and a pomegranate, all around on the hem of the robe.
Ex. 28:35 "It shall be on Aaron when he ministers; and its tinkling shall be heard when he enters and leaves the holy place before the LORD, so that he will not die.
Ex. 28:36 "You shall also make a plate of pure gold and shall engrave on it, like the engravings of a seal, 'Holy to the LORD.'
Ex. 28:37 "You shall fasten it on a blue cord, and it shall be on the turban; it shall be at the front of the turban.

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Ex. 28:38 "It shall be on Aaron's forehead, and Aaron shall take away the iniquity of the holy things which the sons of Israel consecrate, with regard to all their holy gifts; and it shall always be on his forehead, that they may be accepted before the LORD.
Ex. 28:39 "You shall weave the tunic of checkered work of fine linen, and shall make a turban of fine linen, and you shall make a sash, the work of a weaver.

- In the opening of chapter 28, Aaron and his sons are identified as the family who will carry the burden of the priesthood throughout all the generations of Israel

SLIDE 27/28-17

  - The garments worn by Aaron, the first High Priest, were specifically intended to mark them for duty
    - They consisted of six pieces
    - They were required for working in the service of the tabernacle
    - The priestly garments were intended to consecrate Aaron and his sons in v.3
      - The word consecrate means to be dedicated in holiness
      - The priests were wearing garments that set them apart for this duty in a holy way, apart from sin
    - Also, in v.2 and elsewhere, the garments are said to be for beauty and glory as well

- We'll examine each item briefly

SLIDE 27/28-18

  - The ephod and breast plate were one piece
    - The ephod was the gold woven front piece worn over the shoulders
    - On top of each shoulder, the ephod held a sing onyx stone
    - Engraved in each stone were the names of the sons of Israel, six on one stone and six on the second
  - Attached the ephod was a breastplate containing 12 jewels representing the 12 tribes
    - And behind the breastplate was a pouch contained two stones called the Unim and Thummin

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        - They were given to Israel to discern God's will on questions they brought before the Lord
            - The word Urim means "lights" or "illumination"
            - The word Thummim means perfection or completion
            - The LXX translates them "Revelation" and "Truth"
            - Together they represent complete illumination
        - When the High Priest wanted to ask God a question, he must phrase the question in the form of a yes/no answer
        - Then he would either cast the lots the stones as lots (or some say one stones would light up) indicating God's answer

- This method of discerning God's will was less efficient then sending a prophet to speak to the people
    - Still, it served to give Israel divine direction in the face of difficult questions
    - The stones were not special except that God had designated them to be so
    - They remained in the possession of the priests until the Babylonian invasion and destruction of Jerusalem
        - That event ushered in the Age of the Gentiles, according to Daniel
        - And at that point, the ark and the breastplate of the High Priest were both lost forever

- The meaning of the breastplate and ephod was to bear burdens
    - The jewels and engraved onyx stones represent the people of Israel
        - So the High Priest was bearing the burdens of Israel as he performed his duties on their behalf
        - He bore their sins and he had their needs "on his heart"
    - As the High Priest enters the Holy Place and the Holy of Holies each year, he brought those burdens with him
        - Much as he had to bring either the blood of each sacrifice or eat the meat before entering the Holy Place

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- Symbolically, the High Priest was the representative of the people
- And every symbol must be connected to a reality for the symbol to have meaning
    - And this symbol represents the reality of how Christ bore our burdens as our High Priest
    - And He has children on His heart even as He intercedes for us now

- Next we look at the gown or robe of the High Priest SLIDE 27/28-19
    - He wore a gown of fine linen
        - It included a finely woven hem upon which hung pomegranates and bells
        - The pomegranates provided weight to the gown to ensure it never raised up in a wind exposing the nakedness of the priest
        - And the bells would ring as the high priest moved, drawing attention to his position and authority
    - Folklore holds that the bells served another purpose on the Day of Atonement
        - In v.35 we hear that the bells will prevent the High Priest from dying as he enters the Holy Place
        - Folklore developed that if the High Priest entered the Holy of Holies on the Day of Atonement without bells, he was struck down
        - In that sense, the bells saved the High Priest from death
    - Furthermore, the myth held that should his sacrificial offering not be pleasing to the Lord for any reason, the High Priest would be struck down dead
        - Because no one could go in after him, the priests would tie a rope to his leg and listen for the bells
        - If they stopped, the assumption was he died and they would pull him out

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- This is not true, as this analysis from the Biblical Studies Foundation and Zion Messianic Jewish Fellowship Congregation explains:

The Biblical Studies Foundation (loosely associated with Dallas Theological Seminary), similarly reports that their research has put the "the rope around the ankle-or-waist-or-maybe-the-leg" legend "to rest." They also point out that Aaron was to wear a blue ephod with bells on its hem (Exodus 28:31-35), when he entered the Holy Place (not the Holy of Holies) (Leviticus 16:2-4). When he enters the Holy of Holies, he washes and wears special linen garments, not the ephod with bells. "If there are no bells to jingle, there is no need for the rope either."

A Messianic Jewish Fellowship points out the potential difficulty of dragging a dead priest out of the Holy of Holies: "You could only drag out the priest if he died in the Holy place. The way the curtains of the temple were designed, the priest could not have been dragged out of the HOLY of HOLIES. The veil was made using many layers of cloth. The thickness was over three feet. The curtains overlapped and made a small maze through which the priest walked…"

- His headgear was also intended to mark him for duty and provide spiritual cover
  - The front of the head piece had a pure gold plate that said Holy to the Lord
  - The High Priest also wore a sash and tunic of fine linen

SLIDE 27/28-20

- The rest of the sons of Aaron wore less ornate outfits

Ex. 28:40 "For Aaron's sons you shall make tunics; you shall also make sashes for them, and you shall make caps for them, for glory and for beauty.
Ex. 28:41 "You shall put them on Aaron your brother and on his sons with him; and you shall anoint them and ordain them and consecrate them, that they may serve Me as priests.
Ex. 28:42 "You shall make for them linen breeches to cover their bare flesh; they shall reach from the loins even to the thighs.
Ex. 28:43 "They shall be on Aaron and on his sons when they enter the tent of meeting, or when they approach the altar to minister in the holy place, so that they do not incur guilt and die. It shall be a statute forever to him and to his descendants after him.

- Aaron's sons constitute the lessor priests of the priesthood

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        - They had to wear special clothing as well whenever they ministered
        - They had linen robes and linen britches underneath to clothe themselves fully
        - Notice again that this clothing must be worn to prevent death when serving in the Holy Place or approaching the altar

- Through these mandates the Lord is establishing another picture, once that begins back to Genesis 3
    - In the Garden when Man and Woman sinned, they immediately discovered their nakedness
        - By their sin, they became indebted to their Creator
        - God is perfectly just and righteous, which means that all sin must be judged
        - God's perfection is manifested into Creation by His word, and His word cannot be delivered and not be truth
    - Therefore, when God said to Adam that eating the fruit would mean death, then by that word death must be the penalty for sin
        - So as Adam and Woman ate, they sinned, and in their sin they incurred the penalty God's word proclaimed
        - After they sinned, they immediately became aware of their jeopardy before God
        - Their consciousness reflected this spiritual change by experiencing feelings of guilt and vulnerability and shame
        - Even without God present, they sensed their jeopardy, and after God appears, they hide in fear for the same reason
- These feelings caused them to sense a need for physical covering
    - They could no longer feel at ease without it
        - Their spiritual exposure brought with it a physical exposure
        - They could not cover or correct for their spiritual exposure, so they did the only thing they could
            - They sought physical covering

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- The Lord gave Man and Woman covering of animal skins, which were made available to them by the sacrifice of an animal
    - In Gen 3:21 we're told that God accomplished that first sacrifice for Man
    - He sacrificed an animal, spilling its blood, and used the skins to clothe them
        - That sacrifice was the first physical death in God's creation
        - It was made necessary because of sin
    - So the blood of the sacrifice was a spiritual covering while the clothing was a physical covering

- Through this example, we learn about the relationship between sin and blood and covering
    - First, sin in any form immediately makes necessary death
        - If God is to make an escape possible for sinful man, His wrath for sin must still be satisfied, since God's word still stands
        - So there must be a payment of death for sin
        - And according to scripture, the life of a living creature is held in the blood

Lev. 17:11 **'For the life of the flesh is in the blood, and I have given it to you on the altar to make atonement for your souls; for it is the blood by reason of the life that makes atonement.'**

        - The blood is the life of every creature
        - If the blood is poured out of the body, then the life is taken out of the body as well
    - So where sin exists, a pouring out of blood must take place to satisfy God's word concerning sin
    - Secondly, the sacrifice must be a substitute without sin itself
        - We sacrifice animals since they are not creatures capable of sinning against God's Law

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        - Yet they are under the curse of the Law, since they are from the earth which God has cursed
        - So though they are acceptable to God, animal sacrifices cannot put away sin altogether
    - Finally, the sacrifice must be offered in a pure and holy manner, apart from sin, or else the sacrifice is defiled and it is no longer a suitable substitute
        - The priests were sinful men, but for the time they served in the tabernacle, they engaged in ritual cleansing and sacrifice that provided spiritual covering
        - Their garments provided physical covering
        - These things were appointed under the Law so that as the priest's fulfilled their duties under the Law, they were acceptable to the Lord
    - So under the Law, the priests are required to wear special clothing as part of the process of making themselves acceptable to God in performing their duties on behalf of the people
        - Ultimately, these sacrifices were insufficient to address sin
        - Men offered the sacrifices in obedience to the law
        - Their faith brought salvation apart from the Law
        - But the rituals of sacrifice were a constant reminder that sin requires death unless an acceptable covering is provided that is acceptable to God
- We can draw two parallels or illustrations from these things
    - First, Christ's work on our behalf is pictured in lessor form by all these details
        - Christ lived a sinless life making Him a perfect sacrifice
        - He died and spilled His blood to pay our debt
        - His blood covered the offense of sin, not in an earthly tabernacle but in a Heavenly tabernacle

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- Furthermore, since He was not born under the curse but was born of the Holy Spirit, His death could accomplish what no other could
- Finally, Jesus was born in human form so He could serve as man's representative before the Throne
    - Since our Representative must be made like us but without sin
    - Just as the High Priest of Israel represented his people but only after being consecrated

- Secondly, we see a picture of how the saints must serve the Lord today
    - Paul says this in Romans 12

Rom. 12:1 **Therefore I urge you, brethren, by the mercies of God, to present your bodies a living and holy sacrifice, acceptable to God, which is your spiritual service of worship.**

- As we serve in God's house, we serve as priests in the sense that we present our bodies to the Lord as our sacrifice
    - But we must present them in a holy way
    - We must have a covering for our sin before our spiritual service is acceptable to God
- Hebrews puts it succinctly

Heb. 11:6 **And without faith it is impossible to please Him, for he who comes to God must believe that He is and that He is a rewarder of those who seek Him.**

- Romans 1-11 describes God's plan for salvation
    - Romans 12 and onward describes the response of a believer to their salvation
    - You can do Romans 12 unless you've already lived Romans 1-11
- Just like the priests, we must be covered by the sacrifice of Christ, consecrated for service by our faith, before we can serve the loving God

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- Next week we study how these priests were consecrated under the Law and the rest of the tabernacle articles

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Exodus 29-30

SLIDE 29/30-1

- This will be the final part of the tabernacle's design and furnishings
    - In reality, though, we've moved into an examination of the priesthood

SLIDE 29/30-2

        - In chapter 28 we learned about the priestly garb
        - And before that we learned about their work at the altar
        - As we move ahead, we remain focused on the priesthood and the tabernacle items associated with their service
    - In Chapters 29-30 we'll study the consecration of the priests and then we'll look at two more pieces of furniture in the tabernacle
        - The altar of incense and the laver are items associated with the priest's role as representative of Israel
        - They been saved for this point in the narrative because they are so closely associated with the priests
    - As we look forward to chapter 31 in a future night, we'll have a chance to see an interesting connection between Exodus to Genesis
        - The connection helps set the purpose and meaning of the time at the mountain in it's proper perspective
        - And explain the significance of all that we've been studying in the tabernacle
- Speaking of what follows, chapters 32-34 return to a narrative of Moses and Israel in the desert,
    - It centers on their sin with the golden calf and the aftermath of that sin
        - God's judgment comes upon the people
        - And it also will cover Moses' work of intercession to save the nation
    - This story also has a connection to Genesis, which we'll see together
- Let's go to chapter 29 and study the consecration of the priests
    - The first 37 verses describe the consecration procedure

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        - With such a long section of scripture, it's helpful to start by summarizing the major parts

SLIDE 29/30-3

    - First, God is establishing a consecration ceremony for the priests of Israel
        - In v.35 God says this is for Aaron and his sons, meaning his descendants
        - This consecration ceremony was accomplished for each new generation of priests in Israel
        - This is the ceremony in which men are set apart for service to the Lord
    - The next thing we read will be the details of the consecration process, which consisted of three parts
        - First, the priests are ritually cleansed and dressed in their priestly garb and anointed by oil
        - Secondly, sacrifices are made on their behalf to remove sin prepare them to serve the Lord in holiness
        - Thirdly, the priests make a wave offering to the Lord of meat and bread and oil
            - Most of which is then burned as an offering to the Lord
            - But a part is saved to become the portion to sustain the priests, which is consumed in front of the tent of meeting
    - Then finally, this ceremony is repeated for seven days to complete the consecration
        - Following the consecration, the priests are then ready to serve the Lord
        - This ceremony was repeated for each new generation of Jewish priests throughout the history of the tabernacle and the temple

- This ceremony is a beautiful picture of another kind of consecration, and we're going to examine that picture as we go through the details
    - So looking at the details, let's begin with the first section describing the cleansing, clothing and anointing of the priests
        - This section runs from vs.1-9

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Ex. 29:1 "Now this is what you shall do to them to consecrate them to minister as priests to Me: take one young bull and two rams without blemish,
Ex. 29:2 and unleavened bread and unleavened cakes mixed with oil, and unleavened wafers spread with oil; you shall make them of fine wheat flour.
Ex. 29:3 "You shall put them in one basket, and present them in the basket along with the bull and the two rams.
Ex. 29:4 "Then you shall bring Aaron and his sons to the doorway of the tent of meeting and wash them with water.
Ex. 29:5 "You shall take the garments, and put on Aaron the tunic and the robe of the ephod and the ephod and the breastpiece, and gird him with the skillfully woven band of the ephod;
Ex. 29:6 and you shall set the turban on his head and put the holy crown on the turban.
Ex. 29:7 "Then you shall take the anointing oil and pour it on his head and anoint him.
Ex. 29:8 "You shall bring his sons and put tunics on them.
Ex. 29:9 "You shall gird them with sashes, Aaron and his sons, and bind caps on them, and they shall have the priesthood by a perpetual statute. So you shall ordain Aaron and his sons.

- The first verses of the chapter describe the materials needed for the ceremony
    - The animals and cakes and wafers are used in the second section of this chapter, so we'll set them aside for a moment
        - The washing, the oil and the clothing of the priests are the key items used in this first section
        - Moses begins with Aaron and all his sons at the doorway of the tent of meeting

SLIDE 29/30-4

            - This is the place immediately in front of the Holy Place
            - The Holy Place is the place where the priesthood served
        - Any Jew could enter the grounds, but only priests could serve the Lord in the Holy Place
            - So the priests stand at the entrance of the doorway to reflect the meaning of the ceremony, as their means of entering service before God
    - This chapter records God giving Moses the instructions while Moses stands with God on the top of the mountain

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        - But the actual carrying out of these instructions are recorded in Leviticus 8
        - And in that chapter, Moses follows God's instructions exactly as they are recorded here

- After the priests are in the doorway, they are washed
    - This is not ordinary bathing, but a ritual washing intended to teach a point
        - The person who served God must be spiritually clean
        - And to picture God's cleansing of these men, He demands they wash physically in a public way
    - So the first step of priestly service was to be cleansed
        - Having been cleansed, they were able to move forward into service
        - But washing wasn't enough by itself
- Secondly, the priests put on the priestly garments the Lord prescribed for their service
    - The High Priest, Aaron, is clothed first, followed by the other priests
        - This clothing designated the men as priests and set them apart
        - It gave them a new identity
    - So before the men could serve the Living God, they had to assume a new identity
        - Their new identity was evidenced by their new appearance
        - And that appearance communicated their new role and calling to serve in God's house
- Finally, the High Priest was anointed with oil on his head
    - The oil was a symbolic way of demonstrating the person had entered into a position of authority and power assigned by God
        - Priests were anointed
        - Prophets were anointed

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        - Kings were anointed

    - So before these men could serve in God's house, there must be an official anointing to signify that God authorized that service

        - With that authorization, the men served for a lifetime

        - The anointing was permanent

- All of these steps have parallels for believers today, and I believe they are intended to picture the way God is working in the Church today

    - First, who are the priests of today?

        - It might be tempting to make a comparison between the ceremony we see in Exodus 29 and the establishing of Christian leaders or clergy

        - But that is an age-old mistake that Jesus refers to in Revelation as the Nicolaitan heresy

        - The heresy suggests that there is a Christian priesthood or clergy that are distinct or set apart from the rest of the body of Christ

    - But scripture says the opposite SLIDE 29/30-5

1Pet. 2:9 **But you are A CHOSEN RACE, A royal PRIESTHOOD, A HOLY NATION, A PEOPLE FOR God's OWN POSSESSION, so that you may proclaim the excellencies of Him who has called you out of darkness into His marvelous light;**

        - All believers are consecrated priests of Jesus

        - Which means the comparison we are supposed to make in this chapter are between the priesthood of Israel and the priesthood of the believer today

- Before we can serve God as priests in God's house, we must be cleansed spiritually

    - The cleansing or washing away of our sins is accomplished by faith in Jesus Christ

        - In other words, our faith is the necessary prerequisite for any form of service as priest SLIDE 29/30-6

Heb. 11:6 **And without faith it is impossible to please Him, for he who comes to God must believe that He is and that He is a rewarder of those who seek Him.**

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- And the instrument of that washing or cleansing is the Holy Spirit

SLIDE 29/30-7

Titus 3:5 He saved us, not on the basis of deeds which we have done in righteousness, but according to His mercy, by the washing of regeneration and renewing by the Holy Spirit,
Titus 3:6 whom He poured out upon us richly through Jesus Christ our Savior,

- Secondly, we must be clothed properly for service
  - And all believers are clothed by Christ, Who is our High Priest

SLIDE 29/30-8

Gal. 3:26 For you are all sons of God through faith in Christ Jesus.
Gal. 3:27 For all of you who were baptized into Christ have clothed yourselves with Christ.

- Our clothing creates our identity, and begin clothed in Christ means walking in His righteousness and according to His example
- How do you think the priest carried themselves after Moses placed their priestly garb upon them?
  - Can you imagine they walked a little taller, with a greater sense of burden and responsibility
  - Did they think twice about how they conducted themselves around others?

  - Likewise, we are called to walk differently having "put on" Christ

SLIDE 29/30-9

Rom. 13:13 Let us behave properly as in the day, not in carousing and drunkenness, not in sexual promiscuity and sensuality, not in strife and jealousy.
Rom. 13:14 But put on the Lord Jesus Christ, and make no provision for the flesh in regard to its lusts.

- Finally, we are anointed for our service as priests by the indwelling of the Holy Spirit

SLIDE 29/30-10

2Cor. 1:21 Now He who establishes us with you in Christ and anointed us is God,
2Cor. 1:22 who also sealed us and gave us the Spirit in our hearts as a pledge.

  - We have all been anointed by the Holy Spirit, which empowers us for serving the Living God in His holy place
    - The power for our service is given to us by the Spirit

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- Our service to the Lord is not a matter of personal ability or careful planning or even effort
    - The power for service is entirely given to us by the Holy Spirit

SLIDE 29/30-11

2Tim. 1:7 **For God has not given us a spirit of timidity, but of power and love and discipline.**

- Certainly, we must labor with the Spirit, or else we grieve Him
- And this anointing is given to us not to make us feel important or to enflame our pride
    - Like the priests in the tabernacle, the anointing of God is intended to empower us to serve God's people in God's house

SLIDE 29/30-12

1Cor. 12:7 **But to each one is given the manifestation of the Spirit for the common good.**

- The gifts of the Spirit are tools we wield in service to the God
- We have been consecrated by the Spirit, set apart to be Christ's servants

- So by faith in Christ, we are commissioned into the priestly service of God, clothed with Christ, and empowered by Spirit

SLIDE 29/30-13

    - But before we can serve to the fullest, there are steps that must be taken to prepare us for that service

Ex. 29:10 **"Then you shall bring the bull before the tent of meeting, and Aaron and his sons shall lay their hands on the head of the bull.**
Ex. 29:11 **"You shall slaughter the bull before the LORD at the doorway of the tent of meeting.**
Ex. 29:12 **"You shall take some of the blood of the bull and put it on the horns of the altar with your finger; and you shall pour out all the blood at the base of the altar.**
Ex. 29:13 **"You shall take all the fat that covers the entrails and the lobe of the liver, and the two kidneys and the fat that is on them, and offer them up in smoke on the altar.**
Ex. 29:14 **"But the flesh of the bull and its hide and its refuse, you shall burn with fire outside the camp; it is a sin offering.**
Ex. 29:15 **"You shall also take the one ram, and Aaron and his sons shall lay their hands on the head of the ram;**

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Ex. 29:16 and you shall slaughter the ram and shall take its blood and sprinkle it around on the altar.
Ex. 29:17 "Then you shall cut the ram into its pieces, and wash its entrails and its legs, and put them with its pieces and its head.
Ex. 29:18 "You shall offer up in smoke the whole ram on the altar; it is a burnt offering to the LORD: it is a soothing aroma, an offering by fire to the LORD.
Ex. 29:19 "Then you shall take the other ram, and Aaron and his sons shall lay their hands on the head of the ram.
Ex. 29:20 "You shall slaughter the ram, and take some of its blood and put it on the lobe of Aaron's right ear and on the lobes of his sons' right ears and on the thumbs of their right hands and on the big toes of their right feet, and sprinkle the rest of the blood around on the altar.
Ex. 29:21 "Then you shall take some of the blood that is on the altar and some of the anointing oil, and sprinkle it on Aaron and on his garments and on his sons and on his sons' garments with him; so he and his garments shall be consecrated, as well as his sons and his sons' garments with him.

- In this second section, a series of sacrifices are performed
    - A bull and two rams are sacrificed on the altar
        - Before the animals are sacrificed, the priests place their hands on the animals
        - The act symbolizes the priests transferring their sins to these innocent substitutes
        - Symbolically, the priests are demonstrating they are sinful, unworthy to serve in the capacity of priest
            - Yet the Lord has made accommodation for the priests through these sacrifices
        - We know these animals weren't the means of God's forgiveness but were representative of the forgiveness God would provide in Christ
    - The bull was the largest animal, so only the fat surrounding the internal organs and the liver and kidneys were offered on the fire
        - This offering was a symbolic act of public confession by the priests

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        - When they placed their hands on that animal, they were indicating before God's people that they knew themselves unworthy to serve
            - The blood of the bull is used to anoint the horns of the altar
            - And the rest is poured out at the base
        - These steps picture the death that sin requires
    - Bulls are used in the sacrificial system as a picture of sin condemned
        - The rest of the bull was taken outside the camp and burned as a sin offering
        - Burning outside the camp is a picture of Hell, the pit where the damned experience eternal judgment
        - So this sacrifice provides a visceral picture of the priests sending the bull to judgment in their place
- The picture created for the priesthood of believers today is one of putting away sin in our lives
    - We come into service bringing our sins with us, at least initially

SLIDE 29/30-14

        - But we called to acknowledge or confess our sins to one another

James 5:16 Therefore, confess your sins to one another, and pray for one another so that you may be healed. The effective prayer of a righteous man can accomplish much.

        - And in our confession, make clear we recognize we are not worthy for service by our own merit
        - We practice personal humility and transparency before God's people to restrain pride and encourage repentance
    - Then having confessed our sin, we send it outside the camp, so to speak
        - We burn it up, and set it aside

SLIDE 29/30-15

Heb. 12:1 Therefore, since we have so great a cloud of witnesses surrounding us, let us also lay aside every encumbrance and the sin which so easily entangles us, and let us run with endurance the race that is set before us,

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- Then a ram is sacrificed
    - The ram is used as an atoning sacrifice
        - The ram killed and the blood is used to cleanse the altar of the bull offering
            - The blood is sprinkled around the altar
        - Then the entire animal is burned on the altar
    - And the rising smoke is said to be a soothing aroma, an offering to the Lord
        - The Lord's wrath is satisfied or soothed by the ram's death
            - The Lord is not soothed simply by the prospect of an animal dying
            - Moses means the Lord's wrath against the priests' sin is satisfied when the priests obediently apply the Law requirements for atonement
        - The ram is a replacement and therefore an atonement
- The picture created for the church by the second ram is that of our total personal commitment to serving the Lord
    - The priests under the Law dedicated the entire ram to the Lord to please the Lord
        - Christ has satisfied that requirement for us, as we know
        - So how do priests today perform this second sacrifice since no more sacrifice for sin is required?
    - Paul addressed this question in Romans 12

SLIDE 29/30-16

Rom. 12:1 Therefore I urge you, brethren, by the mercies of God, to present your bodies a living and holy sacrifice, acceptable to God, which is your spiritual service of worship.

- Today, we place our entire body and life on that fire and allow it to be consumed in service to the Lord
- We hold nothing back
    - And if we do this, it will be pleasing to the Lord

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- Next, a second ram is sacrificed
    - This blood of this ram is used to cleanse the priests themselves
        - Some blood is placed the priests' right right ear lobe, right thumbs, and right big toe
        - The right is the side of honor and authority
        - And each part of the body carries a symbolic significance
            - The ear meant the priest was to hear the instructions of God
            - The hand symbolized the priest discharge the duties of his role with diligence
            - And the foot because he was to walk in an upright manner in service within the tabernacle
        - Finally the blood was sprinkled on their garments to consecrate them by blood, set apart by the sacrifice
- This ram reminds priests of the church to serve in the same manner that the priests of the Law served
    - The ram died to remind the priests to hear God, serve God, walk with God
        - And by that blood the priests had a visible reminder that the Lord would hold them accountable to their service
        - By the blood of the ram, these men would be called to account for the quality of their service
    - And as priests today, we are held to a similar standard
        - By the blood of the Lamb of God, we have been called and commissioned to serve

SLIDE 29/30-17

Heb. 9:13 For if the blood of goats and bulls and the ashes of a heifer sprinkling those who have been defiled sanctify for the cleansing of the flesh,
Heb. 9:14 how much more will the blood of Christ, who through the eternal Spirit offered Himself without blemish to God, cleanse your conscience from dead works to serve the living God?

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- And we have been cleansed by the blood of Christ to serve the living God
- And that service will be judged
- And they standards are whether we listened to His word, whether we acted according to what we heard and whether we walked by His Spirit

- The last step of the sacrifice is to make an offering

Ex. 29:22 "You shall also take the fat from the ram and the fat tail, and the fat that covers the entrails and the lobe of the liver, and the two kidneys and the fat that is on them and the right thigh (for it is a ram of ordination),
Ex. 29:23 and one cake of bread and one cake of bread mixed with oil and one wafer from the basket of unleavened bread which is set before the LORD;
Ex. 29:24 and you shall put all these in the hands of Aaron and in the hands of his sons, and shall wave them as a wave offering before the LORD.
Ex. 29:25 "You shall take them from their hands, and offer them up in smoke on the altar on the burnt offering for a soothing aroma before the LORD; it is an offering by fire to the LORD.

- We need to get a good picture of what's happening here
  - The ram is slaughtered and the fat of the animal plus the right thigh is set aside
    - In v.22 we're told it is a ram of ordination, or a offering to recognize the Lord for the privilege of serving Him
    - The fat of the animal was most prized in the ancient world
      - It had the richest flavor and produced oil for cooking
      - And the right thigh would have been the best piece of meat on the animal
      - The picture is one of giving the Lord the best of the animal
  - The Lord is receiving the best the priests could offer from the sacrifice they made
    - And to further signify that these things were being given up to the Lord in thanks, they are waved before the Lord

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        - The scene might seem a bit humorous in our mind's eye, but the message was very serious
        - These things belong to God, and the priests acknowledge that publicly
    - Mixed in a cakes, oil and unleavened bread
        - The cakes, oil and unleavened bread represent the fruit of the priest's ministry
            - The cakes (or bread) represent the spiritual nourishment the priest gave the people
            - The oil represents the anointing the priests delivered to others like prophets, kings or even later generations of priests
            - And the unleavened bread represents the sanctification the priests prompted in the life of Israel
        - The fruits (results) of their ministry is dedicated to the Lord, given back to Him to signify that their results are the Lord's work
- In our priestly work, we also give all glory to the Lord for the work we achieve
    - Did someone we make a contribution to God's people
        - Did someone learn a spiritual truth from our teaching?
        - Did we encourage or commission another believe to serve?
        - Did we further the sanctification of a believer through prayer, counseling or by living an example?
            - If so, we turn to the Lord and "wave" these things before Him in thanks for His work done through us
    - Even the great apostle Paul followed this principle, as he wrote

SLIDE 29/30-18

1Cor. 15:10 But by the grace of God I am what I am, and His grace toward me did not prove vain; but I labored even more than all of them, yet not I, but the grace of God with me.

1Cor. 3:6 I planted, Apollos watered, but God was causing the growth.

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- This is our proper heart attitude as we seek to serve God's people

- Finally, the priest of Israel receive their portion in payment for their work in the tabernacle

Ex. 29:26 "Then you shall take the breast of Aaron's ram of ordination, and wave it as a wave offering before the LORD; and it shall be your portion.
Ex. 29:27 "You shall consecrate the breast of the wave offering and the thigh of the heave offering which was waved and which was offered from the ram of ordination, from the one which was for Aaron and from the one which was for his sons.
Ex. 29:28 "It shall be for Aaron and his sons as their portion forever from the sons of Israel, for it is a heave offering; and it shall be a heave offering from the sons of Israel from the sacrifices of their peace offerings, even their heave offering to the LORD.
Ex. 29:29 "The holy garments of Aaron shall be for his sons after him, that in them they may be anointed and ordained.
Ex. 29:30 "For seven days the one of his sons who is priest in his stead shall put them on when he enters the tent of meeting to minister in the holy place.
Ex. 29:31 "You shall take the ram of ordination and boil its flesh in a holy place.
Ex. 29:32 "Aaron and his sons shall eat the flesh of the ram and the bread that is in the basket, at the doorway of the tent of meeting.
Ex. 29:33 "Thus they shall eat those things by which atonement was made at their ordination and consecration; but a layman shall not eat them, because they are holy.
Ex. 29:34 "If any of the flesh of ordination or any of the bread remains until morning, then you shall burn the remainder with fire; it shall not be eaten, because it is holy.

- From that last ram that is slaughtered, the breast of the ram and the other thigh are saved for the priests to consume

  - First, the meat is taken and waved before the Lord again

    - The point is clear

    - The priests are giving the Lord thanks for this offering

    - They acknowledge it came from Him

  - Secondly, it is boiled and cannot be prepared any other way

    - Since fire has come to represent judgment, water is a sign of purity and sanctification

    - So the nourishment for God's people is not confused with the sacrifice for sin

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        - Also, some of the bread is saved for the priests as well
    - But if anything made available to the priests is not consumed immediately, is is not saved for later
        - Instead, it is burned immediately
        - The priests never get leftovers
- The picture of our provision is clear in this example
    - As priests serving in God's house, we expect the Lord to supply our provision
        - Because we have that expectation, we can serve Him without distraction by our physical needs
        - In our world, many of us will be employed, but that employment is simply another venue in which to serve the Lord
        - That service is still at the heart of our purpose and desires
        - And we still recognize that our provision is coming through the Lord's hand, not through our employer
    - And as we receive that provision, our first responsibility is to acknowledge that provision comes from the Lord
        - We may not walk outside and wave dollars bills at the sky to signify our thankfulness
        - But there are other ways we can show that thankfulness
            - Including dedicating some portion to God's work in the church or elsewhere
    - Finally, we don't rely on leftovers
        - God's provision shouldn't be hoarded in such a way that we become reliant on what we store rather than remaining reliant on the Lord's provision
        - As Jesus taught

SLIDE 29/30-19

Matt. 6:31 "Do not worry then, saying, 'What will we eat?' or 'What will we drink?' or 'What will we wear for clothing?'
Matt. 6:32 "For the Gentiles eagerly seek all these things; for your heavenly Father knows that you need all these things.

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Matt. 6:33 "But seek first His kingdom and His righteousness, and all these things will be added to you.

- Then the Lord tells Moses to rinse and repeat this consecration ceremony for the priests

Ex. 29:35 "Thus you shall do to Aaron and to his sons, according to all that I have commanded you; you shall ordain them through seven days.
Ex. 29:36 "Each day you shall offer a bull as a sin offering for atonement, and you shall purify the altar when you make atonement for it, and you shall anoint it to consecrate it.
Ex. 29:37 "For seven days you shall make atonement for the altar and consecrate it; then the altar shall be most holy, and whatever touches the altar shall be holy.

- This ceremony was to be repeated every day for seven days
    - And you think your child's high school graduation ceremony went on forever...
        - This ceremony took an entire week
        - The point was to reinforce the truth of these symbols
    - For us, the repetition reminds us that our service is a daily process
        - We are called into service just for a moment
        - Paul says our calling to serve is a permanent feature of our faith

SLIDE 29/30-20

Rom. 11:29 for the gifts and the calling of God are irrevocable.

SLIDE 29/30-21

Phil. 3:13 Brethren, I do not regard myself as having laid hold of it yet; but one thing I do: forgetting what lies behind and reaching forward to what lies ahead,
Phil. 3:14 I press on toward the goal for the prize of the upward call of God in Christ Jesus.
Phil. 3:15 Let us therefore, as many as are perfect, have this attitude; and if in anything you have a different attitude, God will reveal that also to you;
Phil. 3:16 however, let us keep living by that same standard to which we have attained.

    - Everyday we are called to confess sin, everyday we are called to hear God, everyday we are called to walk in faith

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        - Everyday we serve in God's house, and our service is life long, just as the priests served for a lifetime

- Having consecrated the priests, then the Lord gives them their first daily duty

Ex. 29:38 "Now this is what you shall offer on the altar: two one year old lambs each day, continuously.
Ex. 29:39 "The one lamb you shall offer in the morning and the other lamb you shall offer at twilight;
Ex. 29:40 and there shall be one-tenth of an ephah of fine flour mixed with one-fourth of a hin of beaten oil, and one-fourth of a hin of wine for a drink offering with one lamb.
Ex. 29:41 "The other lamb you shall offer at twilight, and shall offer with it the same grain offering and the same drink offering as in the morning, for a soothing aroma, an offering by fire to the LORD.
Ex. 29:42 "It shall be a continual burnt offering throughout your generations at the doorway of the tent of meeting before the LORD, where I will meet with you, to speak to you there.
Ex. 29:43 "I will meet there with the sons of Israel, and it shall be consecrated by My glory.
Ex. 29:44 "I will consecrate the tent of meeting and the altar; I will also consecrate Aaron and his sons to minister as priests to Me.
Ex. 29:45 "I will dwell among the sons of Israel and will be their God.
Ex. 29:46 "They shall know that I am the LORD their God who brought them out of the land of Egypt, that I might dwell among them; I am the LORD their God.

- This command is a part of the consecration requirement, but it is an ongoing requirement
    - The priests must perform a morning and evening sacrifice every day, everyday including sabbaths
        - The two sacrifices are of a lamb
        - The lamb is a clear picture of Christ, the Lamb of God
        - The priests can maintain their consecration to serve in the tabernacle only so long as they begin and end every day of service by picturing Christ
    - Likewise, we serve God as priests only so long as everything we do begins and ends with Christ

SLIDE 29/30-22

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2Cor. 5:15 and He died for all, so that they who live might no longer live for themselves, but for Him who died and rose again on their behalf.

1Cor. 2:1 And when I came to you, brethren, I did not come with superiority of speech or of wisdom, proclaiming to you the testimony of God.
1Cor. 2:2 For I determined to know nothing among you except Jesus Christ, and Him crucified.

        - We preach and live the Gospel of Christ
        - We speak and teach of Christ
        - We rest in and abide in Christ
    - Like the priests of Israel in the tabernacle, our very purpose in service is found in testifying to Christ
        - Our mission is not to glorify or advance some denomination
        - We are not followers of a pastor or teacher
        - We are not advocates for a system or program or methodology
    - Our only focus and concern is advancing the glory for Christ

- Summary of priestly service... SLIDE 29/30-23
- SLIDE 29/30-24
- To end the night, we'll look at the last piece of tabernacle furniture in the Holy Place

SLIDE 29/30-25

Ex. 30:1 "Moreover, you shall make an altar as a place for burning incense; you shall make it of acacia wood.
Ex. 30:2 "Its length shall be a cubit, and its width a cubit, it shall be square, and its height shall be two cubits; its horns shall be of one piece with it.
Ex. 30:3 "You shall overlay it with pure gold, its top and its sides all around, and its horns; and you shall make a gold molding all around for it.
Ex. 30:4 "You shall make two gold rings for it under its molding; you shall make them on its two side walls — on opposite sides — and they shall be holders for poles with which to carry it.
Ex. 30:5 "You shall make the poles of acacia wood and overlay them with gold.

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Ex. 30:6 "You shall put this altar in front of the veil that is near the ark of the testimony, in front of the mercy seat that is over the ark of the testimony, where I will meet with you.
Ex. 30:7 "Aaron shall burn fragrant incense on it; he shall burn it every morning when he trims the lamps.
Ex. 30:8 "When Aaron trims the lamps at twilight, he shall burn incense. There shall be perpetual incense before the LORD throughout your generations.
Ex. 30:9 "You shall not offer any strange incense on this altar, or burnt offering or meal offering; and you shall not pour out a drink offering on it.
Ex. 30:10 "Aaron shall make atonement on its horns once a year; he shall make atonement on it with the blood of the sin offering of atonement once a year throughout your generations. It is most holy to the LORD."

- The altar of incense is a constructed in a similar fashion as the other items in the Holy Place
    - It's word overlaid with gold SLIDE 29/30-26
        - It was 3 ft high and 18 inches square carried by poles SLIDE 29/30-27
        - It was positioned in the Holy Place immediately outside the Holy of Holies, next to the veil
        - Like the altar, it had horns protruding from its corners SLIDE 29/30-28
    - There was a set of coals ever burning in this altar, which were taken from the altar outside
        - The coals were used to burn incense, fragrant substances
        - Once a year, the coals were taken into the Holy of Holies to burn incense in that place
- This piece of furniture is one of the clearest illustrations of Christ in the whole tabernacle
    - It relates directly to the priests duty to serve the people
        - The High Priest would burn incense in this altar twice every day
        - The smoke would find it's way into the Holy of Holies where the glory of God resided
        - The point was that the High Priest brought the needs of the people of Israel into the Holy Place

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- Then when he lit the incense, the smoke took those needs into the Holy of Holies before the Lord
- The HP was seen as representing the people to God in a daily way

- Since Jesus is our High Priest, we can see the picture easily
  - Jesus has taken His place in the tabernacle in Heaven
  - And He lives to bring intercession for all God's people
  - And this intercession is made possible by the work of Christ on the altar
    - Just as the fire of the altar of incense couldn't have been lit without the fire of the sacrifice on the brass altar
    - Likewise, Jesus could never have acted as our intercessor before the Father were it not for His atoning work on the cross
  - And the position of the altar nearest the ark reflects Jesus' unique position near the Father
  - In fact, when Jesus ascended the veil was removed altogether
- Finally, notice that this altar will never have other types of offerings made upon it
  - No meat sacrifices, no drink offerings, nothing except incense
  - Further proof that once Jesus had died and then ascended into the Holy Place of Heaven, no more sacrifice or offering is needed
  - Christ's sacrifice was sufficient
  - And so now the only thing at the altar is incense, which symbolize the prayer of the saints according to Revelation

Ex. 30:11 **The LORD also spoke to Moses, saying,**
Ex. 30:12 **"When you take a census of the sons of Israel to number them, then each one of them shall give a ransom for himself to the LORD, when you number them, so that there will be no plague among them when you number them.**
Ex. 30:13 **"This is what everyone who is numbered shall give: half a shekel according to the shekel of the sanctuary (the shekel is twenty gerahs), half a shekel as a contribution to the LORD.**

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Ex. 30:14 "Everyone who is numbered, from twenty years old and over, shall give the contribution to the LORD.
Ex. 30:15 "The rich shall not pay more and the poor shall not pay less than the half shekel, when you give the contribution to the LORD to make atonement for yourselves.
Ex. 30:16 "You shall take the atonement money from the sons of Israel and shall give it for the service of the tent of meeting, that it may be a memorial for the sons of Israel before the LORD, to make atonement for yourselves."

- God's instructions on the construction of the tabernacle began with a collection from the people, and now it comes to an end with a maintenance tax
    - Anytime the people of Israel were counted in a census, then a tax would be collected at the same time for the maintenance of the temple
        - God didn't stipulate how often to collect it, but in time it became a yearly "temple tax"
        - The amount was very modest amount of money, something anyone could afford
    - The collection is called atonement money, because it went to the upkeep of the tabernacle
        - And the whole purpose of the tabernacle was to make restitution for the sins of the people
        - So they were giving to make possible their own atonement
    - The giving was connected to a census to make clear that God's people are counted by way of atonement
        - We are not counted among God's people unless we have a personal stake in the atonement God make available in Christ, Who is our tabernacle
        - The picture is not one of participating in our own atonement
        - Instead, it is one of each person identifying themselves with the people of God through a token
    - Today we have a token we offer the Lord as well
        - We make out confession of faith to be counted among God's people
        - We are not creating our atonement through our confession

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- But we are counted among the people because of that token or gesture

- Finally, the last piece of tabernacle furniture

SLIDE 29/30-29

Ex. 30:17 The LORD spoke to Moses, saying,
Ex. 30:18 "You shall also make a laver of bronze, with its base of bronze, for washing; and you shall put it between the tent of meeting and the altar, and you shall put water in it.
Ex. 30:19 "Aaron and his sons shall wash their hands and their feet from it;
Ex. 30:20 when they enter the tent of meeting, they shall wash with water, so that they will not die; or when they approach the altar to minister, by offering up in smoke a fire sacrifice to the LORD.
Ex. 30:21 "So they shall wash their hands and their feet, so that they will not die; and it shall be a perpetual statute for them, for Aaron and his descendants throughout their generations."

- The seventh and final furniture item is the bronze laver
  - Once again, this item is connected to the priestly service

SLIDE 29/30-30

    - The basin was brass or bronze, and had a base to raise the basin above the ground

SLIDE 29/30-31

    - It was placed between the altar and the entrance to the tent of meeting
    - The overall design of the laver wasn't provided in the scripture, but Moses must have seen the pattern on the mountain
  - The priests wash at this laver before they serve in the carious stations of their ministry
    - In v.19 we see that they washed from the water in the basin, but they didn't place their body in the laver
    - The water is removed somehow and then they wash
  - The washing was a requirement before service or else they would be penalized with their life
    - The high standard helps cement the picture created by the laver
    - It is a picture of sanctification
- As we've seen clearly, the priesthood of Israel is actually a picture of the New Testament believer

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- And the laver completes that picture
  - The washing of the water is the means of cleansing the priests ritually of sin
  - And that ritual pictures the literal washing of our bodies from sin through the sanctification made possible by the Spirit
- And the Spirit accomplishes this work by means of God's word, Who is Christ
  - So once again this item of furniture is picturing the work of Christ
  - As Paul taught:

Eph. 5:25b ...Christ also loved the church and gave Himself up for her,
Eph. 5:26 so that He might sanctify her, having cleansed her by the washing of water with the word,
Eph. 5:27 that He might present to Himself the church in all her glory, having no spot or wrinkle or any such thing; but that she would be holy and blameless.

- And how does sanctification happen in the believer's life?
  - The principle method of sanctifying the believer is through service
  - Just as the priests washed regularly as a part of their service in the tabernacle, so do believers "wash" regularly in the Spirit when they serve in God's house
  - The believer can't mature if we "outsource sanctification" by allowing others outside the church to perform the services we are supposed to perform as priests

- As we conclude our look at the tabernacle, we find an interesting visual pattern created by the placement of the furniture
  - The physical placement of the furniture points to Christ SLIDE 29/30-32
    - The altar and the laver and the ark of the covenant are all in perfect alignment East to West
    - While about one third of the way from one end of this line, we find the lamp stand and table of shewbread standing opposite one another in a line running North to South

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SLIDE 29/30-33

- If we connect all seven pieces of furniture with lines, the result is a cross
  - The furniture items themselves are arranged to prefigure the cross of Christ

SLIDE 29/30-34

  - Further evidence that the tabernacle is a picture of Christ's sacrifice

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Exodus 31

- We've studied the design of the tabernacle and it's furnishings
    - And we took time to note many ways in which God carefully designed these things to reflect the person and the work of Jesus
        - The tabernacle came as part of the Law which was given to Israel by the covenant
        - After finding so many pictures of Christ in the tabernacle confirms for us that the tabernacle like the rest of the Law and the covenant that brought them were intended to point to Christ
        - While they serve other purposes within the nation of Israel, their ultimate purpose was to bring men to Christ
    - The Law and the sacrificial system conducted in the tabernacle were parts of a temporary dispensation, one that acted as a custodian Paul says
        - The Law gave opportunity for men to have a relationship with the Lord while they awaited for grace to be available
        - Once grace was available through Christ's atoning work, then the Law and the sacrificial system no longer provided for that relationship
        - The Father would only be found through the Son
            - He was no longer to be found through the pictures or shadows of His Son that He provided in the Law or elsewhere

Heb. 10:1 For the Law, since it has only a shadow of the good things to come and not the very form of things, can never, by the same sacrifices which they offer continually year by year, make perfect those who draw near.

- But each time the Lord brings a new dispensation (a change in the way God regulates His relationship with man), He follows that change with clear evidence that the new dispensation wasn't the solution to our sin
    - Each dispensation is accompanied by a failure of sin that demonstrates the dispensation is sufficient to address the problem of sin
        - The first sin was the beginning of the pattern

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- God created Adam in perfection, but Adam fell

- Then God set men outside the Garden under new conditions, but then Cain killed Abel

- Then God flooded the world and saved Noah to repopulate the world, but then Noah got drunk in his tent

- Then God called Abraham and promised his a son, but then Abraham sinned with Hagar

- After each new dispensation, sin raises its ugly head again, proving that the hero of the story wasn't the solution God had promised

  - And now we're focused on Moses and the nation of Israel

  - God has delivered a new dispensation in His Law and the formation of the nation of Israel

  - Is the Law and Israel the solution to sin? Will this dispensation finally resolve the problem of sin? No

  - And so we await the fall of our heroes, as God's pattern requires

Ex. 30:22 Moreover, the LORD spoke to Moses, saying,
Ex. 30:23 "Take also for yourself the finest of spices: of flowing myrrh five hundred shekels, and of fragrant cinnamon half as much, two hundred and fifty, and of fragrant cane two hundred and fifty,
Ex. 30:24 and of cassia five hundred, according to the shekel of the sanctuary, and of olive oil a hin.
Ex. 30:25 "You shall make of these a holy anointing oil, a perfume mixture, the work of a perfumer; it shall be a holy anointing oil.
Ex. 30:26 "With it you shall anoint the tent of meeting and the ark of the testimony,
Ex. 30:27 and the table and all its utensils, and the lampstand and its utensils, and the altar of incense,
Ex. 30:28 and the altar of burnt offering and all its utensils, and the laver and its stand.
Ex. 30:29 "You shall also consecrate them, that they may be most holy; whatever touches them shall be holy.
Ex. 30:30 "You shall anoint Aaron and his sons, and consecrate them, that they may minister as priests to Me.
Ex. 30:31 "You shall speak to the sons of Israel, saying, 'This shall be a holy anointing oil to Me throughout your generations.
Ex. 30:32 'It shall not be poured on anyone's body, nor shall you make any like it in the same proportions; it is holy, and it shall be holy to you.

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Ex. 30:33 **'Whoever shall mix any like it or whoever puts any of it on a layman shall be cut off from his people.'"**

- The final instructions the Lord gives Moses concerning the design of the tabernacle are for the anointing oil used to consecrate the tabernacle and the incense burned on the altar of incense
    - There were five ingredients for the anointing oil or perfume
        - Four spices and fine olive oil
        - The spices mentioned largely originate from Arabia and lands in the east
        - So how did Israel get their hands on these things while in the desert?
            - They would have brought these things from Egypt
            - Egypt was a world power and conducted trade with many other nations
            - The goods Israel plundered from Egypt included these items
    - The perfume was mixed by the hands of a skilled apothecary
        - And then this oil was used to anoint the sanctuary, all the items in it and the priests themselves
            - But this exact recipe for the perfume couldn't be used for any other purpose
            - Nor could a lay person create this recipe for themselves
            - This particular oil could only be used according to the Lord's instructions and for the holy purposes God had determined
- Anointing oil is a picture of the Spirit working to designate something or someone for the work of the Lord
    - When the Spirit anoints someone or something for service to God, it is holy or consecrated
        - Holy means set aside from sin

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- For example, each believer is anointed by the Spirit with a spiritual gift
- This gift is an ability reserved for use in service to God
  - That ability is holy, or set apart to glorify God
  - As we use that gift in service to the Body, God is glorified by it

- But God alone brings an anointing by His Spirit
  - God controls who, when and how an anointing takes place
  - In this case, the Lord designated that the oil, which pictures His Spirit, would only be used to anoint the priests, tabernacle and its furnishings
  - Collectively, these three things represent the many aspects of Christ's ministry, as we've already seen
    - And so we see the Holy Spirit pictured by the oil anointing Christ as pictured in these items
    - In fact, the word Messiah means Anointed One
  - Jesus was the One selected by the Father to be the solution to sin
    - Only Christ would once and forever solve the problem of man's sin
    - He would withstand its temptations in life
    - And He would conquer it's power by His death
- Even the prohibition against counterfeiting the oil or misusing it teaches us concerning Christ
  - The Father alone will designate the Messiah
  - Anyone may claim to be the Messiah, but only Jesus had the Father's anointing

Luke 3:21 **Now when all the people were baptized, Jesus was also baptized, and while He was praying, heaven was opened,**
Luke 3:22 **and the Holy Spirit descended upon Him in bodily form like a dove, and a voice came out of heaven, "You are My beloved Son, in You I am well-pleased."**

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- Secondly, just as Israel was not permitted to counterfeit their own version of the anointing oil, men cannot take God's place in anointing God's work
    - God anointed His Son as Messiah, and He is still at working anointing men and women for ministry in the church
    - We can't counterfeit the Holy Spirit and bring an anointing to someone outside God's will
- But many men have tried and are trying to do this very thing
    - False teachers and charlatans use the power of persuasion, convincing displays or supernatural power, and other techniques to mimic the Spirit
    - And they do so to gain followers, fame, money or whatever they want
        - Turn on your television and you can see them at work most any night
    - We can also see one of them at work in the book of Acts

Acts 8:18 Now when Simon saw that the Spirit was bestowed through the laying on of the apostles' hands, he offered them money,
Acts 8:19 saying, "Give this authority to me as well, so that everyone on whom I lay my hands may receive the Holy Spirit."
Acts 8:20 But Peter said to him, "May your silver perish with you, because you thought you could obtain the gift of God with money!
Acts 8:21 "You have no part or portion in this matter, for your heart is not right before God.

- So the perfume oil is a picture of the Holy Spirit anointing Christ as the one and only Way and of the anointing of God's people according to God's will

- Then the Lord directed Moses to use additional spices to create the incense to burn upon the altar

Ex. 30:34 Then the LORD said to Moses, "Take for yourself spices, stacte and onycha and galbanum, spices with pure frankincense; there shall be an equal part of each.
Ex. 30:35 "With it you shall make incense, a perfume, the work of a perfumer, salted, pure, and holy.
Ex. 30:36 "You shall beat some of it very fine, and put part of it before the testimony in the tent of meeting where I will meet with you; it shall be most holy to you.

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Ex. 30:37 "The incense which you shall make, you shall not make in the same proportions for yourselves; it shall be holy to you for the LORD.
Ex. 30:38 "Whoever shall make any like it, to use as perfume, shall be cut off from his people."

- Each of these spices are similar to the ones used for the perfume in that they originate from Arabia and India and were rare
    - Once again, Israel brought them up from Egypt
        - The incense was also to be mixed by an skilled apothecary
        - These ingredients were beaten into a fine powder
        - Several of them were made from plant resin, so they had volatile oils that burned easily
        - Salt was added, as a preservative and as a symbol of holiness
    - The incense was to be burned twice each day in the altar of incense we learned about last time
        - The burning incense was the means by which the priest of Israel made intercession for the nation of Israel according to the Law
        - The rising smoke was a pleasing odor which represented how the prayers of the saints please the Lord
            - Three time we read in Revelation that the prayers of the saints are like incense

Rev. 5:8 When He had taken the book, the four living creatures and the twenty-four elders fell down before the Lamb, each one holding a harp and golden bowls full of incense, which are the prayers of the saints.

- Like the perfume, the incense may not be used anywhere else nor may it be made for personal use
    - The picture is of Christ again, our intercessor representing us to the Father
        - Because Jesus speaks for us and represents us to the Father, the Lord consider our requests

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- But if we seek the Father in any other way, our prayers are not heard
- The Father only hears what His Son represents to Him and unless the Son knows us, the Father never hears us

- This is why Hebrews says that without faith (in Jesus) it is impossible for us to please God
  - And even more, the Bible teaches that the prayers of those without the righteousness of Christ are futile

Psa. 34:15 **The eyes of the LORD are toward the righteous**
And His ears are open to their cry.
Psa. 34:16 **The face of the LORD is against evildoers,**
To cut off the memory of them from the earth.
Psa. 34:17 **The righteous cry, and the LORD hears**
And delivers them out of all their troubles.

Prov. 15:29 **The LORD is far from the wicked,**
But He hears the prayer of the righteous.

John 9:31 **"We know that God does not hear sinners; but if anyone is God-fearing and does His will, He hears him.**

- While any man can mix incense, only the method God prescribed will please Him
- And many men can pray, but only those who pray to Jesus in faith will please the Father and be heard

- Now that we're at the end of the description of the tabernacle and all that is in it, we might image that Moses was beginning to wonder about the work ahead
  - We've heard God mention using skilled craftsmen several times in the course of his instructions
    - Where was Moses going to find men with these particular skills?
    - The Israelites were skilled laborers but they had probably never attempted anything so exacting and intricate
  - In the next chapter, the Lord tells Moses where he can find the skilled workman he will need to construct all that the Lord specified

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Ex. 31:1 Now the LORD spoke to Moses, saying,
Ex. 31:2 "See, I have called by name Bezalel, the son of Uri, the son of Hur, of the tribe of Judah.
Ex. 31:3 "I have filled him with the Spirit of God in wisdom, in understanding, in knowledge, and in all kinds of craftsmanship,
Ex. 31:4 to make artistic designs for work in gold, in silver, and in bronze,
Ex. 31:5 and in the cutting of stones for settings, and in the carving of wood, that he may work in all kinds of craftsmanship.
Ex. 31:6 "And behold, I Myself have appointed with him Oholiab, the son of Ahisamach, of the tribe of Dan; and in the hearts of all who are skillful I have put skill, that they may make all that I have commanded you:
Ex. 31:7 the tent of meeting, and the ark of testimony, and the mercy seat upon it, and all the furniture of the tent,
Ex. 31:8 the table also and its utensils, and the pure gold lampstand with all its utensils, and the altar of incense,
Ex. 31:9 the altar of burnt offering also with all its utensils, and the laver and its stand,
Ex. 31:10 the woven garments as well, and the holy garments for Aaron the priest, and the garments of his sons, with which to carry on their priesthood;
Ex. 31:11 the anointing oil also, and the fragrant incense for the holy place, they are to make them according to all that I have commanded you."

- Even while Moses is on the mountain receiving these instructions, the Lord has already selected and equipped the men Moses will need to accomplish this work
    - First, the Lord selects Bezalel, who is the grandson of Hur
        - You will remember that Hur is the name of the one of the men who held up Moses hands in the battle against Amalek
        - Now his grandson has been selected to lead all the construction of the tabernacle
        - The Lord has not only selected this man but equipped him for the duties he will be assigned
            - This man will have the ability to design in metal, to cut stone and to carve wood
            - These are the basic building materials in the tabernacle
            - And with his skills, he will oversee all the work
    - Secondly, the Lord will raise up Oholiab to work under Bezalel

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- Plus the Lord will raise up other craftsman to work along these men
- Collectively, the camp of Israel will find every construction talent they require to obey God's instructions

- By these words of assurance God gave Moses, we can take away three essential lessons concerning our service to the Lord
  - First, God chooses men to serve Him
    - Bezalel and Oholiab were never asked to enlist in God's work crew
    - At this point they don't even know they've been selected, do they?
    - Moses will have to deliver this news to them when he returns, and I suspect they might be surprised to hear it
      - Leadership among God's people is a privilege and it can take various forms
      - But it comes from the Lord, and when it comes, it's an offer you can't refuse...literally
    - Men are called to acknowledge the call of God
      - First we recognize it in ourselves and respond in obedience
      - Secondly, we recognize it in others and respect that calling as from the Lord
  - Secondly, when the call comes, we can't allow our fears or doubts to become an excuse for not obeying God's call
    - The instructions God gave to Moses give every impression that neither of these men were skilled artisans prior to the Lord's call
      - The sense of the passage is that God had equipped these men specifically for this task
      - We should imagine they were surprised themselves to discover they could perform these duties
      - I wonder if they hesitated to follow Moses' orders when they first heard the news?

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        - But like Moses himself, scripture demonstrates that the one God calls, He will also equip for that calling

    - These men couldn't use their previous inexperience as an excuse

        - They had all the experience they needed, because God gave them that expertise supernaturally by the Holy Spirit

        - Likewise, we are given gifts at the point of salvation which become our means to serve and glorify God

            - So these men couldn't have refused their assignment on the basis of skills or preparation

            - Neither can we turn our backs on the Lord's call simply because we lack the pedigree or training we assume is necessary

            - We will work for the Lord using the gifts and talents He has given us

        - Remember, God isn't in the habit of calling qualified men who can then glorify Him by the use of their skills

        - Rather, He equips unqualified men to glorify Him by their obedience

    - Finally, God raises men up to work in partnerships of one kind or another

        - Just like God brought Moses the 70 elders, now he's bringing two craftsmen and a host of others to join in the work

        - When the work matters to God, He will ensure the resources are there to get that work accomplished

            - He'll bring the materials, the expertise, the hands and the feet

            - Each person who is called must labor, certainly, but the work will never languish for the want of supply

- Now, having set forth how the work will be accomplished, the Lord returns briefly to the topic of the Sabbath

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Ex. 31:12 The LORD spoke to Moses, saying,
Ex. 31:13 "But as for you, speak to the sons of Israel, saying, 'You shall surely observe My sabbaths; for this is a sign between Me and you throughout your generations, that you may know that I am the LORD who sanctifies you.
Ex. 31:14 'Therefore you are to observe the sabbath, for it is holy to you. Everyone who profanes it shall surely be put to death; for whoever does any work on it, that person shall be cut off from among his people.
Ex. 31:15 'For six days work may be done, but on the seventh day there is a sabbath of complete rest, holy to the LORD; whoever does any work on the sabbath day shall surely be put to death.
Ex. 31:16 'So the sons of Israel shall observe the sabbath, to celebrate the sabbath throughout their generations as a perpetual covenant.'
Ex. 31:17 "It is a sign between Me and the sons of Israel forever; for in six days the LORD made heaven and earth, but on the seventh day He ceased from labor, and was refreshed."

- As Moses' forty days on the mountain comes to a close, the Lord reminds Moses of His instructions concerning the sabbath
    - We've studied the principle of the sabbath, its meaning and its relationship to Christ in a previous lesson
        - So in this passage, we're only going to look at a few new details
    - First, Moses is told the Sabbath instruction, which the Lord had previously given Moses, was now to be a sign for the covenant
        - Every covenant included a sign of some kind
            - A covenant was similar to a contract, in that is was a solemn agreement between parties
            - Like any agreement, the parties needed some kind of memorial or evidence that a covenant exists
            - Like a signature on a contract, the sign of a covenant reminded both parties that the agreement was in force
        - We've seen signs in earlier covenants
            - The sign of the Noahic covenant was the rainbow
            - The sign of the Abrahamic covenant was circumcision

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- And now we're told that the sign of the Mosaic covenant between the Lord and the people of Israel would be the Sabbath day itself

- We now learn that the Sabbath day was included in the covenant so that it would become the sign of the covenant
  - As long as this covenant remains in effect between the Lord and Israel, the requirement for the Sabbath remains in effect
  - Even though the Messiah has come and fulfilled the Law for believers, the nation of Israel is still observing a Sabbath
  - Indicating that the covenant is still in effect for that nation
  - As you may know from the Revelation study, that the Mosaic covenant is the cause for the Jews experiencing Tribulation in a future day
    - And its result is a glorified nation that will finally embrace their Messiah

- Furthermore, we learn something about our New Covenant when we consider the sign of the Old Covenant
  - The sign given in the New Covenant is the indwelling of the Holy Spirit in every new believer
    - Like all covenants, the New Covenant is forever, and therefore so is the indwelling of the Holy Spirit
    - But that indwelling is also called the circumcision of the heart in scripture

Col. 2:9 **For in Him all the fullness of Deity dwells in bodily form,**
Col. 2:10 **and in Him you have been made complete, and He is the head over all rule and authority;**
Col. 2:11 **and in Him you were also circumcised with a circumcision made without hands, in the removal of the body of the flesh by the circumcision of Christ;**
Col. 2:12 **having been buried with Him in baptism, in which you were also raised up with Him through faith in the working of God, who raised Him from the dead.**

  - What does it mean that our covenant has as its sign a type of circumcision?

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- It teaches us that the New Covenant is connected to the Abrahamic covenant, not the Mosaic covenant
- Abraham's covenant included a promise to produce a seed that would bless all the nations on the earth
    - Jesus was that Seed and that blessing was the New Covenant described in Jeremiah 31
    - We are being invited into the fulfillment of the Abrahamic covenant even while Israel is still waiting for it

- Paul describes this temporary reversal of fortune in Romans 11
    - He taught that the Gentiles are being grafted into the promise given to Abraham while Israel has been hardened for a time
        - And as we enter into the New Covenant, we receive the sign of the New Covenant, which is the baptism of the Holy Spirit or the circumcision of the heart
        - Spiritually speaking, the Holy Spirit cuts away the veil over our heart that original sin deposited, thereby allowing us to know the Lord
        - Like the foreskin removed in physical circumcision upon Abraham's entrance into his covenant
    - But the Mosaic Covenant plays no part in our relationship with Christ, since He fulfilled that covenant on our behalf
        - We trace our salvation to a promise given to Abraham
        - Not to a covenant given to Israel through Moses
    - As Paul taught in Galatians

Gal. 3:17 **What I am saying is this: the Law, which came four hundred and thirty years later, does not invalidate a covenant previously ratified by God, so as to nullify the promise.**
Gal. 3:18 **For if the inheritance is based on law, it is no longer based on a promise; but God has granted it to Abraham by means of a promise.**
Gal. 3:19 **Why the Law then? It was added because of transgressions, having been ordained through angels by the agency of a mediator, until the seed would come to whom the promise had been made.**

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- The second reason the Sabbath is discussed at this point in Exodus is to help us see an important connection between the tabernacle and the Creation story
    - In v.17 the Lord repeats that the Sabbath was to be observed because the Lord Himself rested after the six days of Creation
        - The Lord wants us to see a connection between those two moments
        - And there is a strong connection
    - If we look at the creation account and the time of Israel at the mountain, we find a long list of parallels
        - In both cases the subjects of the stories is how God made a way for made for fellowship with man
            - In Creation, the Lord created the world and made a Garden and created Man in the garden for fellowship
            - In the wilderness, God created a covenant and made a tabernacle, and created Israel for fellowship
        - In both cases, the Lord's Spirit is said to be involved in the Creation process
            - In Genesis, the Spirit of God is central to formation of the Creation and the breath of man
            - In Exodus, the Spirit empowers the workmen to build the structures
        - In both cases, the narrative progresses through seven stages, each one beginning with the words, "And the Lord said"
        - In Creation, God made Adam and Woman according to a specific pattern, which was the likeness of God
            - The Tabernacle was made according to a specific pattern, which is the tabernacle in Heaven
        - The Garden contained gold, and precious jewels, and Cherubim guarded it
            - The tabernacle contained gold and precious stones and Cherubim guarded the mercy seat

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        - When the work was finished in Creation, the Lord inspected it and pronounced a blessing upon it ("very good")
            - When the tabernacle is finished in chapter 39, the Lord has Moses inspect it and pronounce a blessing
        - God rested on the seventh day of Creation
            - And now the Lord is reminding the Israelites that they must rest on the seventh day, even while they work to build the tabernacle

- Why does God want us to make this connection?
    - The answer comes from one more important comparison between the Creation account and Israel's time in the wilderness
        - After the Creation was finished, the Man and Woman fell to disobedience because of an animal that tempted them to sin
            - When Adam and Woman fell they violated the terms of the covenant they were given in the Garden
            - They were told not to eat of the fruit, and so long as they obeyed that command, they could enjoy the fellowship God established for them
        - But when they disobeyed, the violated the covenant and they suffered a great penalty
            - That penalty involved both an immediate consequence and a long term consequence
            - Immediately they suffered the penalty of leaving the place God prepared for them
            - In the future they would suffer the penalty of the curse, when their physical bodies died
    - In the same way, there will be a fall following the establishment of the covenant between Israel and the Lord
        - They nation of Israel will be temped into sin by Satan hiding in the image of an animal
        - And by their fall, the nation will violate the most important and most basic of the commandments in the Law

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- They will break the covenant and they will suffer a great penalty
    - The penalty will include both an immediate consequence and a long term consequence
    - The Lord will pronounce immediate punishment and long term punishment
    - In fact, the covenant itself has provision for curses against Israel for their failure to keep the terms of the covenant

- We study that rebellion next in chapters 32-34, but first we need to set the stage for the transition of Moses leaving the mountain

Ex. 31:18 **When He had finished speaking with him upon Mount Sinai, He gave Moses the two tablets of the testimony, tablets of stone, written by the finger of God.**

- Most has been on the mountain for forty days and forty nights
    - That time period corresponds to chapters 24-31
    - While Moses has been on the mountain, the people of Israel have lacked their leader
    - And without the leader, they begin to revert to old thinking and old behaviors

Ex. 32:1 **Now when the people saw that Moses delayed to come down from the mountain, the people assembled about Aaron and said to him, "Come, make us a god who will go before us; as for this Moses, the man who brought us up from the land of Egypt, we do not know what has become of him."**
Ex. 32:2 **Aaron said to them, "Tear off the gold rings which are in the ears of your wives, your sons, and your daughters, and bring them to me."**
Ex. 32:3 **Then all the people tore off the gold rings which were in their ears and brought them to Aaron.**
Ex. 32:4 **He took this from their hand, and fashioned it with a graving tool and made it into a molten calf; and they said, "This is your god, O Israel, who brought you up from the land of Egypt."**
Ex. 32:5 **Now when Aaron saw this, he built an altar before it; and Aaron made a proclamation and said, "Tomorrow shall be a feast to the LORD."**
Ex. 32:6 **So the next day they rose early and offered burnt offerings, and brought peace offerings; and the people sat down to eat and to drink, and rose up to play.**

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- We remember that when Moses went up the mountain that Joshua accompanied him half way
    - So both of these men have been away from the camp for forty days
        - How did the Lord sustain these men during those forty days?
        - The same way the Lord sustained the nation of Israel...manna
        - Every morning the manna has been coming reliably
    - But while they've been gone, the nation has become impatient
        - The text says they encouraged Aaron, who had been left in charge, to make a golden calf idol for the nation
            - They say they don't know what happened to Moses
            - As if to suggest he isn't coming back
        - But why does Moses' absence lead the nation to want a golden calf of all things?
            - Realistically, how do they expect a golden calf to lead them anywhere?
            - There is more going on here than meets the eye
            - And it makes their sin even more troubling
            - And it will lead to another connection to the Creation story in the Garden
- First, let's take note of what Aaron does in response to their request
    - Later we're going to hear him retell this story to Moses in a creative way
        - We'll wait until then to consider Aaron's role in this plan
        - For now we'll just examine his actions
    - First, he directs all the people to produce gold by giving up the gold in their ears
        - Perhaps Aaron thought this would cause the people to rethink their commitment to the plan, since they were begin asked to give up substantial wealth
        - Whatever he may have thought, the people didn't hesitate

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        - The text says that they tore off their rings and handed them to Moses
        - Next, Aaron melted them down, and fashioned the gold into a golden calf
        - Then he built an altar before the calf
            - And of course an altar implies that they performed a sacrifice before the calf
            - And in v.6 we see the offerings taking place
    - Finally, Aaron announces that a feast will take place tomorrow in honor of the Lord
        - Aaron tells Israel that this calf was the Lord who lead Israel out of Egypt
        - Israel is not worshipping the calf as if it were a different god
            - They are worshipping the true God, Jehovah
        - They have created a graven image of God
            - Remember the purpose of this calf: to replace Moses
            - Moses was the visible representative of God
            - Since Moses was gone, the people wanted someone or something else visible to replace Moses as God's representative
- Having this understanding makes the people's behavior even harder to understand
    - If they just wanted a leader, why didn't they just ask Aaron to be their leader?
        - Why did they prefer a calf made of gold for their leader?
        - The true motivation of the people is found in three clues
            - The first comes in the last verse I read
    - In v.6 we're told the Israelites made their sacrifices, then sat down to eat and drink and the rose up to play
        - The eating was a natural result of the sacrifices

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- After a bunch of animals were sacrificed, the people would roast and eat the meat
    - They've been living on manna now for several months straight
    - So the chance to eat some meat was high on their priority list

- Then it says they rose up to "play"
    - The word in Hebrew means sexual promiscuity
    - The kind of play involved here is not something you find on a playground (hopefully)
    - The people feasted then engaged in a mass orgy
        - In fact, in v.25 Moses sees that the people were uncovered or without clothing
    - So our first clue is that the people were intent on feasting and sexual immorality

- The second clue comes from a poetic commentary on this moment in Psalm 106
    - The psalmist comments on this incident and says

Psa. 106:13 **They quickly forgot His works;**
They did not wait for His counsel,
Psa. 106:14 **But craved intensely in the wilderness,**
And tempted God in the desert.

- The psalmist says the reason the people rebelled was because they craved intensely in the wilderness
- What did they crave?
    - The classics...meat and sex
- So the second clue is that it was a craving of the flesh that drove the people in the rebellion

- But why did they request a golden calf then? We get the answer from our final clue, taken from Paul's first letter to Corinth

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1Cor. 10:1 For I do not want you to be unaware, brethren, that our fathers were all under the cloud and all passed through the sea;
1Cor. 10:2 and all were baptized into Moses in the cloud and in the sea;
1Cor. 10:3 and all ate the same spiritual food;
1Cor. 10:4 and all drank the same spiritual drink, for they were drinking from a spiritual rock which followed them; and the rock was Christ.
1Cor. 10:5 Nevertheless, with most of them God was not well-pleased; for they were laid low in the wilderness.
1Cor. 10:6 Now these things happened as examples for us, so that we would not crave evil things as they also craved.
1Cor. 10:7 Do not be idolaters, as some of them were; as it is written, "THE PEOPLE SAT DOWN TO EAT AND DRINK, AND STOOD UP TO PLAY."
1Cor. 10:8 Nor let us act immorally, as some of them did, and twenty-three thousand fell in one day.
1Cor. 10:9 Nor let us try the Lord, as some of them did, and were destroyed by the serpents.
1Cor. 10:10 Nor grumble, as some of them did, and were destroyed by the destroyer.
1Cor. 10:11 Now these things happened to them as an example, and they were written for our instruction, upon whom the ends of the ages have come.

- Paul teaches the Christians in Corinth a lesson by drawing a comparison to the people of Israel who rebelled in Exodus 32
    - Paul begins by reminding us that the people of Israel had all experienced great manifestations of the Lord
        - They had seen the sea divided and the pillar of cloud
        - They ate the manna and drank from the rock
        - In fact, Paul says the fire that followed them to protect them from their enemies was Christ Himself, the Angel of the Lord
    - Then Paul turns to make his point that their exposure to these incredible manifestations of God didn't protect them from falling to the temptations of their flesh
        - And as a result of their cravings they were laid-low
        - Paul says some of them were idolaters, because not all Israel participated in the event
        - Then he repeats that key phrase from chapter 32

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- FInally, Paul links this occurrence with several other notable examples of Israel's rebellion in the desert
    - In v.8 Paul refers to an incident in Numbers 25 when Balaam told Balak to weaken Israel by enticing the Jewish men to have sex with Moabite women
        - The women agreed to allow the men to come into them if the men first agreed to worship before their god Baal
        - As a result of that sin, God struck down 23,000 who participated in this sin
    - In v.9 Paul refers to Number 21 when the people grumbled over the miserable food the Lord was providing them
        - In response, the Lord sent fiery serpents into the camp to kill the people with their bite
        - Only if the people looked upon the bronze snake on the pole would they survive
    - In v.10 Paul references Numbers 16 when the nation again is called greedy for wanting meat instead of manna
        - So God sends an angel to take the life of many at the outskirts of the camp with a fire
- What's the common denominator in all Paul's examples?
    - Fleshly desires for sex or food
        - Why is Paul raising this concern for the church in Corinth?
        - Because the church was playing with fire
            - They were going to the local pagan temples in Corinth to enjoy a nice night on the town
            - The temples were the best place to buy a nice steak dinner
            - But they also featured idol worship and prostitution
    - So Paul reminds the church that even though they had liberty to eat the meat in that place, they should think twice about subjecting themselves to such temptations

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        - The Israelites had seen great things from God, but they still fell into sin propelled by their fleshly desire for good food or physical pleasure

        - Paul wanted his readers to consider that they could fall in the same way if they underestimated the power of the flesh to draw us into sin

- So with all three clues, we can come to a better appreciation for what the Israelites were doing with that calf

    - We know the Israelites didn't reject the Lord as God, but they wanted a leader

        - They had become impatient waiting for Moses to return down the mountain

        - So they ask Aaron to make a god, a leader, someone they can sacrifice to

            - Worshipping bovines was a common practice in the Egypt they left behind, something the Jews would have been familiar with

            - Egypt worship practices also involved sacrifices, which then led to eating lots of meat and sexual acts of worship

    - So the Israelites had spent 40 days eating manna and waiting for Moses to return so they could have a sacrifice and the meat that it offered, and they had cravings

        - Without a leader, there was no one who could lead worship

            - This is before the priesthood, so the only representative of God the people had was Moses

        - WIthout Moses, there was no one to perform the sacrifice and permit a feast

        - So they ask Aaron to give them an excuse to sacrifice and feast, and Aaron obliges

    - Their fleshly cravings led them into idolatry, the sin of making graven images

        - And next time, we will see the Lord respond

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Exodus 32

- As we learned last week, the Lord has reinforced throughout the ages and with every dispensation that His grace would not be fully realized until Christ
    - The earlier manifestations of His grace served to regular man's relationship with God for a time
        - But none of them were intended as a true solution to man's sin
        - They couldn't address the fundamental problem created by Adam's fall in the Garden, which is the power sin holds over us
            - Sin defines our nature and therefore our behavior
        - Earlier dispensations served to contend with man's sin and mitigate against its effects to a degree
            - But they could not remove sin
        - They regulated man's fellowship with God for a time until the greater revelation of God was made available
            - Therefore, each new dispensation revealed more of the Lord and HIs plan
    - That plan was culminated in the dispensation of grace in Christ, but until that moment God designed each earlier dispensation to make clear its inadequacy
        - The Lord always demonstrated the weakness of prior dispensations by showing the continuation of sin's power
        - After each new dispensation arrived, the protagonist inevitably succumbed to sin's power, demonstrating that the work of God was still incomplete
        - But when Christ came, that pattern changed
            - Jesus lived a sinless life, showing it had no power over Him
            - Then He died and rose again, conquering the penalty of sin, that is death, thus proving He could be the solution to our sin

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- So in Exodus, we;re studying the dispensation of Law and the covenant that brought the Law
    - And therefore we must expect at some point to see the pattern I described re-emerge
    - The arrival of the dispensation of Law must include an example of sin's continuing power over our protagonists, the nation of Israel
    - God must show us that the Law was incapable of addressing the root cause of sin or breaking its power over men
- The story of Israel at the base of mountain is that account
    - This story shows us the inability of the Law to create righteousness
    - Proving what Paul teaches, that the Law did not come to produce righteousness
    - Because it is weak and worthless in that regard, as Hebrews says

- So turning back to our story in Chapter 32, Moses has been on the top of the mountain for forty days, and the people below have grown impatient
    - They are being deceived by their own flesh, which is craving for meat and sexual pleasure, leading them into idolatry
        - So they request a new leader to represent God
        - The new leader will preside over their sacrificial offerings, which then makes possible the feast that follows, which is what they seek after
            - So Aaron complies and makes an idol and an altar
        - The people then celebrate with a feast and debauchery
    - As we rejoin the narrative, let's also considered how these circumstances mirror the time in the Garden, when Adam and Woman fell
        - As we noted last week, both scenes begin as relationships based upon a covenant with the Lord
        - In both cases, God provided them with all the food they needed
        - And in both cases, what God provided wasn't good enough

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- Both craved after prohibited things and sinned
- And as a result, both traded what they had for judgment and exile

- We join Moses is still on the mountain with the Lord, but the Lord warns Moses what to expect when he returns to the camp

Ex. 32:7 Then the LORD spoke to Moses, "Go down at once, for your people, whom you brought up from the land of Egypt, have corrupted themselves.
Ex. 32:8 "They have quickly turned aside from the way which I commanded them. They have made for themselves a molten calf, and have worshiped it and have sacrificed to it and said, 'This is your god, O Israel, who brought you up from the land of Egypt!'"
Ex. 32:9 The LORD said to Moses, "I have seen this people, and behold, they are an obstinate people.
Ex. 32:10 "Now then let Me alone, that My anger may burn against them and that I may destroy them; and I will make of you a great nation."
Ex. 32:11 Then Moses entreated the LORD his God, and said, "O LORD, why does Your anger burn against Your people whom You have brought out from the land of Egypt with great power and with a mighty hand?
Ex. 32:12 "Why should the Egyptians speak, saying, 'With evil intent He brought them out to kill them in the mountains and to destroy them from the face of the earth'? Turn from Your burning anger and change Your mind about doing harm to Your people.
Ex. 32:13 "Remember Abraham, Isaac, and Israel, Your servants to whom You swore by Yourself, and said to them, 'I will multiply your descendants as the stars of the heavens, and all this land of which I have spoken I will give to your descendants, and they shall inherit it forever.'"
Ex. 32:14 So the LORD changed His mind about the harm which He said He would do to His people.

- We must imagine that Moses was surprised and very disturbed to hear the news about the people
  - The Lord says that Moses' people are corrupted
    - Notice the Lord isn't calling Israel "His" people
    - He is calling them Moses' people now
  - He says they have turned aside from the Law they agreed to follow, barely forty days after the agreed to observe it
    - Moses hears they have made an idol, worshipped it, and sacrificed to it

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        - How disheartening it must have been for Moses to learn this

    - This moment is all the proof we need to know the powerlessness of the Law to produce righteousness

        - The people had been given the Law, they had agreed to it, and it was no doubt fresh on their minds

        - Furthermore, they had experienced remarkable manifestations of the living God

        - Finally, they had first-hand evidence of the Lord's presence through the manna and the cloud covering the top of the mountain

        - Nevertheless, they quickly decided to follow their flesh instead of obeying the Law

            - We've never seen the manifestations these people saw

            - So how could we expect anyone to be sanctified by follow a Law that Israel couldn't follow for forty days?

        - Clearly the Law does not have the power to put an end to sin much less bring righteousness

- Let's consider why the Lord chose to share this news with Moses in this way, while they were meeting on the mountain

    - The Lord could have waited for Moses to learn on his own, but the Lord wanted to invite Moses into a conversation now

        - First, we've already noted how the Lord pointedly called Israel Moses' people, not His own people

        - Then in v.9 the Lord declares that the Jewish people are an obstinate people

            - The word obstinate literally translates as the back of the neck

            - God is saying that they are stubborn and stiff-necked

        - The reason God uses the neck as his description of the people is because the neck controls the attitude of the head

            - When the head is submitted, it bows

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- When it is resistant, it remains upright
- The neck that's stiff refuses to submit to God's authority
- These people are have not submitted to His authority

- The Lord is leading Moses to a conclusion
  - The people haven't submitted to the Lord's authority
    - They are following Moses, yes, but they aren't following the Lord in the hearts
    - Which is why the Lord called them Moses' people
  - Secondly, Moses knows what it means to resist the Lord's will
    - He saw the effect in Egypt, as the nation was crushed
    - And he saw it in his own life when the Lord sought to take his son's life for Moses' disobedience
    - So Moses knows that the Lord is willing to bring judgment for failure to submit
  - Finally, Moses realizes that something must be done or the people will perish and he is the only one to do it
    - The Lord has allowed Moses to become the hope of Israel in this moment
    - If Moses is willing to intercede, the nation can be spared

- The key to understanding this scene is noticing the Lord says "let Me alone" so the Lord's anger may destroy the people
  - The Lord is testing Moses
    - The Lord has given Moses a opportunity to intercede
    - The Lord prepared to act in judgment over these people, but He is also willing to forgo punishment for the sake of His servant Moses
  - So then Moses responds in the expected manner
    - Instead of leaving God alone as the Lord asked, Moses does the opposite

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- He petitions the Lord to save Israel
- Moses intercedes for Israel as their representative

- Moses makes his appeal based on three arguments
  - First Moses appeals to God's love and compassion
    - He says these are the people you brought up out of Egypt
    - Moses is implying that the Lord's prior actions demonstrate His care for the nation, and so He can't reject those He has chosen
  - Secondly, Moses appeals to the Lord's name and reputation
    - Should the Lord destroy Israel, then the testimony of the Exodus would be entirely different than it is today
    - Instead of a story of the Lord rescuing His people from slavery, it would be a story of God destroying His people
    - And God enemies could use this to impugn God's character
  - Finally, Moses reminds God of His promises to Abraham
    - Moses was descendant of Abraham, so the Lord could have restarted the nation with Moses
    - Moses is one of Abraham's descendants himself, no different than the rest of Israel
      - So why would there be any likelihood that Moses' descendants would do any better than the rest of Israel?
      - The problem of sin in Israel isn't going to come to an end just because the nation starts again with Moses

- Then Moses tries to close the deal in v.12 Moses by asking God to change His mind
  - So in v.14, we're told that God responds to Moses' request by agreeing to change His plans
    - This statement commonly cause students some concern, since we know that other scripture tells us that God does not change His mind

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1Sam. 15:29 "Also the Glory of Israel will not lie or change His mind; for He is not a man that He should change His mind."

- How do we understand what's happening here then?

- First, remember how this conversation started
  - The Lord told Moses to "let me alone" and if Moses complied, then the Lord would destroy Israel
  - This was a clear invitation for Moses to intervene and advocate for the sake of Israel
    - The Lord expected Moses to intervene, and he did
    - So clearly the Lord didn't intend to destroy His people
    - God wanted Moses to assume the role of intercessor for Israel

- Secondly, students of Genesis should notice a striking similarity between this moment and the moment when God visited Abraham before destroying Sodom and Gomorrah in Genesis 18
  - In that situation, the Lord intended to destroy wickedness and gave Abraham a chance to spare the righteous
    - God revealed a plan in advance
    - Abraham interceded for Lot and his family desiring to change God's plan
    - God agreed to Abraham's request
    - But Abraham's intercession confirmed the very thing God intended to do in the first place
    - From Abraham's point of view he thought he had influencing the outcome and changed God's mind
    - Nevertheless, his intercession went according to God's plan, which is why the Lord revealed His plans in advance
  - This moment in Exodus 32 plays out in a similar fashion
    - The Lord invites Moses to act as an intercessor to save Israel from the destruction they deserve

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        - But the Lord has no intention of destroying the nation
        - Nevertheless, the Lord will punish the guilty for their sin against Him
        - And then He intends to bring the penalties required under the covenant against the nation as a whole in a future day
        - In the meantime, the Lord is teaching Moses and the people a lesson about both the consequences of sin and the necessity of an intercessor
    - So, when we hear that God changed his mind in v.14, it is written from Moses' perspective
        - From the perspective of man, God appears to have changed His mind
        - But this change was not a true change in God's plan
        - God orchestrated the circumstances by which this supposed "change" would take place
            - God chose the moment to reveal the news to Moses
            - God set the terms when he gave Mosses the chance to leave God alone so He could destroy Israel
            - In the end, Moses responded as intended, so God did exactly as He intended
        - From man's point of view, God changed His mind
        - But from God's perspective, everything went as planned
- Through this encounter, the Lord accomplished three things
    - First, the Lord sets the expectation that as the individual Jew goes, so goes the nation under the covenant
        - The Lord was prepared to wipe out all Israel because of the sins of a few who participated in this debauchery
        - And this is the natural result of a national covenant
        - If any in the nation sin under the agreement, then the entire nation has broken the covenant

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- This principle becomes the basis for the Lord setting the entire nation outside the land in a future day because of the sins of the leaders
- This is why the entire nation lost opportunity to receive the Messiah when the Pharisee's rejected Jesus, though some Jews accepted Him
- But this is also why the Bible says the Lord will save all Israel on earth in the last day
- God will always treat the nation of people who are Israel as a nation because of this covenant

- Secondly, the Lord prepares Moses to act as His representative
  - As God's representative, Moses must know God's wrath and intolerance for sin
  - And Moses must be prepared to act as judge when necessary
  - Yet Moses must also maintain a heart of compassion and understanding interceding on behalf of the people when the inevitable sin comes along
  - Like the Lord Himself, Moses must judge the people, but he is not called to destroy the people
- Finally, the Lord used Moses to yield a powerful picture of Christ in this exchange
  - Moses is the representative of God's people before the Lord
    - He must intercede on behalf of the people to save them from God's wrath for sin
    - And because of Moses work, the Lord will not bring His wrath agains the people
    - The people deserve destruction, but because of the work of another on their behalf, they can be spared from the wrath of God
  - And the picture works in another way as well
    - Jesus acts as both to intercede and to judge

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- Today, Jesus is serving as our representative to the Father, interceding on our behalf in the face of our sins
- But in a future day, the Father will assign all judgment to the Son and He will bring judgment against all sin

- So Moses will fulfill both sides of the picture
  - He will not only intercede to spare Israel, but he also exacts God's justice
  - For though the Lord won't bring all Israel to destruction, He will judge sin

- So now that Moses has been prepared for what to find at the base of the mountain and has interceded for the people, he returns

Ex. 32:15 Then Moses turned and went down from the mountain with the two tablets of the testimony in his hand, tablets which were written on both sides; they were written on one side and the other.
Ex. 32:16 The tablets were God's work, and the writing was God's writing engraved on the tablets.
Ex. 32:17 Now when Joshua heard the sound of the people as they shouted, he said to Moses, "There is a sound of war in the camp."
Ex. 32:18 But he said,
"It is not the sound of the cry of triumph,
Nor is it the sound of the cry of defeat;
But the sound of singing I hear."
Ex. 32:19 It came about, as soon as Moses came near the camp, that he saw the calf and the dancing; and Moses' anger burned, and he threw the tablets from his hands and shattered them at the foot of the mountain.

- Moses returns carrying the two tablets
  - As we discussed earlier in the study, the tablets were written on front and back in duplicate
    - Each tablet contained a complete set of God's commands
    - And they were written by the finger of God
    - We also know that angels were involved in the delivery, so it's likely that the angels attended to the preparing of the stones in some way

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        - But the handwriting was God's
            - The only other time we hear of God's finger writing was when Jesus wrote in the dirt in John 8
            - This has led some to think that Jesus was writing the Law again to make a point
            - I have my own theory, which you can learn in the teaching on the Adulterous Woman in John 8
    - As Moses descends, he meets back up with Joshua, who has been enjoying an extended period of alone time on the mountain
        - Joshua was left here for the same 40 days Moses was above
        - When they meet up, Joshua remarks that the sound in the camp below sounds like war taking place
        - What he probably meant was that sounds of men and women shrieking or crying out sounded like that of men and women dying or in distress
        - But Moses knew better
        - He says it's not triumph or defeat in battle
            - It's singing
- Once Moses gets within sight of the camp, he finds quite a scene
    - First, he saw the calf
        - This idol was intended to replace Moses and lead the people
        - Ironically, the calf was to stand for God but it actually represented Satan
        - In fact, Baal is a pagan god associated with Satan worship in the form of a bull
    - Next he witnessed dancing
        - Dancing isn't itself a problem,
            - There is a holy form which is praise to God
        - The problem is when dancing becomes an alcohol-fueled prelude to sexual activity...that's sin

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- A close second would be any type of dancing that I attempt

- In response to what he saw, Moses reacts in anger
  - He throws the tablets down on the ground and they break
  - In that instant, Moses created a perfect symbol of the moment
    - The people of Israel had broken the ten commandments
    - And they had broken the covenant they had made with the Lord

- Moses then takes several steps to correct the situation

Ex. 32:19 It came about, as soon as Moses came near the camp, that he saw the calf and the dancing; and Moses' anger burned, and he threw the tablets from his hands and shattered them at the foot of the mountain.
Ex. 32:20 He took the calf which they had made and burned it with fire, and ground it to powder, and scattered it over the surface of the water and made the sons of Israel drink it.

- Moses breaks up the festivities, seizes the calf
  - Then Moses proceeds to destroy the calf
    - First he burns it
    - Then he ground it into powder
    - Then he scattered the powder on water so that the Israelites drank it
  - This descriptions raises a number of questions
    - Like how can gold be burned?
    - Why did Moses want the people to drink it?
  - First, the construction of the calf was not pure gold
    - Back in v.4 the description of Aaron's actions suggest carving took place
    - In Egypt, statues and idols were commonly made of wood and covered in layers of gold, which is probably what Aaron did

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        - So the idol could be burned to remove the wood leaving only the gold behind

    - Secondly, the gold slag was ground into powder, presumably through additional laborers Moses enlisted

        - Moses scattered the gold dust on the Israelites' water supply

        - The water supply at the base of the mountain was a lake formed from the flow of the water from the rock

        - Moses didn't line up the nation to drink the gold

            - He merely scattered the gold over water supply so that every Israelite couldn't help but consume the idol eventually

    - The point in this exercise was not as a punishment for Israel nor for atonement

        - The point was to destroy the idol fully and then pollute it so that it could never be reconstituted

        - Assuming the gold dust could have even be collected and melted down again, it had gone through the digestive tract of the people and become refuse

            - It was unclean now

            - The idol was now poop!

    - This same approach to destroying idols is repeated at other times in Israel's history

        - Josiah did a similar sort of thing with the Asherah idol he removed from the Jerusalem temple in 2 Kings 23:6

        - He ground it to powder and scattered the dust over the graves of the common people

        - Touching graves made something unclean

- With the idol gone, Moses turns to Aaron for an explanation

Ex. 32:21 **Then Moses said to Aaron, "What did this people do to you, that you have brought such great sin upon them?"**
Ex. 32:22 **Aaron said, "Do not let the anger of my lord burn; you know the people yourself, that they are prone to evil.**

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Ex. 32:23 "For they said to me, 'Make a god for us who will go before us; for this Moses, the man who brought us up from the land of Egypt, we do not know what has become of him.'
Ex. 32:24 "I said to them, 'Whoever has any gold, let them tear it off.' So they gave it to me, and I threw it into the fire, and out came this calf."

- Moses begins his inquiry by assuming that Aaron must have been forced to go along with this plan
    - Moses asks what did the people do to you that you would bring such a great sin upon the people?
        - And this is followed by one of the best (and by "best," I mean worst) excuses in all the Bible
        - In trying to defend himself, Aaron only proceeds to convict himself
    - Aaron begins by saying don't be anger with me
        - Generally speaking, anytime you hear an excuse begin with the phrase "Don't be angry..." you can be sure that when all has been said, you will have good reason to be angry
        - Aaron immediately places the blame on the people
            - Aaron reminds Moses that he knows these people are prone to evil
            - Wouldn't that be the reason Moses left Aaron in charge?
    - Then Aaron begins to retell what happened
        - It's interesting that we have Moses' account in the first part of this chapter given to us already
        - So now we can contrast it with Aaron's own account
            - If Aaron had known Moses was going to be writing all this down later, he might have chosen his words better
        - The differences between what Moses reported and what Aaron reported are readily apparent
            - Aaron says men came to him asking for a god to go before them, since Moses wasn't coming back (true)

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- Aaron says he replied by asking for gold (true)
- Then he placed the gold in the fire (true)

- And behold, out popped a calf - a miracle! (silly lie)

- In his retelling, Aaron does everything he can to remove himself from any of decisions
  - Others asked, he participated against his own will and the result was out of his hands
    - But even Moses' question suggests that Moses saw the situation differently
    - He says how did the people make you give in to such a bad idea?
      - As if to say, "I can't imagine any good reason why you would have voluntarily allowed this to take place."
      - So did they point a knife to your head?
    - Moses expected Aaron to lead Israel away from this situation
      - It reminds us that when the leaders are corrupt or incompetent, the people will always suffer
      - It doesn't require that a leader propose all the bad ideas
      - Bad leadership simply gives opportunity for group sin to emerge
      - The sheep are given shepherds because it's better than allowing sheep to oversee themselves, as this scene demonstrates
  - Hebrews teaches us that God expects leaders to give account for the results of those under their charge

Heb. 13:17 **Obey your leaders and submit to them, for they keep watch over your souls as those who will give an account. Let them do this with joy and not with grief, for this would be unprofitable for you.**

- The scripture commands us to obey and respect our leaders, because they tasked with watching over our souls

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- Watching over souls means shepherding our spiritual development
- That is the role of a spiritual leader in the church

- We are to make that job as easy as it can be, because the easier it is for a leader to shepherd us, the more we have opportunity to learn and mature
  - This truth is predicated on the assumption that our leaders are teaching and leading us in Biblically appropriate ways
  - But in any case, we should make their job easier, not harder
  - But if not, they will give an account (or report) of our souls
    - It seems that our spiritual leaders will have something to say about our compliance with their leadership
    - They will not judge us, but they still get to spend a few minutes on the witness stand
    - What will they say about us?

- Aaron's *coup de gras* was claiming that he played no part in forming the golden calf itself
  - He threw the gold in the fire and magically out came a calf, as if God Himself was responsible for the outcome
    - His explanation is so absurd, Moses doesn't even dignify it with an answer
    - Clearly Aaron was party to the sin, and Moses left it at that
  - Moses gets the last word on Aaron's culpability when he wrote the account of Exodus years later, as we see in the next verse

Ex. 32:25 Now when Moses saw that the people were out of control – for Aaron had let them get out of control to be a derision among their enemies –
Ex. 32:26 then Moses stood in the gate of the camp, and said, "Whoever is for the LORD, come to me!" And all the sons of Levi gathered together to him.
Ex. 32:27 He said to them, "Thus says the LORD, the God of Israel, 'Every man of you put his sword upon his thigh, and go back and forth from gate to gate in the camp, and kill every man his brother, and every man his friend, and every man his neighbor.'"
Ex. 32:28 So the sons of Levi did as Moses instructed, and about three thousand men of the people fell that day.

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- Moses then moves to make an example of the leaders of this rebellion
    - In v.25 we're told Moses saw the people out of control because Aaron allowed them to get this way
        - The phrase "out of control" is literally the word "unfastened" in Hebrew, referring to the way their clothes had come off
        - But this is not a present tense description
        - The text isn't speaking in the present tense
            - The rebellion ended earlier when Moses stopped it
        - We could translate this "Because Moses saw the people had been out of control..."
            - So we've moved past the immediate moment of the dancing and whatever else
            - We're now seeing the aftermath, the judgment Moses applied because of the earlier scene he witnessed
    - We remember from the earlier part of this chapter that the rebellion was instigated by a group of men within the camp
        - And these men led the rest of the nation into sin
        - Aaron's fault was in not standing up to these men
        - Perhaps he was intimidated by the number of them
        - So here we see Moses begin with judging the men who committed this sin against the Lord
    - Moses begins by asking for men who would stand with him
        - We might not understand the full sense of Moses' request, but the men in the camp certainly would have understood
            - Moses was asking for volunteers to perform the necessary justice against the men who committed the crime
            - Moses is asking for an impromptu executioners force, and everyone knew this is what Moses wanted

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- In the face of this request, only the tribe of Levi volunteered for the duty, perhaps because they wanted to stand with another member of their tribe

- So the Levites are called upon to kill the 3,000 men who instigated the rebellion in the camp

  - This required the men kill people they knew

    - The text indicates they found themselves required to kill brothers, friends and neighbors

    - This was a merciless punishment

  - Why does God ask for death in this case?

    - Simply because His word required this penalty

    - Furthermore, the penalty for sin under the Law is death

    - And the nation had yet to see God's justice in their own camp

  - They needed to understand the penalty that sin requires

  - They needed to appreciate the seriousness of the covenant

Ex. 32:29 Then Moses said, "Dedicate yourselves today to the LORD — for every man has been against his son and against his brother — in order that He may bestow a blessing upon you today."
Ex. 32:30 On the next day Moses said to the people, "You yourselves have committed a great sin; and now I am going up to the LORD, perhaps I can make atonement for your sin."
Ex. 32:31 Then Moses returned to the LORD, and said, "Alas, this people has committed a great sin, and they have made a god of gold for themselves.
Ex. 32:32 "But now, if You will, forgive their sin — and if not, please blot me out from Your book which You have written!"
Ex. 32:33 The LORD said to Moses, "Whoever has sinned against Me, I will blot him out of My book.
Ex. 32:34 "But go now, lead the people where I told you. Behold, My angel shall go before you; nevertheless in the day when I punish, I will punish them for their sin."
Ex. 32:35 Then the LORD smote the people, because of what they did with the calf which Aaron had made.

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- The result of the Levi's obedience opens the door for a restored relationship with the Lord
    - The covenant has been broken, and this cannot be undone
        - But still the covenant endures and the nation will continue to walk with the Lord
        - And to allowed for restored fellowship, there must be a price paid and an atonement made for the sin
            - In this case, the Lord doesn't choose to make a substitute available
            - Instead, He requires the life of ever man who led the rebellion
            - They will pay the price for their own sin
    - But there was still the matter of the nation's relationship with the Lord under the terms of the covenant
        - How will the nation's sin under the covenant itself be addressed?
        - So Moses needs to seek the Lord's forgiveness for the nation
        - He says he hopes that the Lord may be pleased with the removal of the sinners from the camp of Israel and bring a blessing to the people
            - The blessing would be the blessing of continued fellowship in the covenant
- The next day, Moses tells the people he is going back up the mountain to make his appeal to God
    - When Moses reaches the Lord again, he tells the Lord that You were right
        - Then Moses asks the Lord to forgive the people for their sin under the covenant
            - And if the Lord will not forgive them, Moses asks to be condemned in their place
            - He says blot me out of the book of life, which is the book recording the names of the saints

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- Moses would be willing to receive the punishment that God was preparing to give the entire nation

- What makes Moses volunteer to do such a thing?
  - It seems he has embraced his role of representing the people
  - Evidently, Moses believes his role as intercessor includes taking upon himself the sin of the people
  - But Moses makes a mistake here
    - He assumes that his leadership role and his earnestness is enough to atone for sin
    - He asks God for to forgive the people under the terms of the covenant yet without making a payment for sin
    - Yes, the 3,000 men died, but they merely paid the price for their own sin
    - What about the sin of the nation regarding the terms of the Law?
  - Obviously, Moses is continuing the picture of Jesus we saw earlier
    - Not only is Moses the intercessor for the nation
    - Now he's offering to be a sacrifice in their place, which is the atoning work Jesus did on the cross
- But Moses failed to understand that God is perfect in mercy <u>and</u> justice
  - God can't overlook sin without a suitable payment, or else that would be injustice
  - While Moses offered himself as payment, Moses isn't sinless
    - He can't serve as a substitute for a sinful nation
    - So the Lord rejects Moses' offer

- The says that whoever has sinned against the Lord will not be found in the book of life
  - This is a poetic way of saying they will not have eternal life
    - This is a general truth of scripture

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        - Whoever has sinned against God will suffer the penalty of eternal death

    - There is no getting around that penalty

        - The only way out is to have someone else pay that penalty

        - But Moses isn't going to be that person

        - He merely pictures that Person

- FInally, the Lord says the nation of Israel not be vindicated from the consequences of this sin

    - The Lord will punish the nation in the day to come

        - Ultimately, that punishment will span generations

        - And it will culminate in the judgments of Tribulation

    - Remember, the nation as a whole is under condemnation because of breaking the covenant

    - And the Lord says that day of reckoning must happen

        - Moses can't stop it with his appeals

        - And even the death of the 3,000 doesn't change the terms of the covenant for the nation

- The Lord will continue to lead Israel in the desert for a time, but a day of reckoning will come for the nation

    - That future day of reckoning will be based on the sin of Israel against God under this covenant

        - That sin began here in this moment

        - But it continued throughout the history of Israel, because the Law couldn't contend with the root problem of sin

    - Moses speaks prophetically of this pattern of sin in Israel in his last words to the nation in Deuteronomy

        - His speech is most of Deut 32,

        - Reading sections of it gives us the overview of how the Lord intends to fulfill His promise to judge Israel

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Deut. 32:5 "They have acted corruptly toward Him,
They are not His children, because of their defect;
But are a perverse and crooked generation.
Deut. 32:6 "Do you thus repay the LORD,
O foolish and unwise people?
Is not He your Father who has bought you?
He has made you and established you.

Deut. 32:16 "They made Him jealous with strange gods;
With abominations they provoked Him to anger.
Deut. 32:17 "They sacrificed to demons who were not God,
To gods whom they have not known,
New gods who came lately,
Whom your fathers did not dread.
Deut. 32:18 "You neglected the Rock who begot you,
And forgot the God who gave you birth.
Deut. 32:19 "The LORD saw this, and spurned them
Because of the provocation of His sons and daughters.
Deut. 32:20 "Then He said, 'I will hide My face from them,
I will see what their end shall be;
For they are a perverse generation,
Sons in whom is no faithfulness.
Deut. 32:21 'They have made Me jealous with what is not God;
They have provoked Me to anger with their idols.
So I will make them jealous with those who are not a people;
I will provoke them to anger with a foolish nation,
Deut. 32:22 For a fire is kindled in My anger,
And burns to the lowest part of Sheol,
And consumes the earth with its yield,
And sets on fire the foundations of the mountains.
Deut. 32:23 'I will heap misfortunes on them;
I will use My arrows on them.

Deut. 32:26 'I would have said, "I will cut them to pieces,
I will remove the memory of them from men,"
Deut. 32:27 Had I not feared the provocation by the enemy,
That their adversaries would misjudge,
That they would say, "Our hand is triumphant,
And the LORD has not done all this."'

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Deut. 32:28 "For they are a nation lacking in counsel,
And there is no understanding in them.
Deut. 32:29 "Would that they were wise, that they understood this,
That they would discern their future!

Deut. 32:35 'Vengeance is Mine, and retribution,
In due time their foot will slip;
For the day of their calamity is near,
And the impending things are hastening upon them.'
Deut. 32:36 "For the LORD will vindicate His people,
And will have compassion on His servants,
When He sees that their strength is gone,
And there is none remaining, bond or free.

Deut. 32:43 "Rejoice, O nations, with His people;
For He will avenge the blood of His servants,
And will render vengeance on His adversaries,
And will atone for His land and His people."

- In this day the Lord had taking revenge against the 3,000 guilty, but the offense of breaking His covenant will not be cleared easily
    - In fact Israel will continue to sin against God and the covenant
        - As a result, Moses says they will be set outside the land, defeated by their enemies and heap misfortunes upon them
        - This is the long term relationship they will experience as punishment for sin
    - Just as Adam suffered a long term penalty for breaking the covenant in the garden, so will Israel suffer for this covenant
        - But this too is part of God's plan to bless Gentiles
        - Because of the Jews' sin, God can be just in setting them aside during the coming of the Messiah
            - Their rejection of the Christ makes available an opportunity for Gentiles to receive the Gospel
            - Yet God remains just in this plan, since He set the terms and they disobeyed

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Exodus 33-34

- In chapter 32, the nation of Israel broke the terms of the SInai covenant when they worshipped the golden calf
    - As a result of that sin, the Lord declared they would all be killed, which was the normal penalty for violating a covenant
        - Instead, Moses interceded on behalf of the people, offering his own life to spare their lives
        - In the process, Moses formed a picture of the Messiah, who gave His life to spare ours in the face of our violation of God's law
        - And so the Lord delayed the execution of His penalty against that generation of Israel
            - They did eventually die in the desert as a result of their sin under the covenant
            - But the Lord condemned them to die slowly rather than all at once
        - So the word of God concerning these people hasn't changed
            - They broke the covenant, so they will die
    - Meanwhile, the covenant with Israel has been broken, which means God is no longer bound to His part of the covenant either
        - So so as we enter chapter 33, Israel and the Lord stand at a crossroads
        - Will the nation go forward with the Lord leading them, or will the Lord abandon them?

Ex. 33:1 Then the LORD spoke to Moses, "Depart, go up from here, you and the people whom you have brought up from the land of Egypt, to the land of which I swore to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, saying, 'To your descendants I will give it.'
Ex. 33:2 "I will send an angel before you and I will drive out the Canaanite, the Amorite, the Hittite, the Perizzite, the Hivite and the Jebusite.
Ex. 33:3 "Go up to a land flowing with milk and honey; for I will not go up in your midst, because you are an obstinate people, and I might destroy you on the way."

- Moses has returned to the top of the mountain to meet with the Lord

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- At the end of chapter 32, he told the people he would return to see if something could be salvaged of the covenant
    - Moses stands before the Lord, and he receives good news and bad news
    - The good news is found in vs.1-2
    - The Lord says the people will still enter the land the Lord promised to them
        - They will enter Canaan
        - And the Lord will send His angel before the people to drive out the peoples in the land
- More importantly, the Lord tells the people why He is still willing to do this for them
    - The Lord is acting to fulfill a promise He delivered to Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, starting in Genesis 15
    - He's referring to the covenant the Lord made with Abraham, a covenant that was a one-way agreement
        - It was never dependent on Abraham's performance
        - In fact, Abraham had no terms at all
        - He merely received the blessing God promised
    - So God's promise came without conditions
        - And that promise was not to be forgotten even though the people of Israel committed such a great sin

- Then the bad news comes
    - The Lord tells Moses that the people are to leave the mountain and go to the Promised Land by themselves, without the Lord's presence
        - In v.3 the Lord says I will not go up in your midst
        - That phrase is a powerful statement
        - It means the Lord has revoked everything given to the nation in chapters 25-31, which was the building of the tabernacle

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- The tabernacle's purpose was to serve as the place God would dwell within Israel

- But because of the sin of the nation under the covenant, the Lord no longer plans to dwell with Israel, thus negating the need for the tabernacle

- Furthermore, the Lord says if He did dwell with this people (referring to this generation of Israel), He would likely destroy them because they were so obstinate or stiff-necked

- Because they won't submit to Him, it was only a matter of time before they offended Him again provoking Him to anger to their own destruction

- Everything we're hearing confirms what we're told by the writer of Hebrews, concerning this generation of Israel

Heb. 3:16 For who provoked Him when they had heard? Indeed, did not all those who came out of Egypt led by Moses?
Heb. 3:17 And with whom was He angry for forty years? Was it not with those who sinned, whose bodies fell in the wilderness?
Heb. 3:18 And to whom did He swear that they would not enter His rest, but to those who were disobedient?
Heb. 3:19 So we see that they were not able to enter because of unbelief.

- In the next passage we learn the peoples' reaction to learning that the Lord would not dwell among them

Ex. 33:4 When the people heard this sad word, they went into mourning, and none of them put on his ornaments.
Ex. 33:5 For the LORD had said to Moses, "Say to the sons of Israel, 'You are an obstinate people; should I go up in your midst for one moment, I would destroy you. Now therefore, put off your ornaments from you, that I may know what I shall do with you.'"
Ex. 33:6 So the sons of Israel stripped themselves of their ornaments, from Mount Horeb onward.

- This was indeed a sad word, and the people went into mourning over their sin and the consequences the Lord imposed

- As a sign of their mourning, they were told by the Lord to remove all their ornaments, which means jewelry and other trappings

- The were to go about in a plain & bare appearance

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        - Notice in v.5 the Lord tells them the same thing He told Moses
            - They were so stiff-necked they were in jeopardy of destruction were the Lord to remain in their midst
            - Remember, stiff-necked doesn't just mean a stubborn personality
            - In scripture it refers to a failure to submit to God, which is a sign of unbelief
        - So the Lord is saying that He would be forced to destroy them eventually because of their unbelief
    - So He tells them to strip themselves of their ornaments while He decides what to with them
        - Why does the Lord make this requirement?
        - First, we know He doesn't need time to make up His mind
        - Secondly, why does He want them to strip themselves bare of jewelry in the meantime?
- The answer is another connection back to the Fall in the Garden
    - When Adam and Woman fell in the Garden, they experienced numerous consequences for their sin
        - They were set outside the Garden, so they lost the opportunity to enjoy fellowship with the Lord
        - We've seen that same consequence in this moment
            - The Lord says He can't be in their presence or else He will have to destroy the Israelites
        - Secondly, Adam and Woman were immediately aware that they were naked
            - They sensed they were bare and vulnerable before the Lord
            - So they hid from Him
    - Now we see that consequence mirrored here in a sense
        - Obviously, the Lord isn't going to require the people of Israel strip naked in response to their sin

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- Going about naked is what got them into trouble in the first place

- Instead, the Lord commands them to strip bare of any adornments

- Through this order, the Lord creates a comparable picture

- In fact, the people stop wearing the jewelry from that point forward in the wanderings of the desert

- Then Moses explains how the breaking of the covenant impacted the Lord's presence in the camp of Israel

Ex. 33:7 **Now Moses used to take the tent and pitch it outside the camp, a good distance from the camp, and he called it the tent of meeting. And everyone who sought the LORD would go out to the tent of meeting which was outside the camp.**
Ex. 33:8 **And it came about, whenever Moses went out to the tent, that all the people would arise and stand, each at the entrance of his tent, and gaze after Moses until he entered the tent.**
Ex. 33:9 **Whenever Moses entered the tent, the pillar of cloud would descend and stand at the entrance of the tent; and the LORD would speak with Moses.**
Ex. 33:10 **When all the people saw the pillar of cloud standing at the entrance of the tent, all the people would arise and worship, each at the entrance of his tent.**

- Up to this point in the story of Exodus, we've been told that the glory of God in the form of the fire and cloud were over the camp of Israel

  - God's glory was positioned in the midst of Israel until this moment

    - And Moses' own tent was also pitched inside the camp of Israel

    - The image created was clearly that God was among His people and God's representative was nearby

  - But now as a result of the sin of Israel, Moses moves the tent of the meeting outside the camp of Israel

    - This is not the tabernacle, since it hasn't been built yet

      - This is another structure that Moses used to meet with God

      - And now it is moved outside the camp, away from the people of Israel

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- In v.7 we're told that anyone seeking for the Lord would have to go outside the camp of Israel to find the Lord
- In fact, when Moses left the camp of Israel and walked out to his tent, the event caused all of Israel to stop what they were doing and stare at Moses
- As Moses entered the tent and God's glory descended upon it, the people worshipped

- Notice, what triggered the people to participate in acts of worship?
  - The appearance of a physical manifestation of God's glory upon Moses' tent
  - It was an act of worship triggered by a physical manifestation
  - What does this tell us about that generation of Israel?
    - We could say that it's nice to see them worshipping the true God finally
    - But what does the Bible say faith is?

Heb. 11:1 **Now faith is the assurance of things hoped for, the conviction of things not seen.**

- True faith is an acceptance of things not seen
- And what must faith hold?

Heb. 11:6 **And without faith it is impossible to please Him, for he who comes to God must believe that He is and that He is a rewarder of those who seek Him.**

- We must believe not only that God is, but we must also believe in His promises of good things to come
- We must believe He is a rewarder of those who seek Him

- Finally, how are we to demonstrate our faith in Him through worship?

John 4:24 **"God is spirit, and those who worship Him must worship in spirit and truth."**

- Jesus said men are to worship God in spirit, which means to worship Him in His invisible form

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        - And to worship Him in truth, which means to worship Him according to His word
        - These are things that cannot be seen or touched, but we accept on faith alone
    - This is why the writer of Hebrews says in Hebrews 12 that this generation could not stand though they worshipped at a mountain they could touch
        - But we worship greater things, things we have yet to see in Heaven
        - Thus demonstrating our true faith
- So in this new location, Moses went to speak with the Lord in the tent of meeting
    - And Moses made a point to beseech the Lord to continue forward with the people as they traveled up into the Land

Ex. 33:11 Thus the LORD used to speak to Moses face to face, just as a man speaks to his friend. When Moses returned to the camp, his servant Joshua, the son of Nun, a young man, would not depart from the tent.
Ex. 33:12 Then Moses said to the LORD, "See, You say to me, 'Bring up this people!' But You Yourself have not let me know whom You will send with me. Moreover, You have said, 'I have known you by name, and you have also found favor in My sight.'
Ex. 33:13 "Now therefore, I pray You, if I have found favor in Your sight, let me know Your ways that I may know You, so that I may find favor in Your sight. Consider too, that this nation is Your people."

- In v.11 we're told that Moses met God face to face
    - The phrase "face to face" in Hebrew does not suggest a theophany
        - Moses was not staring into the face of God
            - This becomes readily apparent in toward the end of this chapter
        - Instead, this refers to the degree of intimacy of Moses' communication with the Lord
        - No man since Adam had enjoyed the kind of regular, intimate communication with the Lord that Moses was given

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- Nor would any prophet be given such opportunity again
    - In fact Moses became known as the man who spoke to God face to face

- And alongside Moses was Joshua
    - Joshua was a young man at this point, but still he has been given the responsibility of guarding the tent of meeting in Moses' absence
    - This is our early indication that Moses will be succeeded by Joshua

- Then in vs.12-17 Moses appears before the Lord to makes a new request of God in an attempt to repair the covenant
    - The request has two parts...first, Moses makes a request for himself
        - In v.12 Moses reminds God that He ordered Moses to lead the people out of Egypt and into the Promised Land
            - That's what is meant by "go up" which means up to the Promised Land
        - But Moses also reminds God that when He gave Moses that directive, the Lord promised to be with Moses in that work
            - And so now Moses asks who will go with him in leading the nation?
    - Moses says God told him previous that Moses had received favor (which is the word grace)
        - So Moses says if Moses has received God's grace, then let me know your ways and find favor (grace) in your sight
            - By these words, Moses is asking the Lord to establish an intimate relationship with him on the basis of grace
        - In fact, the word for grace appears four times in Moses' appeal
        - Moses is seeking assurance on the basis of God's grace that the Lord would never leave Him
            - Moses is asking the Lord to establish a relationship of lovingkindness with him on the basis of grace alone

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- Why did Moses insist on such a relationship for himself?
  - Clearly, Moses' relationship with the Lord must be based on something other than Law if it was going to persist
    - Moses is God's representative to the people of Israel, and yet he is also one of Israel
    - For if Moses' relationship with the Lord were based solely on a covenant of Law, then sooner or later the nation would violate their covenant again
    - And when the nation falls, Moses would fall too
  - With a relationship based on grace rather than Law, however, Moses could be assured that the Lord would never forsake Him
  - So he wanted God's assurance of His enduring presence based on His grace rather than on the covenant of Law
- In the second part of his appeal, Moses reminds the Lord that the nation Israel was God's people
  - Moses is appealing to another covenant based on grace, the covenant the Lord made with Abraham
  - In that covenant, the Lord promised Abraham to make a great nation from his descendants
  - God said He would bring those descendants into land He gave Abraham
    - So Moses is once again appealing to God's grace on behalf of Israel

- Then we hear the Lord's response

Ex. 33:14 **And He said, "My presence shall go with you, and I will give you rest."**
Ex. 33:15 **Then he said to Him, "If Your presence does not go with us, do not lead us up from here.**
Ex. 33:16 **"For how then can it be known that I have found favor in Your sight, I and Your people? Is it not by Your going with us, so that we, I and Your people, may be distinguished from all the other people who are upon the face of the earth?"**
Ex. 33:17 **The LORD said to Moses, "I will also do this thing of which you have spoken; for you have found favor in My sight and I have known you by name."**

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- The Lord agrees to Moses' request
    - The Lord makes a statement that has no conditions
        - He will accompany Moses and give Moses rest
        - This is the Lord's personal covenant with Moses, and there are no conditions or exceptions
        - It is a one-way, suzerainty covenant on the basis of grace
    - Moses then asks the Lord to how will it be known to the world that the Lord has promised to accompany the people of Israel
        - Moses is seeking a sign of this promise
        - And the Lord responds again with a statement of His promise
        - He says He will honor Moses's words because Moses has found favor
            - Once again, that phrase means God has bestowed grace upon Moses
            - And the Lord knows Moses in an intimate way
- Once more Moses presses for a sign, and this time the Lord grants Moses' request in a unique way

Ex. 33:18 Then Moses said, "I pray You, show me Your glory!"
Ex. 33:19 And He said, "I Myself will make all My goodness pass before you, and will proclaim the name of the LORD before you; and I will be gracious to whom I will be gracious, and will show compassion on whom I will show compassion."
Ex. 33:20 But He said, "You cannot see My face, for no man can see Me and live!"
Ex. 33:21 Then the LORD said, "Behold, there is a place by Me, and you shall stand there on the rock;
Ex. 33:22 and it will come about, while My glory is passing by, that I will put you in the cleft of the rock and cover you with My hand until I have passed by.
Ex. 33:23 "Then I will take My hand away and you shall see My back, but My face shall not be seen."

- Moses proposes that the Lord allow Moses to see the Lord's glory
    - Remember up to this point Moses has been meeting with the Lord in the form of cloud and fire and thunder

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- These manifestations of God's glory were not the actual appearance of God Himself but only physical representations of God

- For weeks now Moses has conversed with God through these methods, but now Moses proposes that the Lord reveal Himself truly to Moses as a sign of their new, intimate relationship

- The Lord agrees to the request but with significant limitations

  - And these limitations are grace to Moses as well

  - The Lord speaks in covenantal language in v.19

  - First, He says He will allow His "goodness" to pass in front of Moses

    - The word goodness is tub in Hebrew

    - It simply means a good thing or the best of something

    - The Lord will show the fullness of His goodness to be manifested to Moses

  - Secondly, the Lord says He will proclaim His name before Moses

    - This is the name of God which no Jew hence forth would pronounce

    - The name represented by the letters YHWH in scripture

  - Thirdly, the Lord says He will be gracious upon those He chooses

  - Finally, the Lord says He will show compassion on those He chooses

    - These final two statements emphasize that His covenant of grace with Moses is not a promise to show mercy on all of Israel

    - Instead, He is making a promise of grace to Moses and to those the Lord chooses within the camp of Israel

  - But not all Israel will necessarily receive this grace

    - The Lord still intends to hold many within Israel guilty for their sin under the Sinai covenant

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- Finally, the Lord spells out how He will reveal Himself to Moses as a sign of this promise
    - He will not allow Moses to see the Lord's "face"
        - The reference to face is an anthropomorphism
        - It is a human characteristic assigned to God to help us relate to Him
            - But it is not a literal description of His being
            - God does not have a physical face
            - As we saw earlier in John 4, the Father is all spirit according to Jesus
        - So the word "face" refers to the witnesses the full expression of God's glory
            - Just as we get a better appreciation of a human being by looking at their face than their back
            - When we see only their back, we have a sense of who they are, but we lack the most important details
            - Similarly, to see God's glory in partial or limited form is described as not seeing God's "face"
    - God tells Moses that no man can see Him in His fullness and live
        - The reason this is true relates to our sinfulness
        - God is so pure and holy and just that He cannot allow sin to coexist in the fullness of His glory
            - He can permit it to exist while it is outside His presence
            - But if it enters into His presence, He must judge it as His perfect nature requires
        - As an analogy, a perfect judge can allow a criminal to go unpunished so long as he does not stand trial in the courtroom
            - But once the accused enters the court and stands before the judge, now the judge has no choice but to convict the person
            - To do otherwise would be an injustice

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- So the Lord's solution was to place Moses in a recessed part of the rock on the Mountain
    - From within that cleft, Moses can only see a narrow sliver in front of him
    - From that vantage point, the Lord can control Moses' exposure to the Lord
        - The Lord could reveal more of Himself to Moses while allowing Moses to remain protected from immediate judgment
- When the fullness of God's glory passed in front of the cleft, the Lord would cover the cleft to preserve Moses' life
    - But after God had passed in front of the cleft, then He would allow Moses to see God's "back" but not His "face"
    - Once again, this is an anthropomorphism
        - God no more has a back than He has a face
        - The literal Hebrew word for back is afterward, which refers to the afterglow of God's presence
        - Like a reflection or a photograph
    - The image Moses would see was not God Himself but the afterglow of God's glory reflected or left behind as a result of God's presence passing by

- So the Lord executes this plan of granting Moses a sign of His promise of grace, which takes us into Chapter 34

Ex. 34:1 **Now the LORD said to Moses, "Cut out for yourself two stone tablets like the former ones, and I will write on the tablets the words that were on the former tablets which you shattered.**
Ex. 34:2 **"So be ready by morning, and come up in the morning to Mount Sinai, and present yourself there to Me on the top of the mountain.**
Ex. 34:3 **"No man is to come up with you, nor let any man be seen anywhere on the mountain; even the flocks and the herds may not graze in front of that mountain."**
Ex. 34:4 **So he cut out two stone tablets like the former ones, and Moses rose up early in the morning and went up to Mount Sinai, as the LORD had commanded him, and he took two stone tablets in his hand.**

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Ex. 34:5 The LORD descended in the cloud and stood there with him as he called upon the name of the LORD.
Ex. 34:6 Then the LORD passed by in front of him and proclaimed, "The LORD, the LORD God, compassionate and gracious, slow to anger, and abounding in lovingkindness and truth;
Ex. 34:7 who keeps lovingkindness for thousands, who forgives iniquity, transgression and sin; yet He will by no means leave the guilty unpunished, visiting the iniquity of fathers on the children and on the grandchildren to the third and fourth generations."
Ex. 34:8 Moses made haste to bow low toward the earth and worship.

- To begin, the Lord orders Moses to cut two new stone tablets like the ones that he broke when he descended the mountain
    - By ordering Moses to cut these tablets, the Lord is indicating that He intends to re-establish the covenant of Law with Israel
        - We'll see the Lord re-instate His covenant in the latter part of this chapter
        - But for now we understand that the Law and the covenant of Law is not going to be dissolved as a consequence of the nation's sin
        - The Lord will also explain later in this chapter why it must continue
        - However, the covenant is going to be changed in several ways as a result of the nation's sin, which we'll see
    - Meanwhile, the Lord grants Moses the sign of His grace that He promised to him
        - The Lord says that nothing can be on the mountain except Moses himself
            - Not even the herds may graze on the mountain
        - Then Moses cuts the stones as directed
        - Then the Lord passed in front of Moses as He promised declaring the covenantal word of lovingkindness
    - Then the Lord gives a testimony to how He assigns His grace and lovingkindness

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        - The compassion and grace and mercy of God is vast, the Lord says

            - He assigns it to "thousands" which can also be translated as "families" or clans

            - In other words, God is prepared to show mercy to families and clans of sinners

        - But nevertheless, the Lord is also prepared to hold the guilty accountable

            - There will be those within the clans and families of the nation that will see God's wrath for sin

            - And this wrath will play out over generations, since sin is inherited

- What makes the difference between those who will receive His grace and those who will not?

    - As the Lord said earlier, He will show compassion on those He will show compassion

        - It is a matter of God's will alone

        - Moses had requested grace and mercy, both for himself and for the people of Israel

        - And the Lord responded with His promise of grace to Moses to never leave Him

    - But in the sign of the promise, the Lord makes clear that His grace will be manifested as He pleases to whom He pleases

        - It is here that we see the formation of the principle of a remnant in Israel receiving God's grace

        - God's covenant of Law given to Israel holds all Israel guilty of sin

            - And God's promise of favor (or grace) is limited to a remnant within Israel according to God's choice

    - This is the teaching Paul gives in Romans 9-11, which he culminates by saying

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Rom. 11:5 In the same way then, there has also come to be at the present time a remnant according to God's gracious choice.
Rom. 11:6 But if it is by grace, it is no longer on the basis of works, otherwise grace is no longer grace.

- Paul reminds us that throughout Israel's history, there was the remnant within Israel who had received God's grace and the rest that had not
- And the distinction was purely a matter of God's favor or grace
  - It did not depend on the Law
  - For God Himself stated to Moses that He is showing favor or grace on whom He wishes within Israel
- Then in response to the Lord's declaration, Moses bows low, and requests that the Lord re-establish His covenant with the people

Ex. 34:9 He said, "If now I have found favor in Your sight, O Lord, I pray, let the Lord go along in our midst, even though the people are so obstinate, and pardon our iniquity and our sin, and take us as Your own possession."
Ex. 34:10 Then God said, "Behold, I am going to make a covenant. Before all your people I will perform miracles which have not been produced in all the earth nor among any of the nations; and all the people among whom you live will see the working of the LORD, for it is a fearful thing that I am going to perform with you.
Ex. 34:11 "Be sure to observe what I am commanding you this day: behold, I am going to drive out the Amorite before you, and the Canaanite, the Hittite, the Perizzite, the Hivite and the Jebusite.
Ex. 34:12 "Watch yourself that you make no covenant with the inhabitants of the land into which you are going, or it will become a snare in your midst.
Ex. 34:13 "But rather, you are to tear down their altars and smash their sacred pillars and cut down their Asherim
Ex. 34:14 – for you shall not worship any other god, for the LORD, whose name is Jealous, is a jealous God –
Ex. 34:15 otherwise you might make a covenant with the inhabitants of the land and they would play the harlot with their gods and sacrifice to their gods, and someone might invite you to eat of his sacrifice,
Ex. 34:16 and you might take some of his daughters for your sons, and his daughters might play the harlot with their gods and cause your sons also to play the harlot with their gods.
Ex. 34:17 "You shall make for yourself no molten gods.

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Ex. 34:18 "You shall observe the Feast of Unleavened Bread. For seven days you are to eat unleavened bread, as I commanded you, at the appointed time in the month of Abib, for in the month of Abib you came out of Egypt.
Ex. 34:19 "The first offspring from every womb belongs to Me, and all your male livestock, the first offspring from cattle and sheep.
Ex. 34:20 "You shall redeem with a lamb the first offspring from a donkey; and if you do not redeem it, then you shall break its neck. You shall redeem all the firstborn of your sons. None shall appear before Me empty-handed.
Ex. 34:21 "You shall work six days, but on the seventh day you shall rest; even during plowing time and harvest you shall rest.
Ex. 34:22 "You shall celebrate the Feast of Weeks, that is, the first fruits of the wheat harvest, and the Feast of Ingathering at the turn of the year.
Ex. 34:23 "Three times a year all your males are to appear before the Lord GOD, the God of Israel.
Ex. 34:24 "For I will drive out nations before you and enlarge your borders, and no man shall covet your land when you go up three times a year to appear before the LORD your God.
Ex. 34:25 "You shall not offer the blood of My sacrifice with leavened bread, nor is the sacrifice of the Feast of the Passover to be left over until morning.
Ex. 34:26 "You shall bring the very first of the first fruits of your soil into the house of the LORD your God. "You shall not boil a young goat in its mother's milk."
Ex. 34:27 Then the LORD said to Moses, "Write down these words, for in accordance with these words I have made a covenant with you and with Israel."

- The Lord summarizes the Law again to remind Moses of all that the Lord had spoken
    - And in the summary, the Lord promises to re-establish the covenant with the people of Israel
        - The formal re-instatement of the covenant doesn't happen until Deuteronomy at the end of the 40 years of wandering
        - The word deuteronomy means the second law, because it was the second time the covenant of the Law was given to Israel
        - In that future day, it is given to a new generation of Israel after the older generation has died out
            - The wait for their death was a requirement of their sin with the golden calf

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- So here we see the Lord renew this covenant with Israel, which will begin to regulate their life even now
  - The terms of the law are unchanged in this quick summary from what was given earlier on the mountain
  - Obviously, we have already covered their meaning in those earlier chapters
- Notice that the Lord particularly emphasizes the importance of not falling to idolatry again
  - They should not associated with the people of Canaan else they will fall prey to idolatry
  - This is a reminder of a basic principle of scripture
    - When God's people seek to bind themselves with the world, we do not make the world more holy by our association
    - On the contrary, the world will corrupt us
    - Only by a shared faith in the promises of God can men find the opportunity to be yoked together
- Interestingly, in v.24 the Lord promises that when they leave their property to attend the three feasts each year, their homes and land will not be disturbed in their absence
  - That's a powerful reminder of how our obedience to God's commandments bring blessings that make obedience easy
  - We need not worry about the consequences of obedience, for they are always a blessing whatever form they take

- But there is also a change coming to the law as a result of the sin of Israel at the mountain
  - If we go to Numbers 3 we discover that the Lord will only permit the the Levites to serve Him in the temple, rather than the firstborn of all tribes

Num. 3:5 Then the LORD spoke to Moses, saying,
Num. 3:6 "Bring the tribe of Levi near and set them before Aaron the priest, that they may serve him.
Num. 3:7 "They shall perform the duties for him and for the whole congregation before the tent of meeting, to do the service of the tabernacle.

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Num. 3:8 "They shall also keep all the furnishings of the tent of meeting, along with the duties of the sons of Israel, to do the service of the tabernacle.
Num. 3:9 "You shall thus give the Levites to Aaron and to his sons; they are wholly given to him from among the sons of Israel.
Num. 3:10 "So you shall appoint Aaron and his sons that they may keep their priesthood, but the layman who comes near shall be put to death."
Num. 3:11 Again the LORD spoke to Moses, saying,
Num. 3:12 "Now, behold, I have taken the Levites from among the sons of Israel instead of every firstborn, the first issue of the womb among the sons of Israel. So the Levites shall be Mine.
Num. 3:13 "For all the firstborn are Mine; on the day that I struck down all the firstborn in the land of Egypt, I sanctified to Myself all the firstborn in Israel, from man to beast. They shall be Mine; I am the LORD."

- The original command from the Lord was to have the firstborn of every tribe dedicated to the tabernacle service
  - Since only Levites stood with Moses on the day of the sin at the mountain, God now makes the Levites the tribe to serve Him
  - Of course, the Lord always had this plan in mind, which is why there was a thirteenth tribe in Israel after the time of Joseph

- Having received the renewing of the covenant and the Law, Moses descends a second time to the people, but this time something is different

Ex. 34:28 So he was there with the LORD forty days and forty nights; he did not eat bread or drink water. And he wrote on the tablets the words of the covenant, the Ten Commandments.
Ex. 34:29 It came about when Moses was coming down from Mount Sinai (and the two tablets of the testimony were in Moses' hand as he was coming down from the mountain), that Moses did not know that the skin of his face shone because of his speaking with Him.
Ex. 34:30 So when Aaron and all the sons of Israel saw Moses, behold, the skin of his face shone, and they were afraid to come near him.
Ex. 34:31 Then Moses called to them, and Aaron and all the rulers in the congregation returned to him; and Moses spoke to them.
Ex. 34:32 Afterward all the sons of Israel came near, and he commanded them to do everything that the LORD had spoken to him on Mount Sinai.
Ex. 34:33 When Moses had finished speaking with them, he put a veil over his face.
Ex. 34:34 But whenever Moses went in before the LORD to speak with Him, he would take off the veil until he came out; and whenever he came out and spoke to the sons of Israel what he had been commanded,

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Ex. 34:35 the sons of Israel would see the face of Moses, that the skin of Moses' face shone. So Moses would replace the veil over his face until he went in to speak with Him.

- Once again Moses spends forty days on the mountain with the Lord
    - During this time we're told Moses never eats or drinks, yet the Lord sustains him
        - This is a powerful example of the truth of Jesus' words, when he said:

Matt. 4:4 But He answered and said, "It is written, 'MAN SHALL NOT LIVE ON BREAD ALONE, BUT ON EVERY WORD THAT PROCEEDS OUT OF THE MOUTH OF GOD.'"

        - In the case of Matthew 4, Jesus was teaching that our eternal life is sustained ultimately not by physical means but by the power of God's word
        - Here we see a dramatic proof of the power of God's word to sustain us, both spiritually and even physically when necessary
        - Once again, Moses descends the mountain carrying the two stone tablets
    - But this time as Moses returns from this restating of the covenant, he finds his face glowing
        - The shining of Moses face was another example of the afterglow of God's glory
        - This was an effect of coming so close to the glory of God
            - Each time that Moses came to speak to God in the tent of meeting, he found the same effect occurring
            - His face would shine with the reflected glory of God
    - We're told that this effect was very unnerving to the people of Israel
        - They were made very nervous by it
        - Nevertheless, Moses commanded the people to come near him so he could once again relate all the commandments of God
        - Thereafter, Moses took to wearing a veil when he wasn't speaking to the Lord to hide the glow of his face from the people

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- We might assume from this text that the reason Moses did this was because the people were so uncomfortable with the image of Moses' shining face
    - But Paul teaches us in 2Corinthians that this was not the reason for the veil

2Cor. 3:5 Not that we are adequate in ourselves to consider anything as coming from ourselves, but our adequacy is from God,
2Cor. 3:6 who also made us adequate as servants of a new covenant, not of the letter but of the Spirit; for the letter kills, but the Spirit gives life.
2Cor. 3:7 But if the ministry of death, in letters engraved on stones, came with glory, so that the sons of Israel could not look intently at the face of Moses because of the glory of his face, fading as it was,
2Cor. 3:8 how will the ministry of the Spirit fail to be even more with glory?
2Cor. 3:9 For if the ministry of condemnation has glory, much more does the ministry of righteousness abound in glory.
2Cor. 3:10 For indeed what had glory, in this case has no glory because of the glory that surpasses it.
2Cor. 3:11 For if that which fades away was with glory, much more that which remains is in glory.
2Cor. 3:12 Therefore having such a hope, we use great boldness in our speech,
2Cor. 3:13 and are not like Moses, who used to put a veil over his face so that the sons of Israel would not look intently at the end of what was fading away.
2Cor. 3:14 But their minds were hardened; for until this very day at the reading of the old covenant the same veil remains unlifted, because it is removed in Christ.
2Cor. 3:15 But to this day whenever Moses is read, a veil lies over their heart;
2Cor. 3:16 but whenever a person turns to the Lord, the veil is taken away.
2Cor. 3:17 Now the Lord is the Spirit, and where the Spirit of the Lord is, there is liberty.
2Cor. 3:18 But we all, with unveiled face, beholding as in a mirror the glory of the Lord, are being transformed into the same image from glory to glory, just as from the Lord, the Spirit.

- Time does not permit an in-depth treatment of this important passage, so we'll hit a few highlights as they apply to Exodus 34
    - Paul compares two covenants in this passage: the covenant of the Law with the New Covenant of grace in Christ
        - The old is called a covenant of letter engraved on stone and a ministry of death
        - The new is called the covenant of the Spirit, of life and a ministry of righteousness

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- Both covenants were revealed with a measure of glory, Paul says
  - The Old came with the glory of God revealed in Moses' face
  - But that glory was one that faded
    - The glory of God shining in Moses' face would slowly fade away in the days after Moses had an encounter with God
  - Paul says it was this fading of God's glory that caused Moses to begin wearing a veil
    - In v.13 Paul says Moses took to wearing a veil so Israel would not stare at the fading of God's glory
    - Moses didn't want the people to see the glory of God leaving

- Paul then ends by teaching that Moses unknowingly created a beautiful picture of the relationship between the Old Covenant and the New
  - The hearts of the people of Israel in the desert were hardened, by God, just as He had done to Pharaoh in Egypt
    - So that even as the Law of God was read to them, they couldn't see the glory of God in it
    - They couldn't appreciate the testimony of Christ and of grace hidden in the meaning of the Law
    - The truth of these things was hidden from them, as pictured in the way Moses hid the glory of God by putting a veil over his face
  - That veil over their hearts is only lifted by Christ Himself, Who is the author and perfecter of our salvation Hebrews says
    - Even today, when the Law of Moses is read to someone, they cannot see it as a picture of Christ until they have first come to the Lord in faith
    - Then the veil of understanding is lifted

- Finally, Paul alludes to a beautiful picture of Christ in the circumstances of Exodus 34
  - Paul says in v.18 that today we are reflecting the glory of God as well, in the way we are being transformed into the glory of Christ by the Spirit

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        - Just as Moses reflected the Lord's glory by his testimony to Israel, so are we reflecting the Lord's glory to the world by our testimony
            - But our testimony is one of life not merely words
            - We shine the glory of Christ by how we reflect Him in our actions as well as our testimony
    - Finally, Moses himself becomes another picture of Christ through His intercession in Exodus 34
        - He sought for an intimate relationship with the Father
        - He asked for God's grace to be given to His people
        - He asked to see the Father's glory, and then He reflected that glory to the world
        - And the Father responded that He will have mercy on those He chooses
            - And Moses would speak to a people who could not perceive the message because of a veiled and hardened heart
- These details picture Christ's ministry to Israel as well
    - Paul says Christ was the reflection of God's goodness and glory

Col. 1:15 **He is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of all creation.**

Col. 1:19 **For it was the Father's good pleasure for all the fullness to dwell in Him,**

    - In John's Gospel, we hear Jesus petitioning the Father in ways similar to the way Moses petitioned the Lord

John 17:18 **"As You sent Me into the world, I also have sent them into the world.**
John 17:19 **"For their sakes I sanctify Myself, that they themselves also may be sanctified in truth.**
John 17:20 **"I do not ask on behalf of these alone, but for those also who believe in Me through their word;**
John 17:21 **that they may all be one; even as You, Father, are in Me and I in You, that they also may be in Us, so that the world may believe that You sent Me.**

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John 17:22 "The glory which You have given Me I have given to them, that they may be one, just as We are one;
John 17:23 I in them and You in Me, that they may be perfected in unity, so that the world may know that You sent Me, and loved them, even as You have loved Me.
John 17:24 "Father, I desire that they also, whom You have given Me, be with Me where I am, so that they may see My glory which You have given Me, for You loved Me before the foundation of the world.

- Jesus seeks to have the world know that the Father sent Him, just as Moses wanted the world to know that he represented God and Israel was His people
  - Jesus asks that the Father would love His people even as He loved Christ
  - And that those the Father has given to Christ from among those in the world would see the Father's glory which was given to Christ
  - Again these words mirror the way Moses appealed to the Father and saw His glory and reflected it to the world

- So as we end these chapters, the nation is once again in a covenant of Law
  - Yet they this generation is also bound to endure penalties for their sin
    - Because they are an unbelieving generation, one that has been hardened and will not receive God's grace
    - Yet Israel will be preserved through a remnant
  - In the meantime, God is showing grace to Moses and others within the nation
    - And in His grace, He fulfills His promises to Abraham's descendants to bring them into the land
  - And by the renewing of the covenant, the nation may now proceed forward with building the tabernacle
    - So that the glory of the Lord may dwell in the midst of Israel
    - Just as the Lord promised to Moses

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Exodus 35-40

- Our study of Exodus is coming to close
    - The story of Moses and Israel freed from slavery with great power and miracles, brought into a covenant, and given a new relationship with the Lord is remarkable to say the least
        - I encourage you to revisit this study again someday
        - You'll probably find there were many things that escaped your notice the first time
    - But for tonight, we've got five chapters of scripture to cover
        - You might wonder how we're going to cover so much ground in an hour
            - The answer is simple...we're not
        - We will certainly read every verse...after all, this is VBVM!
        - But most of the material we're covering tonight is an almost word-for-word repetition of the instructions the Lord gave Moses in chapters 25-31 concerning the tabernacle
            - So as we read through those chapters, we won't pause to comment on most of it
            - Except to note how attentive to detail Moses and the people were in executing the Lord's instructions
    - Having said that, this does not mean there aren't opportunities to teach and learn from the material tonight
        - On the contrary, we find several places where the text raises new ideas or issues we can examine
        - And in the end, we will alls celebrate concluding another in-depth study of a book of scripture
            - I know I will
- Let's remember what transpired in last week's lesson
    - The people of Israel had sinned against the Lord and broken the covenant

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        - So the Lord told Moses that the people would go forward to the Promised Land, but He would not dwell with them
            - Therefore, the tabernacle was no longer needed
        - In response, Moses interceded and appealed to the Lord for grace
            - And the Lord responded to Moses' request by granting a new covenant, one of grace
            - The covenant was granted to Moses and to the nation
            - But God reserved the right to extend His grace to whom He chooses
    - Meanwhile, He also renewed the covenant of Law
        - With the SInai covenant reinstated, the building of the tabernacle is revived as well
        - This explains why the breaking and the renewing of the covenant is sandwiched in between the giving of the tabernacle instructions and the building
            - Unless the covenant was renewed, there would have been no reason to build
            - Everything hinged on the Lord renewing His offer to dwell in their midst

- So now the construction of the tabernacle can proceed, and that brings us to chapter 35

Ex. 35:1 Then Moses assembled all the congregation of the sons of Israel, and said to them, "These are the things that the LORD has commanded you to do:
Ex. 35:2 "For six days work may be done, but on the seventh day you shall have a holy day, a sabbath of complete rest to the LORD; whoever does any work on it shall be put to death.
Ex. 35:3 "You shall not kindle a fire in any of your dwellings on the sabbath day."

- As construction begins, Moses first reminds the people that though the construction of the tabernacle is important, it can't take precedence over the Sabbath

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- In fact, no instruction in God's word can be excuse to violate another instruction
    - The nation of Israel had been given both the Sabbath and the instruction to build the tabernacle
    - They needed to observe both
    - And in anything we've been given in God's word or as personal conviction by the Spirit, we need to perform as well
        - But we must perform these things in union with the rest of God's word as it pertains to us
- We can't use one command as excuse to violate another
    - I've heard Christians excuse their lack of consistent Bible study by claiming they don't spend like to spend too much time in study since we're called to be doers of the word
    - So they excuse their own lack of scholarship in the word by pointing to other instructions in the Bible that command us to live out our faith
        - They have taken one instruction of scripture and set it against another
        - As if one is an enemy of the other
    - Clearly, this isn't the way to understand and apply the Bible's teaching
        - Scripture tells us to be life-long students of the word, giving ourselves over to it in a sincere and consistent manner
        - And then it also says to life it out actively
    - In fact, we can't successfully do one without the other!

- Having set that expectation, Moses then instructs the people to contribute the building of the tabernacle through giving

Ex. 35:4 **Moses spoke to all the congregation of the sons of Israel, saying, "This is the thing which the LORD has commanded, saying,**
Ex. 35:5 **'Take from among you a contribution to the LORD; whoever is of a willing heart, let him bring it as the LORD'S contribution: gold, silver, and bronze,**

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Ex. 35:6 and blue, purple and scarlet material, fine linen, goats' hair,
Ex. 35:7 and rams' skins dyed red, and porpoise skins, and acacia wood,
Ex. 35:8 and oil for lighting, and spices for the anointing oil, and for the fragrant incense,
Ex. 35:9 and onyx stones and setting stones for the ephod and for the breastpiece.
Ex. 35:10 'Let every skillful man among you come, and make all that the LORD has commanded:
Ex. 35:11 the tabernacle, its tent and its covering, its hooks and its boards, its bars, its pillars, and its sockets;
Ex. 35:12 the ark and its poles, the mercy seat, and the curtain of the screen;
Ex. 35:13 the table and its poles, and all its utensils, and the bread of the Presence;
Ex. 35:14 the lampstand also for the light and its utensils and its lamps and the oil for the light;
Ex. 35:15 and the altar of incense and its poles, and the anointing oil and the fragrant incense, and the screen for the doorway at the entrance of the tabernacle;
Ex. 35:16 the altar of burnt offering with its bronze grating, its poles, and all its utensils, the basin and its stand;
Ex. 35:17 the hangings of the court, its pillars and its sockets, and the screen for the gate of the court;
Ex. 35:18 the pegs of the tabernacle and the pegs of the court and their cords;
Ex. 35:19 the woven garments for ministering in the holy place, the holy garments for Aaron the priest and the garments of his sons, to minister as priests.'"
Ex. 35:20 Then all the congregation of the sons of Israel departed from Moses' presence.
Ex. 35:21 Everyone whose heart stirred him and everyone whose spirit moved him came and brought the LORD'S contribution for the work of the tent of meeting and for all its service and for the holy garments.
Ex. 35:22 Then all whose hearts moved them, both men and women, came and brought brooches and earrings and signet rings and bracelets, all articles of gold; so did every man who presented an offering of gold to the LORD.
Ex. 35:23 Every man, who had in his possession blue and purple and scarlet material and fine linen and goats' hair and rams' skins dyed red and porpoise skins, brought them.
Ex. 35:24 Everyone who could make a contribution of silver and bronze brought the LORD'S contribution; and every man who had in his possession acacia wood for any work of the service brought it.
Ex. 35:25 All the skilled women spun with their hands, and brought what they had spun, in blue and purple and scarlet material and in fine linen.
Ex. 35:26 All the women whose heart stirred with a skill spun the goats' hair.
Ex. 35:27 The rulers brought the onyx stones and the stones for setting for the ephod and for the breastpiece;
Ex. 35:28 and the spice and the oil for the light and for the anointing oil and for the fragrant incense.

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Ex. 35:29 **The Israelites, all the men and women, whose heart moved them to bring material for all the work, which the LORD had commanded through Moses to be done, brought a freewill offering to the LORD.**

- Moses tells the people that the Lord asked Moses to take a collection from among the people
    - And the collection would be taken from those will a "willing" heart
        - The word for "willing" in Hebrew is nadib, which means "inclined to be generous"
        - Moses was to seek from among generous hearts within the people
    - The list of items includes all the essentials needed for the tabernacle as God directed earlier
        - What are the odds that every kind of diverse material and item God required for the construction of the tabernacle would just happen to be found in the possession of the nation?
        - Clearly, the Lord had sovereignly planned for the people to acquire these items as they left Egypt, so they could be employed in the building of the temple
    - But then Moses says in vs.21-22 that the items were given freely by those whose hearts stirred and whose spirits were moved
        - The word translated stirred in v.21 is nasah, which means to be lifted up
            - It conveys the sense of an outside force acting on the heart
            - And we know the that outside actor is the Lord's Spirit, moving the hearts to meet the need
        - Then later in the verse, it says that every whose spirit moved came forward
            - So the Spirit's stirring caused men to them act according to the movement of their hearts
            - Again in v.22 it says that those with hearts that were moved came forward

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- Then we see the effect of this movement of the Spirit among the people
    - Notice that throughout the passage I read we see mentions of "every man" and "everyone" and "all" who had something to offer came forward
        - The text makes clear that there are no holdouts
        - Everyone is coming forward willingly and giving what they have for the tabernacle
        - This is a 100% participation rate
            - Which is what we would expect since the Lord has moved hearts to respond
            - Men who are moved by God will act according to His will
    - But then in v.29, Moses sums up the process by emphasizing that this offering to the Lord was a "freewill" offering
        - To our modern ears, this phrase carries loaded and distorted meaning
        - Many assume this term means acting entirely free of outside influence - including free of God's influence
    - That has become the common understanding of "free will" in the culture including the church culture of today
        - There is God's will and there is man's will
        - And many teach that God has created man with a will that operates completely independently of God's will
            - In fact you will often hear people throw around the comment that it's a sign of God's love that he allows us to have free choices
            - And on the contrary, it would be unloving for God to intervene in men's lives and override our desires
- This passage sets the records straight and corrects those false notions of God and man's will
    - First, the definition of a "freewill" offering means a voluntary offering
        - It is the opposite of a mandatory or compulsory offering
        - The terms is describing nature of the request and response

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- Moses says the giving act is voluntary
- He does not require the people to give
- So when they give, it is a voluntary act, a freewill gift

- But the term "freewill" in this context does not mean free of God's influence
  - The passage makes clear this act was not free of God's influence
  - The text says plainly that the Lord orchestrated a movement in the hearts of these people
    - They are reacting to the Spirit's leading
    - They came forward to give because the Lord spurred it
  - And we can see further evidence of the Lord's influence in the fact that everyone participates
    - No one in a nation of over 2 million hold back from the Lord
    - This kind of participation clearly reflects how the nation is being led by the Lord
  - So a "freewill" offering doesn't mean an offering absent God's influence
    - It means that no man compelled the giving
    - It was a voluntary gift

- Secondly, let's deal with the false notion that God's love is evidenced by His unwillingness to intervene in our "free will"
  - The Bible's definitions of "love" never include a mention of free will
    - Love is defined as sacrificing oneself for another
    - For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son...
    - The Bible says this

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Rom. 5:6 For while we were still helpless, at the right time Christ died for the ungodly.
Rom. 5:7 For one will hardly die for a righteous man; though perhaps for the good man someone would dare even to die.
Rom. 5:8 But God demonstrates His own love toward us, in that while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us.

- Furthermore, our own experience as parents raising children tells us that the truth is the opposite of this notion
  - If you love your child, do you show that love by refraining from intervening in their free will?
  - If you love your child, do you allow them to rule themselves?
    - Your child will certainly love it, at least at first
    - And if you ask your child how best to show your love to them, they will likely tell you that want you to leave them alone and have what they want
  - That's where this notion comes from too
    - God's children, immature and uninformed of what the word says, have proposed a rule for themselves
    - We said we think God shows us love by not intervening in our free will
    - It's the same lie, born of pride, that the enemy sold in the Garden
- What is the truth? A healthy, happy child is created when a parent frequently intervenes to control his will
  - Parents are constantly imposing their will on the child, and they do so because they love their child
  - What do we say about a parent that will not control a child's free will?
    - We say they are bad parents

- So is it reasonable to say that God's love is found in His willingness to let us do whatever we please absent any intervention?
  - If we know it's a good thing when an imperfect, weak human parent intervenes to control the will of his child

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- Then why do we say it's a bad thing for a holy, perfect, wise and strong God, Who has the power to lead His children into all righteousness, to intervene in our will?
- It's simply illogical

- The Bible says we were helpless to save ourselves, so the Lord had to intervene to save us
  - Left to our own will, we would have perished
  - Thank the Lord He loved us so much that He intervened to impose His will upon us

- So the Lord stirred the hearts of Israel to do the right thing when the request came, and so they willingly responded to Moses' request
  - With their response, the Lord ensures that Moses receives what He needs
    - Therefore, the time comes to put all that material to use
    - So now the nation needs a team of workman capable of building what the Lord wants

Ex. 35:30 **Then Moses said to the sons of Israel, "See, the LORD has called by name Bezalel the son of Uri, the son of Hur, of the tribe of Judah.**
Ex. 35:31 **"And He has filled him with the Spirit of God, in wisdom, in understanding and in knowledge and in all craftsmanship;**
Ex. 35:32 **to make designs for working in gold and in silver and in bronze,**
Ex. 35:33 **and in the cutting of stones for settings and in the carving of wood, so as to perform in every inventive work.**
Ex. 35:34 **"He also has put in his heart to teach, both he and Oholiab, the son of Ahisamach, of the tribe of Dan.**
Ex. 35:35 **"He has filled them with skill to perform every work of an engraver and of a designer and of an embroiderer, in blue and in purple and in scarlet material, and in fine linen, and of a weaver, as performers of every work and makers of designs.**

- Just as God's Spirit led the people to give, so He will guide the hands of the workmen to craft exactly what the Lord needs built
  - We already heard that God would call and equip Bezalel to lead the effort and here we see it happen
  - He is filled with the Spirit

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- The term "filled with the Spirit" is another misunderstood term in Christendom
    - When used in the context of preparing a person to respond to God's call (like the response to build the tabernacle), it means the Spirit's control over a person
        - Like today we might say that someone is filled with jealousy
        - We mean they are controlled by their jealousy
    - So here we see Bezalel filled, that is controlled, by the Spirit for the purpose of fulfilling his call to build the tabernacle
        - He is filled in four ways: wisdom, understanding, knowledge, and craftsmanship
        - Wisdom refers to an ability to make wise judgments, insightful decisions, based on experience
            - Solomon had wisdom
            - Our elders often acquire wisdom after living many years and making many mistakes
        - Understanding means discernment, the ability to reason through a set of facts and appreciate their true significance
            - A gifted Bible teacher could be said to have an understanding of God's word
            - Joseph and Daniel had understanding of the dreams God gave to Gentile rulers
        - Knowledge is an acquiring of learned facts and the application of those facts
            - Luke, author of the Gospel, was a doctor who demonstrated a knowledge of the facts of Jesus' life
            - And he endeavored to collect that knowledge and report it accurately
- Finally, Bezalel was given craftsmanship, which is the skill of working in raw materials to create finished goods
    - In his case, he was gifted to work in silver, bronze, stone, wood, setting precious stones, carving and other inventive works

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- Normally, a craftsman would work a lifetime to become an artisan in just one of these
- Bezalel will have the ability to do all these things with great skill

- Is there any doubt remaining that the Lord overrides our will by His Spirit to accomplish His work?
  - How else could we explain this man's ability to perform such amazing work out of the blue?
  - Clearly, the text says the Spirit filled him to enable this talent
- And along with him, God raises up other men and gifts them as well
  - This pattern is something we discussed in an earlier lesson
  - But it bears repeating here...God's work never goes unfinished for lack of men or materials
  - As we see in the opening of chapter 36

Ex. 36:1 "Now Bezalel and Oholiab, and every skillful person in whom the LORD has put skill and understanding to know how to perform all the work in the construction of the sanctuary, shall perform in accordance with all that the LORD has commanded."
Ex. 36:2 Then Moses called Bezalel and Oholiab and every skillful person in whom the LORD had put skill, everyone whose heart stirred him, to come to the work to perform it.
Ex. 36:3 They received from Moses all the contributions which the sons of Israel had brought to perform the work in the construction of the sanctuary. And they still continued bringing to him freewill offerings every morning.
Ex. 36:4 And all the skillful men who were performing all the work of the sanctuary came, each from the work which he was performing,
Ex. 36:5 and they said to Moses, "The people are bringing much more than enough for the construction work which the LORD commanded us to perform."
Ex. 36:6 So Moses issued a command, and a proclamation was circulated throughout the camp, saying, "Let no man or woman any longer perform work for the contributions of the sanctuary." Thus the people were restrained from bringing any more.
Ex. 36:7 For the material they had was sufficient and more than enough for all the work, to perform it.

- Moses tells the workmen to begin the construction
  - And even as the work begins, the gifts from the people continue to arrive

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- Every morning there is yet another contribution awaiting the workmen
- Construction is underway, and yet more donations are made
- This reminds us of Paul's statement in Ephesians

Eph. 3:20 Now to Him who is able to do far more abundantly beyond all that we ask or think, according to the power that works within us,

- God's work never goes unfinished for lack of supply
  - God supplies what is required for His work
  - And He can always do more than we imagine or expect
  - But don't overlook that He chose to bring that provision through the hands of individuals who responded to the Spirit's leading
  - Never sit on your supply and assume that God will raise it somewhere else
    - The fact that God can raise money without your help doesn't acquit us for failing to support God's work when the Spirit leads us to do so
    - We are expected to be as generous as these Jews

- Eventually, Moses says turn off the spigot
  - There was more than enough material to support the construction
    - And more would be unneeded
    - Therefore, collecting more than was needed for God's work was not helpful
  - This example forms a powerful counter principle to the earlier truth that God's people should be generous to fund God's work
    - A ministry or work of God should not seek to obtain more than it needs to support the work God has commanded
    - Ministries are not banks
      - We are not called to sit on large amounts of money

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- We are called to be funnels, that receive and then pour it out again
- And when the supply exceeds the need, don't seek more until the need resumes

- This can be difficult to manage precisely, but in general terms support should be put to use,
  - And if it can't be used, then allow it to go somewhere else where it can be put to work

- Now we enter the chapters devoted to the construction of the tabernacle and its furnishings
  - The order of the description is different than the order in which the Lord spoke it to Moses
    - The difference in the order is in keeping with the difference in the two narratives
    - In the earlier part of the Exodus, the Lord described the parts of the tabernacle in an order that reflected a progression from the Holy of Holies outward
    - In this part of the book, the narrative explains the work done to construct the building and furnish it
      - So the description follows the order in which the work was accomplished
  - The work on the tabernacle and the furnishings is chapters 36-38 while the priesthood garments are in chapters 39-40
    - I'm going to read these chapters in two sections
    - And after each section I'll make a few observations as we finish this powerful book
    - So sit back and relax as you listen to the melodious (monotonous?) sound of my voice reading four chapters of scripture

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Ex. 36:8 All the skillful men among those who were performing the work made the tabernacle with ten curtains; of fine twisted linen and blue and purple and scarlet material, with cherubim, the work of a skillful workman, Bezalel made them.
Ex. 36:9 The length of each curtain was twenty-eight cubits and the width of each curtain four cubits; all the curtains had the same measurements.
Ex. 36:10 He joined five curtains to one another and the other five curtains he joined to one another.
Ex. 36:11 He made loops of blue on the edge of the outermost curtain in the first set; he did likewise on the edge of the curtain that was outermost in the second set.
Ex. 36:12 He made fifty loops in the one curtain and he made fifty loops on the edge of the curtain that was in the second set; the loops were opposite each other.
Ex. 36:13 He made fifty clasps of gold and joined the curtains to one another with the clasps, so the tabernacle was a unit.
Ex. 36:14 Then he made curtains of goats' hair for a tent over the tabernacle; he made eleven curtains in all.
Ex. 36:15 The length of each curtain was thirty cubits and four cubits the width of each curtain; the eleven curtains had the same measurements.
Ex. 36:16 He joined five curtains by themselves and the other six curtains by themselves.
Ex. 36:17 Moreover, he made fifty loops on the edge of the curtain that was outermost in the first set, and he made fifty loops on the edge of the curtain that was outermost in the second set.
Ex. 36:18 He made fifty clasps of bronze to join the tent together so that it would be a unit.
Ex. 36:19 He made a covering for the tent of rams' skins dyed red, and a covering of porpoise skins above.
Ex. 36:20 Then he made the boards for the tabernacle of acacia wood, standing upright.
Ex. 36:21 Ten cubits was the length of each board and one and a half cubits the width of each board.
Ex. 36:22 There were two tenons for each board, fitted to one another; thus he did for all the boards of the tabernacle.
Ex. 36:23 He made the boards for the tabernacle: twenty boards for the south side;
Ex. 36:24 and he made forty sockets of silver under the twenty boards; two sockets under one board for its two tenons and two sockets under another board for its two tenons.
Ex. 36:25 Then for the second side of the tabernacle, on the north side, he made twenty boards,
Ex. 36:26 and their forty sockets of silver; two sockets under one board and two sockets under another board.
Ex. 36:27 For the rear of the tabernacle, to the west, he made six boards.
Ex. 36:28 He made two boards for the corners of the tabernacle at the rear.

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Ex. 36:29 They were double beneath, and together they were complete to its top to the first ring; thus he did with both of them for the two corners.
Ex. 36:30 There were eight boards with their sockets of silver, sixteen sockets, two under every board.
Ex. 36:31 Then he made bars of acacia wood, five for the boards of one side of the tabernacle,
Ex. 36:32 and five bars for the boards of the other side of the tabernacle, and five bars for the boards of the tabernacle for the rear side to the west.
Ex. 36:33 He made the middle bar to pass through in the center of the boards from end to end.
Ex. 36:34 He overlaid the boards with gold and made their rings of gold as holders for the bars, and overlaid the bars with gold.
Ex. 36:35 Moreover, he made the veil of blue and purple and scarlet material, and fine twisted linen; he made it with cherubim, the work of a skillful workman.
Ex. 36:36 He made four pillars of acacia for it, and overlaid them with gold, with their hooks of gold; and he cast four sockets of silver for them.
Ex. 36:37 He made a screen for the doorway of the tent, of blue and purple and scarlet material, and fine twisted linen, the work of a weaver;
Ex. 36:38 and he made its five pillars with their hooks, and he overlaid their tops and their bands with gold; but their five sockets were of bronze.
Ex. 37:1 Now Bezalel made the ark of acacia wood; its length was two and a half cubits, and its width one and a half cubits, and its height one and a half cubits;
Ex. 37:2 and he overlaid it with pure gold inside and out, and made a gold molding for it all around.
Ex. 37:3 He cast four rings of gold for it on its four feet; even two rings on one side of it, and two rings on the other side of it.
Ex. 37:4 He made poles of acacia wood and overlaid them with gold.
Ex. 37:5 He put the poles into the rings on the sides of the ark, to carry it.
Ex. 37:6 He made a mercy seat of pure gold, two and a half cubits long and one and a half cubits wide.
Ex. 37:7 He made two cherubim of gold; he made them of hammered work at the two ends of the mercy seat;
Ex. 37:8 one cherub at the one end and one cherub at the other end; he made the cherubim of one piece with the mercy seat at the two ends.
Ex. 37:9 The cherubim had their wings spread upward, covering the mercy seat with their wings, with their faces toward each other; the faces of the cherubim were toward the mercy seat.
Ex. 37:10 Then he made the table of acacia wood, two cubits long and a cubit wide and one and a half cubits high.
Ex. 37:11 He overlaid it with pure gold, and made a gold molding for it all around.

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Ex. 37:12 He made a rim for it of a handbreadth all around, and made a gold molding for its rim all around.
Ex. 37:13 He cast four gold rings for it and put the rings on the four corners that were on its four feet.
Ex. 37:14 Close by the rim were the rings, the holders for the poles to carry the table.
Ex. 37:15 He made the poles of acacia wood and overlaid them with gold, to carry the table.
Ex. 37:16 He made the utensils which were on the table, its dishes and its pans and its bowls and its jars, with which to pour out drink offerings, of pure gold.
Ex. 37:17 Then he made the lampstand of pure gold. He made the lampstand of hammered work, its base and its shaft; its cups, its bulbs and its flowers were of one piece with it.
Ex. 37:18 There were six branches going out of its sides; three branches of the lampstand from the one side of it and three branches of the lampstand from the other side of it;
Ex. 37:19 three cups shaped like almond blossoms, a bulb and a flower in one branch, and three cups shaped like almond blossoms, a bulb and a flower in the other branch — so for the six branches going out of the lampstand.
Ex. 37:20 In the lampstand there were four cups shaped like almond blossoms, its bulbs and its flowers;
Ex. 37:21 and a bulb was under the first pair of branches coming out of it, and a bulb under the second pair of branches coming out of it, and a bulb under the third pair of branches coming out of it, for the six branches coming out of the lampstand.
Ex. 37:22 Their bulbs and their branches were of one piece with it; the whole of it was a single hammered work of pure gold.
Ex. 37:23 He made its seven lamps with its snuffers and its trays of pure gold.
Ex. 37:24 He made it and all its utensils from a talent of pure gold.
Ex. 37:25 Then he made the altar of incense of acacia wood: a cubit long and a cubit wide, square, and two cubits high; its horns were of one piece with it.
Ex. 37:26 He overlaid it with pure gold, its top and its sides all around, and its horns; and he made a gold molding for it all around.
Ex. 37:27 He made two golden rings for it under its molding, on its two sides — on opposite sides — as holders for poles with which to carry it.
Ex. 37:28 He made the poles of acacia wood and overlaid them with gold.
Ex. 37:29 And he made the holy anointing oil and the pure, fragrant incense of spices, the work of a perfumer.
Ex. 38:1 Then he made the altar of burnt offering of acacia wood, five cubits long, and five cubits wide, square, and three cubits high.
Ex. 38:2 He made its horns on its four corners, its horns being of one piece with it, and he overlaid it with bronze.
Ex. 38:3 He made all the utensils of the altar, the pails and the shovels and the basins, the flesh hooks and the firepans; he made all its utensils of bronze.

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Ex. 38:4 He made for the altar a grating of bronze network beneath, under its ledge, reaching halfway up.
Ex. 38:5 He cast four rings on the four ends of the bronze grating as holders for the poles.
Ex. 38:6 He made the poles of acacia wood and overlaid them with bronze.
Ex. 38:7 He inserted the poles into the rings on the sides of the altar, with which to carry it. He made it hollow with planks.
Ex. 38:8 Moreover, he made the laver of bronze with its base of bronze, from the mirrors of the serving women who served at the doorway of the tent of meeting.
Ex. 38:9 Then he made the court: for the south side the hangings of the court were of fine twisted linen, one hundred cubits;
Ex. 38:10 their twenty pillars, and their twenty sockets, made of bronze; the hooks of the pillars and their bands were of silver.
Ex. 38:11 For the north side there were one hundred cubits; their twenty pillars and their twenty sockets were of bronze, the hooks of the pillars and their bands were of silver.
Ex. 38:12 For the west side there were hangings of fifty cubits with their ten pillars and their ten sockets; the hooks of the pillars and their bands were of silver.
Ex. 38:13 For the east side fifty cubits.
Ex. 38:14 The hangings for the one side of the gate were fifteen cubits, with their three pillars and their three sockets,
Ex. 38:15 and so for the other side. On both sides of the gate of the court were hangings of fifteen cubits, with their three pillars and their three sockets.
Ex. 38:16 All the hangings of the court all around were of fine twisted linen.
Ex. 38:17 The sockets for the pillars were of bronze, the hooks of the pillars and their bands, of silver; and the overlaying of their tops, of silver, and all the pillars of the court were furnished with silver bands.
Ex. 38:18 The screen of the gate of the court was the work of the weaver, of blue and purple and scarlet material and fine twisted linen. And the length was twenty cubits and the height was five cubits, corresponding to the hangings of the court.
Ex. 38:19 Their four pillars and their four sockets were of bronze; their hooks were of silver, and the overlaying of their tops and their bands were of silver.
Ex. 38:20 All the pegs of the tabernacle and of the court all around were of bronze.
Ex. 38:21 This is the number of the things for the tabernacle, the tabernacle of the testimony, as they were numbered according to the command of Moses, for the service of the Levites, by the hand of Ithamar the son of Aaron the priest.
Ex. 38:22 Now Bezalel the son of Uri, the son of Hur, of the tribe of Judah, made all that the LORD had commanded Moses.
Ex. 38:23 With him was Oholiab the son of Ahisamach, of the tribe of Dan, an engraver and a skillful workman and a weaver in blue and in purple and in scarlet material, and fine linen.

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Ex. 38:24 All the gold that was used for the work, in all the work of the sanctuary, even the gold of the wave offering, was 29 talents and 730 shekels, according to the shekel of the sanctuary.
Ex. 38:25 The silver of those of the congregation who were numbered was 100 talents and 1,775 shekels, according to the shekel of the sanctuary;
Ex. 38:26 a beka a head (that is, half a shekel according to the shekel of the sanctuary), for each one who passed over to those who were numbered, from twenty years old and upward, for 603,550 men.
Ex. 38:27 The hundred talents of silver were for casting the sockets of the sanctuary and the sockets of the veil; one hundred sockets for the hundred talents, a talent for a socket.
Ex. 38:28 Of the 1,775 shekels, he made hooks for the pillars and overlaid their tops and made bands for them.
Ex. 38:29 The bronze of the wave offering was 70 talents and 2,400 shekels.
Ex. 38:30 With it he made the sockets to the doorway of the tent of meeting, and the bronze altar and its bronze grating, and all the utensils of the altar,
Ex. 38:31 and the sockets of the court all around and the sockets of the gate of the court, and all the pegs of the tabernacle and all the pegs of the court all around.

- This brings us to the first of our breaks, and we're pausing here to note the amount of material contributed by the people
    - All the gold used was 29 talents and 730 shekels
        - Since coin money wasn't invented until many centuries after this moment, these units are measures of weight
            - They aren't numbers of coins
        - So the weight of gold is approximately 1 ton (about 2,000 lbs)
        - That would be about $47 million today
    - All the silver used would be about four tons in weight
        - That would be about $3 million
        - The silver was taken from every male, a total of 603, 550 men
        - Based on that many adult males, we assume somewhere near 2 million total in the population of Israel at the Exodus
    - All the bronze was about 2.5 tons in weight

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        - That's only about $11,000 in bronze

- Then our final section

Ex. 39:1 Moreover, from the blue and purple and scarlet material, they made finely woven garments for ministering in the holy place as well as the holy garments which were for Aaron, just as the LORD had commanded Moses.
Ex. 39:2 He made the ephod of gold, and of blue and purple and scarlet material, and fine twisted linen.
Ex. 39:3 Then they hammered out gold sheets and cut them into threads to be woven in with the blue and the purple and the scarlet material, and the fine linen, the work of a skillful workman.
Ex. 39:4 They made attaching shoulder pieces for the ephod; it was attached at its two upper ends.
Ex. 39:5 The skillfully woven band which was on it was like its workmanship, of the same material: of gold and of blue and purple and scarlet material, and fine twisted linen, just as the LORD had commanded Moses.
Ex. 39:6 They made the onyx stones, set in gold filigree settings; they were engraved like the engravings of a signet, according to the names of the sons of Israel.
Ex. 39:7 And he placed them on the shoulder pieces of the ephod, as memorial stones for the sons of Israel, just as the LORD had commanded Moses.
Ex. 39:8 He made the breastpiece, the work of a skillful workman, like the workmanship of the ephod: of gold and of blue and purple and scarlet material and fine twisted linen.
Ex. 39:9 It was square; they made the breastpiece folded double, a span long and a span wide when folded double.
Ex. 39:10 And they mounted four rows of stones on it. The first row was a row of ruby, topaz, and emerald;
Ex. 39:11 and the second row, a turquoise, a sapphire and a diamond;
Ex. 39:12 and the third row, a jacinth, an agate, and an amethyst;
Ex. 39:13 and the fourth row, a beryl, an onyx, and a jasper. They were set in gold filigree settings when they were mounted.
Ex. 39:14 The stones were corresponding to the names of the sons of Israel; they were twelve, corresponding to their names, engraved with the engravings of a signet, each with its name for the twelve tribes.
Ex. 39:15 They made on the breastpiece chains like cords, of twisted cordage work in pure gold.
Ex. 39:16 They made two gold filigree settings and two gold rings, and put the two rings on the two ends of the breastpiece.
Ex. 39:17 Then they put the two gold cords in the two rings at the ends of the breastpiece.
Ex. 39:18 They put the other two ends of the two cords on the two filigree settings, and put them on the shoulder pieces of the ephod at the front of it.

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Ex. 39:19 They made two gold rings and placed them on the two ends of the breastpiece, on its inner edge which was next to the ephod.
Ex. 39:20 Furthermore, they made two gold rings and placed them on the bottom of the two shoulder pieces of the ephod, on the front of it, close to the place where it joined, above the woven band of the ephod.
Ex. 39:21 They bound the breastpiece by its rings to the rings of the ephod with a blue cord, so that it would be on the woven band of the ephod, and that the breastpiece would not come loose from the ephod, just as the LORD had commanded Moses.
Ex. 39:22 Then he made the robe of the ephod of woven work, all of blue;
Ex. 39:23 and the opening of the robe was at the top in the center, as the opening of a coat of mail, with a binding all around its opening, so that it would not be torn.
Ex. 39:24 They made pomegranates of blue and purple and scarlet material and twisted linen on the hem of the robe.
Ex. 39:25 They also made bells of pure gold, and put the bells between the pomegranates all around on the hem of the robe,
Ex. 39:26 alternating a bell and a pomegranate all around on the hem of the robe for the service, just as the LORD had commanded Moses.
Ex. 39:27 They made the tunics of finely woven linen for Aaron and his sons,
Ex. 39:28 and the turban of fine linen, and the decorated caps of fine linen, and the linen breeches of fine twisted linen,
Ex. 39:29 and the sash of fine twisted linen, and blue and purple and scarlet material, the work of the weaver, just as the LORD had commanded Moses.
Ex. 39:30 They made the plate of the holy crown of pure gold, and inscribed it like the engravings of a signet, "Holy to the LORD."
Ex. 39:31 They fastened a blue cord to it, to fasten it on the turban above, just as the LORD had commanded Moses.
Ex. 39:32 Thus all the work of the tabernacle of the tent of meeting was completed; and the sons of Israel did according to all that the LORD had commanded Moses; so they did.
Ex. 39:33 They brought the tabernacle to Moses, the tent and all its furnishings: its clasps, its boards, its bars, and its pillars and its sockets;
Ex. 39:34 and the covering of rams' skins dyed red, and the covering of porpoise skins, and the screening veil;
Ex. 39:35 the ark of the testimony and its poles and the mercy seat;
Ex. 39:36 the table, all its utensils, and the bread of the Presence;
Ex. 39:37 the pure gold lampstand, with its arrangement of lamps and all its utensils, and the oil for the light;
Ex. 39:38 and the gold altar, and the anointing oil and the fragrant incense, and the veil for the doorway of the tent;
Ex. 39:39 the bronze altar and its bronze grating, its poles and all its utensils, the laver and its stand;

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Ex. 39:40 the hangings for the court, its pillars and its sockets, and the screen for the gate of the court, its cords and its pegs and all the equipment for the service of the tabernacle, for the tent of meeting;
Ex. 39:41 the woven garments for ministering in the holy place and the holy garments for Aaron the priest and the garments of his sons, to minister as priests.
Ex. 39:42 So the sons of Israel did all the work according to all that the LORD had commanded Moses.
Ex. 39:43 And Moses examined all the work and behold, they had done it; just as the LORD had commanded, this they had done. So Moses blessed them.
Ex. 40:1 Then the LORD spoke to Moses, saying,
Ex. 40:2 "On the first day of the first month you shall set up the tabernacle of the tent of meeting.
Ex. 40:3 "You shall place the ark of the testimony there, and you shall screen the ark with the veil.
Ex. 40:4 "You shall bring in the table and arrange what belongs on it; and you shall bring in the lampstand and mount its lamps.
Ex. 40:5 "Moreover, you shall set the gold altar of incense before the ark of the testimony, and set up the veil for the doorway to the tabernacle.
Ex. 40:6 "You shall set the altar of burnt offering in front of the doorway of the tabernacle of the tent of meeting.
Ex. 40:7 "You shall set the laver between the tent of meeting and the altar and put water in it.
Ex. 40:8 "You shall set up the court all around and hang up the veil for the gateway of the court.
Ex. 40:9 "Then you shall take the anointing oil and anoint the tabernacle and all that is in it, and shall consecrate it and all its furnishings; and it shall be holy.
Ex. 40:10 "You shall anoint the altar of burnt offering and all its utensils, and consecrate the altar, and the altar shall be most holy.
Ex. 40:11 "You shall anoint the laver and its stand, and consecrate it.
Ex. 40:12 "Then you shall bring Aaron and his sons to the doorway of the tent of meeting and wash them with water.
Ex. 40:13 "You shall put the holy garments on Aaron and anoint him and consecrate him, that he may minister as a priest to Me.
Ex. 40:14 "You shall bring his sons and put tunics on them;
Ex. 40:15 and you shall anoint them even as you have anointed their father, that they may minister as priests to Me; and their anointing will qualify them for a perpetual priesthood throughout their generations."
Ex. 40:16 Thus Moses did; according to all that the LORD had commanded him, so he did.
Ex. 40:17 Now in the first month of the second year, on the first day of the month, the tabernacle was erected.

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Ex. 40:18 Moses erected the tabernacle and laid its sockets, and set up its boards, and inserted its bars and erected its pillars.
Ex. 40:19 He spread the tent over the tabernacle and put the covering of the tent on top of it, just as the LORD had commanded Moses.
Ex. 40:20 Then he took the testimony and put it into the ark, and attached the poles to the ark, and put the mercy seat on top of the ark.
Ex. 40:21 He brought the ark into the tabernacle, and set up a veil for the screen, and screened off the ark of the testimony, just as the LORD had commanded Moses.
Ex. 40:22 Then he put the table in the tent of meeting on the north side of the tabernacle, outside the veil.
Ex. 40:23 He set the arrangement of bread in order on it before the LORD, just as the LORD had commanded Moses.
Ex. 40:24 Then he placed the lampstand in the tent of meeting, opposite the table, on the south side of the tabernacle.
Ex. 40:25 He lighted the lamps before the LORD, just as the LORD had commanded Moses.
Ex. 40:26 Then he placed the gold altar in the tent of meeting in front of the veil;
Ex. 40:27 and he burned fragrant incense on it, just as the LORD had commanded Moses.
Ex. 40:28 Then he set up the veil for the doorway of the tabernacle.
Ex. 40:29 He set the altar of burnt offering before the doorway of the tabernacle of the tent of meeting, and offered on it the burnt offering and the meal offering, just as the LORD had commanded Moses.
Ex. 40:30 He placed the laver between the tent of meeting and the altar and put water in it for washing.
Ex. 40:31 From it Moses and Aaron and his sons washed their hands and their feet.
Ex. 40:32 When they entered the tent of meeting, and when they approached the altar, they washed, just as the LORD had commanded Moses.
Ex. 40:33 He erected the court all around the tabernacle and the altar, and hung up the veil for the gateway of the court. Thus Moses finished the work.
Ex. 40:34 Then the cloud covered the tent of meeting, and the glory of the LORD filled the tabernacle.
Ex. 40:35 Moses was not able to enter the tent of meeting because the cloud had settled on it, and the glory of the LORD filled the tabernacle.
Ex. 40:36 Throughout all their journeys whenever the cloud was taken up from over the tabernacle, the sons of Israel would set out;
Ex. 40:37 but if the cloud was not taken up, then they did not set out until the day when it was taken up.
Ex. 40:38 For throughout all their journeys, the cloud of the LORD was on the tabernacle by day, and there was fire in it by night, in the sight of all the house of Israel.

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- The chapter opens with the final words of the Lord to Moses in Exodus
    - The Lord commands Moses to erect the building on the first day of the first month
        - This is one year from their departure from Egypt and nine months since arriving at the mountain
        - This tells us that several months were required for the people to build all the materials needed for the tabernacle
    - Secondly, the Lord tells Moses how to move the materials into place
        - And once again, the construction begins with the Holy of Holies and moves outward
        - The final step was setting up the courtyard around the tabernacle
- Once the building was in place, the Lord comes down to indwell this building, making His presence visible and resident among sinful men
    - In this first occupation, the Lord's presence occupied the entire tabernacle, just the Holy of Holies
        - This prevented Moses was entering the tent at all
        - The Lord has taken it all for Himself
        - Normally and thereafter, the Lord occupied the space above the mercy seat
    - Why is there no temple for the Lord today? Why does the Lord not dwell with men today?
        - The answer is He does!
        - During the dispensation of the church, the temple of God is the body of every believer
            - While beforehand God indwelled the Jewish temple, today He indwells the Church
            - In a future day, the Lord will physically reside with men on Earth, once again living in the temple of the Millennial Kingdom

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- So consider that the same power that the Lord displayed in His dwelling of the earthly tabernacle has now come to reside in you by faith
    - How did the Lord demonstrate His presence to the people and the world?
    - His glory shone in the temple, and whether day or night the people could see the Lord presence

- So then listen to Paul's words to the church today

2Cor. 6:16 Or what agreement has the temple of God with idols? For we are the temple of the living God; just as God said,
"I WILL DWELL IN THEM AND WALK AMONG THEM;
AND I WILL BE THEIR GOD, AND THEY SHALL BE MY PEOPLE.

1Cor. 6:17 But the one who joins himself to the Lord is one spirit with Him.
1Cor. 6:18 Flee immorality. Every other sin that a man commits is outside the body, but the immoral man sins against his own body.
1Cor. 6:19 Or do you not know that your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit who is in you, whom you have from God, and that you are not your own?
1Cor. 6:20 For you have been bought with a price: therefore glorify God in your body.

Luke 8:16 "Now no one after lighting a lamp covers it over with a container, or puts it under a bed; but he puts it on a lampstand, so that those who come in may see the light.
Luke 8:17 "For nothing is hidden that will not become evident, nor anything secret that will not be known and come to light.

Matt. 5:14 "You are the light of the world. A city set on a hill cannot be hidden;
Matt. 5:15 nor does anyone light a lamp and put it under a basket, but on the lampstand, and it gives light to all who are in the house.
Matt. 5:16 "Let your light shine before men in such a way that they may see your good works, and glorify your Father who is in heaven.

- Let's allow the Light in us, which is the glory of God's Spirit indwelling the temple of our body, shine before men

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